A New Life With Old Wounds

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52731196.

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Explicit

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Additional Tags:
Angst, Fluff, Smut, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), really everyone needs therapy, post s5, Mating Bites, Catra and Adora were in a relationship before, Shadow Weaver liked to mind wipe them, Abusive Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Flashbacks, Catra is more magicat than she realizes, Catra and Adora are in love and always have been, So much guilt, Self-Harm, Suicidal Thoughts

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Part 1 of A Beautiful Wish

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A New Life With Old Wounds

by Indy (DrJones36), Sokuly

Summary

Horde Prime is gone. One would think that would make life easier, but trauma from a war can still make some moments difficult to deal with months later.

Rebuilding Etheria is going to take a while and Catra wants to right her wrongs. Even if not many are pleased to see the old Horde commander.

Catra and Adora have always loved each other, they know that now that Shadow Weaver is gone. How can one simple thing become a little more complicated only a few months later? Not that Adora is complaining.

And how can a simple trip to Beast Island go so wrong and just create more questions than answers?

Notes

New year, new fandom!

I've personally come to enjoy this fandom and, of course, Catra and Adora so much over the past several months but haven't written anything to post until recently. As usual for us, there's going to be lots of angst, smut, some good wholesomeness, and pretty long chapters at times. That will apply to not only this story/series, but also to anything in the future aside from any one shots that may happen.

The two of us try to be responsive to comments as we can. We try to leave some life updates and further notes at the end of each chapter, because why not. We both hope you can enjoy the nonsense and wild ride with us.

-S and Indy

See the end of the work for more notes

Nightmare

A maniacal laugh bubbled from her chest as she held her old best friend over the ledge in Horde Prime's throne room. They could have been together in a world of peace, but the woman she had by the collar of her shirt had made her decision. It was a needless waste. She walked herself closer, never loosening her grip, the moment she noticed the blonde shuffling her feet to stay on the ledge.

"We could have been together". Her voice sounded unfamiliar, so sickeningly sweet.

"Catra, snap out of it! Don't do this!"

She smirked at the pure terror in her face. Catra had never seen that look before as Adora fought against her hold, willing gravity to just work with her for a second to be able push her back and regain footing.

"This is such a needless waste," Horde Prime's voice came through mixed with Catra's. "It's rather unfortunate".

"Don't…" one of her feet slipped off the edge and she grabbed onto Catra's wrist, desperate to not fall, "don't do this. You never listened to anyone in your life! Don't start now!"

Catra then let go with a forceful push. Adora's nails raked down her hand while she tried to hold on.

"Catra!" Adora's voice echoed through the throne room as her body vanished into the dark abyss.

Her eyes flashed from empty green back to her normal blue and yellow as Prime released his control. She fell to her knees, reaching over the edge, reaching for the woman she just dropped while Prime's laugh echoed around her.

"Adora!"

_____

Catra sat straight up, panting with tears in her eyes. She let go. Prime stopped controlling her the moment she did to let her see what she had done. Of course that happened. Right? She put her face in her hands as the tears finally spilled over. Her breathing was choppy as the sobs overtook her.

"Catra?"

"H-huh?" She looked at the spot next to her to see Adora rubbing the sleep from her eyes. Her tail puffed as she jumped from the bed. "You're not real! You-you're supposed to be dead! I… let go".

“Hey, no”. Adora sat up and held out her hand. “Come here”.

Catra dug her claws into the back of her neck. “Get out of my fucking head!”

“Wait!” Adora yelled after her as she ran out of their room.

The door slammed closed behind Catra as she stumbled into the hall. She wasn’t quite used to Bright Moon’s castle yet, even if it had been a few months, and wasn’t exactly sure where she was going. Catra continued to claw at the back of her neck. She needed the chip out. She killed her best friend before she was able to tell her she loved her.

“Just kill me already!” She cried out into the empty hall, hoping any of Adora’s friends would put her out of her misery.

Between attempting to claw the chip from the back of her neck and stumbling down the hall in tears, Catra wondered why Adora’s friends even bothered to bring her back. Even if they defeated Prime, she feared any of the clones could still somehow regain control. Her claws raked down the back of her neck as she backed into someone else who seemingly couldn’t sleep.

“Brother!” Wrong Hordak greeted with a wink before his grin disappeared at seeing the blood and claw marks over Catra’s neck. “You seem to have been fighting. Is there an intruder?”

“You!” Catra growled, turning and pouncing on him. “What did you do to me?!”

“I do not understand,” he whimpered when she grabbed him by the hair. “I have done nothing wrong”.

“Liar!” She landed a punch to the side of his face as another sob came from her chest. “You have to tell someone to remove the chip. I don’t want this! I’d rather be dead”.

He grabbed her wrist when she threw another. “I do not wish to harm you. Please explain-“

“He. Chipped. Me! Take it out!”

“It’s already been removed!” He closed his eyes when Catra let go of his hair and drew her arm back, claws completely unsheathed.

“There you are!” Adora, in the form of She-Ra, wrapped her in a tight hug from behind before she could drag her claws across his face. “I’m sorry, Wrong Hordak. She… uh, bad dream. It’s okay. We’re going to go back to bed. Sorry again!”

“She does seem to be injured”. He rubbed the side of his face as Adora held a still combative Catra in a bear hug. “Should I seek

medical attention for her?”

“No, no”. Adora picked Catra up so her feet were no long on the floor. “I’ll take care of it. Goodnight!”

Adora sighed sadly upon seeing the scratches and the short, blood matted fur around and over the scar where the chip had been. She tightened her hold when Catra started to fight against her body again, her growls and sobs in a heartbreaking mix. As she walked, her girlfriend was driving her heels into her knees, trying to use every step as leverage to escape. Adora could feels claws attempting to dig into her sides and hips, tearing the fabric of her pants and top.

This wasn’t the first time something like this happened. However, this was the first time someone else got hurt. Normally no one else was around and she was usually much easier to catch and drag back to bed. The nightmare must have been far worse than normal.

“Stop fighting,” Adora whispered. “You’re going to wake everyone up”.

“I don’t even know why they brought me here!” Catra squirmed more.

“I told you I was bringing you home. And I did that. Months ago”. Adora winced and squeezed Catra’s body tighter for a moment as

her teeth sank into her forearm. “Ow! Did you really just bite me?”

Adora saw Glimmer come around the curve in the hallway, a ball of light surrounding her hand. Catra blinked at the light while trying to tug at least one arm free. Eventually she gave up and her shoulders just shook as she cried.

“Would someone like to explain-“ Glimmer lowered her hand. “Is she okay?”

“She will be”. Adora shifted Catra’s now mostly limp body in her arms. “I think this one was really bad. Like… first few weeks bad”.

Glimmer nodded and joined them on the walk back to their room. “Is there anything you need?”

“Uh, could you get the door?”

Glimmer opened the door for the two, but stopped in the doorway. Adora gave a small nod with an apologetic smile to her friend. Glimmer gave her a concerned look when another series of sobs came from Catra.

“I got it from here,” Adora said quietly. “Go back to bed. I’ll… let you know later”.

“Goodnight, you two”.

Glimmer closed the door quietly and Adora let out a breath. If it weren’t for the shuddered breathing and quiet crying, she would have assumed Catra had fallen asleep with how much she became a dead weight in her arms.

“Alright, I’m gonna put you down. If you start fighting again, I’m picking you back up”.

Testing if Catra would go back to putting up a fight, she eased her hold and set her back on her feet. When Adora wasn’t met with resistance, she fully let go, only to have to grab her under the arms as her knees buckled.

“Catra?”

“I want to go back to bed,” she whispered around her tears while she kept her gaze at her feet.

Adora sighed quietly, returning to her normal form while still holding her girlfriend upright. She walked her to the bed and watched sadly as she laid down and curled into a ball. It was clear Catra had fully come back to her senses.

“You haven’t done that in a while”. She said softly and crawled back into bed behind her. “Do you want to talk?”

She shook her head and flattened her ears as Melog curled up next to her feet. Adora pulled her close to her own body before rubbing Catra’s downturned ear. Slowly, her cries died into quiet sniffles. Adora moved her hand to rub along her jaw. For now, she knew Catra needed the quiet, comforting contact while she calmed down. She wasn’t trying to push Adora away, a good sign she was well on her way to being okay with talking.

Adora wanted to at least the clean the scratches, but knew better than to get up quite yet. Just as she was considering simply healing the claw marks on the both of them, she heard a quiet, choppy purr come from next to her. It sounded like Catra was trying to comfort herself more than anything.

“I love you,” Adora said quietly and continued to stroke along Catra’s jaw. “I really do. Can I… at least clean up your neck before we go back to sleep?”

“Take care of it in the morning,” she replied just as quiet, resting a hand over the one on her jaw. “Just… stay in bed with me. Please?”

“I’m not going anywhere. Do you want to talk about it yet?”

Catra only shook her head.

“That’s okay”.

Adora kissed the scar where the chip had been. If she could, she would bring Prime back just to torture him until he died. And then she would do it again, just to get her point across. The hand over hers grew heavier until it slowly fell away as Catra gradually fell asleep. Adora resumed stroking along her jaw gently as she closed her eyes, the soft purr coming from by their feet slowly eased her into light sleep.

Catra yawned as she followed Adora into the dining hall. She could have used a couple more hours to recover from the night, but her stomach had other ideas. And so did Adora’s. There was no way Catra would be able to get back to sleep with the way her girlfriend’s stomach was growling.

The two took their seats next to each other between Glimmer on Adora’s left and Scorpia on Catra’s right as Wrong Hordak was taking lids off of platters to reveal various breakfast dumplings, some sort of breakfast stew, and a few donuts. And of course there were tiny versions of it all, which Entrapta eagerly helped herself to before offering the miniatures to everyone else. The platters were passed around amid quiet conversation while Catra remained silent.

“It really is nice for all of you to join us for breakfast,” Glimmer said happily. “I know it was last minute and all”.

“Who are we to deny such an invitation from the queen herself?” Sea Hawk said and passed a tray of dumplings to his right. “This calls for-“

“No,” Mermista said sternly. “It’s way too early for any kind of singing”.

“It really is so wonderful to have breakfast with our friends again,” Perfuma said, putting her hands together. “Catra, why do you seem so… upset?”

“Huh?” Catra looked up from her plate. “I’m… I’m not. It’s just been a while since we’ve seen,” she shot a glance to Hordak, “literally everyone”.

“How has Bright Moon been treating you, Wrong Hordak?” Entrapta asked, a little too excited.

“Just wonderful!” He exclaimed with a wink. “They let me cook all of the meals. With help from the rest of the kitchen staff, of course”.

Catra didn’t break eye contact with Hordak. She could feel her tail starting to bristle. They hadn’t spoken since being on Prime’s ship. She felt she didn’t deserve to be granted such a pardon for the things she had done, let alone Hordak. Yet, here they were. They

were both welcomed into what she was still calling the Rebellion. It wasn't with open arms at first, but at least the Princess Alliance warmed up quickly.

Adora rested a hand on Catra's leg under the table upon see her tail bristle. The small ear twitch let her know she got at least a sliver of her attention. She watched quietly until Hordak finally broke the eye contact and resumed his breakfast. Catra begrudgingly returned to eating as well, her ear twitching again as Adora grabbed her tail and smoothed it back out.

"What was that all about?" She asked quietly.

"We still haven't spoken since Prime's ship. And I don't know why he's here". Catra replied just as quiet and took a bite out of her dumpling. "I mean, I don't even deserve to be here".

Adora sighed and squeezed her leg comfortingly. She never liked it when Catra's mind started going down that path. Regardless of what anyone told her, she still sought after a harsher punishment as if going through being chipped and the Heart of Etheria fiasco wasn't enough.

Everyone was well aware of King Micah's decision when it came to Hordak. He was allowed to have some freedoms as long as he served several days a month on Beast Island, for an undetermined amount of time, to clean up the old dump site. Micah said he believed in second chances and redemption. Even Entrapta vouched for him changing, not unlike Catra herself.

Most conversation had dwindled to small talk while everyone ate. Catra could feel Wrong Hordak glancing at her sadly between conversations with Hordak, Entrapta, and Micah. She finally looked at him and lowered her ears apologetically. He didn't seem upset with her, just upset that she even had to deal with the nightmares.

"What happened to you?" Scorpia finally asked, unable to ignore the dried blood in her fur and the claw lines across the back of Catra's neck.

"I… um…"

"It happened again, didn't it?" She asked sadly and extended a pincer. "But it's been so long".

"It hasn't been that long," she mumbled hurriedly. "Maybe two weeks since I had a nightmare".

"To the point you hurt yourself?" Scorpia questioned. "I'm pretty sure it's been a while since that".

Catra put a hand over the back of her neck. She definitely forgot to wash the blood away. And forgot to ask Adora to heal her before they headed to breakfast. Scorpia went to say more but

stopped when she noticed Glimmer make a face and shake her head. Not the time.

"Yeah," Catra said and looked up at Perfuma. "I-It has been a while. But… but it happened".

Perfuma smiled and nodded, urging her to continue. She had been helping Catra process through her feelings and trauma on occasion. Or at least trying to. She was just happy that Catra was actually attempting to talk about it.

"I…" Catra closed her eyes tightly. She couldn't do this in front of so many people. "It's okay, though".

Adora let out the breath she had been holding.

Perfuma still nodded approvingly for the small amount Catra managed to get out. "You know we're all here for you and-"

"Why?!" Catra suddenly stood, tail flicking in irritation. "Shouldn't I be on Beast Island too?! I… I opened a fucking portal that killed Sparkle's mom! I killed the *queen* ! That should be a death sentence for me. Why do you all-" she took a deep breath at Perfuma's corrective stare and sat back down. "I'm sorry".

Micah stood and rested his fingers on the table before explaining calmly, "you're not serving the same punishment, or worse, as

Hordak because you've already shown your change of heart. You had a far worse chipping experience than the rest of us and you were a large part in saving the universe with Adora. While Angella is… gone, your bravery and love," he glanced at Adora before looking back to her, "has not gone unnoticed. At all. You've shown that you're taking full responsibility for the things you've done and as king, I truly feel you've been through enough".

Glimmer wiped a tear from her eye and offered her hand in front of Adora. "We've discussed this, Horde Scum".

Catra finally cracked a smile and squeezed the outstretched hand. If anyone else were to call her that, she wouldn't exactly hesitate to take them out. Really, she grew to accept the nickname from Adora's best friend.

"Is everything settled now?" Micah asked.

"Yeah". Catra glanced to him and held Adora's hand under the table. "It is. Thanks. For everything. And I'm sorry for the… outburst. It's still something I'm working on".

"Excellent," he said and sat back down. "Please, continue to enjoy the meal Wrong Hordak made for all of us this morning. I see there's still some leftovers on those trays".

"You're doing so well," Perfuma said happily around Scorpia while everyone else seemed to be clamoring for the leftovers in the

center of the table.

Catra just smiled and sat back in her chair to watch the chaos. Entrapta had snatched her platter of tiny food with her hair and held it protectively. Adora was half on the table with Sea Hawk across from her, the two snatching what they could around other hands grabbing. Micah watched in amusement at the scene he had caused while Wrong Hordak watched in almost genuine fear.

Scorpia jumped back when Netossa threw a net over one of the platters for herself and Spinnerella. After what seemed to be mere seconds, almost everyone was using magic to secure the last of the food, now including Micah himself. Catra, Perfuma, and Wrong Hordak were the only ones not participating in the battle for food, each already having their fill.

"Was it a nightmare or another panic attack?" Perfuma asked.

"Nightmare," Catra answered simply. "It was… too real. My… my memory was even altered for a bit from it".

"How so?" She scooted her chair back and leaned forward towards her friend.

She sighed and looked at the continued commotion before looking back to Perfuma. "I remembered that Prime was defeated but not that Adora was part of it because I… in the nightmare… I killed her under Prime's control".

Perfuma frowned at the way Catra's ears drooped as she talked. "You know-"

"For the honor of Greyskull!"

Catra snorted a half laugh as the commotion stopped and everyone stared at Adora in disbelief.

"Okay, that's cheating," Mermista said and snatched up the last dumpling.

"Are you even going to be able to finish all of that?" Catra asked with an eyebrow raised while pointing to her overflowing plate. "I think you have plenty, dummy".

Adora returned to normal. "It isn't *all* for me. I got you some too".

"I'm full but I appreciate it".

Catra rubbed the back of her neck once Adora took a step back, returning to her normal form. The claw marks were gone, yet the scar from the chip remained, a small patch where the fur wouldn't grow back completely. She had voiced her desire for it to go away

and Adora explained that, for some reason, no matter how hard she tried, She-Ra's powers couldn't get rid of the scar. And she really did try many times. Exactly like she did just now.

She turned from the window and Adora wrapped her arms around her almost immediately. Catra closed her eyes and rested her head on Adora's shoulder while returning the embrace. Her ears twitched when there was a knock on the door.

"Really? Haven't we hung out with them enough today?" Catra groaned. "She was serious about the scavenger hunt, wasn't she?"

"I'll tell Glimmer we're not up for any nighttime scavenger hunts, okay?" She chuckled. "Get yourself ready for bed. I got it".

Catra snuck a kiss before Adora could completely slip from her embrace. The loving smile she got in return is one she would willingly kill for. It suited her. Missing out on Adora's smiles and laughs for nearly three years, she realized was torture. She couldn't do it again. Instead of getting around for bed, Catra just watched with a warm smile as she opened the door.

The warmth was quickly replaced by anger, reflected just as fast through Melog. When Adora opened the door to Hordak, it took everything in her to not lose control of herself as her ears turned back in anger.

“I hope I’m not intruding”.

“You always are,” Catra nearly spat as she joined Adora’s side.

“Entrapta pulled me away before I could thank you for ridding the universe of Horde Prime, as well as apologize for almost everything back in the Fright Zone”.

“Almost?” Adora questioned, grabbing the base of Catra’s tail to keep her in place. “What does that mean?”

“I won’t apologize for bringing you in, and letting you keep Catra. I won’t apologize for giving you both a home. I do, however, apologize for…” he stopped for a moment, trying to think of the words we wanted to use.

Catra took the momentary pause. “The manipulation? Letting Shadow Weaver do whatever she wanted to us? Using not only the two of us, but the others as pawns in a losing game? I could stand here for *hours* and list-“

“Enough!” Hordak cleared his throat and put his hands behind his back. “Yes. Those things and so much more. Goodnight, to the both of you”.

Catra let out a quiet hiss as he turned on his heal and walked down the hall. She crossed the room as Adora was closing the

door and stood at the window, arms folded in front of her. Melog's mane and tail turned from a fiery red to a yellow orange. Adora joined her girlfriend and cracked a smile when she felt Catra's tail hit against her butt. Out of the corner of her eye, she watched Melog's color return to normal.

"Do you-"

"No," Catra mumbled, "I don't want to talk about it".

"You can't keep hiding these things from me," she said and rested a hand on her shoulder. "Despite what you might think, I do want to hear about the bad things too".

Catra's shoulders relaxed under the touch. She wanted to start fresh, let Adora see her happy. How it used to be before everything happened.

"It's just us".

"What am I supposed to say?" Catra asked quietly.

"Anything". Adora slid her hand down Catra's back from her shoulder before wrapping her arm around her waist.

“Sometimes I just feel like everyone’s being too nice to me. After everything I did, Adora, the last thing I deserve is any of this”.

“Even me?” She asked, resting her head on Catra’s.

“*Especially* you,” she whispered sadly.

The two stood at the window quietly, watching the world pass by in front of them. They watched Scorpia and Perfuma meet in the garden below, the latter kissing the former’s cheek before they started to walk around the garden paths. Glimmer and Bow were out on their balcony next door. Everyone else seemed so flawless.

Catra twitched her ear when Adora’s arm fell from her waist. She was turned to face her girlfriend and that stupid loving gaze she would always get. Adora forced her arms to uncross and held her hands.

“I forgive you, Catra. I know I’ve said it before, but I’ll say it a million times until you get it if I have to”. She pressed her forehead against hers. “I love you”.

“I love you too,” she replied quietly.

Adora was searching for something in Catra’s eyes. Anything to answer for Melog’s mane seeming to shift to a darker blue than usual by their feet on top of why she wrapped her tail loosely

around her own legs. She was usually so readable, but there was a sturdy wall blocking the reason for the sudden downturn in her mood.

Catra attempted a slow blink, an effort to reassure Adora. She was okay. Maybe. When it wasn't returned like it usually was, she knew she was caught. The series of meows from next to her had her ears fall as she closed her eyes, letting Adora win the little stare down.

"Catra, please, stop hiding from me. Put your walls up around everyone else for all I care, just…" Adora took a step back and squeezed her hands. "Talk to me".

"I'm… I think I need to go to Thaymor. Help rebuild after the destruction… I caused".

Adora held Catra's hands tighter when she felt her trying to pull away. She'd be damned if she was going to let her go out to the village in the middle of the night. So far, none of the villages requested assistance in their rebuilding with everyone still riding off the high of magic being restored to Etheria.

Deep down, she knew something bigger was going on. Breakfast with the rest of the princesses was sudden. Maybe someone did need help. Maybe Catra overheard a conversation earlier regarding Thaymor.

“Not tonight. I know you want to help, and it’s appreciated-“

“If you say I can’t help at all, I’m sleeping in the woods”.

Adora sighed. “I’m not saying that. At all. I’m saying maybe you showing up in the middle of the night isn’t a good idea. Sure the Horde is basically gone, but it’s only been a few months. Not everyone is so forgiving in a such a short time”.

“There are still clones out there, Adora,” Catra said and looked out the window. “I don’t know if they’re hostile. I don’t… want them to hurt more innocent people. And we both know there are still displaced Horde soldiers out there. If they try to find shelter in any of the villages, they’ll be attacked too. We should find them”.

“All of them?” When the question wasn’t answered, she continued, “is this about Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle? I’m sure they went back to the Fright Zone. It’s familiar and you know damn well Scorpia wouldn’t ever kick them out. Those three are fine”.

Adora heard the faint rumble of a low growl at the mention of their old friends. Melog somehow managed to get an even darker blue around their mane and tail. She could only take that as Catra feeling an immense amount of guilt, a deep self hatred settling in. So she shut up about it and pulled her into a tight hug. Adora hoped Catra knew she wasn’t going to have to go through any of this alone again.

“How about we call it a night?”

Catra nodded into her shoulder, even if she knew sleep wasn’t going to be particularly restful. Any amount of time to turn off her racing mind was welcomed. Adora let her get comfortable first before curling her own body around her. Catra had to admit, this was far better than sleeping at her feet. Or even the handful of times she did crawl in bed next to Adora back in the Horde when she would have a bad dream.

An unexpected purr vibrated in Catra’s throat moments after Adora started running her fingers through her hair, massaging the back of her head. Her other arm was under her neck, bent at the elbow with her hand resting on her chest. Catra smiled, closed her eyes, and brought her hand up to cover Adora’s. She slowly let her own low purrs lull them both to sleep.

You Love Me Enough For That?

Chapter Notes

> Okay, so… this chapter is mostly smut. If you'd like to skip, stop reading at "Catra stood and grabbed Adora's hand to lead her back to their bedroom. She meant what she said about after the meeting".
>
> You can then continue on once you hit "Adora hummed in contentment when Catra put her head on her chest and trailed her fingers up and down her side. "You'll have to tell me about it one of these days". Or at the chapter break which is immediately after that.
>
> Anything important during it will be in the end notes so you're not too lost later.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Do you two care to join the rest of us in the war room?" Glimmer asked after teleporting into Adora and Catra's room.

Catra jumped out of bed, hair and fur on end, while Adora bolted upright, knife in hand. Their excursion to Thaymor was halted a week ago, being told there was already a plan. Now, it seemed that plan was going to be set in place. At least after they got clothes on.

"Can you knock first?!" Catra yelled and attempted to cover herself while climbing back in bed to use the blanket as a shield with Adora.

“Why are we still calling it that?” Adora asked, still half asleep. “The war’s over”.

“Fine!” Glimmer pinched the bridge of her nose. “Would you two care to join the rest of us in the *meeting* room? *After* you get clothes on”.

Adora chuckled as she flopped back down on her back once Glimmer teleported out. They must have slept through the alarms they set. She scratched base of Catra’s tail, getting her to relax and let the blanket fall back into her lap.

“Wanna go again?”

“If Sparkles wouldn’t have our heads, absolutely. After this meeting, you’re mine again, princess”.

Catra watched Adora get out of bed with a stretch. The faint claw marks across the backs of her shoulders make her smirk. She knew they’d be long gone before lunch and any new ones gone before dinner. Adora’s pheromones only seemed to grow stronger over the past few hours they managed to sleep and it was already driving Catra’s mind into a frenzy.

The little smirk of satisfaction fell away, and her instinctive desire with it, when her wandering eyes betrayed her and looked over the long scars across the middle of Adora’s back. They could talk in circles about it, why she refused to heal them like everything

else. Shaking those half answered questions and blurred memories away, Catra finally removed herself from the bed and began rummaging around for clothes. She quickly got dressed while keeping her focus straight ahead. If she saw those scars again, they'd be skipping the meeting and having a long talk. Again.

"Come on. You're the one who didn't want to wait a little longer, fearing Glimmer's wrath".

Catra adjusted the stirrup opening at her foot with a snarky laugh. "I'm not afraid of her. I'm afraid of her grabbing me and teleporting me".

"So… you're afraid of her".

"I am not!"

Catra gave chase when Adora bolted from their bedroom. She considered skipping the meeting and dragging Adora right back to bed to make her take it back. Catra used the wall as a launching pad and slammed into Adora, taking her off her feet. The two rolled into the doorway of the meeting room, both laughing as Catra straddled Adora's hips and pinned her hands next to her head.

"Take it back," She said with a smirk, tail flicking side to side. "I'm not scared of her".

"*Ahem*!"

Catra perked her ears and sat up. Not exactly the room she thought they wound up in. She helped Adora to her feet and decided to at least try to behave for the meeting as she took her seat.

"As we were saying," Glimmer said, staring down the two latecomers, "Thaymor has asked for a little help getting back on their feet. Some of us were so eager to go last week, I hope you still are".

Catra nodded while picking at her unsheathed claws and put a foot on the edge of the table.

"Adora?" Glimmer questioned.

"Well, yeah. I figured I was going by default. She-Ra and all…"

Catra easily caught the touch of bitterness in Adora's voice. Normally she was all for going and doing the heavy lifting. She'd ask about that later.

"Excellent. Entrapta, you're going too. Set up whatever tech they ask for". She smiled at the way her face lit up. "Hordak… my

father has graciously taken you from your duties at Beast Island and requires you to help in Thaymor as well. Seeing as to how not many others have reached out, any and all of us can come and go to help as needed. Except those four of you I mentioned".

"What's our shift?" Hordak asked politely.

"Daylight hours. You specifically have to stay here in Bright Moon, per my father's orders. Everyone else, you can either stay or return to your kingdoms".

"Bossy, bossy, bossy," Catra whispered to herself and retracted her claws.

"Care to speak up?"

"I was just saying it's up to you, boss". Catra cleared her throat. "I mean, your majesty".

"You're all dismissed until morning". Glimmer gave Catra a pointed stare. "Early".

"How early?!" Frosta asked, her arm in the air.

Catra started to tune out the question and answer part of all of this. She had no problem with early and Adora wasn't one to sleep in. Usually. Absentmindedly, she flicked her tail against her girlfriend's leg and returned to picking at her claws.

Catra needed a distraction, not from the meeting, but from Adora. While seated a couple feet apart, she could smell her. Adora didn't exactly have the time to shower away the previous night's activities given their rude awakening. But she knew a shower wasn't going to help the real issue. Catra took in a deep breath in an effort to calm herself, only to realize that only made it worse when a low, quiet rumbling purr started in her chest.

"You can go, Catra. Unless you had a question about what you're supposed to be doing. Also, are you okay?" Glimmer looked around at the empty room, save for herself, Adora, and Catra. "I'm being serious. You've been around long enough that even I know you pick at your claws when you're stressed".

"I'm okay, Sparkles," she said with a true smile. "Really. I just have something on my mind".

"Do you need to talk?" Adora asked, concern becoming apparent across her face.

"I'd prefer much less talk and more… doing, Adora".

“Well, what do you want to do? Hey! We can go to the market! We haven’t been out that way since… about a month after we got home”.

Glimmer and Catra both let out a deep sigh. Sometimes Adora would catch on, other times, it took a little more of a push.

“Not in here,” Glimmer said, shaking her head. “Or the armory. Or the dining hall. Or-“

“I get it!” Catra cut her off. “We’ll see you later”.

Catra stood and grabbed Adora’s hand to lead her back to their bedroom. She meant what she said about after the meeting.

“So, what are we- oh. Oh!”

“And now you figure out what I want to do?” Catra chuckled and pulled her into the room before making sure the door was locked. She flicked an ear before saying, “unless you don’t want to right now”.

“I would like to, yes. But,” Adora rubbed Catra’s lower back when she was pulled into a hug, “what’s with you?”

“You smell *good* ,” she mumbled around a growing purr and buried her face into Adora’s neck.

She couldn’t help but let out a silent laugh. “Are you really sniffing me right now?”

“Is that a problem?”

Adora dug her fingers into Catra’s back when she felt her canines graze the side of her neck. It wasn’t often Catra would get like this, nearly getting intoxicated from she way she supposedly smelled. That’s when another piece might have clicked into place for her.

“Is this,” she’s closed her eyes at the sharp pressure against her neck, “because I didn’t have time to shower?”

“You are such an idiot sometimes, you know,” she whispered. “Do you not know your own body?”

“What are you talking about?”

“You’re ovulating, dummy”.

“O-oh”. A soft moan escaped when Catra lightly nipped her neck again. “I… I sometimes forget you can smell that or whatever”.

“Just the subtle change in your pheromones”. Catra backed Adora into the door and held her wrists above her head. “The past few months I’ve been way too tired from everything to act on this little window of yours like I used to. Now that I’ve settled in a bit more-“

“What are you gonna do? Mark up my neck so everyone knows I’m taken?” She pushed Catra back with her knee slightly. “Last time you marked me up and I forgot to heal it all, Glimmer wouldn’t let either of us live it down”.

Catra raised an eyebrow. “I could do so much more than leave a few hickeys, you know”.

“You should know I d-don’t,” Adora stammered at the sudden burning look in Catra’s eyes while she snapped her teeth together, “want… uh, want anyone else”.

A slow smile came to her face when she felt Adora’s wrists flex under her grip the moment she clicked her teeth together. So she did it again and was able to faintly pick up on the gulp Adora took. Catra pushed her hips into her girlfriend’s and gave a gentle teasing bite to the side of her neck while she briefly struggled against her hold. Really, Adora just wanted to grab the back of her head and hold her in place while she nipped, bit, and sucked at her neck.

“Is that what you want, Adora?” She teased with a purr before giving another soft bite. A roughness made its way into her voice when she continued to ask, “my teeth in you, claiming you as *mine* ?”

Never in any of their sexual encounters had Catra been like this. Rough? On occasion. Letting her instincts take over sometimes? Sure. But nothing to the extent of her current predicament. Of course, those times were still always satisfying and fun. Somehow, the rough possessiveness in her tone now had Adora’s knees growing weak with a warmth between her legs increasing by the second. She knew this wasn’t about to be some kind of slow lovemaking.

Her mind continued to race when Catra’s thigh was pressed between her legs. None of her thoughts were exactly coherent when little nips were being trailed down her neck and felt the grip around her wrists tighten. Adora knew Catra was a word away from losing what little control she had.

“I’m yours,” she finally whispered and felt a smile form against her neck. She cleared her throat and managed to actually find her voice again, “show me what you’ve been too tired to do”.

“Perfect. If it gets to be too much-“

“I’ll tell you. Now, shut up and-“

Adora was cut off with a bruising kiss as her wrists were released. She felt claws digging into her back and involuntarily tensed, ready to deal with the pain. Catra wouldn't severely hurt her again. Not on purpose. She must have retracted her claws just enough to where she wasn't going to tear into her skin, but she still heard the ripping of her shirt.

Catra pulled her from the door and finished tearing the garment and bra from her body before backing Adora to the bed. She pushed her down onto it and made quick work of her own clothing before grabbing the waistband of Adora's pants.

"Please don't claw these off. I like them".

"Fine," she groaned and fumbled with tugging them from her legs. "Are we caring about the underwear too?"

"Not really, no".

"Okay," she said around a smirk, gently dragging her claws down Adora's sides and making quick work of the offending garment before tossing it aside. "Good".

"Don't you dare use those claws *in* me".

“Seriously? I would never do that to you”.

Catra kissed her stomach and trailed lingering kisses up to her neck. Every fiber of her being told her to go down, but she wanted to make sure Adora felt loved on top of the pleasure. She lingered at her neck a little longer, giving soft love bites and taking a deep inhale, taking in more of Adora’s pheromones, before catching her lips in another kiss.

“I love you,” she mumbled against Adora’s lips as her legs wrapped around her waist.

“Holding back already?” She teased.

Adora knew that completely flipped the switch that needed flipped. She heard Catra’s tail whip the bed and felt the fur on the back of her neck bristle while she was gently running her fingers through the fur there. Before Adora’s brain could catch up, Catra’s hand was between their bodies and sinking two fingers into her. A low, pleased growl came from next to her ear and she gasped at the small hook Catra placed with her fingers.

Her thrusts were hard and rough, yet still slow. Each one seemed to be take the breath from Adora’s lungs as she clung to Catra’s shoulders. Adora could barely make out a faint ripping sound from next to her head between her own gasps and Catra’s dominating growls. The last time she could even remember a roughness to this extent was back just before she left the Horde, not that she actually remembered it back then. Adora adjusted her hips slightly under Catra’s body and earned herself another finger.

“Ah, *fuck* ,” she moaned and grabbed a fist full of Catra’s hair.

Another low growl and more ripping next to her head made her tighten her legs around Catra’s hips. The pace picked up and a thumb against her clit joined the mix of pleasure. Adora wasn’t sure if she would even need to reciprocate as the growls stared to get mixed with soft gasps and moans next to her ear. Catra had quickly made a slight adjustment to their position and kept one of Adora’s legs around her hips and straddled the other. She desperately needed some kind of friction for herself or she thought she was going to implode. The sound of just how wet Adora was as she drove her fingers a little faster and harder was making her simply ache. It didn’t take Catra long to find a satisfying pace with her hips, grinding against Adora’s thigh.

“Catra,” Adora barely managed around a moan as her girlfriend nipped at her neck again, “bite me already”.

“What?” She slowed her pace with her hand and looked her in the eyes.

“Fucking *bite* me,” she said again and grabbed her face. “As hard as you want. You… you clearly want it rough. I… kinda do too”.

Catra’s breathing picked up as she returned to the previous pace her hand was going. If only Adora knew what she was getting into by saying that at a time like this. She shifted her weight just enough to grab her girlfriend by the throat.

“What do you want, Adora?” She asked around a growing possessive growl.

“Bite me,” she told her again and pressed the back of her head into the mattress.

“Do you know what that means?”

“I’m yours,” she whispered around a moan.

Catra leaned foreword and rested her forehead against Adora’s after she moved her hand from her throat. She slowly stopped her movements between their bodies. As bad as she wanted this, Adora needed to be absolutely sure about it too.

“If… I do what I want, it means you’re my… mate, Adora. I’ve always loved you, but after everything we went through… are you sure about this? I would like to, but I’m not going to take our relationship to that step if you’re not ready”.

“No one else has to know”. She held her face gently. “What I do know is I have always loved you too. So yes, my love, I’m sure. Now, please, finish me. Be as rough as you want. *Bite me*”.

Catra nodded as Adora was the one to place her hand back around her own throat with a smile. She wanted it. And she did say she wanted it rough. So she obliged and resumed her rough pace with a gentle squeeze to her neck. As much as Adora wanted to keep looking up at her girlfriend, every other hard thrust was making her squeeze her eyes closed in pleasure. She knew Catra was absolutely thrilled with the obscene sounds she was letting past her lips. If Bright Moon didn't know they were together before, Catra was sure they would all know within the next few minutes.

She moved Adora's head to the side and lowered her own to next to her neck. As much as she would have loved for the bite mark to be on display, Adora did say no one else had to know. Instead, Catra placed a row of nips and gentle bites down the side of her neck before resting her lips an inch past the junction of her neck and shoulder, just enough most shirts would cover it. She could feel her getting tighter around her fingers. The bite would definitely throw her well over the edge.

"Catra," she whimpered, " *please* ".

Not needing any more encouragement, she sank her teeth into the flesh where her lips had been. Catra let go of Adora's neck and moved her hand to rest on her cheek. It was the only part of her showing any level of comforting her girlfriend. The rest of her was rough, nearly feral. Instinct took over and she bit harder, finally realizing she broke skin when she tasted blood.

Catra remembered Adora's scream of her name as she finally hit her breaking point. She vaguely remembered a warmth pooling in her hand as she never relented with her fingers roughly reaching

as deep as she could. She barely remembered Adora's nails digging into the back of her neck, holding her in place, with one hand as well as digging into the back of her shoulder with the other. Catra was pretty sure she fell over her own ledge shortly after, her hips jerking against Adora's thigh, still latched on to the flesh between her teeth.

They laid like that until Catra felt fingers running through her hair and she came back to her senses, no longer running on pure instinct alone and coming down from her own orgasm. She heard a quiet groan of pain once she let go of the bite and immediately looked Adora in the face, searching for even the smallest flicker of regret. Instead, she found contentment and love in her expression as her hand ran around the back of her neck to cup her cheek.

"Y-you can heal it if you want," she said quickly and averted her gaze to a point on the pillow next to Adora's head.

"I don't want to. I meant what I said, Catra". Adora rubbed behind her ear. "It wasn't some… brash, horny, in the moment decision. You told me what it meant and… my heart said yes. So I said yes".

Catra started purring at her words and closed her eyes. She opened them again when Adora gently turned her face towards her again.

"I mean it. When did you… figure this out, what it meant?"

“When I, uh, overthrew the Crimson Waste”. She chuckled. “There were a couple of… my kind out there and overheard a few things so I asked a few questions”. She finally removed her fingers from being buried in Adora and flopped down next to her. “You know how great the Horde was at teaching about other species”.

Adora hummed in contentment when Catra put her head on her chest and trailed her fingers up and down her side. “You’ll have to tell me about it one of these days”.

Catra nodded with a yawn. She definitely would someday, even if the things she found out were minimal in teaching her about herself at best. For now, a late morning nap didn’t sound too terrible at the moment.

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“Woah! Hey!”

Catra turned her ear at the commotion and peered over the edge of the roof she was on. As if the rebuild wasn’t enough for everyone to handle, someone just had to go piss off a rhino like creature from the woods. Without much of a second thought, she jumped down and got in front of the beast.

“Go back!” She yelled at it to get its attention.

It stomped its foot and Catra took a step to the side. If she could get it to chase her, she'd lead it back into the woods, climb a tree or two, and get back to the village safely. Easy enough plan.

"That's right. Keep your eyes on me".

"Catra!" Bow yelled as it decided to charge.

"I got it, Arrow Boy!" she yelled back and barely jumped out of the way. "Keep-" she dodged the beasts path again, "-Adora occupied, she doesn't need to fight this thing if we can help it!"

"O-Kay?"

Catra finally got into a clear path to the woods and took off running on all fours. She didn't need to look back to know the beast was on her heels. She saw a low vine, jumped to grab onto it, and pulled herself up just to let go to land on the creature's back. The bucking as it tried to throw her off seemed to disorient it just enough that she felt comfortable leaping off. The beast and Catra locked eyes for a moment. She glanced over her shoulder and took a step backwards.

It dug at the ground and charged at her again. She took off running again with it at her heels. Staying just enough out of reach was getting more difficult. Catra slid around a tree just in time, narrowly avoiding getting clipped with the horn. During the slide, her foot found a root and sent her face down into a mud

puddle. She quickly got to her feet and shook off what she could before climbing the tree next to her to watch the beast stumble off, confused as to where its target went. She sat still in the tree for a moment, wishing she would have brought Melog. They could have made them invisible and the muddy mess wouldn't have happened.

She leapt from tree branch to tree branch before deciding she was at a safe enough distance to climb down and walk back to the village. Catra continued to wipe mud away from her body as much as she could, not paying attention until she ran face first into Adora's back.

"I was wondering where you ran off to," she said when she turned around. "What did you get into?"

"Angry beast". She wiped more mud from her face and shook it from her hand. "No longer a problem. Aren't you supposed to be She-Ra right now?"

"I needed a break," she said and sat on a nearby crate. "I don't think anyone realizes that she's- *I'm* not an unlimited source of energy. More energy than a normal person, sure, but-"

"You're frustrated," Catra pointed out and sat next to her. "Wanna talk about it? You seemed a little… bitter at the meeting we had about this project".

“No,” she said around a sigh. “I mean, I guess I just feel that a lot of people just see She-Ra, Princess of Power, and don’t seem to care about… me. I still get tired and sore. I’m still… me, you know?”

“I know”. She held out her hand and gave a small smile when Adora took it. “You’re still Adora to me. Even if there were times I tried to force myself to see She-Ra as someone else. To… justify my anger or whatever. Now, it doesn’t matter if you’re, like, eight foot tall and glowing or if you’re how you are right now… you’re always my Adora, okay?”

She nodded and squeezed Catra’s hand. In a way, that what she needed to hear. Someone to tell her that She-Ra isn’t a completely separate person, especially since the sword stopped controlling everything years ago. Adora just wished anyone other than her girlfriend would acknowledge it more. Even if Glimmer and Bow knew that as well, sometimes Glimmer would still push a little too hard.

Catra kissed her cheek. “Do I need to beat someone up?”

“No, you don’t. Not this time. I just needed a break from everything. And you,” Adora pulled Catra’s arm from her mouth, “are going to have to bathe when we get back. We both know you’re not going to get all of that out of your fur yourself”.

“Adora,” she complained, “you know the rule”.

“Once a month, maximum, I know. We both know it’s been a little while as it is. Tonight will be that, and I won’t bother you about it again until next month. Deal?”

Catra rolled her eyes and tackled Adora from the crate with a laugh. “Looks like you’re taking a bath too”.

“Get off!” She yelled with a laugh, playfully shoving Catra away. “We gotta get back to work. Queen Glimmer might get suspicious that we ran off to fuck in the woods”.

“Yeah, yeah. Okay, She-Ra. Go back to being really tall and insanely strong. Meet you at the ship at sunset?”

“See you then”.

_____

Catra yawned as she stepped out of Darla following the rest of their work crew. Bow and Perfuma were a nice addition for the day to help speed things along. The people of Thaymor urged them to take a break for a little while for some much needed rest, an offer Catra wasn’t exactly going to refuse. And she hoped Adora wouldn’t refuse it either, considering the way she rubbed her lower back as she walked just in front of her. Bow opened the gate and held it open for everyone as the tired group entered the castle’s grounds. Catra stopped and turned to him.

“Hey, thanks for joining us today”.

“You’re welcome? Really, it’s not that big of a deal. No one else has really asked for help anyhow. Even my dads, oddly enough”.

“Well, get some rest. It was a long day”.

“I’m more worried about you guys! You, Adora, Entrapta, and Hordak have been doing all of that for three days now. You need some sleep”.

“I’ll get right on that,” she said with a small smile and turned to Adora when a hand was placed on her shoulder.

“After you get clean”.

Catra rolled her eyes and scoffed. She knew she needed to. As she decided to take a step forward, back towards the castle, Glimmer appeared directly in front of her, causing her to jump back a step.

“Well, hello to you too, Sparkles”.

“You can tell me why you’re both covered in mud later”. She grabbed an arm on both Adora and Catra. “But you’re not about

to track it through the castle. Especially after Wrong Hordak decided to clean all day".

"Wait, wait! We can climb in through-" Catra shuddered and put her hands on her knees when they were suddenly in their room. "… the window".

Adora rubbed Catra's back gently. Even with warning, she still wasn't exactly fond of the whole teleportation thing as it gave her a few seconds of motion sickness.

"Seriously though," Glimmer said, "get cleaned up. And definitely get some sleep. You guys deserve it. Thaymor sends their thanks and will let us know when they would like more assistance".

Catra gave a thumbs up just before Glimmer teleported out of their room. She looked to Adora when she tossed her soiled shirt into the corner. A smile came to her face as she took a few steps towards her to close the space between them. She tilted her head and traced over the healing bite mark she had left a few days ago. A part of her was still surprised Adora hadn't actually healed it and made it disappear like almost all of her other injuries.

"What?"

"Mrrrp?"

“Oh, that was cute”. Adora held her face gently and gave her a quick kiss. “I told you I don’t want to make it go away. I mean it”.

“You… don’t regret it? At all? It’s not a small thing to be marked like that, you know. At least… it’s a huge deal for my kind”.

“Not even a little bit,” she reassured. “I really do love you, okay? Come on. Let’s get a shower and we can go to bed”.

Catra nodded and watched as she finished getting undressed and walked into the bathroom. Only when she knew for certain Adora wasn’t going to turn back around, she let her happy smile fall away and lowered her ears when she saw her back. If there was any injury Catra wished she would make disappear, it was the long claw mark across her back that she inflicted while under Prime’s control. Subconsciously, she rubbed the back of her neck, running her fingers over the scar.

She shook herself out of it and finally decided to get undressed and tossed her clothes into the corner with Adora’s. Catra could hear the water running and shivered. Getting a shower wasn’t exactly something she was ever fully ready for, but she didn’t want to get dried mud all over the bed. That, and she was definitely due for her monthly deep clean, as she called it. She patted Melog’s snout and opened the bathroom door to see Adora closing the shower curtain behind her.

“Adora”.

“You’ll be fine,” she said and pulled the curtain back slightly to look out. “I made sure it’s not too hot. And I got you something”.

Catra sighed and stepped closer, hugging herself.

“Come here. Please?” Adora held her hand out. “I’ll let you have the corner as long as you need it”.

Catra carefully stepped in and kept herself backed against the wall furthest from the stream. It usually took her a while to talk herself into stepping under the water. She took the shampoo bottle from Adora with a questioning look.

“I found one that won’t strip the natural oils from your fur. I know you said the soap here feels like it drys you out a little last time you managed to deep clean yourself”.

“I also said it doesn’t dry me out nearly as bad as the soap back in the Horde. But thanks,” she said quietly and put her hand under the water. “You know that doesn’t really make this easier, right?”

“I know. But we both know you’re a little overdue anyhow”.

Catra nodded and stepped closer, letting the water finally hit her legs. She knew once she was fully under the water, she would be mostly fine. Getting there was the issue. Unfortunately, Adora was right, she was going on over a month and a half of not having a

good deep clean. With a quiet hiss she stepped in more and hugged herself a little tighter.

Adora tentatively reached out and touched her shoulder. She slowly ran her hand down Catra's arm and grabbed her fingers, gently coaxing her to let go of herself.

"Stop it," she growled and turned away, instantly arching away from the water now hitting her back as her claws dug into the wall. "Give me a second!"

"Hey, it's just me. Relax. Do you want me to wash your back real quick?"

"Touch me right now and I'll kill you". She took a sharp inhale before continuing, "can you warm it up a little more?"

Adora obliged her before rubbing the back of her head. When she realized just how empty the threat had been, she rubbed the back of Catra's neck and felt her muscles slowly relax. She couldn't help but giggle a little when she was being given the bottle of shampoo.

Catra covered her ears as she leaned her head back to get her hair wet before Adora started massaging the soap into it. She didn't quite realize how much the day wore her out until she finally relaxed under the water. Her goal was still to get clean and out as quick as she could but the warmth felt amazing. She

figured part of that was Adora's fingers working out the knots over and down her back.

"Aw, no little purrs?"

"Water, Adora. I'm in water. Not gonna happen".

Adora gave the soap back to Catra and stepped away from the water so she could finish getting clean. Catra continued to wash and rinse herself until the water at her feet was no longer brown from the mud before she switched places with Adora so she could get cleaned up as well. She shook her hair out, much to Adora's displeasure at the spray she got from it, before stepping out of the shower and grabbing a towel.

She toweled herself as dry as best as she could. After a drawn out stretch, Catra wiped the condensation from the mirror and winced at her own reflection. She just looked absolutely exhausted. No wonder Bow and Glimmer urged them to get to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> The important stuff you missed if you skipped the smut: The mating bite happened. Yes, Adora wanted it. Catra learned a little more than the minuscule amount the Horde taught about her species' instincts while in the Crimson Waste.
>
> S: I think weekly posts are going to be Saturdays instead of Mondays as of now. It's just easier since I'll be leaving for vacation next Sunday, so you'll get at least one more. This past almost week was kinda… meh with getting back to work

after the holidays so I still feel like I'm recovering from that. But I did get to actually hang out with Indy again, so that was nice! It was definitely good to see him in person again. If any of you are starting to look a full week of work next week in the face like I am, I hope it doesn't tire you too much. Don't forget to take a little time for yourself. I say this like I do it for myself.

Indy: As stated by my lovely coauthor we are changing posting days. I am starting school Monday…at a new school… yay. It's gonna be like reinventing the wheel, but with more anxiety. I got to hangout with S in person. It was very much needed. I already miss her. Take me with you on vacation 😭. Don't forget to take care of yourselves. You are all fantastic people and I love you all. I am here for anyone who needs to talk.

Reminders Of The Past

Chapter Notes

> Warning for an instance of self-harm at the end of this one. Nothing too bad… yet. But it's there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Adora?"

"Hmmm?" She tried to roll over to face Catra but was pushed back. "Hey!"

"Why do you keep them?" She asked, tracing over the scars she left while under Prime's control.

"I told you it's out of fairness".

"Are we really going to talk circles around this again? You can tell me the truth".

Adora lazily drew patterns in front of her face on the pillow with her finger. Maybe it wasn't the whole truth, but it was all she could bring herself to tell Catra.

"If you really want to. I can't get rid of your scar from the same shitty incident, so I might as well keep mine. You know, they don't

really bother me. I forget they're there most of the time anyhow".

"You're such an idiot". Catra wrapped an arm around her waist and tugged her close before nuzzling the back of her neck. "But you're my idiot. I still want the truth. Keeping them out of sympathy is a halfassed excuse, even for you".

Adora absentmindedly rubbed Catra's forearm. She did have a point.

"Are you keeping them out of spite or something?"

"*What*?!" Adora quickly rolled over in her hold and grabbed her face. "Absolutely not. Listen to me. I'm not keeping them to throw it in your face or whatever you're thinking. It's just…"

"Fair?" Catra questioned and pulled her head free.

"Prime hurt you and made you hurt me. He hurt both of us. I could heal myself and get rid of them at any point, but I can't get rid of yours. And until I can, mine stay. Okay?"

"Fine".

It was always the same conversation when it came to the scars. Adora's voice always held the same distant tone when she would talk about it, like there was far more of a reason that had nothing to do with the chip scar. Catra just wanted to understand why she would hang on to such a painful memory willingly. Instead of continuing to talk in circles again, Catra sat up to get out of bed. Her wrist was quickly grabbed and when she looked over, Adora's face said enough. She didn't even have to voice that she wanted her to stay in bed for a little longer. Catra laid back down with a huff, her back to Adora.

"Don't be like that," she whispered and traced the stripes on her back.

"Why can't you just… give me the real reason?" She mumbled.

Adora stayed quiet. The real reason sounded ridiculous. She shouldn't want to keep them for the memory. Just as she was going to try to say something in an attempt to defend the only thing she seemed to be able to tell Catra, there was a knock on the door.

"Are you two decent?" Glimmer asked from the other side.

"No!" They both called out.

"Of course you're not. Why'd I even ask? Catra, Bow needs your help with something. He wouldn't elaborate".

Catra put her face in her hands and groaned. Truthfully, she wanted to go back to sleep instead. She wanted to retry their morning, without bringing up the damn scars.

"Be there in a few minutes!" She rolled over to face Adora. "You really should try to get some more sleep. Even though we didn't do anything you still look exhausted. You really gotta stop working yourself to death when you're helping rebuild."

"Yeah," she said with a half smile. "I'll try".

She watched Catra get up and get dressed before giving her a quick kiss. After she left the room, Adora grabbed a pillow and held it in her arms. While Catra's nightmares left her rather violent for a few minutes, Adora's could leave her heartbroken for hours. Sometimes she wondered if anything after Prime's ship was even real. That wasn't exactly something she wanted to bring up yet again to Catra either.

They've spent many nights where Adora would wake up with a scream or Catra straddling her while holding her wrists because of her sleep fighting. It was easier to come down from the sleep fights and the occasional typical nightmare. It was never easy to come down from reliving Catra falling from the platform of Prime's throne room, especially when there were several different endings in her mind. She wouldn't wake up screaming from them every time, which somehow felt worse. Adora could rarely bring herself to wake Catra when that happened.

This was one of those mornings.

She had already been awake for hours by the time Catra finally stirred awake. At first, Adora thought she had accidentally woken her with the gentle rubbing of her cheek with her thumb. That worry was quickly washed away with Catra's normal sleepy smile as she slowly blinked awake. Thankfully, she hadn't seemed to notice that Adora had been crying quietly just a couple hours prior.

Adora squeezed the pillow tighter, fighting away the memory of Catra's last breath and her limp body in her arms. She fought the memories of the raw anger and grief that was powerful enough to bring She-Ra back. Again, the tears escaped her eyes with a silent, choked sob. Adora forced herself to remember and hold onto the memory of Catra waking up in her arms and hugging her, clinging to her as if she was the only thing keeping her alive.

"Come on," she muttered to herself while wiping her cheeks dry for what felt like the millionth time over the past few hours. "She's fucking alive, idiot".

Adora finally managed to pull herself from the bed and walked into the bathroom with clothes in her hands. Before she even considered getting clothes on, she washed her face with cold water a few times in hopes she wouldn't look like she had been crying. She didn't want anyone asking questions that she definitely didn't want to give the answers to. The last thing anyone needed to do was worry about her.

As she was getting dressed, Adora saw her back in the mirror and sighed as she reached around to trace over the parts of the scars she could reach. It sounded absolutely insane to want to keep them for the memory. It was one of the worst days of her life and there she stood, keeping the five lines willingly, adamantly. Really, it was for a self reminder. Again, it sounded insane. Adora finally tugged her shirt over her head before she pulled her hair back into a ponytail and decided to leave her room.

As she walked down the hall, she rubbed her face with a groan. Catra just had to ask if she kept the scars just to remind her of what she did. That was the furthest thing from it. She stopped walking and stood in front of the door that led to a usually quiet recreational space. Maybe a little workout would clear her mind if the person she was looking for wasn't in there. Perfuma had said she would be in Bright Moon for a few days.

"Oh, you are in here," Adora said as she opened the door and saw Perfuma sitting crosslegged in the middle of the room. "I'm not interrupting your little meditation thing, am I?"

"Of course not!" She said with a smile, opening her eyes. "Were you looking for me?"

"No!" She looked down. "Maybe". She finally hung her head and closed the door behind her. "Yes".

"Seeking out someone to talk is not a bad thing, Adora. Please, sit with me. In fact, I don't think you've sought me out once since

we've started working through your trauma. This must be something that's really bothering you".

Adora sat down in front of the other princess and hugged her knees. She wasn't particularly fond of their talks, or as Perfuma called it, therapy sessions. And as usual, everything she wanted to say got caught in her throat.

"You know what is said in this room, stays in this room," Perfuma encouraged, flicking her wrist and causing a few plants in the planters next to the door to grow, creating a blockage so the door wouldn't be able to open. "It's just us".

"She brought up the scars again," she said quietly, still not looking at her friend. "I don't know why she won't just accept that I'm keeping them out of fairness".

"Fairness?"

"I can't get rid of the chip scar no matter how hard I try. I still don't know why. So… I keep the scars she gave me during all of that. It's only fair, right?"

"Adora," Perfuma said and scooted closer, "she grew up with you. I'm sure she knows when you're being a little dishonest with her. I've only known you as long as you've known your She-Ra and even I can tell there's dishonesty in those words".

“What?!” She whipped her head around to stare at her. “N-no. That’s… that’s the reason”.

“Let’s try the truth this time. Why don’t you heal them like you have with everything else?”

Adora looked away again, glancing at the door.

“No one can get in. And you know I won’t say anything. You also know you’ll feel better once you say it out loud. It may even give you the courage to tell Catra as well”.

“I almost lost her,” she whispered.

Perfuma touched her forearm gently to let her know she was safe in their little room together.

“Sh-she literally *died* in my arms,” she continued, tears finally spilling from her eyes as she turned back and looked at her own hands. “I… I felt her take her last breath. I didn’t know if I… if She-Ra… could reverse death like that. I took a final shot in the dark, hoping like hell it would work”.

“Let it out,” she said quietly, gently urging her to continue.

“That’s why I keep them, okay?!” Adora wiped at her face furiously, growing irritated she couldn’t stop crying. “I almost lost her. But I didn’t. She’s here, she’s alive, and… and I love her. I keep them to remind myself to never let her go. Ever again. Because if I do… everything will spiral out of control again. And I *just* got her back. I… can’t lose her now”.

Perfuma moved to sit beside her and wrapped an arm around her shoulder with a saddened look. She knew of the things that had happened on Prime’s ship, as well as the events immediately after. It was something she managed to coax out of Adora early in their talks.

“Would you have kept them even if the worst happened?”

All Adora could manage was a nod as a sob shook her shoulders. She always tried to keep that particular ‘what if’ far from her mind.

“To remind you specifically of her, right?”

She nodded again and curled into Perfuma’s comforting embrace.

“You’re okay,” she reassured gently. “And Catra’s alive and well. She loves you too, you know that. I really do think you should tell her. Don’t you think she deserves to know?”

“Yeah, but,” Adora wiped her nose with the back of her hand, “don’t you think she’s going to be pissed I haven’t told her to begin with?”

“No. No, I don’t. From what you’ve said, I feel she’s more hurt that you *still* haven’t told her”.

Adora continued to sit in Perfuma’s comforting hold. She needed just a little more time to calm down before she tried to find Catra. She noticed the vines ease away from the door and sighed quietly before sniffling and wiping her nose with the back of her hand again. She hadn’t had such an emotional visit with Perfuma in a while.

Clearing her throat she turned and gave her friend a true hug before thanking her for the visit and stood. The last she knew, Catra was with Bow doing who knows what. She opened the door, the heels of her hands pressed against her cheekbones just under her eyes and ran face first into Scorpia.

“Woah!” She said and grabbed Adora by the shoulders when she stumbled back. “I’m not interrupting am I?”

“No. We’re, uh, we’re done. All yours”. She shrugged out of Scorpia’s hold and stepped around her.

“Are you sure you’re okay?” Scorpia asked as she walked away.

Adora gave her a thumbs up without stopping or turning around. No, she wasn’t exactly okay, but she didn’t need to know that. Scorpia definitely saw enough, in her opinion, when she literally ran into her. Seeming to not be able to avoid anyone, the next person she crossed paths with was Bow. At least he’d definitely know where Catra was.

“Are you… okay, Adora?” He asked when she stopped in front of him.

“Yeah. I’m great,” she said without a trace of a smile. “Where’s Catra?”

“Oh, she went back to your room. We-“

“I don’t care about what you needed her for right now”. She rubbed her face with a groan at his frown. “That came out terribly wrong. I’m sorry. We can talk later”.

“Are you sure you’re okay?” He asked again and held her shoulders. “You look really, really upset”.

“Bow, please, not right now”. Adora patted one of his hands. “And tell Glimmer to not, and I mean it, bother Catra or me for at least the next hour. I don’t really care what you tell her to make sure it

doesn’t happen, but we’re going to be talking about… something important. I’ll be okay”.

“Uhhhh, yeah. Sure?”

Adora tried to give a reassuring smile, but wasn’t quite sure if it worked as she knew he watched while she walked away. She stopped in front of her and Catra’s bedroom door. Instead of walking right in, she knocked. And it felt absolutely stupid. The time it took Catra to open the door was too short. She felt she didn’t have any time to try to relax and prepare herself more.

“Why are you knocking?” She asked after opening the door. “It’s your room…” she tilted her head and gave Adora a concerned look, “…too. What’s wrong?”

“Nothing,” Adora tried to lie as her girlfriend grabbed her wrist and pulled her into their room, closing the door behind her.

“Nothing?” She repeated as a question. “Adora, you’ve clearly been crying. What’s going on? Hey,” Catra wiped an escaped tear from her face, “you’re freaking me out a little”.

“C-can we talk?”

“Oh…” Catra folded her ears back and looked away as she dropped her hand from Adora’s cheek. “Yeah… we can”.

“Shit,” Adora cussed herself out and grabbed her hand. “No, no. Not like that! It’s… it’s about my back. You wanted to know”.

Catra sighed and gave a small nod. It still wasn’t the conversation she was expecting to have in the middle of the day. At least it wasn’t the worst kind of talk her mind came up with immediately. She was truthfully expecting the same conversation they always had about the topic again.

“You said it was out of some kind of fairness since you can’t get rid of my scar,” she said but still didn’t look at Adora. “I get it”.

“No,” she tearfully whispered. “That’s such an insignificant part of the reason. I keep them… as a reminder to myself”.

Catra finally looked back to her girlfriend to find her hugging herself with tears running down her cheeks. She opened her arms and wrapped them tightly around Adora when she took the invitation. The way she was holding onto Catra made it seem like she was going to disappear if she let go.

“That’s almost dumber than keeping them out of sympathy”. She said quietly as she rubbed her back.

“Listen,” she half laughed around her tears and petted the back of Catra’s head, similar to how she did back on Prime’s ship, “I don’t

want to remember any of that. You died in my arms. You were *gone* . I didn't know if I could bring you back from that, but I took a shot".

Catra nuzzled into the side of Adora's neck. She didn't know what to say. Nothing would ever ease the pain she went through.

"I keep them to remind myself to never let you go again. No matter how bad we fight or what our fights are about, no matter if I have any fleeting thought that I can't do this… because I can. And I love you. I love you so damn much, Cat".

Catra suddenly noticed she was actually holding most of Adora's weight as she cried. She carefully eased both of their bodies to the floor, gently rubbing her back.

"Okay," she said softly and adjusted Adora so she was holding her in her lap. "You're okay. I have you. I promise I'm very much alive".

Adora continued to cling to her, hugging her tighter, even after she got her breathing back under control and wasn't crying as hard. Catra had taken her hair from her ponytail and ran her fingers through her hair. She started a quiet and comforting purr trying to help calm her down.

"Here. Come here". Catra adjusted her again to hold her head to her chest and stopped her purr. "Hear that? I'm alive and I'm

here. And I definitely love you too”.

“Can you purr again? It was helping”.

Without saying a word, she resumed purring while rubbing the side of her face with her thumb. Adora’s cheeks were still a little damp, but she had calmed down considerably. Catra wiped her own cheek with the back of her hand before quickly returning to rubbing Adora’s gently.

Adora opened her eyes and looked up to see Catra’s sad, yet loving look. She reached up and cupped her cheek, brushing a tear from under her eye. It didn’t take her long to realize just how tired she was from the big waves of emotion she had been dealing with for hours.

“Can we lay down?” She asked. “And maybe take a nap for a little bit? I told Bow to make damn sure Glimmer doesn’t bother us for at least an hour”.

“Of course we can”.

“Where’s Melog?”

“I had them go fuck around with the guards,” Catra chuckled and got up with Adora in her arms. “It was a great distraction so I

could get Bow up to the moonstone. And since when are you calling me 'Cat' again?"

"Why the hell- you know what, no. I don't want to know. I mean, I do. But not right now". She waited until Catra laid down behind her to roll over and lay her head on her chest. "Do you not like the nickname anymore?"

"No, I do. It's just been… years". She gently ran her fingers up and down Adora's arm. "You can keep using it if you want".

"I know". Adora slipped her hand under Catra's shirt to rest her hand on her stomach. "Right now, I'm just wanting to fall asleep to your heartbeat".

"Anything you want, princess," she said with a smile and gently rubbed Adora's back.

"Stop calling me that," she lightly complained but snuggled closer. "Nap time".

Catra stopped walking and actually took a step back. She definitely wanted to back out of this particular Best Friend Squad field trip once she realized they were at Bow's dads' place. It just felt like something was going to go horribly wrong. At least for her.

“Come on, Catra!” Bow urged and gently pushed her forward. “My dads aren’t bad people. If they could accept me for fighting with the rebellion, they’ll accept you having a change of heart. It might take a few minutes, but they’re reasonable”.

“They even accepted his best friends are princesses,” Glimmer said with a smile. “It’ll be okay”.

“Guys!” She stepped from in front of Bow and backed away from the door, gesturing to herself. “Ex Horde commander. I opened a portal to destroy Etheria. I also literally helped Hordak conquer nearly all of the kingdoms. I highly doubt they’re going to welcome me with open arms. *Ever* ”.

“Okay, but you changed!” Glimmer yelled, hoping to get through to her. “You helped save the universe from Prime. You saved *me* from Prime”.

“Exactly!” Bow exclaimed and grabbed her arm to tug her inside. “Just give them a few minutes”.

“Get your hand off of me or I’ll bite you,” Catra growled while shoving his hand away.

She begrudgingly followed him and grabbed Adora’s hand for a source of comfort. The feeling of something going very wrong

continued to grow as Bow called out for his dads and saying something about meeting them in the library. Adora squeezed her hand in an attempt to reassure her when she noticed her hair and tail had puffed up.

The reassurance was short lived when Catra's ear twitched and she stopped dead in her tracks just before an arrow flew in front of her face and stuck into a pillar. She shoved Glimmer and Bow away and stood in front of Adora with a low, protective growl when she heard another draw back of a bow. Her tail flicked as she turned her attention to the direction of the sound. Before she had a chance to really focus on the source, Bow stood in front of her.

"Stop!" He shouted. "She's one of us!"

"One of us?! Bow, she's the Horde commander that led so many advancements!" Lance yelled back.

"I left them!" Catra yelled from around Bow. "I'm on your side".

"You keep quiet!"

Catra folded her ears back. She flinched when Adora put her hand on her shoulder and moved to stand beside Bow.

“We’re telling you the truth. Surely you know how the magic came back,” Adora tried reasoning. “Yes, she did some bad things, but she’s one of us now. She’s not a bad person”.

“Of course we know about what happened,” George said and stepped forward. “And it’s still hard to believe. After everything, *she* helped save the universe?”

“Yes!” Adora nearly pleaded. “I doubt we would have been able to without her”.

“Have you forgotten about the portal *she* opened?” George continued.

“Of course not! But-“

“Or all of the First Ones technology she stole to turn the war into the Horde’s favor? How about the destruction of Salineas? Or….”

Catra sat on the floor with her head in her hands. The bickering back and forth between Bow’s dads and her friends and girlfriend started to become a muffled mess to her. The list of things she had done just seemed to grow. She didn’t deserve the three people in front of her defending her.

But when she heard George scream at Adora, “you gave her every chance in the world to join you and the rebellion and she still

chose *them* over *you*," she felt something inside her shatter.

She slowly got to her feet and quietly walked from the library. Again, she could hear the three different voices defending her as the door closed behind her. Catra only managed to get a few feet down the hall before she felt like she couldn't breathe.

She opened the portal. It was her fault Angella was gone. She led the siege on Salineas. It was her fault for so much destruction across Etheria. She didn't deserve the friendship she found in Bow and Glimmer. And she definitely didn't deserve the love Adora had for her. Her mind continued to race and force her to see fleeting flashes of the things she had done, the people she hurt.

Catra fell to her hands and knees in the middle of the hall. She finally realized she was in tears as she watched the droplets falling to the floor as she gasped for air. She further collapsed to her elbows on the floor as she dug her claws into her scalp.

"Don't".

The single word from Glimmer made her flip onto her back, slashing into the air with her claws with a hiss as she rolled. A small part of her wished she had made contact, just to keep her away.

"It's okay!" Glimmer yelled and teleported behind Catra when she weakly lunged at her. "I told them I was going to get you".

“I don’t care! Get the fuck away! You… you heard them! I’m a fucking *monster*”. She fell back to her knees and looked at her hands. “I’m not *good* ”.

“You did some pretty horrible things, Catra. But you’ve *changed* . We know that”. She sat on her knees in front of her and grabbed her wrists when she went to claw the back of her own neck. “Hey. Hey, Catra, listen to me. I’m here”.

“Why?” She hissed and tried to pull her hands free. “Why do you care? I’m the reason your mother is gone!”

“Because you acknowledge the things you’ve done and actually show regret for all of it. We both know sorry doesn’t fix any of it, but you’re trying . We all see that. Come here”. Glimmer pulled her into a hug once she stopped trying to pull her hands free. “They calmed down. I promise. How about I take you to a quiet part of the library where there’s some pretty interesting books?”

Catra swiveled her ears at the sound of Adora stumbling backwards into the hall and looked over to see Bow looking around the edge of the door way. When he saw her looking, he gave a sheepish smile and disappeared back into the library. Adora just gestured to her and Glimmer while staring down who she assumed was Bow.

Glimmer stood first and held out her hand. Catra rolled her eyes and pushed it away before getting to her feet and following her

back into the library. She made a point to not bother looking at either of Bow's dads but still let her ears droop as she pulled Adora to the side.

"Why didn't you tell me to stay?" She asked.

"Because I knew you would. And you clearly needed some space away from all of that".

"So you sent Sparkles after me?"

"Not exactly, no". Adora kissed her forehead. "She teleported before I could really stop her. She said she'd handle it and I think it's safe to say she did".

"Catra!"

"Okay, okay! I'm coming". She gave Adora a quick hug before following Glimmer over to a small nook.

As she looked over the shelves, she raised an eyebrow. All she could find was history. There was history about Etheria, the First Ones, the runestones, all of the kingdoms, and even the magic of the planet. Some of the books were clearly old and possibly outdated.

She grabbed a random one about the Horde. Of course she had learned about the history in their classes, but she was certain what they were taught probably wasn't even accurate. Catra sat at the small table in the center of the nook and opened her chosen book.

"Can't get away from it, can you?" Glimmer asked and sat across from her.

"Whatever we learned probably wasn't even true. They always made it sound like we were the good guys, that all of the princesses were evil. Clearly, that wasn't the case". She skimmed the page she had randomly opened the book to. "But I guess I can't get away from it after all. After everything I did, I-"

"Drop it," Glimmer said quietly and put her hand on the page of Catra's book. "Listen, you can sit there and ignore everyone saying they forgive you, or at minimum recognize you're trying to move on. If there is anyone you should listen to, it's me. You're directly responsible for the reason I'm even queen".

"Yeah". Catra looked away. "I know".

Glimmer reached across the table and grabbed her by the jaw to force her to look at her. "Which is exactly why you need to listen to me when I say I mostly forgive you. I'm not going to lie to you and say it's all completely forgiven, because I don't think it ever will be. That was my *mom*. But… I do mostly forgive you. You had every chance and reason to keep me there on Prime's ship but you didn't. You did that one good thing in your life. And then…

you kept doing good things. You're working on it. That's what matters".

Catra pushed her hand away and hugged herself. The last one who should ever forgive her, even a little, was Glimmer. They shouldn't even be friends. Yet, there she was, getting an earful from one of the people she hurt the most. She dared to look down at the book again and felt a gentle smack to the side of her head.

"Hey!" She snapped and sent Glimmer a glare. "What was that for?"

"Get out of your head! Are you even listening?"

"No".

"You are impossible, you know," she groaned and took Catra's book to replace it with a different one.

"Yeah, I've been told. You're making me learn about…" she picked up the book and raised an eyebrow, "First Ones? Really?"

"Learn about something new for a change. You have all the time in the world. Pick something more interesting than the Horde".

“You are aware I was almost always late to training, right? And I slept through most of our classes. New material isn’t exactly the best”.

Glimmer hung her head, exasperated. “How did you even survive with them?”

“Because Adora liked me,” she said with a laugh. “Shadow Weaver even said she only kept me around because of her. Other than that, your guess is as good as mine, Sparkles”.

“Maybe it’s partly because you’re not a complete idiot. You’re… surprisingly smart”.

“Surprisingly? Ouch”. Catra chuckled. “Regardless, Adora is the main reason I wasn’t ‘disposed of’ at the hands of Shadow Weaver”.

She opened the book and rested her cheek in her hand as she decided to read. Catra figured it was better to do something to keep her mind occupied to pass the time. Adora was upstairs with Lance and George working on translating some documents while Bow was trying to keep the peace by not letting Catra’s name even be brought up. Catra was able to faintly pick up the quiet conversation and whenever her name was mentioned, Bow was quick to ask Adora what something said. Even as faint as the conversation was to her ears, she could somewhat hear the stress in her girlfriend’s voice. The argument earlier clearly set her on edge.

She blinked as the words on the page started blurring together. Reading was never the strongest of her abilities, always making her tired. Slowly, her eyes succumbed to the drowsiness and her head slipped from her hand and landed on the table. Catra quickly sat up and gave Glimmer a sheepish smile at her questioning look.

"You can sleep if you want. I don't know how long we're going to be here".

"Ugh, thank you!"

Catra laid her head in her arms on top of the open book and closed her eyes. It wasn't long until she drifted into a light sleep.

"Hey," Bow said as he came into the nook and lowered his voice when he saw Catra asleep, "Adora said she's going to get through one more scroll and we can go. How long has she been out?"

"About an hour and a half," Glimmer said quietly. "I think it's safe to say she needs it. Are you sure your dads are okay?"

"Honestly, no. They really just seem to be barely tolerating the fact she's here. You know they're not usually like that".

Catra suddenly woke with a growl and fell backwards in her chair before rolling to her side. Bow was quick to make sure she was okay only to get shoved away. He felt his stomach drop as Catra got to her feet and stood over him.

"C-Catra. Hey, uh, it's me. Are you okay?"

"Just leave me alone!"

"I'll go get her," Glimmer sighed. "I think she has a small nightmare again".

"No". Bow got to his feet. "I'll go this time".

Bow sighed and quietly followed Catra up the stairs. The last thing he needed was for her to get involved in a heated argument with his dads. He knew how she could snap if the wrong thing was said. Bow stopped next to the table when she stood behind Adora and waited.

"You guys understand this stuff?" She asked, looking over Adora's shoulder at the scroll filled with lines and shapes that made no sense.

"Only what Adora has been able to teach us. Which, as I'm sure you know, hasn't been a lot with everything that happened," Lance answered.

Catra didn’t entertain his comment as she watched Adora continued to write the translation of the line she was on. She definitely couldn’t make any sense of it until she watched Adora’s hand. It was clearly a scientific scroll going on about the unique flora and fauna of Etheria. Something else she wasn’t exactly interested in.

“Do you have anything other than… books and old scrolls?”

“We have an artifact room, yes,” George said, “But *you* are not permitted in there. You’ve done enough damage and we’re not losing what little we have”.

“You can tie my hands behind my back,” she said sarcastically.

“The answer is final”.

“Fine,” she said around a barely concealed snarl. “What’s the arm say? ‘I’m a fucking asshole’?”

“Catra!” Adora scolded, putting her pen down and held out a scroll in a feeble attempt to defuse the situation. “Here. Help us”.

“I can’t read any of that,” she said and pushed the scroll away.

“The arm doesn’t matter,” George said.

“It says ‘lunch’,” Adora finally said with a smile.

“Oh…” Catra cleared her throat to cover a laugh. “Well at least you have her to make sure of what it says now. In case you want another”.

“I don’t think I asked a Horde soldier for an opinion,” George said and stood.

“Dad!” Bow gave a smile to try to calm the air. “Can we… drop the whole Horde soldier thing? You can’t just blame her. Adora was one too”.

“But Adora didn’t cause so much destruction”.

Catra laughed. She put her hand on Adora’s shoulder and continued to laugh at his comment.

“Really?!” She yelled, barely able to get her laughter under control. “She didn’t cause destruction? You are aware *she* was given Force Captain over me. And then she defected so I took it. She was training to do *everything* I did. We had plans to rule the

Horde togther, for fuck sakes! If she wouldn't have found that fucking sword-"

"Okay!" Adora stopped her. "That's enough".

"The difference, Catra, is that she walked away from that. *You* didn't". George folded his arms. " You caused the destruction. Not her".

"I know I did! I take responsibility for it. I did a ton of really, *really* bad things. After she left, I was so hurt and bitter," Catra dug her claws into her palm, "all I wanted to do was win. To prove myself to Shadow Weaver and Hordak that I was worth *something* without Adora around. Winning sucked . I thought it would be so much different. And when I, when we," she gestured to Adora, Bow, and Glimmer when she came up the stairs at the commotion, "truly won… *that's* what finally felt good. That's what winning was supposed to feel like. So just give me a fucking chance!"

Adora grabbed her thrashing tail, ready to yank her back if she decided to lunge. She hated when she had to resort to the tail pulling, but sometimes it was the only possible way to make sure Catra didn't haul off and commit murder.

"You've been given plenty of chances to turn your life around," George said, glaring at Catra. "You declined every single one of them. Had it been me, you'd have been taken care of *the moment* your portal incident happened. Adora has shown you too much mercy. Really, everyone has".

“You weren’t there, dad!”

“For the millionth time,” Glimmer yelled back, “she saved my life! She even begged Adora to not go back for her!”

“Catra,” Adora said quietly, standing up, “we can go”.

“I told Glimmer to *kill* me at one point!” She screamed back at George. “I *wanted* to die. I realized I ruin everything! Winning with the Horde wasn’t what I wanted. I… I wanted Adora. And I thought I knew I couldn’t even have that so I was better off dead!”

A tense silence fell over the group. Glimmer gently touched Catra’s arm and frowned when she pulled away. She even pulled Adora’s hand from her tail and took a step forward as her claws subconsciously unsheathed.

“So, please, give me a fucking chance. One last chance to *try* to show you I’ve changed since clearly saving the universe didn’t prove a single fucking thing”.

She knew she didn’t deserve any kind of forgiveness from either Lance or George. Everything they said was true. Every memory of every bad thing she had done was at the front of her mind. Every fight with Adora, the portal, becoming Hordak’s second in

command when Shadow Weaver was gone, pushing every last friend away even when it came down to Scorpia, gaining Prime's favor. Catra grit her teeth, just daring them to say something more.

George glanced at her hand before back at her with a hate filled glare. He thought in that moment that she clearly had not changed at all, willing to cause harm in an instant.

"Catra, don't," Adora whispered, shifting her feet to prepare to tackle her if she decided to do something stupid. "Let's just go home. Walk away from this".

"At the end of the day," George said, "we're surprised Adora chose *you* as a partner and lover".

Adora closed her eyes when Glimmer grabbed her wrist the moment her hand balled into a tight fist at the comment. She fought off the transformation that was threatening to happen due to her strong reaction. If it felt like someone kicked her in the gut several times over, she didn't want to know the damage it did to Catra.

"Honestly," she said with a dark, bitter laugh, "me. Fucking. Too".

She suddenly sank her claws into her own leg. Bow grabbed her arm to try to get her to stop. He was quickly pushed away when she turned, a frightening look on her face he had never seen.

“Okay. Hey,” He stepped in front of her, walking backwards as she continued on, “it’s gonna be okay. We can fix this. I’ll clean up the leg or… or Adora can heal it. We-“

“Move!” She yelled and grabbed his shoulders, tossing him to the side, saving him from falling backwards down the stairs. “Maybe I don’t want healed!”

“Shit. Shit! I’ll… fuck…” Adora quickly broke free of Glimmer’s hold and ran after her. “Catra!”

Chapter End Notes

S: So, even with breaking this chapter up in the way I did (trust me, the original cut was much longer) it was still rather long. But that’s to be expected coming from us, I suppose. I know I didn’t get to comments this week before posting this, but I will! Work really took it out of me this week on top of getting around for vacation. With that said, I’ll try to get to any new comments sooner since I’ll have a little more time on my hands for the week.

On another note, I’m considering starting a Patreon for this stuff. Don’t worry, I’ll definitely still be posting on here. If I do decide to go for it, it’ll probably be mostly one-shots or “between the lines” type of stuff. Plus I do enjoy a large majority of interactions with everyone and I’d absolutely love for even more of that. I’ll definitely let you all know when I’m more certain.

Indy: Hello everyone! We have been hard at work, mainly Sokuly, with editing and making this the best we can. We just have so many ideas we want to share with you all. We hope you love this chapter!

On a more personal level I have finished my first week of school hence why I've not been able to comment. I am hoping that school won't be too much for me but it is a completely different school than the one I had been previously going to. I hope to continue to be able to supply good ideas but I may potentially have to take a backseat, only working as a consultant for all the stuff I've worked on. For now I am still coauthor and will be working to deliver quality content alongside Sokuly.

Here We Go Again

Chapter Notes

> Warning for self-harm stuff and some mild suicidal tones closer to the beginning. Also some mild PTSD moments around half-ish way through.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra slammed the front door closed behind her, knowing full well Adora probably ran right into it. Anything to slow her down. Next was Glimmer appearing directly in front of her, another obstacle she quickly pushed to the side. Catra now had new claw marks across her chest as she walked, thankfully not nearly as deep as her leg. Yet.

"Catra, wait!" Bow yelled as Adora ran by him while wiping her bloody nose.

Adora full body tackled her before she even stepped foot onto Darla's ramp. Catra growled and pushed Adora off of her before quickly scrambling to her feet. As if expecting her next move, Adora grabbed her ankle before she could make a run for it again. She yanked her back down and managed to pin one of her hands down. The other was cocked back, fist ready. Adora was ready for the swing. When she easily caught her wrist, she realized just how weak the punch would have been.

For the moment, she had Catra subdued. Her breathing was heavy and shakey. At least she stopped fighting for a moment. Within the anger showing through her eyes, there was a deep hurt. Adora could nearly see the tears in her eyes. Not that Catra

was going to let them fall yet. In a moment of strength, Catra fought harder against Adora's hold. She wanted to lock herself in one of the rooms, hide away so she couldn't hurt anyone but herself.

"Stop!" She yelled at her. "Knock it off. Look at me!"

"I want to go home, Adora!" She yelled back and suddenly used her legs to flip their positions. "And I want *you* to leave me the fuck alone".

Adora narrowed her eyes and gave chase up the ramp and through the ship. She could hear the underlying tone of Catra's voice, not truly wanting to be left alone. The last time she could remember her acting like this was shortly after the chip was removed, plagued with regret and even voicing she was better off dead as she cried in her arms late one night on the ship. Adora had healed every scratch that night and would do the same this time.

That is, if she could gain enough ground to at least dive and grab Catra's ankle or, at worst, the end of her tail. With her running on all fours, gaining on her was nearly impossible. Adora knew her girlfriend still wasn't going as fast as she could. Once she even had a chance to even attempt to grab anything she could, Catra made a hard left into one of the rooms and closed the door in her face. Adora heard the lock engage and punched the door.

"Let me in, Catra!" She yelled around breathing heavily from the chase.

“What part of leave me alone do you not understand?!” She yelled back from inside, her voice laced with tears she couldn’t hold back any longer. “Go away!”

Adora punched the door again. She had half a mind to turn into She-Ra and rip the door open. That would be a last resort. If she did that now, it would make things worse. She would break the door if anything in that room fell absolutely silent.

“I’m not losing you again!” She quickly wiped the tear from her cheek. “Please, Catra, I know you can talk through this. You have before”.

She took a startled step back when there was a hit from the other side. Followed by another. And another. Adora had seen her cut through solid steel with her claws before and was almost expecting that, yet also knew she wouldn’t. Not if she was making a point to keep her out.

“I can go in,” Glimmer said quietly, putting a hand on Adora’s back.

“No!” She cleared her throat and wiped her face again, wincing at the sudden crash from inside. “You don’t want to do that right now. Trust me”.

“So it’s safe for you to go in?”

“No. It’s not. But I can restrain her a little better as She-Ra if I have to”. Adora rested her forehead on the door. “She’s gotten like this several times in the past. Both while we were in the Horde and then the whole being chipped thing. I can handle it. If she would let me in”.

“I could override the locks, I think. But I’m pretty sure I’d need administrator access”.

“Yeah, alright. Give me a few minutes. Have Bow watch the schematics. Once it shows the door unlocked, we can take off. If not, I’ll be on the bridge soon”.

Glimmer nodded sadly and patted her back. Once she teleported away, Adora hit the door again. And again when she was met with silence.

“You have ten seconds to make some kind of sound or I’m breaking the the door! One!” She waited. “Two!” She wiped a tear from her face again. “Three!”

“Just leave, Adora,” came the almost too quiet to hear reply.

“I can override any and all locks to this ship. I’m not joking around this time, Catra. Let me in”. She closed her eyes and used

a special series of knocks from the Horde days she only ever used for Catra. “Please”.

She waited. And waited. When she went to head to the bridge to override the lock, she finally received an old, yet familiar, reply knock just before she heard the lock disengage. Adora opened the door and locked it when it closed behind her.

She stood quietly and looked around the room. Her eyes went from the broken lamp on the floor to the blood smears and deep claw marks on one of the walls. She noticed the several blood drops on the floor and tried to prepare herself for what she was going to see. Adora walked over to Catra who was sitting in the corner, head on her knees, sobbing as quietly as she could. Adora crouched in front of her and gently tried to get her to uncurl herself. When there was too much resistance, she opted to kiss the top of her head and rub one of her ears gently.

“Can I look?” She asked quietly. “I know you did far more than just the back of your neck, leg, and shoulders. I need to know what I’m working with”.

“I don’t want healed,” Catra said around her tears and tried to curl into herself further.

“And what if you’re slowly bleeding out from them?”

“ *Good* ”.

“No. Not good”.

Adora gently pulled her away from the wall and sat behind her. Hearing that one word answer to her question made her heart sink. She absolutely hated it when Catra was hurting so bad she wanted to die. Again. It had been several months since it happened.

“I do love you, Catra,” she finally spoke again “And like you said, I always have”.

Catra tensed as Adora wrapped her arms around when the ship lurched on takeoff. She let Adora unwrap her arms from around her legs slowly. The sadness in her voice made Catra’s stomach turn that much more. She felt she didn’t deserve the love. If anything, Adora should leave her in the room, alone and bleeding.

“Oh, Cat,” she whispered sadly as she looked at the claw marks over her wrists and blood covered hands. “Come here. Let me see the rest”.

She leaned back into Adora’s body, silent tears still running down her face. Catra knew she was taking inventory of the marks across her throat and chest, over her thighs and abdomen on top of the ones over the back of her neck and through her hair, some far deeper than others. Catra hated how gentle she was being. Or at least she wanted to.

Adora didn’t care that someone was bound to ask why she had blood on her when they returned to Bright Moon. All that mattered was trying to make sure Catra would be okay. Thankfully nothing was going to be fatal.

“Can I heal you? Please?”

“No. At least not yet. Can it wait?”

“Only until we get back to Bright Moon. Once we land, you don’t get a say”.

Catra nodded and hugged her knees close again. She closed her eyes when Adora started rubbing her back gently.

“You can stay in here while I get you clean clothes, okay?”

She nodded again.

“We’ll be back in a couple minutes,” Glimmer informed from the other side of the door.

Adora nodded as if her friend could see her. She continued rubbing Catra's back, careful of the ends of a few of the claw marks. Slowly and gently, she pulled her girlfriend's shirt up and over her head. As the garment was peeled away from her body, a few of the scratches were ripped back open from where it clung to the drying blood. Catra turned to her side and curled herself into her girlfriend's arms as a hand was pressed against one of the wounds that had started bleeding again.

"You really love me?" She asked, her voice barely audible. "After everything I did? Adora, you're such an idiot if you say yes".

"I didn't want you to bite me just because," she whispered and kissed the top of her head. "So maybe I'm an idiot according to you. I promise I really, truly, do love you. You know I always have too".

"Me too," Catra whispered back. "At least you're my idiot. And I wouldn't want it any other way".

Adora picked her up and sat her on the desk in the room after she felt the ship land. Holding her face she kissed her before stepping back and turned into She-Ra. She figured she would need the extra power of the warrior for the number of scratches littering Catra's body.

"No choice?" Catra asked.

“No choice. We’re home and you didn’t say so before we landed”.

“Fine,” she mumbled and opened her arms.

Adora stepped in between her legs and pulled her close. She felt Catra slowly relax as she healed her wounds. After transforming back, she held her a little longer, rubbing her back and simply running her fingers through her fur. The visit with Bow’s dads definitely did not go as planned. Some of the things they said even burned Adora. But they were home now and could have dinner before calling it an early night.

_____

“Hey there, arrow boy,” Catra greeted and pulled herself up to the tree limb Bow was sitting on. “Why the down and out look?”

“My dads won’t speak to me. It’s been over two weeks”.

She sighed and picked at the bark.

“It’s not your fault. I chose my friends over them. And honestly, I’d do it again if we could redo it”.

“I wouldn’t let you. I would have raised Darla’s ramp and figured out how to leave you there”.

“Wow,” he sighed, “that makes me feel so much better”.

“Really, though,” she insisted. “They’re your family. I know I sure as fuck wouldn’t have chosen me over them”.

Bow cracked a half smile and handed her his tracker pad. She looked at it and raised her eyebrow and the cluster of flashing dots. A slow smile came to her face when he elbowed her arm.

“Wanna go check it out?” They asked each other at the same time.

“Shouldn’t we tell the others?” He asked, a little nervous. “The more the merrier?”

“Ahhhh, no. After my little… incident, Adora barely leaves me alone”. Catra picked a leaf from the branch above her head. “I say we keep it the two of us”.

“How are you doing from that? I didn’t want to bring it up, but you did so…”

Catra shrugged. “It’ll continue to ease up and I won’t be so upset soon enough. Adora has, unfortunately, dealt with all of this

before. So the whole not leaving me alone thing is pretty normal in this situation. Give it a couple more days".

She looked over the tracker pad again and scrolled around until she found their location. It wasn't a terribly far walk, maybe fifteen minutes. Catra gave the device back with a toothy smile. She was curious and it seemed Bow needed the company. A nice hike to find something that hadn't been there before would keep him occupied.

Catra jumped down from the branch and waited as Bow clumsily climbed down the tree. She took one last look over her shoulder and smirked when Adora seemed to still not realize she wasn't on the castle grounds and about to wander off into the woods. If anything, she wasn't technically alone. Bow started to lead the way to their target as she followed close. The Whispering Woods wasn't exactly her favorite place to be, having gotten lost more than once.

"Since no one really explained it, when are we actually out of Bright Moon?" Catra asked.

"We all kinda agreed that it's the edge of the woods. Though, the technical limit is about a mile into the woods. At least the way we're going". Bow shrugged. "Then there's the unincorporated areas that are still technically Bright Moon. Like where my dads are. We don't have a lot of problems with the villages, so there's some overlap. How about the Fright Zone?"

She let out a half laugh. “Our property ended at the Whispering Woods. There was no other technicality. Just an abrupt end”.

Bow simply nodded in acknowledgment. The two continued to walk deeper into the woods. It was an almost comfortable quiet between them, even if Bow definitely wanted to talk more. He had gotten to know Catra better over the past few months, but she was still guarding herself around almost everyone. It was a rare occurrence she would let anyone see her practiced mask fall away to see how she was actually feeling when Melog wasn’t giving her away. Sometimes Bow thought that only happened when things became too much for her.

“What was the Horde like?” Bow suddenly asked. “I mean, not with Prime but before. When Adora was still there”.

“Nothing special,” she dismissed. “A lot of Shadow Weaver manipulating us, Hordak being… Hordak”. She gave a small smile when a few better memories came to mind. “Adora and I causing trouble. There were times we’d sneak out of the barracks after curfew to go to our spot and stare into the empty night sky and talk about… whatever. Our little squad would make fun of Kyle or we’d all play pranks on each other”.

“You blamed him for everything!”

“Well, yeah,” she laughed. “It’s Kyle!”

“He seemed pretty nice, for the record,” Bow said and stepped over a large root sticking up from the ground.

“That was the problem! He was too nice for the Horde. It, unfortunately for him, made it so easy to blame him for everything. And it wasn’t just me. Adora did it too”. Catra clawed some vines out of their path. “There was a time where she broke her stupid little ‘miss perfect’ attitude and told Shadow Weaver off. That was a pretty funny day. She didn’t know what to do when Adora mouthed off like that. Of course, she only got a very stern verbal warning. She never did it again”.

Bow genuinely laughed. “She must have learned that from you”.

“Most definitely”.

They stopped for a moment to check the tracker pad to make sure they were still on course. Bow motioned her along and slowly grew suspicious of Catra’s silence. While there were moments of quiet between talking to each other, she was mostly keeping up. Now, she had fallen back several paces. He glanced over his shoulder to see her looking rather distant.

“Are you okay? We don’t have to talk about the past like that anymore”.

“No, it’s alright. I’m okay. There’s just… memories. Things I, uh, forgot about”.

Bow climbed down a small ledge of rocks and waited for Catra to join him. “Do you want to discuss it? Maybe it’ll make sense”.

“It already makes sense!” she bit after she got to the bottom of the small ledge. “Sorry… listen, I haven’t told anyone this, but… Shadow Weaver could wipe our minds when certain things happened and she didn’t want us to remember”.

“I know. Adora told us all about that. I mean, Glimmer practically witnessed it. I’m really sorry that happened to you guys”. Bow stopped and looked at the pad in his hands again. “I don’t think I’d know what to do if I was missing whole chunks of my memories”.

Catra sighed softly. “That’s the thing… when she sacrificed herself, those spells died with her. I… we remember everything now. And I mean everything”.

“Hey! That’s good!” He turned and smiled, only to have it fall away when he saw Catra rubbing her arm. “That is good… right?”

“Adora and I had a relationship before”.

“What?! Are you serious?!”

“Shhh! Keep it down”. Catra looked around for a moment and took the tracker pad. They still had quite a bit of walking. “Yeah. I’m serious. Relationships were… more or less forbidden in the Horde. Friendships were fine, something about being able to work together better. But love? Love clouded your judgement. Love could get you killed. And… we got caught one day”.

“Oh…” Bow nodded and motioned her along. “Shadow Weaver got rid of that”.

“Yeah. Actually, she wiped us more than once. The last one having a much stronger effect. It lasted. Really, I think it’s because Adora left not too long after that. We didn’t have time to find each other again. We were, obviously, still really close and cared about each other a lot . But we were just best friends”. She laughed quietly. “We didn’t know what love was anymore”.

“That explains why when you guys had every chance to kill each other, you never did. I mean, what kind of enemies do that?!”

Catra only chuckled. Looking back, it made all the sense in the world. Once Shadow Weaver was gone, their memories came back. It wasn’t all at once, but rather in small parts as they walked to the Heart of Etheria. When she told Adora she had always loved her, she truly meant it. And when she said she loved her too, Catra realized Adora remembered as well.

Even in the days and weeks that followed, more and more of the memories came back. The good and the bad. Catra hadn’t told anyone but Adora about any of this. It felt odd, but relieving. The

only thing she would keep completely to herself is how she held even more regret for her actions than she let on. If she would have known anything, even a sliver of her memory, she felt like she likely would have left with Adora and fought along side her and the rebellion.

Things could have been so much different.

She quietly wiped the tears away before Bow could notice when he turned back around and motioned for her to be quiet. Catra crouched and moved a little closer to peer around a bush. Her ears flattened back as she took a step back when she saw a small group of clones. Bow took a look for himself and grabbed his bow with a couple arrows from his back.

"What do you want to do?" He whispered.

"I don't know. They look… confused. If they're anything like Wrong Hordak, we'll have to figure out what to do with them. And if they're hostile… we fight two on five".

"You want *me* to make a decision?"

"That would be preferable, yes. Considering I would personally like to run out there and kill them all".

Bow sighed and held out his hand. “If things go bad, you have my back, right?”

“Promise,” she said and grabbed his hand. “As if I’d simply let Sparkles lose you”.

“And you think I’d go back to Adora empty handed? She would literally kill me”.

Catra smiled and shook his hand. They were in this together. They gave each other a chance to fall back and pretend this never happened and neither took it. Catra was ready to fight or capture them and Bow just wanted to see if there were still hostile clones roaming Etheria.

They both stood and continued to approach. When the group of five turned, two pointed their arm cannons at them. Catra immediately unsheathed her claws and prepared herself.

“We have few rations of amniotic fluid left,” one said with his hands up in front of him. “Excuse the defensive measures, we’re simply protecting what little we have”.

“So, you don’t want to kill us?” Bow asked, a little shocked.

“No! You do have our beloved little sister with you, do you not?”

With that, Catra snapped. Her vision went hazy and she charged forward.

“Catra! Wait!”

Bow was too late to stop her from pouncing on the poor clone. She had a fist full of the front of his clothes while her other hand drew claw marks directly beside his head into the ground. The only thing that stopped her from ripping his face open was Bow calling out to her. Even with Prime long gone, they still had enough of their own memories to know who she was for such a short time. A short time she wished could be erased forever.

Catra knew the arm cannons were trained on her as she drew her arm back again. She wanted to hear them preparing to blast her so she could jump away at the last moment and watch as they took one of their own. And then she would take care of the rest herself. She was enraged enough it wouldn’t take long.

“Little sister-“

“Stop calling me that!” She snarled and began to bring her hand down when she was suddenly wrapped in a net. “What the fuck, Bow?!”

“I’m sorry! You need to… take a second and breathe. I don’t think they mean us harm”. Bow politely turned to the group as the clone got back to his feet. “If you guys could definitely not call her that, it would be appreciated. And you might stay alive”.

“Then what shall she be called?” Another clone asked.

“Catra. If you value your life, like I value mine, call her that”.

“Very well”.

“Get me out of this!” Catra yelled and continued to try to wiggle herself free.

“Not until you calm down”. He picked her up from the ground so she was on her feet. “We’re taking them back”.

Catra gave a small hiss in response and slowly walked behind the group for the journey back. Bow wouldn’t stop talking to the clones, much to her annoyance. She tried to ignore the memories of her time on Prime’s ship. When that didn’t work, she focused on the period of time both her and Glimmer were there. She truly believed the one thing that kept her somewhat sane was the small conversations they would have.

It all worked until she was faced with the small rocky ledge. Finally Bow helped her from the net so she could climb. Being the

one to willingly be behind the group, she was the last one up. When two of the clones grabbed her arms to help her up, she froze. Catra could feel the ghost of pain from the electrocution she had to endure coursing through her body.

She lashed out, dragging her claws across the face of the nearest close. Unfortunately to her, her claws weren't fully out and only left the clone with minor cuts. Two others quickly grabbed her and held her arms behind her back as she struggled against them. Bow turned looked to Catra and saw the panic in her eyes. He only helped her through these moments a handful of times. He didn't exactly feel like being bitten or mauled if she broke free of the clones restraining her. He quickly stood in front of her and grabbed her face, keeping his hands away from her mouth.

"Hey, look at me," he said gently. "These guys aren't going to hurt you. They're like Wrong Hordak".

"Make them let go!" She pleaded. "Please, Bow. I can't do that again".

"Hey. Hey, hey, hey. Keep looking at me," Bow continued in a calm voice. "You're safe now. Prime is gone. None of that will ever happen again. Breathe".

"Tell them to let go," she said quieter. "It's making it worse".

Bow nodded to the clones and caught her when she fell forward.

"Claws," he whimpered as she dug into his back. "Catra, claws".

He rubbed her back as she shook. Her claws remained firm. Bow looked at the clones looking between each other in confusion. They clearly had no idea what was going on, much like Wrong Hordak in the beginning. Their own bumbling clone ended up figuring out a few things the hard way a couple times.

Catra eventually let go and rubbed her face. "Better than being upset about your dads yet?"

"Uhhhh, I don't know about that. It's a distraction, sure, but I don't exactly like seeing you freak out like that."

Catra nodded and waited until everyone was back in front of her. She made a conscious move to rub the back of her neck just to make sure the chip was truly gone. She really needed calm down before she even caught sight of Adora. Answering a million questions about her emotional state wasn't something else she needed. There would already be plenty about why they have five clones with them and where they even found them.

The group made it to the castle grounds and quietly snuck back in. At least Catra snuck back in. She technically wasn't supposed to be out without Glimmer or Adora knowing for now. Glimmer's orders. The only thing that definitely blew her cover was Frosta.

“Clones!” She yelled and punched one with an ice first. “Five of them!”

“Shhh!” Catra grabbed her and put a hand over her mouth. “Shut it, kid. Ow! Don’t bite me!”

“I’m not a child! I rule my own kingdom!”

“Uhhh, hi, guys,” Catra said and put Frosta down before waving to Glimmer, Adora, Scorpia, and Wrong Hordak as they came running from the castle.

“You,” Glimmer said sternly and pointed at Catra, “meeting room. Now!”

“Sorry,” Bow whispered as she lowered her ears and walked up to the castle.

Catra tried to give Adora a smile as she touched her hand while she walked by. The look on her face spelled worry. She was definitely going to be asked plenty.

“And you,” she pointed at Bow, “why did you bring clones back?”

“They’re like him!” He defended and motioned to Wrong Hordak.

“There’s more?” Wrong Hordak asked and approached. “My brothers!”

Adora rubbed her temples with a groan. “I thought we were done with this! Helping villages is one thing, but clones again? Really?”

“I’ll go deal with Catra,” Scorpia volunteered. “Unless, uh, one of you want to”.

“You can go,” Glimmer said. “We have our hands full with… this situation. Can you get my dad on your way?”

“No problem, boss!”

Scorpia walked away from the group and into the castle. She greeted Melog as they trotted past her and got a meow in return. Her first order of business was to find Micah. Then she needed to find where Catra ran off to if she ended up not being in the meeting room. Which would have been a very Catra like move. She wandered the halls for a moment before she heard Micah speaking to someone. Scorpia followed the voice until she ended up in the meeting room to see Micah talking to Catra.

“Ah, Scorpia,” Micah greeted. “I’m going to guess you’re here for her and not me”.

“Actually, I’m here for both of you. This is rather convenient. Okay, um, sir, your majesty, Queen Glimmer needs you outside in front of the castle”.

“Is she okay?” He asked, concerned, as he hurried towards the doorway.

“Oh, she’s fine. Somebody,” she looked at Catra who hung her head, “brought clones home with Bow”.

“Ah, I see. Thank you”.

Scorpia waited until he left and took her seat next to Catra. She gave Melog a gentle pat on the top of his head before looking at her friend.

“Catra-“

“Save it,” she grumbled. “I’m in enough shit with Sparkles and Adora as it is”.

“Well, for the record, they didn’t exactly know you were nowhere on the grounds until about fifteen minutes ago. How long were you gone?”

“A about forty five minutes. Maybe a little longer”. She played with the tip of her tail. “How mad are they?”

“They’re not mad. Just… worried”.

Catra nodded and petted Melog’s snout as his color shifted ever so slightly darker. She overall felt better than she did a week ago. There was no need for essentially being grounded. At least that was her feelings on it.

“Oooo. Something happened out there,” Scorpia said pointing a pincer at Melog. “Tell me”.

“It’s nothing”. She glared at Melog when they meowed a few times. “Knock it off”.

“Come on, Catra! It’s me or Adora. And we both know she’s already going to give you an earful. Plus if she sees them, she’s not going to shut up”.

A few more meows came from Melog as they put their paws on her chest to lick her face. Catra tried pushing them away with a growl of complaint. Her efforts failed as her magical cat bumped their head against her jaw with more meows.

“Fine!” She finally wrapped her arms around Melog’s neck and petted along their spine with one hand. “I had flashbacks again”.

“About?” Scorpia urged.

Catra wrinkled her nose at her friend. “Man, Perfuma really got to you. I think she’s rubbing off. Stop it”.

“I’ve learned some things, yes. Besides, she thinks you’ll have an easier time talking to me since I’ve known you longer and all”.

She rolled her eyes with a scoff.

“I’ll get the blanket”.

“Don’t you dare,” she growled while Melog’s mane and tail slowly started to turn orange with her irritation.

“Then talk,” Scorpia said with a smile.

“The… electrocution pool,” Catra finally said quietly while petting Melog. “It hurt so much. Worse than anything Shadow Weaver had done. I would take Hordak suffocating me a hundred times over that. And the clones holding me in when I tried to get out…”

“Weren’t you already chipped?” Scorpia asked, leaning forward.

“I was. But he kept me in my own senses for everything, taking control once it was over”.

Scorpia frowned when Catra pulled her knees to her chest in the chair and wrapped her tail around her ankles. She knew the whole thing was extremely traumatic. She even helped with Catra, and in some cases Adora, the first week after the Heart. Never had she seen either woman so broken and scared than in those moments. Some were nightmare driven, others were caused by some kind of trigger to send them into a panic attack.

“Alright,” Adora said as she walked in and sat on the table in front of Catra, “where did you go?”

“I went for a walk and then ran into Bow,” she explained. “He showed me something on the tracker pad and we decided to go check it out. I wasn’t alone!”

“Catra,” Adora groaned and pinched the bridge of her nose. “You could have said something. I don’t know, called someone with the pad? Are you sure you’re okay?”

“Yeah”. She saw Scorpia fold her arms out of the corner of her eye. “Mostly. I don’t need babysat if that’s what you’re asking”.

“You scratched one of them! They weren’t hostile from what Bow said”. Her expression softened before asking, “What happened, love?”

“I’m just… gonna, um, go,” Scorpia said and saw herself out.

“They called me little sister,” Carta said quietly. “It brought back some… stuff”.

Adora stayed quiet and got off of the table to pull Catra to her feet. She gave her a hug and rubbed her back. Hearing the monicker always set Catra off. Sometimes even Wrong Hordak would use his typical greeting of ‘brothers’ and she’d fight herself to not jump him. Though, she was definitely getting better with the bumbling clone.

Unfortunately these newcomers used an even worse name for her. Adora just hoped it wouldn’t happen again. Either that or they relocated the group elsewhere before they even had the chance. The last she heard before stepping away to find Catra was that Glimmer was trying to relocate them to Dryl. They’d be safe there.

Adora held Catra by the shoulders and gave her a smile. While a little shaken, she seemed otherwise okay. And Adora had an idea to make her feel better.

“I’ll race you to the top of the spire”.

“What?” Catra raised an eyebrow. “You know I’ll win. You’re terrible at climbing”.

“She-Ra to make it fair then”.

“Oh, you’re on, princess ”.

Chapter End Notes

S: I figured I’d give you guys another chapter this week since I have more time on my hands. You’ll still get one on Saturday too. It definitely is nice to be on vacation and away from the cold hellscape that is Ohio. My wife and I seemed to have picked a really good time to go 6 ish months ago. Oh, and the angst is going to get worse before it gets better.

Indy: I’m in class right now as I write this little author note. I’m jealous of Sokuly as I’m freezing my ass off. Stay warm and enjoy

Old Vices

Chapter Notes

> Warning for more self-harm in this chapter. Read with caution, it's brought up quite a bit.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra snuggled further into the blankets around her body before adjusting the tablet to in front of her face and smiled. Normally she'd be snappy for the crime of waking her, but this particular wake up call was welcomed.

"Can you still see me?" She asked sleepily.

"Yes," Adora laughed. "I can still see you. I didn't mean to wake you up".

"I wouldn't have answered for anyone else, dummy. You know I sleep with this thing on your pillow". She yawned. "When are you gonna be home?"

"Hopefully tomorrow". She gave a soft smile at Catra's small frown. "Oh, don't pout. You could have joined us".

"You know why I couldn't. If I remember right, you're the one who told me I couldn't kill every single clone on sight," Catra teased, rolling her eyes.

“And you told me you didn’t want to blindly lash out at another one that wasn’t hostile. Which is good for you, Catra. I’m proud of you”.

“Stop being gross. Does the Crimson Waste miss me yet?” She tucked the blanket under her chin. “Or did Huntara take my place?”

“Is that Catra?” Glimmer asked and entered the picture before giving a laugh at the tufts of hair sticking up from the top of her head. “Good morning, sleepyhead. Nice hair”.

“Hey! I’m talking to my girlfriend!” Adora shouted as Glimmer took the pad from her. “Give that back!”

“Oh, you’ll see her tomorrow. And I’ll give you all the space you need for the next week so you can have sex all you want”.

Catra rolled her eyes with a smile.

“Glimmer!”

“We won’t bother you either,” Catra said. “I’m sure Bow will be taking all of your free time too. Just *please* make sure you guys use protection. I’m not ready for a mini you running around”.

She could hear Adora laughing somewhere in the background.

"Catra! Adora, that's not funny! Guys! I hate you both".

Catra closed her eyes with a smile as she listened to the two picking on each other as Adora begged for the pad back while threatening She-Ra. A low purr rumbled in her chest when her girlfriend finally managed to get her hands back on the pad with a triumphant laugh.

"I'm only letting you win because I know you miss her!" Glimmer yelled from somewhere out of view.

"Did you fall back to sleep?" Adora asked.

"No," she answered and opened her eyes. "Just listening to you two have fun when you should be working on finding the clones Huntara was bitching about".

"To answer your question, they only sorta miss you. Huntara did take your spot, though".

"That bitch," she joked. "Tell her I expect to have my spot back whenever I visit".

“Yeah, I’ll get right on that”. Adora smiled when she saw the tip of a claw poke into view. “Are you really trying to touch me through this thing?”

“What?” Catra scoffed with a smile. “I miss you. You can’t tell me you haven’t done it”.

“Guilty. I miss you too. Hey, I’ll call you before bed, okay?”

“Alright. Stay safe out there. No quicksand incidents, please. I love you”.

“No quicksand,” she promised. “I love you too”.

Catra sighed and tossed the pad back to Adora’s pillow when the video call ended. Everything she said was true. She opted to sit this mission out, afraid she’d lash out at any clone, hostile or not. The group of five they found had been sent to Dryl without much further incident, much to Entrapta’s excitement.

Two weeks later, Adora went out to the Crimson Waste with Glimmer when Huntara contacted them about seeing clones. She wanted the queen’s input on how they were to handle it. It was supposed to be a two day excursion, but plans always seem to change when it comes to the best friend squad and they were on a third day. At least they’d be home first thing in the morning.

The first day Adora was gone wasn't so bad. Her and Bow wandered around a large market for a few hours followed by him teaching her archery. She wasn't necessarily terrible at it, but she hated the way the string caught the fur on her forearm on one of the shots. She promptly threw the weapon on the ground before threatening to cut the sting. Bow begged her not to. That evening, she had joined Bow on his balcony. They talked for a few hours about the past and even their future hopes.

"So, you really wanna marry Sparkles?"

"I mean, yeah. Don't you want to marry Adora?"

Catra thanked the stars the weather had grown colder and her fur was a little thicker. It mostly hid the blush that came to her cheeks at the question. He didn't know about the bite or what it meant. She took a careful sip of the hot milk Bow made for her.

"Aw, don't get shy". He chuckled. "I might call you cute if you do".

"I'm not cute!" She scoffed and looked over the edge of the balcony before finally saying, "I guess someday. If she even wants that".

"She's probably never thought about it. This is Adora we're talking about". Bow took a drink of his hot chocolate. "But she loves you. A lot. I don't think it's such a far fetched idea. You should at least talk about the possibility of it happening someday".

Catra smiled.

That night was when it started to go downhill. Catra fell asleep for only a couple of hours before a nightmare ripped her awake. It wasn't like the usual ones surrounding Prime. That would have been a little easier to handle than seeing Angella, someone she never met in person, sacrificing herself in the portal. Catra never heard her voice, but she could read lips just fine. 'Kill the cat for this'. From what Glimmer had said many times before, Angella wasn't like that. Her mind clearly said otherwise.

Catra rubbed at her eyes while she trembled and cried quietly. Melog was pressed against her side in an effort to comfort her. She pushed them away when the ache in her chest wasn't letting up and got out of bed. Melog's pleading meows and chirps were falling on deaf ears. She only realized what happened when she was tackled to the ground with a very unceremonious thud.

Her wrists stung. Her fur was damp. Catra sat up when Melog finally got off of her and looked at the few fresh claw marks on both of her wrists and inner arms.

“Fuck”.

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The second day was more forced. She managed to get out of bed barely in time for breakfast. If Bow or Micah noticed the old sleeve on her right arm and long glove covering her left forearm, they didn’t say a word. After breakfast, she went back to her room in silence. She tried to ignore the mural of Angella that was on the way. It didn’t work. That was the second time she made herself bleed.

She barely pulled herself together by time the tracker pad rang. At least her and Adora had a good conversation that morning and again that night.

Between the calls, Micah and Bow barely managed to pull her from her room to play some made up games and talk about the whole clone situation. She was sure she didn’t eat the rest of the day, preferring to stay away from specifically Micah. Catra saw him looking at the mural before dinner and her stomach turned.

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Catra quietly closed the bedroom door behind her before heading into the bathroom. Melog was probably out in the garden chasing birds. That was good enough for her. She had a few minutes before the alien cat inevitably tackled her to the ground and laid on top of her.

She tossed her sleeve and arm band to the floor and looked over her arm and wrists. Catra could practically hear Glimmer telling her Angella wasn't the type to hate anyone and that she would have never held a grudge against her.

"Liar," she mumbled and sunk her claws into her arm.

Catra sat with the pain for a moment before dragging her claws across her arm. She knew it wasn't the smartest idea. It wouldn't help anything. But it was something. She wanted to feel something other than the sickening guilt.

This time, the scratches were coherent and fully intentional. She pulled back and made four separate lines beside the ones she just did as she thought of Adora. Usually that would pull her out of whatever blind self-torture she was in. Not this time. The new lines were deeper than the first set as she remembered all the times she hurt Adora.

A third set joined older claw marks on her other wrist. She hurt too many people. Maybe if she could hurt herself enough……

Before she could continue, her back hit the cold tiled floor of the bathroom and a the familiar weight of Melog settled on top of her. Eventually she calmed down and washed the scratches.

Those were the things she didn’t share with anyone. The nightmares, the hours she wanted to spend alone even if her thoughts consumed her, and the way she was hurting herself again. She wasn’t exactly sure how she let herself get so out of control with it.

Her eyes fell closed again when Melog curled up behind her legs. They were still the only one that knew of her continued slip up. It was impossible for her to hide anything from them, regardless of how much she tried. And when she did try to hide things, Melog would basically chew her out about it and lay on top of her.

An involuntary growl escaped when there was a knock on the door.

“Busy!” She yelled and pulled the blanket tighter around herself.

“Breakfast is ready,” Micah said from the other side. “If you’re hungry”.

She reluctantly pulled herself from bed and cracked the door. “Not really, but thank you. You don’t need to set a plate for me this morning”.

“Will you be joining me for lunch at least? I invited the others”.

“Yeah. Sure. Um, are you having breakfast alone?” She opened the door a little more, sure to keep the self inflicted wounds from sight. “I can get dressed and at least sit with you”.

“I’ll have Bow and Wrong Hordak this morning. You look tired. Please, I insist you rest more. If I don’t see you, I’ll be back to let you know lunch is ready”.

Catra gave a small smile and thanked him before quietly closing the door. She flinched when she turned around and Melog was right behind her.

“I’m fine”. She sighed when they gave a few short meows. “I’m still not telling anyone. Insist all you want, buddy”.

Catra crawled into back into bed and curled up under the blankets. Truthfully, she hadn’t been sleeping well at all. It felt like every time she tried recently, a different thing she had done for the worst flashed through her mind. Some nightmares were far longer than others, torturing her until her body finally let her wake from it.

She grabbed Adora’s pillow and put the pad in its spot. Catra held it close to her face in her arms, trying for what felt like the millionth time to use the faint scent left there to calm down. If nothing else, it usually helped ease her to a light sleep.

Catra sat up only a short hour later and rubbed her face. Finally deciding sleep was a lost cause, she got up and got dressed. She rubbed Melog's snout with a yawn before leaving the room. There was still a few hours until she was expected for lunch. Just enough time take a walk through the garden to hopefully clear her mind. Scorpia insisted she try it and still had yet to do so.

"You wanna go harass Bow?" She asked Melog with a smile. "He might play with you if you pester him enough".

She crouched and kissed their nose when they meowed at her. "I'll be okay. Really. I just need to be alone for a few minutes. If that's okay with you".

When she got a head bump in return, she patted their rump before they trotted off to find Bow. With a sigh, Catra rubbed her sleeved arm and made her way towards the garden. It felt like ages since she wore the thing. Unfortunately, it was for all of the same reasons and not the chilly air.

Catra sneezed when she decided to smell one of the few remaining flowers in the garden and rubbed her nose. "Stop and smell the flowers, she said. It's rather relaxing, she said".

"Awww, you *are* taking my advice!" Scorpia said as she ran into Catra on one of the paths. "I knew you would".

“I guess it’s better than staying in bed doing nothing,” she mumbled. “You’re here early”.

“Ah, the Fright Zone is under control. We got the foundry back up and running! Thanks for your help with the clean up, by the way. It was a huge help for us”.

“I mean, I was kinda part of the reason it got destroyed in the first place”. She subconsciously rubbed her arm again with a shrug. “Really, it was the least I could do for you. I can even come out that way in a couple days and help-“

“You’re wearing that sleeve again,” Scorpia pointed out. “Catra…”

“It’s fine! I’m fine. Just… cold. Winter is right around the corner”. She quietly hissed at the look she got that said she wasn’t buying it and turned away. “It… it doesn’t matter”.

“I have an idea and if it’s because of the same as last time-“

“I’m not talking about this out here!” Catra took a deep breath. “Just… come to my room”.

“You’re going to talk? Oh, Perfuma would be so proud!”

“Keep it up and I won’t talk about anything,” she growled. “I’m working on it. Please, let me take my time with all of this… therapy stuff. I’m not good at it”.

Scorpia kept her mouth shut all the way to Catra’s room. She sat on the floor, patiently waiting for her friend to at least try to open up as she paced in front of her. Scorpia knew it was her way of trying to form a sentence that would get her feelings into words the best. Instead, she quickly turned away and covered her face with a pincer when Catra started to take her top off.

“Woah, woah, woah! You do know we’re both very much taken and in serious relationships, right? A little over a year ago, I don’t think I would have minded-“

“It’s not like that!” Catra groaned. “We’ve changed in front of each other plenty. Just… fucking look at me!”

Scorpia finally looked at her, Catra now in only her leggings. Her heart clenched when she saw the claw marks across her chest, as well as littering the parts of her arms she was keeping covered. Catra couldn’t bring herself to look at her friend, knowing the exact look she was being given. Scorpia was notoriously horrible at hiding her feelings. The saddened tone of her voice confirmed plenty.

“Oh… I mean, I had an idea it was like last time but not… like this”. Scorpia stood and held her pincers out. “Oh, wildcat, this looks worse than back then. Though, you never really let me look

at the scratches for long. Are you eating enough? You look… a little thinner”.

Catra shook her head. Sure she was eating, but it was nowhere near enough. If she could remember right, she’s only had two actual meals and maybe a handful of really small snacks over the past two and a half days.

“This is where you need to remember you can talk to her. Or me. Or *anyone* . You don’t have to resort to hurting yourself or trying to do this alone”. Scorpia hugged her gently, a new worry setting in when she didn’t bother to fight the embrace. “I know back then was far different. But this doesn’t have to be like that. People care about and love you”.

“Sometimes I don’t even realize I’m doing it,” she said quietly. “Not until it’s already done. Last night was… uh, completely intentional”.

“Can you promise me something? Just one little thing”.

“What? Tell everyone? Not happening”.

“Um, no. But someone. I don’t care if it’s you wanting to or that you already did, okay?”

Catra nodded and rested her head against Scorpia's shoulder. That seemed easy enough. Maybe. She cleared her throat and poked her friend's back. The hug really needed to end once she suddenly remembered she was still shirtless.

"Oh! Sorry, Sorry. You looked like you needed it".

"Maybe I did," she said with a small smile and tugged her shirt on. "Don't make a big deal of it, though. Scorpia, wait".

"Hm?" She turned around instead of continuing to open the bedroom door.

"Thanks. For all of this". Catra pulled her sleeve and long glove on. "Let Micah know I'll be down for lunch in a few minutes".

Scorpia nodded with a smile before seeing herself out. Catra sat on the edge of the bed and grabbed the pad from Adora's pillow. Tapping the screen, she swallowed her pride and called Adora.

"Hey, you! Woah! Hold on".

Catra raised her eyebrow at the soft grunt and the sound of stones scraping and falling. She blinked at the picture on the pad of the open sky over the Crimson Waste. As she waited patiently, she looked over her claws. A quiet yelp left her mouth when She-Ra appeared in the frame, a smile she loved to see on her face.

“Sorry about that. Are you okay?”

“I don’t know. I’d like to talk to my girlfriend if you don’t mind,” she teased before growing a little more serious. “Is now not a good time? Sounds like you have your hands full”.

“No! No, we’re fine. Those damn sand snakes, you know. You usually don’t call in the middle of the day”. She looked around for a moment before letting out a sigh of relief and returning to her normal form. “You look exhausted. And is that your sleeve?”

Catra looked away from the pad for a moment to try to gather her thoughts. She finally resigned to what Scorpia had said. It’s best to just tell her.

“Yeah. I… I fucked up. Uh, a few times actually. I just… I don’t know why I keep doing this fucking shit. I know there’s better ways, so why can’t I do that instead? Why do I just fuck it all up and hurt myself to feel something?”

“Hey, no. We’re not doing that whole ‘I’m a fuck up because I keep doing this’ game. Look at me, Cat”. Adora let her finger poke over the camera in an attempt to let Catra know she would love to wipe her fresh tears away. “Are they bad? Do I need to come home now?”

“No! Finish your mission, dummy. I’m okay. Well, okay enough. Besides, you’ll be home tomorrow”. Catra closed her eyes and wiped her cheeks dry. “I’m sorry I haven’t said anything”.

“You’re working on it,” Adora said as she stood up and started to walk. “I’m just glad you said something instead of waiting for me to get home. Hey, don’t look away again. I love you”.

“I love you too”. Catra swiveled one of her ears at the footsteps approaching her door. “Did you find any clones?”

“Um… yeah. We found a few separate groups. One group decided they wanted to call the Crimson Waste home. We ended up having to fight another”. She scratched her head. “And we might be bringing two clones home with us? Glimmer’s still debating that”.

“So some are still hostile… great,” she groaned and then sighed at the gentle knock. “I guess I have to go”. She lowered her voice, “Micah won’t leave me alone. At all. Is this what having a dad is like?”

Adora laughed and gave her a warm smile when she got a bit of a glare from Catra. “Go on. Give me a call before you pass out tonight, okay? I love you”.

“Yeah, yeah. Don’t get hurt out there. Love you too”.

Catra tossed the pad back to the spot it's been the past few days and stood. She just had to agree to lunch. The moment she opened the door, Micah almost knocked on her forehead but stopped short and gave her an apologetic smile.

"I was just-"

"It's alright, pops. Let's go".

"Pops?" He questioned and stepped back as she walked out and closed the door behind her. "Are you calling me old?"

"What? Me? I would do *no* such thing," she said with a toothy grin and continued on to walk down the hall. The mask she liked to put on was well practiced, regardless of how exhausting.

"You know, I believe the term of endearment you're looking for is '*dad*'," he said when he caught up.

"Oh, no. Definitely not". She faked a shudder. "That's what Sp-Glimmer calls you. I'm *not* calling you that".

"Catra-"

“Not discussing this”. She stopped at the top of the stairs and looked over to him as she flicked an ear. “But there is something I want to talk about. After lunch. Privately”.

“Um, okay?” He scratched the back of his head as he watched her slide down the railing on her butt.

Catra raised her eyebrow at the halfhearted glare Bow was giving her as she took her seat. He then raised his arms to show a few faint scratches. She chuckled a little and mouthed an apology as Melog appeared at her feet.

“Now, you look rough,” Mermista commented. “Which is saying something for you”.

“I didn’t exactly sleep the best, thanks. Set any boats on fire?” Catra shot back.

“Actually, we did!” Sea Hawk said excitedly. “You should have seen it! Those pirates coming for Salineas didn’t know what to think. They sure were quick to turn tail”.

“Did you hear there’s still hostile clones out there?” Frosta asked and stood on her chair. “I’m ready to kick some clone butt!”

“How’d you find that out?” Netossa asked her. “I thought we were done with all of that”.

“Glimmer and Adora are out in the Crimson Waste and found a couple groups. Glimmer said one of them was rather hostile”.

“I wouldn’t think there would be much hostility around our area,” Perfuma said.

“Ah, I don’t know,” Entrapta said. “From a data standpoint, where there’s one, there’s likely to be more. And they could be *anywhere* . That group that Bow and Catra found wandered rather close. Though, with rations running low, I’m not too terribly shocked they’re trying to find somewhere to find nourishment”.

Catra put her head in her hands. There was so much noise and talking that it was starting to get a little overwhelming. She turned with a short hiss when a plate was placed in front of her.

“My apologies,” Wrong Hordak said and stepped back. “I didn’t mean to startle you. You seem distressed”.

“Tired. I’m tired and my head hurts,” she said as calmly and quietly as she could. “But thank you for lunch. I’ll send my compliments to the chef”.

“You’re far too kind to say such a thing without even taking a bite. Enjoy, my broth-“ he stood straight and put his hands behind his back, seeming far more formal, “Catra”.

She gave him a half smile. That was new. She quickly turned back to her plate and grabbed a fork, suddenly realizing just how hungry she was. Skipping breakfast was one thing, but she couldn't quite remember the last time she had an actual meal.

As usual, Wrong Hordak made a wonderful lunch for everyone. He usually saved the larger dishes for dinner, but also seemed to go a little overkill when everyone else was invited. The time of day didn't matter.

Catra took a quick glance to her left and slumped a little. Quietly, she began to eat. She couldn't pick a conversation to focus on. Everyone seemed to be talking about the new discovery of the potential for even more hostile clones roaming around, straying closer to their kingdoms.

The only other people that were quietly enjoying their meal were Bow and Hordak. She looked up at the latter for a brief moment before focusing her attention back to her plate, her brows scrunched together in contemplation. One day couldn't hurt.

"Um, Catra?" Scorpia said, finally getting her attention. "Are you… Frosta asked you something".

"Sorry," she said quietly and looked up. "I didn't hear you".

“With those ears, I thought you would have,” she teased before sticking her tongue out at the glare she received. “I was wondering if you wanted to go on a hunt of our own. You, Bow, and me!”

“I, um… uh… sure?” Catra looked at Bow. “What are we hunting for?”

“She wants to try to find more clones. You in?”

Catra sighed then nodded. “I’m in. *Only* if Adora and I can have at least one full, *uninterrupted* , day together when she gets back”.

“Without a doubt!” Bow agreed. “I’d like a day with Glimmer as well”.

“Oh, I’m sure you would, Arrow Boy,” she said with a cocky smirk.

“Catra!” Bow half squeaked and subtly gestured to Micah before a look of horror came to his face at her growing smirk. “Don’t. Please ”.

“Hmmm. You caught me on my *best* behavior. You’re safe. This time”.

“Am I missing something?” Micah asked, looking between the two.

“No, sir!” Bow cut in before Catra could get a word out. “Nothing at all”.

She quietly laughed and returned to her food. When no one was watching her, she slipped the last few bites to Melog before scratching behind their ear. Catra still wasn’t fully sure if they even needed real food, but still provided plenty. Just in case.

Lunch slowly wrapped up with more discussion of the clones, particularly the two that were supposedly coming back with Glimmer and Adora. The conversations around the table soon changed to talks about what to do for the rest of the day. Somehow, the vote ended up being dodgeball in the courtyard.

Not exactly something Catra was too thrilled about. She liked the idea Mermista had about sparring. Or, as she had put it, ‘hitting each other with sticks’. That somehow got taken as beating each other up in general by Frosta, who was far too excited. And the idea ended up being shot down all together.

Micah dismissed everyone with a laugh at the decision that was made, saying he would join in a few minutes. Catra hung back while everyone else made their way out.

“What is it you wanted to talk about?” Micah asked kindly.

“Beast Island”.

Chapter End Notes

S: I wanted to post this earlier in the day, but I have to take some anxiety meds to even get on a plane and it puts me on my ass for the rest of the day. It’s hard to edit and get it all ready when half asleep. I apologize for anything I missed running through it. At the time of posting, I’m still a bit out of it. Unfortunately, that also means my vacation is over.

The angst is about to pick up for a few chapters. Warnings will be put at the beginning as usual. Posts may be twice a week to get through the worst of it faster. No promises on that with me getting back to work next week and all.

Sorry again about the late post.

Indy: Well things are getting dicey but trust us we have a plan. My coauthor has stated the important things in regards to TW.

School is going ok for me. Had some meetings and things are going to be picking up for me but I promise to deliver on quality entertainment alongside Sokuly. Stay safe and I love you all.

A Deal And Its Consequences

Chapter Notes

> Just some small mentions of more self-harm. Nothing too crazy in this one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Beast Island?” Micah questioned and closed the tall double doors to the dining hall for privacy.

“I want to go. Send me with Hordak first thing in the morning”. Catra paused for a moment before adding, “please?”

Micah cleared his throat and approached her. “Was I not clear? You’ve been through en-“

“No I haven’t!” She suddenly yelled and backed into the doors while shaking her head. “I haven’t paid for anything I’ve done! Every last one of you keeps acting like everything’s okay now. It’s not! I don’t care if I helped save the universe or whatever. I tried to destroy an entire planet! I… Angella is *gone* because of me”.

“Catra-“

“I’ve hurt so many people,” she continued as she stared at her shaking hands. “I… I made sure the Horde was able to take control of so much ground. Prime found Etheria because of me and that fucking portal. And…” she slid her back down the door

until she was sitting on the floor with her face in her hands. "A-and… *please* ".

Micah grabbed a napkin from the table before he crouched down in front of her and gently pulled her hands away from her face. He carefully dabbed the small amount of blood from the small fresh scrapes she caused with her claws along her hairline.

"There are so many other things I can assign to you as your so called punishment. Beast Island doesn't, and shouldn't, have to be it. You saved Glimmer at the cost of yourself. You put your life in jeopardy to make sure Adora was able to get to the Heart of Etheria with the failsafe. And when Shadow Weaver took your place in that situation, you made sure Adora got there and made sure she stayed with us, stayed with you". He gently dabbed the tears from her cheeks with the napkin when her hands fell back to her lap. "Do I need to remind you that Glimmer initially activated the Heart of Etheria?"

"But Angella-"

"Is gone, yes. I can assign you to… protecting Salineas from pirates. You gave the order for siege, so you can do some time there. Or you can go work in Dryl for a while. I'm sure Entrapta could find something".

"You don't get it," she said and pushed Micah's hands away. "I don't deserve you caring about me like this. Or the way Adora loves me. Or the way Glimmer and Bow brought me into their little… best friend squad thing. I can't punish myself enough. I… I

hurt myself to feel anything other than guilt. It's not… it's not enough. I'm asking you to, *please*, send me with Hordak tomorrow".

"You're punishing yourself plenty from what I'm gathering right now. I don't think you deserve to be this hard on yourself. Or to be sent to clean up Beast Island". Micah shifted and sat next to her crosslegged. "I spent so many years there. I'm sure it's different now with the magic unleashed, but it was still a hazardous material dump site. There's still plenty danger to be found there".

Catra closed her eyes and hit the back of her head against the door when Melog finally had enough of watching the conversation and curled up under her arm. She sniffled and patted their side. She had been to dangerous areas before. No one really expected her to survive the Crimson Waste, but she did. Beast Island couldn't be that much different. Besides, the danger could be just what she needed to feel even a little better.

"Right now, begging isn't beneath me," she said quietly. "I will if I have to. If nothing else I've done matters, send me just because I took Angella from you and Glimmer. Okay?"

Micah sighed deeply and resigned that there wasn't anything to change Catra's mind. "One day. I will allow one day. Deal?"

"Two if I need it," she countered.

“Two days period. I don’t want you to ask me for a third”.

“Deal,” she finally said looked over to him. “Thank you”.

He smiled at her and patted her knee. “Now, we’re going to play dodgeball. And no, you’re not getting out of it”.

Catra groaned and got to her feet. “As long as no one, and I mean no one, knows of this conversation”.

“Of course”. He opened the doors. “After you”.

_____

Catra only liked dodgeball in the horde when she was younger and everyone still, mostly, got along. Horde rules were far different from what she was being told now. Back then, she was allowed to pop holes in the ball and hurl the rubber remnants at her next target. In the Horde, using your surroundings to your advantage was highly encouraged. That usually meant her and maybe one or two other cadets climbing and using their new vantage point. Now, the tree in the courtyard was off limits.

Another thing that was apparently not allowed was crossing the dividing line. At all. In fact, she couldn’t even recall there being a line dividing the teams all those years ago. It was usually a free for all and win my any means necessary, just short of actually killing each other or putting each other in the infirmary for more

than a few days on purpose. This new way to play dodgeball seemed… boring.

“Princesses versus Horde!” Frosta shouted.

Catra raised an eyebrow and folded her arms. “If I remember right, you guys didn’t do so well last time Hordak and I were on the same team”.

“Okay, question,” Scorpia raised her pincer. “What side do I go to? I kinda fall under both”.

“Are we also including anyone that worked for the Horde for a while?” Entrapta asked. “Because if so, I’m also with them. If we go that route, it’ll be four against eight. If we decide that Scorpia and myself are with you all, that leaves Catra and Hordak against ten of us”.

“Aw, come on. Let the four of us be on a team,” Catra said with a smirk. “It’ll be just like the old days. The four of us conquering you without even trying”.

“I thought we discussed using this kind of humor to cope with your guilt,” Perfuma warned.

“Yeah,” Scorpia rubbed the back of her head. “That was a little much. Not exactly funny”.

“At least I’m trying to cope better than…” she sighed sharply. “Whatever!”

“Four against eight!” Micah cut in. “The playing field is slightly more even. That’s the final decision”.

“The king has spoken!” Frosta yelled and started setting six balls in a line.

“You can go watch,” Catra told Melog and patted their head. “You just can’t chase the balls, okay?”

She got a meow in return and watched as they wandered off of the playing area to lay down.

“Where did that little comment of yours come from?” Hordak asked as Catra prepared herself to run and grab a ball.

“Let’s not talk about that”. She growled and folded her ears back. “Just win the game”.

“Melog, tell us when,” Scorpia decided. “Just so no one has an unfair start. Oh! And no magic”.

Melog let out a loud, short meow and the game was on. Both sides rushed for a ball to grab. Catra hissed in shock that the ball wasn't inflated rubber.

"What the fuck is this?!" She yelled as she ran back, glaring at the ball in her hand. "This isn't rubber!"

"It sure isn't!" Entrapta exclaimed and threw the ball she had at Sea Hawk. "It's actually reticulated polyether type polyurethane foam".

"Make it make sense!" she yelled and chucked the ball at Perfuma.

"It's a sponge like foam," she replied as if it was the easiest thing to understand and picked up a ball that almost rolled by. "It won't hurt as much-"

"It's too soft!" Catra jumped over a ball and caught a ball Hordak tossed to her.

"And you can't pop it with your claws!"

Her lip twitched at the comment. She felt that the softer object made the game far less interesting. She whipped the ball at Spinnerella which got deflected by the ball she had in her hands. Scorpia hit a preoccupied Frosta in the shoulder before stepping

to the side when Mermista threw one at her. Micah caught the one Entrapta lazily threw at him.

"I'll be watching with Melog!"

Catra rolled her eyes and sent another ball to hit Mermista in the chest. She walked off to join Frosta with a groan. The next ball came from Hordak, which Micah narrowly dodged before sending his own at the former Horde leader. Perfuma took aim at Catra, who sidestepped out of the way. Bow slung his own, hitting Scorpia square in the shoulder.

Catra shot him a glare and caught the ball Sea Hawk threw at her. It was on. Even back in the Horde she didn't exactly like seeing her team dwindled down to two, especially if there was something she could still do about it. She leapt into the air threw the ball, hitting Bow in the back as he was scrambling to pick up a ball.

A low growl came from her when Netossa hit her in the side of the face. Normally, it would have counted to her. Under these new rules, headshots were apparently not allowed. She was definitely still in play and picked up a ball. She stopped another with her foot before picking it up.

"I didn't mean it!" Netossa called to her. "I was going for your shoulder and you moved!"

“It’s just a game!” Scorpia reminded her from the sidelines as Catra’s tail lashed and Melog’s mane started to turn a fiery orange from the hit. “It was an accident, you know that!”

“Do you need to take a minute?” Perfuma asked and dodged a ball Hordak sent at her.

Catra didn’t say a word. She threw her first ball as hard as she could, nailing Netossa square in the chest. Payback. The second one she hurled at Perfuma for even suggesting such a thing, hitting her hard in the arm.

“Line!” Frosta reminded her when she stepped over.

Catra looked down and growled before stepping back. Hordak again threw a ball, taking aim for Spinnerella who dodged and threw her ball at him. Micah threw a ball that Hordak dodged with ease. The former Horde leader picked up two balls and tossed one to Catra. She quickly launched it at Spinnerella while looking at Micah, catching the princess off guard. With a smirk, she picked up a ball she kept stashed on her and Hordak’s side of the line.

“How am I the last one left?” Micah voiced and dodged the ball Catra threw.

He returned the throw. Catra leapt away, snagging another ball to toss to right back. The two threw a ball at each other at the same time, both taking the hit.

“Sorry, Catra!” Entrapta called from the sidelines, “it hit you approximately half a second before it hit him”.

Catra walked off with a huff and sat next to Melog and Scorpia. She would be lying if she said she didn’t have at least a little fun. Even if it was with foam balls and she couldn’t use her claws. Or climb a tree in the courtyard. Or just go grab any ball she wanted.

She laid back in the grass with a small smile, satisfied. She played a game. That’s all that counted in that moment. It was better than the alternative she had in mind. Even if Netossa hit her in the face. Her ears perked up at the cheering from beside her. Clearly the princesses had won. Barely.

“Rematch?” Scorpia asked.

“I’m gonna pass on that one,” Catra said and closed her eyes. “I’ll lay here instead. The afternoon moon’s warmth feels good”.

Adora was half curled up in her chair on the bridge. She had set auto pilot to get back to Bright Moon and decided to at least try to nap on the way. Unfortunately, the two clones they were bringing back weren’t exactly the quietest. She could hear them clattering around, and talking to each other. Something crashed from somewhere behind her and she finally stood. Her body was tired and her eyes were heavy. They had decided to get up rather early,

eat a quick breakfast, and get back home. Even Glimmer was exhausted and asleep in one of the rooms.

"What are you two doing?" Adora asked when she walked into one of the bedrooms, rubbing her eyes.

"Just looking!" One of them said and closed the top drawer of the dresser. "You don't seem to have much aboard".

"There's no need to keep anything other than basics when we're just traveling between kingdoms, villages, the Crimson Waste, and Beast Island," she explained tiredly. "Whenever we get around to heading back into space, we'll have plenty more".

"Can I ask what happened?" The other clone asked while tracing the deep claw marks still in the wall. "Were you ambushed at some point?"

Adora grabbed both of them by the wrist and pulled them from the room. "Short answer, no. Now please, can I get some sleep for the next… half hour?"

"Doesn't the ship go faster? I'm sure we could get back to your home sooner".

"I *was* trying to have a little more silent time before going back to the quiet happenings of Bright Moon. I would really, really

appreciate it if you two would just… explore quieter”.

“Of course. We didn’t mean to upset you”.

“I’m not upset. Just exhausted. I have an idea.” She drug them further down the short corridor and opened a door. “You two can organize the cargo hold. *Quietly* ”.

“Anything to help!”

Adora went back to the bridge to curl back up in her chair and closed her eyes. Bright Moon wasn’t loud by any means, it was truly rather peaceful most of the time. There was just something about the silence of Darla, besides the quiet hum of the engine, that was relaxing.

She had fallen asleep and only woke when there was a loud beeping followed by Darla announcing they had arrived. Her nap definitely wasn’t long enough. While she wasn’t one for sleeping in due to the rigorous training from the Horde, she also wasn’t one to wake up earlier than she needed to.

“Are you coming?” Glimmer asked as she watched Adora stand and stretch. “Where are the clones?”

“Yeah, yeah. I’m comin’. They’re in the cargo hold. I told them to organize it so they would be quiet and leave me alone”.

Glimmer was the first to go down the ramp and was instantly hugged by Bow and spun around a couple times. Adora couldn't help but smile from behind the clones as she watched. Really, she was just glad they were together and happy. She didn't see the enthusiastic hug coming and let out a tired grunt before returning the hug from Bow. He was acting like both of them had been gone for months rather than a few days. Wrong Hordak welcomed the other clones enthusiastically with Micah.

Realization had finally hit after a few seconds. Bow was the first to hug her. Not Catra. Even with it being fairly early, she was expecting her girlfriend to be awake and waiting impatiently. Adora looked around for a moment, looking for any sign of the missing individual.

"Where's Catra?" She asked. "Still asleep?"

"Oh…" Bow cleared his throat. "She didn't tell you?"

"Tell me… what?" She took a step back.

"She… kinda went to Beast Island this morning with Hordak".

Adora stared at him for a moment, carefully weighing what he said. It wasn't long until she laughed and shoved his shoulder.

“So, yes, she accidentally slept longer than I’m sure she meant to. Nice joke, though”.

“Adora,” Bow grabbed her arm as she started to walk towards the castle’s doors, “I’m not joking”.

There wasn’t a crack in his demeanor. There was no half smile or teasing glint in his eyes. He was being quite serious. Adora was feeling a lot of different things all at once. Worry, anger, sadness, hurt, and, most of all, confusion. The rapid shifting of her emotions must have shown on her face considering Bow’s question.

“She really didn’t tell you, did she?”

“No,” Adora said quietly. “She didn’t. When did she go?”

“You guys missed her by about an hour. She didn’t tell anyone, actually. I only knew because I saw her on Swift Wind with Hordak.”.

“Even Swift Wind didn’t say anything?!” Adora rubbed her forehead. “Wait… Catra’s on him *without me* ? Oh, I feel a little bad for Hordak. She hates it when he flies and only barely manages when I’m there constantly reassuring her that she isn’t going to fall as long as she holds on. That and the motion sickness she’s prone to”.

“So… you don’t know why?” Glimmer asked Bow.

“If I did, I’d tell you”.

“Does *anyone* know what’s going on?!” Adora yelled.

“Adora,” Micah said as he walked over, “come with me. Excuse us”.

Bow waved as Adora turned to walk with Micah.

“I thought she would have told at least you,” he said. “She asked me to go”.

“Catra *a sking* to go to Beast Island? You have got to be joking”.

“Unfortunately, I’m not. Believe me when I say she wouldn’t take any other option. I tried. Has she always been so stubborn?”

“You have *no* idea,” Adora mumbled. “Did she say why?”

“Mostly the guilt. She feels so guilty about everything. The portal, hurting so many people, hurting you. I’m sure you know the rest”.

Adora just nodded.

“I gave her other options since she wanted a punishment she couldn’t give herself”. He noticed Adora flinch at that. “She was set on Beast Island. We made a deal. She gets to go twice at most. She needs to use her so called punishment wisely”.

Adora felt a hand on her shoulder and stopped from going upstairs. A part of her still hoped this was all some stupid, twisted joke and wanted to get to her room to find Catra still curled up in bed.

“Really, I’m just glad you and Glimmer are back safe. Would you like something to eat? I can have something quick made”.

“Me too,” she said with a fake smile. “And no, thank you. Huntara gave us quite the breakfast before we left. I think I’ll be good until dinner”.

“Well, if you need anything…”

“I’ll let you know. Right now, a hot bath sounds amazing”.

Micah nodded and let her go. As soon as she started up the stairs, her false smile fell away. She wasn't sure if she wanted to be furious with Catra or if she wanted to cry for her feeling like she couldn't come to her.

Catra was very much not in bed when she opened the door. It hadn't been a joke. She sighed as she closed the door behind her before she noticed a note propped up against a vase filled with light blue irises and yellow daisies. Adora grabbed the note and read it. And then read it again.

` *I went to Beast Island with Hordak for the day. I needed to get out, to feel like I'm finally getting what I deserve. Even if only a little. Really, I feel like I deserve to stay there for a while. A long while. Adora, I have so many regrets and if I could go back and change it, I would. In a heartbeat. I'll still see you tonight when we get back. We can talk then. I'm sorry I didn't say anything.*

Love, Catra

Ps, I know the flowers aren't going to help, but I hope you like them '

Of course she liked them. Adora set the note down and trailed her fingers gently over the petals. The irises were definitely one of her favorites. And the color scheme was awfully familiar too. She smiled and rolled her eyes. At least Catra tried.

Adora decided on actually taking a bath. She grabbed the tracker pad and brought it with her. Once she walked into the bathroom, she set the pad on the counter and picked up the blood stained towel that was likely accidentally left by the tub. If Adora had to guess, it was from early this morning. She quickly grabbed the pad and tried to call Hordak. The pad he carried with him to Beast Island was mainly for emergencies or for someone to contact him if needed. Unfortunately he didn't answer. With a groan, she set it back down and resigned to the two of them being busy with clean up.

She eased herself into the hot water after throwing her clothes into the corner. She wanted to be mad, sad even. Anything but feeling hurt. Catra promised she would try to be more open, to try to work on her bad habit of running off without a word when things got hard to deal with. Adora could only guess the reason she even asked anyone to go was simply because it was an island and Darla was being used, Swift Wind would blow her cover if she hopped on alone and told him where to go, and Melog couldn't exactly float over the water.

She knew she wasn't really connected with Melog in the way Catra was. Still, the magical cat phased through the door and dropped their invisibility before sitting next to the tub. They didn't try to communicate much more than putting a large paw on the edge of the tub. Melog knew Adora couldn't understand the meows, chuffs, and grunts.

"I'm surprised she didn't take you," Adora said aloud. "I'm guessing there just wasn't enough room on Swift Wind, huh?" She put a hand over their paw. "Sometimes I wish I could understand you. It would be a lot more helpful when things like this happen, where I can't just ask her what's wrong and get an answer".

Finally, Melog meowed and put a second paw on the edge of the tub.

"I'm going to pretend you told me that she went because she was guilty or something. Micah told me". She watched as they glanced at the towel. "Don't worry, she at least told me about that. Well, not the towel. She told me she hurt herself while I was gone. I'm going to guess she downplayed it, huh?"

Adora took the soft chuff as an affirmative answer and let herself sink lower in the tub until the base of her head rested against the edge. She had feeling that was the case.

"Did she go so I wouldn't see it?" She spoke her thoughts. "Did I do something wrong?"

Melog whined and made their form small enough to lay on the ledge behind her head.

"Can you… feel her from here?"

A whine followed by a huff.

"I'm taking that as a no". Adora sighed. "I'm sorry. We could always go to Beast Island and talk to her".

Melog let out a growl.

"Or… not. Are you really defending her just leaving?" She shifted and looked over her shoulder at the creature. "I know she'll be back, but come on!"

"You can get your claws out of my shoulders," Hordak grumbled. "We're not in the air anymore".

Catra dared to open an eye and sighed a breath of relief. She finally let go of Hordak and jumped off of Swift Wind before smoothing out her bristled tail. Her head was still spinning and her legs were a little shaky.

"That was a little better than before," Swift Wind commented. "Progress!"

"Still not a fan of feeling like I'm going to fall off at every little turn". She ran her fingers through her hair at the back of her head, forcing it to not be puffed up. "Sorry about scratching your sides. Again".

"Ah, that's nothing compared to what you've done in the past with those feet. You two have a good night. I have apples and hay to eat!"

“We should probably get dinner as well,” Hordak said and started to walk back towards the castle.

“If they have anything left,” Catra rubbed her stomach when it growled once the annoying wave of nausea subsided and followed after him.

“My brother usually puts up something for when I return from these excursions. Unless they’re having a late dinner or I’m returning to Dryl”.

“For what it’s worth,” Catra said as they walked inside, “Beast Island isn’t as bad as you guys made it out to be. Unless your clean up has something to do with that”.

“The clean up and a small amount of help from Adora when you all released the magic. It used to be much worse”. He turned the corner to the dining hall. “Though, having you provoking creatures was no help today”.

“It’s not my fault you wanted to clean up that area!” She defended herself.

“No, but it is your fault for losing some of my tools. They’re not meant to be throwing weapons”.

“Welcome back,” Micah greeted and stood from his seat. “There’s still plenty and I’m sure you’re hungry”.

Catra genuinely smiled at the invitation and hurried to her seat. She quickly filled her plate, ignoring the tense silence at the table. Just after taking her first bite, she chewed slowly, suddenly very aware Adora didn’t even look at her. One of her hands was balled into a fist on the table and the other gripping onto her own thigh.

Adora was definitely not happy.

Bow gave her a very sheepish smile while Glimmer quietly looked at her then Adora, silently telling her to talk. To say anything, really.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra managed quietly after she swallowed her bite.

“We’ll talk after dinner”.

Catra’s ears lowered at the sharpness as she turned her attention back to her plate. She made a mistake. Deep down she knew the note and flowers weren’t nearly enough to cover the fact she chose to not tell Adora of her trip to Beast Island. She was definitely more than okay with talk now. A discussion about it all needed to happen. She had already planned on it.

“So,” Bow tried to start a conversation, “how was it? Is it still a scary death trap that makes you want to give up on everything?”

“Um,” Catra took another bite of her meal before continuing, “it’s not as bad as the horror stories they told us in the Horde, but yeah. It’s not the best place out there. I got charged by some kind of creature”.

“Now there’s something to talk about!” Glimmer said and nudged Adora. “Let’s hear about it”.

“What’s there to say? It was there, I got too close and made it mad accidentally, it charged, and I threw a few screwdrivers at it in an attempt to get it to back off”.

“You… didn’t use your claws to fight it?” Bow asked.

“Listen, I know I’ve dealt with larger creatures, but there wasn’t exactly much to climb on where we were”. She shrugged. “And there was no point in exhausting myself in that kind of fight. It ended up liking one of the screwdrivers. Picked it up and took off towards the middle of the island”.

“Do you feel better?” Adora asked without looking at her, tone still sharp.

“I… don’t know how to answer that without making you more upset right now”. Catra reached for her hand that was under the table and growled quietly when she pulled it away. “What do you want me to say, Adora? Yeah, everything’s great. I guess I didn’t need to go after all. I feel so much better”.

Adora stood and looked at Micah. “Excuse me. I’m going to bed. Thank you for dinner”. She then turned to Catra for the first time since she got back. “Finish eating before you even think to come to bed”.

“Adora, I’m-“ she hung her head as she kept walking, “-sorry”.

The room was filled with a very uncomfortable silence as everyone was finishing up their meal. Catra, however, spent most of the time staring at her half finished plate. She was running through every scenario possible in her mind and didn’t like the outcome of most of them. In hindsight, she probably just should have kept her mouth shut.

Bow and Glimmer excused themselves, followed shortly by Hordak after he was offered a room to stay for the night. It was just her and Micah sitting in silence. She took another bite, slowly dwindling her plate to empty.

“Are you feeling better?” Micah suddenly asked.

“Not anymore,” she muttered. “Two more days?”

“You have one left. Don’t forget about the deal we made. You can use it for the next time Hordak goes out, or save it for a later time”.

“I’ll let you know”. Catra stood and quietly picked up the dishes around the table. She wanted to give Adora just a little more time.

“You don’t have to clean up”. He also stood and held out his hands to take the tableware. “Go on. You two clearly need to talk”.

Catra only nodded and let him take the items. She wasn’t in any rush to get upstairs. Melog startled her when they appeared next to her, but she quickly relaxed and patted their head.

“Not tonight, Melog. I think Adora and I need to be alone”. She stood in front of the door and took a deep breath. “Wish me luck”.

Without further hesitation, she slowly opened the door. Adora was laying on her side, facing away. She didn’t move or even seem to acknowledge anyone even entered the room. The vase of flowers had been moved to closer to the window for more light during the day. If it wasn’t for the barely audible sniffle, it could have easily been mistaken that Adora was asleep.

“Adora?”

Chapter End Notes

S: I really do want to get through this heavy angst stuff a little faster, so you're getting two chapters again this week. Next chapter, scheduled for Saturday, is the big heavy hitter with all of this. Also, don't ask about the dodgeball thing. We wanted something a little lighter in mood.

I don't have much to say about life at the moment. Work is work and I'm suffering what I like to call "weather whiplash". It was chilly when I went on vacation, nice and comfortable in Florida, and I come back to Ohio where it's still cold. My sinuses are not pleased. Though… I did hear we have a bit of a warmup coming? We'll see how much that changes by next week.

In any case, I hope you're all well.

Indy: School is school and work is work. I'm hanging in there. I hope you are all doing well

I Hate To See You Like This

Chapter Notes

This chapter is a lot and it's painful so here's the list of things to be very mindful of:

-self harm and mentions of it
-suicidal thoughts and actions
-general severe depression
-child abuse (in a brief flashback) and mentions of it
-some PTSD tones

If you decide to not proceed, general info will be provided in the end notes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was met with silence as Adora pulled the blanket tighter around her shoulders. She looked at the floor with a quiet sigh.

"Do you want to skip the talking thing?" She pulled her sleeve, glove, and shirt off to toss it into the corner. "I know I fucked up, okay? I should've have told you. You have every right to be upset or angry or… whatever you're feeling. I'll… sleep on the floor if you want".

"That's not at all what I want!" Adora yelled and sat up. "I want to know why, Catra. Why didn't you say anything?"

"You would have tried to talk me out of it!"

“It’s Beast Island! You… you didn’t need to go there. You’ve been ‘punishing’ yourself enough as it is”. She threw the bloodstained towel at her and took in her shocked expression when she caught it. “You left that by the tub before you left this morning. I know you told me you had been hurting yourself while I was gone, but you didn’t say it was like this, how… bad it is. I mean look at yourself! You’re covered in scratches.”

Catra looked back at the floor and twitched her ear. Her tail was ever so slightly tucked between her legs. Maybe this was the exact punishment she truly deserved. Adora finally got up and stood in front of her. She took a better look at the scratches over her arms, chest, and abdomen before grabbing her hands.

“Just… why, Cat? You haven’t been this bad in years, and that’s including after you were chipped.”

“Because I feel like I deserve it, okay?!” She pulled her hands away with a short hiss. “You know the long list of things I’ve done and who I’ve hurt. Fuck, you’re included in it! I hurt *you* . Is it so wrong to want a fitting punishment that isn’t the… execution I clearly deserve?”

“Is this because of what Lance and George said weeks ago? If it is, damn it, don’t let them keep getting to you like this! I love you”. Adora sighed at the way Catra hugged herself. “You’ve been off and on with hurting yourself since we went to the library. What they said hurt me too. Just… talk to me!”

Catra smacked her hands away when she tried to hold hers again and took a half step back. Her chest was burning as she tried to take deep breaths as to not let herself resort to the anger she was so good at finding. The yelling back and forth wasn't helping. She was only vaguely aware that her ears were pinned back and her tail was starting to whip back and forth in agitation.

"Hey, come here," Adora said calmly. She knew the signs too well and held out her hands as something of a peace offering. "I'm sorry I yelled".

"You want to know why I deserve it, Adora?" She finally looked up and wanted to claw the concerned look right off her face. "Because all I ever do is fuck up and make everything worse for everyone".

"That's not true, Catra".

"It's not?!" Catra let out a laugh in disbelief. "How can you say that?"

"You're past that! Bad things happened, you made mistakes. We all did!" Adora took a step closer. "Glimmer tried to activate the Heart. I… left you with the Horde. Huntara led me into a trap when we first met. Entrapta sided with the Horde for a while. They're not bad people because of a few fuck ups and neither are you!"

“Tell that to Shadow Weaver then! You knew of the abuse and torment she put me through. She manipulated you too, but she never laid a hand on you more than *maybe* twice. Shadow Weaver beat me for every single minor misstep. She hit me, threw me to the ground, electrocuted me, *tortured* me. Adora, you…” her voice broke as she fought her tears, “you kept me sane until and alive for all of those years. You were there for me. And then you weren’t”.

“I know. And I wish I could take it back. Just, please, listen to me”. Adora wiped a stubborn tear from her own cheek. “Please… talk to me about this stuff instead of making brash decisions that could get you killed”.

“Everyone left me but had no problem coming back for you”. Catra couldn’t fight the tears any longer and the first of many finally slid down her cheek. “You came back for your new friends, but not me. Shadow Weaver hurting me wasn’t enough for you to want to ditch the Horde, but seeing the Horde hurt *others* that were *innocent* was. We were *kids* when she started doing that shit to me and it only got worse as we got older”. She hugged herself tightly as she cried from the memories. “I was an innocent child”.

“Catra-“

“I… I wanted to die after you left and I finally thought I could, even if it meant I was taking everyone with me. So I opened that fucking portal and Angella is gone because of me. You weren’t the one to pull the lever. Then it was because of me the Horde was winning. And in the end,” she took a full step back when Adora reached out to her, “winning was *horrible* . It didn’t matter

because I wasn't winning with you. I even told Glimmer to kill me, to get it over with. I was done".

"Cat-" Adora quickly blinked away her own tears as much as she could. "Please, come here".

"And to put the fucking cherry on top, I hurt *you* so much. I did things I promised myself I'd never do to you. So I'll just do it to myself over and over," she unsheathed her claws and grit her teeth, "and over again until I can make up for the things I've done".

"Catra, don't!"

She slashed her leg open as tears dripped from her chin. "How much blood is enough, Adora?!"

"Stop!" She screamed and grabbed her wrist when she reached for her own throat.

"Let go!" Catra pulled against her grip. Her mind was racing far too fast for her mouth to keep up as she tried to say more around choked sobs, "please… I can't… I don't want… it hurts… Adora… I need… make it all stop."

Adora quickly grabbed her other wrist when she tried to push her away. Even if the shove to her chest was weak, she knew exactly

what Catra was capable of when she was like this. She had kept a suture kit hidden behind a wall panel next to their bunk for especially bad nights, usually the nights Shadow Weaver wanted a ‘conversation’ after curfew. Adora would be damned if she were to let go of Catra now.

“Catra, listen to me. I’m here. I’m right here. I need you to put your claws away. I’m not letting your wrists go until you do.” Adora touched their foreheads together. “For me. Please?”

Catra retracted her claws and let Adora pull her into a hug. She only cried harder against her shoulder as her tail wrapped around her own uninjured leg.

“It’s okay. I’m here”. She gently rubbed her back. “I want to help you with all of this, but you can’t keep it to yourself. I’m not a mind reader. I love you, all of you”.

One of Adora’s hands moved to the back of her head to run her fingers through Catra’s hair while the other continued to soothingly trail along her spine. She knew it was bad when Catra still hadn’t made any move to hug back or even touch her more than the contact they were already in. Adora held her tighter when another broken round of sobs shook her girlfriend. Somehow it was still all so familiar, even if things were definitely more intimate between them now.

“Hey, I’m gonna take your pants off, okay? I just don’t want you getting blood on the bed”.

Catra simply nodded and wiped her face with the heel of her hands when Adora knelt down. She was gentle with pulling Catra's leggings down, especially around the new scratches. If she couldn't heal wounds, they would have definitely needed stitches. Both internally and externally. Adora only realized that Catra was holding her weight fully on her uninjured leg when she tried to get her to step from her pants. It only worked when Catra braced her hands on Adora's shoulders.

She let Adora gently pull her towards the bed after she grabbed the towel from the floor. The numbness finally settled in and she wanted no part of it. Adora had her sit on the edge of the bed and pressed the towel to the fresh gashes on her leg as she knelt in front of her. Catra tried to wipe her own face dry again, but gave up as tears leaked from her eyes the moment Adora stopped holding her own back. She hated the mix of love, concern, and gut wrenching sadness Adora held in her eyes.

"You don't deserve Beast Island. You don't deserve to hurt yourself. You never deserved anything Shadow Weaver or Hordak did to you". Adora knew her voice was shaking as she cried. "You're *not* a bad person, Catra. Help me understand why you're doing this to yourself like… this again, please".

"I want to feel something that isn't guilt or anger or… this numbness," she said quietly and wiped her face with the back of her hand. "The nightmares and panic attacks aren't helping. I just want it all to stop. Just like back then".

Adora wiped the tears from her own face with the hand that wasn't holding the towel before brushing away fresh ones from Catra's cheek with her thumb. The last time she could remember having to witness Catra hurt herself to the extent she had was one of the times Shadow Weaver verbally beat her down and then some, telling her just how useless and worthless she was as well as making damn sure she knew the only reason she was being kept around was for Adora's sake. Those were a very sleepless few nights for her. She had quietly bandaged her self inflicted scratches, some she even had to stitch closed in secret late at night, just to make sure Catra would wake up the next day. Adora never pressed more about the bruises on her arms and jaw after Catra told her, shakily, it was just from training. In hindsight, she should have.

"You've always deserved a chance when we were in the Horde," Adora finally said. "And I'm so sorry I left you there. There are days where that's all I can think about and how I should have tried so much harder to bring you with me. I… I used to hurt myself because of it".

Catra blinked then shook her head like she didn't want to believe what she heard.

"It's true". She cupped Catra's cheek and continued to gently rub her thumb under her eye. "We can talk about that another time. This isn't about me. Just listen, okay? You deserve love and patience. And right now, you deserve forgiveness. I forgive you, Catra. And I love you. And I hate that Shadow Weaver took that from us when we were younger".

Catra continued to cry quietly. She wanted to tell Adora she was wrong, that she didn't deserve any of that. But she couldn't, not when there was suddenly She-Ra kneeling in front of her. The towel was removed from her leg and dropped to the floor. Catra sniffled at the warmth that always seemed to come with the healing powers. The gashes on her thigh quickly sealed closed, gone without a visible trace.

"I love you," Adora whispered as she held Catra's scratched up arms to heal them too.

Catra knew she could heal all of it all at once if she wanted to. She felt like Adora was simply proving a point. It was working for the most part. Catra still had the bitter taste of guilt in her throat and the deep, almost numbing ache of self hated settled in her chest. Really, she still wanted to die. Maybe then, she'd have finally paid off her crimes of the past.

"I… I love you," Adora said again, this time around her tears as she put a hand directly in the middle of Catra's chest to heal the scratches littering her torso.

"Adora," she spoke her name almost silently. "Don't heal me again".

She returned to her normal form and looked up at her girlfriend. There, she saw a haunting look, one of giving up. Adora watched, heartbroken at her words, while she slowly laid down and curled up.

“I hope you know that’s one request of yours I’m going to ignore completely.” She laid down behind her and tugged her body close. “Please, Catra, I’m not losing you again. I know you struggle with this stuff. You always have from time to time. I’m here now and I’m never letting go of you again. Ever. I promise. So please, don’t let your mind win”.

“Okay,” she barely whispered and closed her eyes. “I love you”.

“I’ll be right here if you need anything at all tonight. If I’m asleep, wake me up”. Adora gently ran her knuckles over Catra’s stomach. “You’ve shed more than enough blood over this”.

_____

“Who wants to check on them?” Bow whispered, standing outside of Catra and Adora’s room. “It’s been days”.

“Do you want me to just pop in?” Glimmer asked and jabbed her thumb over her shoulder. “I’ve been giving them some space after Adora snapped a little yesterday, but I’ll forcibly check on her if I have to. I… don’t think she’s sleeping much, if at all”.

“What do you mean that she snapped a little?” Perfuma asked.

“A lot of what she said, well… yelled, boiled down to needing to be left alone. She’s hiding something more, but I couldn’t get it

out of her”.

“Oh, no. I would avoid just… poofing in there if she needs to be left alone,” Scorpia said quietly. “We all know Adora usually ignores concerns about her wellbeing instead of getting snappy about it”.

They all stood huddled together for a few more moments. Glimmer sighed in frustration and stepped towards the door.

“Since none of you are jumping for it, I will”. She gave a few knocks. “Did you guys want anything to eat? Dinner’s just about done”.

She was met with silence as Bow backed away and partially hid behind Scorpia. Bothering the two at all didn’t seem like the best idea, but they were worried. No one had seen Catra at all in days since she got back from her Beast Island trip. They only ever saw Adora briefly when she would grab snacks or a small plate of food to take back and conversations were always short.

Glimmer knocked again, only a little harder. Perfuma and Scorpia exchanged a worried look. They felt this may be a bit too soon for such a demanding knock from her.

“Guys, come on. Join us for dinner,” she tried again.

The door, finally, barely cracked open.

"Seriously, Glimmer, leave us alone," Adora bit quietly. "She doesn't want to sit through a meal with everyone yet. I'll be down later".

"But you want to?" She asked and pushed on the door. "Then you come".

Adora swung the door open and stepped out before she quickly and quietly closed it behind her. She looked exhausted. Her hair was down and messy, and there were dark circles under her eyes that looked puffy as if she had been crying recently.

"I don't have time for this," she said. "My girlfriend wants to kill herself in a way I haven't seen in *years* . I'm saying the last time she was like this was when we were in our teens. I'm sorry if I seem like I don't want to spend a lot of time with any of you but I'm trying to make sure she's not going to kill herself the moment I leave the room. When I do, she's usually asleep".

Glimmer stared at her in shock. She knew Catra wasn't doing particularly well, just not that bad. That was definitely what Adora wouldn't say. It sounded like Catra was worse than she was after being chipped and it made Glimmer feel sick. They had gotten close over the past year, true enemies to friends. The last thing she wanted was for her friend to feel the way she did.

“This isn’t because of a fight over her not telling you about Beast Island, is it?” She asked.

Adora shook her head. “I wish we would have actually fought about it. She would have bounced back by that next morning”.

“Then what happened?” Perfuma asked sincerely.

“She told me why she wanted to go in the first place. And now she’s…” she sighed and rested the back of her head against the door. “Look, she feels like no matter what she does, she’ll never pay the price for what she did to everyone… to me. And that’s on top of the things Shadow Weaver and Hordak did to her growing up. Maybe I was the catalyst when I asked her why she felt she needed to go. Maybe I wasn’t and this has been brewing for a while. Whatever the reason behind it, this is what the situation is and I’m trying to fix it or at least be a consistent variable for her right now”.

“Are you… sleeping at all?” Bow asked timidly.

“Barely, but yes”. She rubbed her face before turning the door handle. “I’m not asking anymore. I’m *telling* you to just leave us alone for now”.

“It’s been days,” Scorpia quietly pointed out. “Can I talk to her?”

" *No* ," Adora answered sternly. "She's made it very, *very* clear she doesn't want to talk to anyone. She's barely talking to *me* . Any other questions or can I go back?"

"Adora?" Catra barely whispered through the small crack in the door, voice shaky.

"Go on," Perfuma answered for everyone before Glimmer could get a word in. "We can talk more when you're ready".

Adora didn't wait for anything else any of them wanted say. She opened the door just enough for her to squeeze in and quietly closed it. Catra shivered in her arms when she hugged her.

"Are you cold?" She asked gently. "I'm sure I could get you another blanket".

Catra shook her head and buried her face into the side of Adora's neck.

"Okay. It's okay". Adora rubbed her back gently when there was a quiet sniffle. "Can you give a little something to help with? Are you hungry? Are you bleeding at all? Talk to me, just a little".

"Not hungry." She trembled again before finally admitting, "m-my… my arm."

“Let me look”. She let go and took a small step back to look over the four fresh claw marks over her inner forearm. “They’re not too bad. Do you want me to heal them yet?”

Catra hesitated before shaking her head.

“Alright”. Adora kissed her forehead. “I’ll give you… two hours with these. I’m sure you heard, but dinner’s almost ready. Did you want to try joining them today?”

She shook her head again and looked at the floor with her ears falling back slightly. Adora knew that it was in mild shame.

“Hey, look at me”. She gently lifted Catra’s gaze. “It’s okay if you’re not up for it yet. I’ll bring something back up and-“

“It’s not your fault”.

Adora let out a breath. “I didn’t mean it like that. I’m just a little worried-“

“It’s not your fault!” Catra held her arm close to her body. “You didn’t do this. You asking why didn’t set me off like you think. I’m… I’m sorry I made you feel…”

Adora quickly wrapped her arms around her when she saw a tear run down her cheek. “Shhh. It’s okay. You didn’t make me feel like it was my fault. I made myself think that. Not you. Okay? I promise”.

“I’m tired of feeling like this, Adora”.

“Like what?” She urged softly while rubbing her back.

“The guilt. The hurt. The nightmares. Feeling numb because of it all. I… I was doing better and now this again. I want it to stop”.

“I do too. I don’t like seeing you like this. I never have. It… scares me”.

Catra only sighed and slipped from Adora’s hold to go lay back down, a clear signal she was done talking for now. Adora quietly joined her and kissed the back of her head. That was the most she had gotten out of Catra at one time in days. It wasn’t a lot, but she would take it.

Adora waited until Catra’s breathing finally evened back out and slowed. She didn’t dare say or do anything to make sure she was asleep. Instead, she carefully got out of the bed and waited a few seconds. When Catra didn’t stir, she kissed her cheek and waited

again. Adora finally stroked her ear lightly and knew she was at least in a light sleep for now.

She quietly exited the room and made her way downstairs. Grabbing something to eat for herself was needed. As usual as of lately, she would also grab something small for Catra. Any small amount she would willingly eat was a win.

Adora walked into the dining hall and only waved to everyone. They all knew she wasn't going to stay for dinner, but still stay long enough for a short conversation. Only this time, Adora was the one to beat anyone to saying anything.

"No, she's not okay. Yes, she's alive". She grabbed a couple plates and made her own first. "I'm okay, just tired and worried. Oh, and she actually talked to me a little more so at least there's some progress. She let me know it's not my fault she's like this now".

"You *really* need to sleep," Bow said. "Do you want help? I can make Catra's plate so you can eat".

"It's fine, really. She won't want much, if anything". Adora put a dumpling on the second plate and added a small cake on the side. Just in case. "And I'm sleeping when I can. We managed three hours last night and some short naps in between".

"That's so not enough. Is there anything we can do to help? We can take turns or something so you can rest".

“You won’t even have to leave your room,” Glimmer added. “We’ll just be another body in there so you can sleep and we’ll make sure Catra doesn’t… you know”.

“You seriously look like you could fall asleep standing up,” Scorpia said. “We can check on-“

“Ask Catra if it would be okay,” Perfuma said. “If she still wants the privacy, we’ll respect that”.

Adora sighed quietly and shook her head. She knew Catra wouldn’t cooperate with any of it.

“I’m banning her from Beast Island,” Micah finally said. “We had a deal and her second trip is suspended until she’s better. I won’t let her use it as a death sentence”.

“Thank you,” Adora said and picked up the two plates. “And really, guys, I appreciate the offer, but I can’t let that happen. Not yet. Believe me when I say she doesn’t want to involve anyone else”.

Glimmer stood and gave Adora a quick hug, careful of the plates. She looked like she needed it.

“She’ll come around,” Glimmer said and watched Adora’s expression. “Right?”

“Yeah”. Adora tried a half smile. She knew it was weak and tired at best. “She will. I just… I haven’t seen her like this since back in the Horde. That’s a story for another time. Goodnight, everyone”.

“Goodnight, Adora,” they all replied as she walked out.

Adora quietly opened the door and let out a breath of relief. Catra hadn’t moved and was still asleep. She quietly closed the door with her foot and set the plates on the dresser. Catra needed to eat, but she also really needed sleep. A total of ten hours over three days wasn’t helping anything for her.

She understood. Adora would still get nightmares about things that happened during the war, almost losing Catra forever, even random things that happened back in the Horde. She understood not being able to get back to sleep.

She sat on the floor to eat in the silence. Her mind involuntarily wandered to holding Catra’s limp body, feeling her take what she was certain was her last breath. Adora was far too tired to fight the onslaught of memories. Tears ran down her cheeks as she forced herself to eat. She remembered in sickening clarity the way her legs hurt when she regained consciousness after jumping off the ledge Catra fell from, the weak breathing as she held her mostly lifeless body, She-Ra coming back with a vengeance, Catra’s last breath.

Her mind wandered through memories from back in the Horde. Shadow Weaver had only sent a full electrical shock through her body one time for skipping training. Catra still ended up with the brunt of the punishment. Adora wiped her face and set her plate aside. She remembered every detail of being powerless to save Catra from anything Shadow Weaver did to her. Especially the first time they were caught kissing, the first time their minds were wiped of the incident. They were only twelve.

"Is this what they mean when they talk about love?" Catra asked after giving Adora another quick kiss. "Because if it is, then I think I love you".

"You said that yesterday". Adora giggled. "But I think I might love you too. I wish we didn't have to hide this".

"Someday we won't".

Adora matched Catra's warm smile and held her face gently. It wasn't their first kiss, but the spark they had when they did kiss for the first time never left. There were rules about it all. Romantic relationships weren't allowed. There was no love. They had to ignore everything about their changing bodies and desires.

Those were rules Adora was more than happy to break if it meant she could have Catra in that way.

She giggled again when Catra nuzzled the side of her neck and her mane tickled her nose. Catra pulled back and kissed the tip of her nose. The kisses were always innocent and soft. Just like all of the other touches. Adora held her face again and gently brought their lips together.

It was perfect until it wasn't.

When she opened her eyes at the sudden loss of the warm body in front of her, it felt like everything was crashing down around her and air left her lungs. Shadow Weaver had a terrified Catra by the back of the neck while sending a glare right into Adora.

"You know better".

Adora swallowed hard as tears welled in her eyes. She felt absolutely paralyzed and could only watch as Shadow Weaver's electricity surged through Catra. Adora could only watch while she was ungracefully thrown to the ground, only to be snapped upright again by their superior's magic. A hard hand came across Catra's face.

"Stop!" Adora finally screamed, having found her voice again. "Please! It… it won't happen again".

"You're right. It won't." Shadow Weaver sent another shock of magic through Catra. "Both of you, come with me. Immediately".

The only thing that broke through those gut wrenching memories was the occasional whimper from Catra. Part of her wanted to wake her up from a possible nightmare, but the other part thought it was just her usual occasional sounds she would make in her sleep. Lately it was hard to distinguish between the two. Adora looked up from the random spot on the floor she had been staring at when she heard Catra groan and roll over before she sat up, looking panicked.

"Hey," she said and quickly wiped the tears from her face before she stood up, "I'm right here. I didn't go far. I brought up some dinner".

Catra lowered her ears hugged herself as she got out of bed. She crossed the room and took her plate from the dresser and sat on the floor. Adora sat back down next to her and offered what little was left on her own plate. She liked to at least try to give her some options to pick from.

"Anything?"

Catra took a piece of the steamed fish from Adora's plate and stared at her own.

“You can have more if you want”.

“This is more than enough,” she said quietly. “Thanks”.

“Do you want Melog yet?” She asked as Catra took a small bite of the fish.

“N-no. Not yet”. Her tail twitched and Adora held it gently, idly stroking it. “How are they? Are they mad too?”

“No”. She gave a half smile. “They’re not mad. No one is. They’re just worried about you and want you give you the space you asked for. At least… that’s what I’m guessing considering I have no idea what they’re saying the few times I ran into them”.

Catra rested her head against Adora’s when she laid her head on her shoulder. “You’ve been crying”.

“Guilty”. She sighed quietly and resumed stroking the tail in her lap. “It’s just… things I wish I could forget”.

Catra only nodded.

“Are you not up for conversation yet?”

A shrug. “We can… try”.

“Okay”. Adora half chuckled when her tail twitched in her lap. “We can try. So… what did you do for fun while I was away?”

“I don’t know. I guess there was the one day I stole Bow’s quiver and made him chase me for it. He’s worse than you when it comes to climbing”. She took a small bite from a dumpling. “Oh, and we played princess dodgeball”.

“He’s only worse because he doesn’t have Horde training. Or ever tried to keep up with you through the Fright Zone. And I’m sure he didn’t have a grappling hook to help”. Adora raised her eyebrow. “What’s princess dodgeball?”

“You know, foam balls and a bunch of stupid rules”.

Catra set her plate beside herself, only managing to get through the small piece of fish, one dumpling, and a single small bite from the cake. She was just tired. Even the small conversation, although not forced, felt like it took too much energy.

“I love you,” Adora told her quietly and gently laced their fingers together. “And don’t say that I shouldn’t”.

She scoffed. Of course she already knew what she was going to say.

"I'm not holding your hand because I like you," she said instead.

"Yeah, keep telling yourself that. I know you like me".

"No. I don't". Catra closed her eyes. "I love you far more than I like you. Can we go to bed?"

"Are we done talking for the night?"

"Is… is that okay?" She asked and stood up before pulling Adora to her feet.

"Of course. You said more than you have in days". She stroked her cheek. "Any progress is good and I'll take the baby steps. Go lay down".

Adora picked the plates up off the floor and set them on the dresser. She would deal with them in the morning. It also wasn't completely unlike Catra to at least snack on the leftovers when she woke up on her own. When she turned back around, she saw Catra holding her arm out. Adora gave a small smile and healed the scratches without a word.

She waited until Carta was comfortable before crawling into bed with her. Except she clearly wasn't truly comfortable until she had her head on her chest and cuddled against her as close as she could. Adora kissed the top of her head and stroked her hair. There was still no sign of a content purr. Even if not completely audible, she could usually still feel it when they were laying like this. Adora resigned to still not getting at least the soft vibration she hoped for. The talking was progress. Good progress. Now she just hoped they could make it at least four hours before Catra was inevitably forced awake by her own mind.

Chapter End Notes

General info: Catra's a depressed mess as she runs through the things she's done and experienced in the Horde. We find out Adora has harmed herself in the past after leaving. Adora remembers things of the past as well. Prime related and the first time her and Catra got caught kissing at twelve years old (flashback, Shadow Weaver is physically abusive).

S: Okie dokie. This one hurt. I hope we gave enough warning. If anyone relates to Catra (in the show and even in this story) like I do, I'm sorry and I'm here for you if you need someone to listen and be there.

There is a possibility for another week of two posts. It'll depend on how work decides to be and how much editing the next chapter I can get done. Things won't be nearly as heavy and dark as this, though.

Here's hoping you all have a good rest of the weekend and upcoming week!

Indy: This chapter promises to be extremely painful and for those who wanna talk I'm here to listen. I promise that things will eventually get better and that they will have a happy life together.

Hope y’all have a good weekend and don’t hate us for the pain lol.

Involuntary

Chapter Notes

> A small warning for this one:
> Adora has a pretty rough PTSD episode that involves Catra being “dead”.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra quietly opened the bedroom door and looked down both directions of the hallway. She still hadn’t ventured out from her room in nearly a week. Adora at least felt a little more comfortable leaving the room while she was awake to grab something to eat, which is where she had currently disappeared to. Catra looked down the hallway again and finally took a small, tentative step out when there wasn’t any sign of a guard. Taking a deep breath, she closed the door behind her and slowly started to walk down the hall.

She wanted, needed, this. She was starting to feel a little too cooped up. Catra just didn’t feel like running into anyone. Her hair was a disheveled mess, more so now that it was a little longer than it had been after everything with Prime. Though, it still wasn’t long enough to pull back if she wanted to. She didn’t even feel like putting actual clothes on and wandered out in her sports bra and shorts. Her ears twitched at the quiet laughter coming from downstairs and decided to go investigate.

The further she got from her room, the more she could feel her hair and fur starting to stand on end. She didn’t want anyone other than Adora to see her like this. Once at the bottom of the stairs, Catra peered around the corner. There still wasn’t any real sign of a guard other than the one walking in the opposite direction and deemed it safe enough. The closer she got to the

dining hall, the lower she crouched to the floor. She came to a stop and crouched next to the doorway to listen in on the conversation.

"Come on! We need to do *something* !" Glimmer said. "You're looking rested again and I at least hope Catra has been feeling better too".

"No, no! Guys!" Adora half laughed. "I mean, I can ask her but don't be hurt if she absolutely refuses. She's feeling a little better, not hurting herself and sleeping a bit more, but… I don't know. She still doesn't really want to see anyone".

"So she's still not taking visitors?" Bow asked sadly.

"I haven't outright asked. I doubt it, though. I really should get back up. She actually mentioned being a little hungry". She picked up the plates. "She told me she didn't want to come down for lunch yet. Though… she did consider it a little longer this time. Maybe she'll come around about it soon".

"Well, ask her about the scavenger hunt. I'm sure she'll be really good at it," Glimmer said before doing a double take at the doorway. " *Catra* ?!"

She lowered her ears and rubbed one of her arms. She wasn't quite sure if it was the food that drew her from her hiding spot or the want to tell them to shove their scavenger hunt up their ass

simply because there was snow covering the ground. Whatever the reason, she wanted to turn around and get back to her room.

Catra was definitely having second thoughts about venturing out. Glimmer was smiling, clearly happy to see her for some reason. Bow looked like he was about to jump out of his seat to hug her. Micah seemed pleased to see that she was out of her room. Adora, however, had some kind of mix of shock, worry, and confusion plastered on her face.

"I said I'd be right back," Adora told her and set the plates back down on the table. "Is everything okay?"

Catra nodded and took a small step backwards. Fighting the urge to run, she quietly looked at her usual chair and back to Adora.

"Sure! You can join us". Adora stepped to the side to let her sit and put her plate in front of her before she kissed the top of her head. "If it's too much we can go back".

"You can go whenever you want, okay?" Bow reinforced with a small smile. "We won't force you to stay".

Catra glanced up briefly before looking back to her plate. At least there wasn't any real obligation to hang around for lunch.

“It really is nice to see you down here with us,” Glimmer told her calmly. “How… are you feeling?”

She shrugged a shoulder and started to slowly eat. The last thing she really wanted was a conversation. Just being in their presence again was almost overwhelming. Catra lifted her head just enough to look at Micah a question on her lips, and apparently on her face when he responded before she could even ask.

“The answer is no,” he said with authority. “I’m not letting you use it as a death sentence. You need to be in a better state of mind before I can, in good faith, allow you to return to Beast Island. Am I making myself clear?”

“But-“

“This is not up for discussion, Catra. Do you understand?”

“Yes,” her voice was weak as she looked back to her plate. “I understand”.

“Is that why you came down?” he asked.

Catra shook her head. It really wasn’t and she didn’t have any real reason to lie. Or have the energy. She took another small bite as Adora rubbed soothing circles on her upper back before taking her seat next to her to eat.

“I’m glad you’re at least looking like you feel better, even if your hair could use some help,” Glimmer told her.

Catra twitched her ear in acknowledgment. She still didn’t quite know what she wanted to do. Her only real focus was on the small lunch in front of her. The plan was to eat what she could stomach and get back to her room. Talking wasn’t part of the plan.

“So, do you think you’re up for a scavenger hunt?” Bow asked her cautiously.

Catra only shrugged. She was still largely undecided.

“You can talk to them, you know,” Adora said quietly and gently rubbed Catra’s forearm.

“I know,” she barely whispered. “It’s… I’m just… a little uncomfortable. I think”.

“You don’t have to finish lunch with us,” Glimmer tired to reassure.

“I… I want to try”. Catra finally looked to her friend. “If you’ll… let me”.

“Of course!” Glimmer gave her a warm smile. “Whatever you want to do”.

Lunch was otherwise mostly quiet. Catra only offered very short verbal responses to anything she was directly asked. Usually it was more physical responses. Shrugs, a nod, shaking her head, an occasional movement of her ears or tail. Some of which Adora needed to translate for everyone.

Catra only really kept her attention on the now empty plate in front of her. Everyone let her know she didn’t have to stay any longer if she was still uncomfortable. She just wanted to see how much longer she could handle being up and about now that she had food in her stomach. Quietly, Catra touched Adora’s leg under the table in search of a hand. Adora quickly held it under the table and gave it a comforting squeeze. She had a feeling she knew how taxing this was for her.

“We’re being serious about the scavenger hunt,” Glimmer said. “I’d really like it if you joined us, Catra. But I understand if you don’t want to”.

Adora could feel the hand in hers starting to tremble. The way Catra’s tail flicked about and the clenched jaw let her know she was thinking about it. She was running through every scenario, good and bad, to make a decision. Just like she did for battle simulations from what Adora could remember.

“Maybe for a little bit,” she finally said and glanced up. “After… after I take a nap. If that’s okay”.

Glimmer smiled and nodded. It was definitely more than okay if it meant Catra was finally coming out of her room a little more. It wasn't perfect, but it was a few more steps in the right direction. Maybe in a few weeks she'd be on her feet well enough to take on a short mission. That was the hope.

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Catra sat on the ledge of the window and looked out over the courtyard below. Maybe agreeing to the scavenger hunt wasn't such a good plan. She felt sick even thinking about it, but she had to try. Sleep was easier, she wasn't hurting herself, and she was actually eating fuller meals. The next logical step for getting better, at least to her, was to hang out with the other half of the best friend squad.

Maybe it was still too soon. Sitting through lunch was more exhausting than she thought it would be. Catra ended up asleep for two and a half hours instead of the quick one hour nap she was going to take. She half remembered Adora trying to wake her and she asked to let her sleep a little longer.

"Hey," Adora said quietly as she entered the bedroom. "You don't have to if it's too much right now. I'll let them know and then find us a deck of cards if you want to play a game".

Catra shook her head with a huff.

“What’s going on?”

“I don’t want to back out of it. I want to go do the scavenger hunt thing. At least try. But it’s just… I’m *tired* , Adora. I slept longer than I was planning to and… and I feel like I could still sleep”. She rested her chin on her knees. “It’s all I’ve been doing for a week. Sleep whenever I’m not eating or talking to you. I want to do things again but I’m just…” she let out a frustrated sigh.

“Tired?” She sat on the ledge with her. “I know you’re still not getting restful sleep often enough. You’re going to be tired. It’s okay, Cat. Really. They’ll understand”.

“No. I’m doing it. At least for a little bit”. Her eyes fell closed when Adora started running her knuckles along her jaw. “But I’m tired. I… I might have to come back up here before you guys are done with it”.

“And that’s okay. I want you to take your time. You’re starting to come out of one of the worst depressive episodes I’ve seen in *years* . We both know you’re not going to go back to normal overnight”. She gently scratched just under her ear and smiled when Catra leaned into it. “We all know that. Are you ready to head down?”

“I guess so”.

Catra slid from the window ledge and walked to their door. She stopped when a gentle hand landed on her shoulder.

"No," she stated when she turned and saw Adora holding up a pair of white and gold winter boots. "I'm not wearing your boots. Your feet are bigger than mine".

"I don't want to hear you complain that your feet are freezing then. I… don't have any other shoes to offer other than sandals". Adora put the boots back in the closet. "Unless you want these". She gestured to her usual boots she was wearing. "I'll wear the winter ones".

"I will break my ankle if I'm trying to run around in your shoes. Period. Next time I go the Fright Zone, I'll grab my winter gear, alright?" She opened the door. "Besides, it's only a little snow. It's not like we're going to the Northern Reach".

Adora chuckled and followed her out. She knew it was a matter of time before Catra was totally 'not asking' for her jacket or shaking her feet in an attempt to force feeling back into her toes. One freak snow storm that hit the Fright Zone when they were little taught her that even Catra's feigned indifference had certain limits. One limit was in the form of extended exposure to snow on her feet and any that clung to her fur. The only other random round of snow to ever hit, they were in their early teens and had Catra accepting the issued winter gear without hesitation. Sure, Bright Moon didn't have much more than an inch, but snow was snow and Adora knew what was coming.

They met Glimmer and Bow at the doors to the courtyard. Bow was in the middle of taking off his coat when Catra narrowed her eyes. She appreciated the gesture but she was definitely not wearing his coat. Or mittens. It's not like it was even that cold. Besides, she had fur.

"Would it kill you to at least wear something on your feet?" Glimmer asked.

"I own one pair of shoes and they're my winter boots from the Horde. And they're at the Fright Zone". Catra shrugged. "And yes, it would kill me. Have you seen the size of Adora's feet? I'm not wearing hers."

"Hey! My feet are average!" Adora crossed her arms. "Yours are just small".

"Maybe, but they're proportionate".

"So are mine! I'm taller!"

Glimmer smiled at the interaction. That was the Catra she knew, full of snark and willing to poke teasing jabs. Things were slowly getting better and back to some kind of sense of normalcy.

"Alright, alright," she said and grabbed the two by the arm. "Enough about who's taller and foot size. Are we going outside or

not?”

“Fine”. Catra dramatized a groan. “Only if she admits she has She-Ra sized feet”.

“I do!” Adora huffed. “ *As She-Ra* ”.

“Yeah, yeah. Whatever”. Catra waved her off with a chuckle. “Let’s just do this scavenger hunt thing”.

She followed Bow and Glimmer outside and flinched slightly at the cold gust of wind. It seemed like her fur did absolutely nothing to help. She was having some second thoughts about not at least asking Adora for one of her shirts. Catra flicked an ear while she continued to follow her friends.

“Alright, so what the first riddle of this thing?” She asked.

“I didn’t realize we had some freezing rain before the snow,” Glimmer said with a smile. “We’re going to show you something!”

Catra raised her eyebrow.

“The garden looks so cool with the fresh glaze of ice!” Bow said excitedly. “You need to see it. You never have yet”.

“I mean, it is kinda pretty,” Adora said with a smile. “You’ll love it”.

“I’ve seen ice before. Northern Reach and there were the two freak winter storms the Fright Zone had when we were still there”. Catra shrugged. “It’s just ice”.

“It’s not that kind of ice.” Bow told her. “I promise. I just hope the guards finished clearing the- woah!”

Catra felt her foot slip and quickly crouched down to dig her claws into the patch of ice. Adora barely missed grabbing Catra’s shoulder as she slipped and landed flat on her ass. Bow slid a couple feet rather gracefully even as Glimmer grabbed his arm. The guards clearly hadn’t gotten around to clearing the ice from some of the walkways yet.

Adora carefully got to her feet and took small steps to get across the small patch of ice with Bow and Glimmer. Catra chose to stay on all fours with her claws digging into the ice as she crossed the few feet to not slippery ground. She quietly cursed the winter season under her breath as she stood upright and continued to follow her friends into the garden.

She did have to admit that the glaze of ice primarily on elevated surfaces was kinda pretty. Catra could feel a smile tugging at her lips when Adora found a patch of ice and took a running start to slide across it with a laugh. She watched quietly while Glimmer joined her and laughed when they slid into each other.

“Come on, Catra!” Adora urged while she got back to her feet. “Don’t just stand there”.

She rolled her eyes and started to gather what snow she could that would pack together. When the other three weren’t exactly paying attention, Catra threw the small snowball she managed at Glimmer and hit her in the shoulder. The queen was quickly in front of her in a single poof. Without warning, Glimmer threw a handful of powdery snow into her face before quickly teleporting away.

“Hey!” She yelped and brushed the snow from her ears and cheeks.

“So much for those catlike reflexes,” Glimmer joked and gathered more snow in her hands. “You started it”.

Adora snuck up behind Bow with her own handful of snow and promptly put it down the back of his coat. He yelled in shock when some even went down the back of his shirt.

“No,” Catra warned and stepped backwards with a finger pointed at Adora who wore a smirk that always meant trouble. “Don’t. Adora, I swear. Put the snow dow- Sparkles!”

Catra quickly started trying to shake the snow from her hair from the snowball that hit her in the back of the head. This was nowhere near the scavenger hunt she had agreed to. While she was occupied, Adora tackled her with a laugh like she was a kid again. So far the only one not on her shit list was Bow. Granted, she knew he was always a little worried about the claws coming out.

"Isn't this better than a scavenger hunt?" Adora asked after rolling Catra onto her back. "And better than staying in".

"You know I'm not particularly a fan of snow. Especially when it starts matting in my fur". She quickly flipped their positions and threw a handful of snow into Adora's face. "But I will admit *that* was fun".

Adora's shit eating smile never left her face. She cracked an eye open with a laugh and returned the favor without warning. Catra was wiping her face off when Adora flipped their positions again and pinned her hands down.

"Are you cold?" She asked and let go when she felt Catra shiver under her.

"What? No! I'm fine".

Adora let her sit up and yelped when at least two handfuls of snow were thrown down the back of her shirt. She didn't even

have a chance to get to her feet when more snow found her face.

"Glimmer!"

"Then pay attention next time!"

Glimmer set her sights on Bow next. Catra watched her chase him around with her hands full of snow. Bow's foot caught a slick spot and sent him face down just before Glimmer added insult to injury by dumping the snow she had on the back of his head. As Catra laughed, Adora took her jacket off and wrapped it around Catra's shoulders.

"You're shivering, Cat. Come here". Adora got to her feet and pulled Catra to hers. "How are your feet?"

"My feet are fine". She flicked her ear when she took a step and finally noticed her toes were a little numb. "Well… cold. But I was just rolling around in the snow, no thanks to you".

Adora gave her a warm smile when she pulled the jacket around herself tighter. Catra would never admit she was probably freezing, especially with the bitter cold wind. Fur or not, the wind was unpleasant. Adora gently pulled some clumped snow from the fur on her cheeks and jaw before kissing her forehead.

"I thought this was supposed to be a scavenger hunt, Sparkles".

“Hey, it got you out of the castle, didn’t it?” Her smile fell away at the scowl she received. “Oh, you know you were having fun”.

“You could have just asked if I wanted to play in the snow with you guys”. Catra tried to hide another shiver.

“I thought it was a scavenger hunt too,” Adora said as she wrapped her arms around her girlfriend in an attempt to provide some warmth. “But this was more fun”.

Catra scoffed and slipped from Adora’s arms before sending Glimmer a glare. “Not only did Shadow Weaver teach you magic, she taught you how to manipulate us too. *Wonderful*”.

“Catra, no…” Glimmer sighed as her friend carefully climbed into a nearby tree. “I didn’t mean to make it seem like that. That’s the furthest thing from my intention. I just… I wanted to see you out of the castle and having fun again. Can we go back to that? I won’t throw any more snow at you”.

“Not in the mood”. Catra found a sturdy limb and sat on it with her back against the trunk. She curled her tail around her ankles and pulled Adora’s jacket around herself tighter. “I’m done for the day”.

“I honestly didn’t think you’d say you were okay with joining us without some kind of incentive,” Glimmer tried. “I didn’t mean to upset you”.

“Catra, come down,” Adora said gently as she stood at the bottom of the tree. “We can go back to our room where it’s warm”.

The only response was Catra tucking her chin and nose under the collar of the jacket.

“I’ll brush the snow out of your fur and hair,” she tried. “And you can hog the blankets all to yourself until you get too warm”.

Bow put a hand on Adora’s shoulder with a smile. She turned to him with her eyebrow raised.

“I would say you could have hot chocolate with the rest of us,” he told Catra, “but I know it really upsets your stomach and makes you feel kinda sick. So… how about a small glass warm milk instead?”

“Milk upsets my stomach a little too, you know”. Catra’s tail fell from around her ankles and she didn’t really notice the tip started twitching as it hung down. “Not as bad, but still”.

“That’s why I said a *small* glass. Was the last time too much?”

Catra shook her head.

"Alright. So how about you come down and I'll get you some? You won't even have to talk to Glimmer for the rest of the night".

"Hey!" Glimmer protested.

"Shhh!" He lightly scolded before he smiled at the continued twitch in the tip of Catra's tail. "You do know I can see your tail, right? Adora's told me before that the tip twitching like that either means curiosity or excitement. Which is it?"

Catra quickly wrapped her tail back around her ankles. "Leave my tail- ugh! Fine! I want your stupid milk, okay?"

Adora started to completely ignore the meeting. She wasn't exactly pleased about doing more work on one of the many abandoned spires from the war in the middle of winter. The other topic was something to do with a sandstorm that had unburied some First Ones tech in the Crimson Waste. Huntara had expressed concern about the thieves and bandits that hadn't pledged any loyalty interfering with retrieval. Adora knew she was needed around the Bright Moon area. Rather, She-Ra was needed. Adora herself had one of her most hated things to look forward to. Paperwork. She just wanted to go back to a couple weeks ago when they were all having fun in the snow.

She mentally returned to the meeting at Catra's voice, more insistent than she had heard it in several weeks.

"I'll go. I think it would be a wise choice".

"Are you sure you're not just going to kill yourself out there?" Glimmer asked and folded her arms. "My father is still forbidding you from going to Beast Island again. Can we trust you in the Crimson Waste?"

"For fuck sake, Sparkles". She pulled up a holographic map of the dig site on the surface of the table. "Look. If I can have Bow and Scorpia with me, we can cover this area without a problem. Entrapta can do whatever she wants with the tech while Huntara and her goons are digging".

"And what's your plan?"

Catra smacked her forehead into her hand. "I just- *your majesty* , I don't think I need to remind you I took over the place in less than a day while you," she pointed to Glimmer, Bow, and Adora, "all got walked right into an ambush on your first day. Oh, and we managed to steal the ship out from under you three. To recap, Entrapta's going to play with the tech, Bow can take any high ground he needs, Scorpia is the muscle, and I have the experience you need to make sure nothing fucks up. It would be wise to send me. I promise I'm okay enough to at least go to the Crimson Waste".

Adora watched the stare down between her friend and girlfriend. She felt a little bitter she couldn't be part of the team to go. They wouldn't have to do so much digging if she could. A small part of her was saying that it was also for the best with the headaches she'd been having the past couple of days. She knew she shouldn't have be ignoring the throbbing in her skull.

The last time the headaches and migraines happened, she nearly got her hands on Wrong Hordak in the worst way. He ended up being in the wrong place at the worst time. Adora had decided to try drinking even more water to at least try to ease the splitting migraine. Something absolutely snapped when she saw the clone. The migraine was gone, but she was instantly so full of unbridled rage that she had involuntarily transformed and her sights were set on Wrong Hordak. If it wasn't for Glimmer teleporting her and Micah quickly doing a containment spell to keep her in the war room, the clone would be dead.

She remembered screaming about how much he supposedly hurt Catra, willing to let her die, and how dare they let him even be near the castle, let alone in it. It took a good fifteen minutes for her to even be able to transform back. After she did, all she remembered was breaking down in tears and flat out begging for Catra.

That was several months ago, maybe a month or two after unleashing the magic. Adora knew she should be at least a little concerned, but felt it wasn't worth making anyone worry. She hadn't snapped yet. There wasn't really anything to throw her into a PTSD episode, except maybe the nightmare she had overnight.

“With respect, your majesty,” Scorpia said, “I think Catra asking for others to go with her should prove she’s at least doing better than a few weeks go”.

“Fine”. Glimmer locked eyes with Catra. “I’ll allow it. Consider this something like an evaluation test. If you complete your little mission without your selected team worrying about what you may do to yourself, within reason because I know how you can be in general, then-“

“What’s that supposed to mean?!”

Glimmer held up her hand. “Then I will let my father have full authority to decide if you get to have your second Beast Island trip with Hordak. Am I understood?”

Catra sighed and nodded. “Yes, your majesty”.

“We’re just looking out for you, Catra. That’s all”. She turned her attention to Adora who had her head in her hands. “Adora? Are you okay?”

“Yeah!” She looked up and smiled despite the light in the room making her head pound more. “I’m okay. Just… uh, thinking about how exactly we’re going to repurpose that spire out by Elberon”.

“Erelandia,” Glimmer corrected. “Are you sure-“

"I'm fine, Glimmer! A spire is a spire at this point. Most of them are damaged enough we're going to have to tear them down. We can melt the metal down and use it for… whatever we need to". Adora closed her eyes when her ear started ringing. "The one near Erelandia needs to be completely gutted if we're repurposing it for anything. I'll take Mermista and Frosta with me. It's the middle of winter and the more help I have dealing with *that* issue, the better".

Catra rubbed Adora's leg under the table. She knew something wasn't right when Adora had moved her hand to cover her left ear and still hadn't opened her eyes.

"Are you sure you're okay?" Catra asked quietly.

Adora nodded and let out a long breath. She hoped in vain that Catra couldn't feel her leg twitching under her hand. Her girlfriend knew some of the signs she gave when she was fighting off an involuntary transformation. It wasn't often, but there had definitely been times where she was almost too happy about something and had to suppress it when Catra had been present.

Glimmer looked at Mermista and Frosta while keeping Adora in her peripheral vision. "Is, uh, that request for aide alright?"

The two nodded quietly while Glimmer looked back to Adora.

“Adora, you have your team set. You three should get started in the morning. Catra, you and your team will head out tomorrow afternoon”. Glimmer looked at everyone else. “Questions?”

“Are we done here?” Adora asked, still not looking up.

“I… think so. Are you sure you’re okay?”

“Yeah. I just… need to…. I don’t know”. She stood up and quickly left the war room.

Adora knew Catra called out to her but she couldn’t stay. She quickly went into the closest empty room and closed the door.

“What are you protecting me from?!” She yelled at herself after giving into the transformation. “There’s no danger around here, I slept fine, and *you’re* the one pissing me off right now with the headaches again!”

“Adora?” Catra said from the other side of the door with a knock. “I know you’re in there. What’s going on?”

She sighed and opened the door for her. Her fists clenched at the concerned look she was being given.

“What’s with… this?” Catra vaguely gestured at the height of She-Ra.

“I don’t know!” Adora grabbed her head again. “The… involuntary transformations happen with intense emotion or out of protection, you know that. I don’t know what the fuck *her* deal is right now”.

“Headaches like the last time you told me what happened?” Catra’s tail swayed behind her idly. “Listen, love, I’m fine. I’m here. It’s not a First One’s ruin simulation. You destroyed the sword. Adora, you’re in control now. Not them”. She sat on the floor and patted the space beside her. “Sit”.

Adora sat next to her and put her forehead on her knees. “I can’t transform back yet”.

“That’s okay. Let’s work through this like we did before. Are you worried that I’m in danger currently?”

She shook her head.

“Are those spires stressing you out?”

“A little”.

“Okay”. Catra scooted closer so their hips were touching and wrapped her tail around Adora on the floor. “How about we only focus on one at a time. You’re going to Erelandia in the morning. It sounds like the plan is to gut the inside of it and build something new, right?”

Adora nodded.

“Focus on getting it gutted. Nothing else matters with it right now. Just clear it out”. She rubbed Adora’s back gently. “I’ll be out in the Crimson Waste for two days. And I promise I’ll be careful. You don’t need to worry about that right now either. I’ll call you when I can, just like you did, okay? Tell your inner She-Ra to chill and that I’m not in any kind of danger I can’t handle. And neither are you”.

She transformed back as soon as she felt herself able to do so and laid down on her back. Her head still hurt but it wasn’t as bad. Adora lifted her head when Catra moved before laying it back down on her thigh.

“Learn to relax a little more,” Catra said. “I’m willing to bet that’s part of the problem with this”.

Adora scratched her head as she flipped through a folder Glimmer had given her. Everyone asking for help had finally started to flow into Bright Moon now that the magical high was over and with her best friend giving her the position of her co-leader of the Princess

Alliance, that meant she had to start making plans to help with more rebuilding. Getting the spire near Erelandia completely gutted a couple days ago went mostly flawlessly. The requests for aide were mostly about clones showing up, wanting information on nearby spires, or general aide and supplies for rebuilding.

She rubbed her face when she read the report of yet another clone group wandering into Thaymor in search of food and shelter. The people had every right to be wary and have the desire for them to be relocated as soon as possible. She grabbed her tracker pad and called Entrapta.

"Hello, Adora!"

"Hey, important question. How long will it take you to get to Thaymor?"

"Approximately… two hours and thirty two minutes. Why?" Entrapta vanished from the screen. "No, no! Put that down! Hordak, can you please get a handle on… which one are you?"

"There's a few more clones if you think you can handle more. If not, I can see if we can house them here for now". She rubbed her forehead.

"Oh, I can always use more help!" She popped back into frame. "Thaymor, you said? How many?"

“Uh,” she looked over the paper in front of her, “three. I can ask Scorpia too”.

“Don’t be ridiculous! The six I have are doing wonderful here!”

“Okay, okay. I’ll get Swift Wind to let them know you’re on your way”.

Adora ended the call just as her steed barged into the old war room. “Did somebody say-“

“Yes. I did. Can you let Thaymor know Entrapta is coming for the clones? Thanks”.

“Oh, you’re not doing well. Your hair poof fell out”.

Adora sighed and tried to wave him off.

“Ah, I’m sure Catra will be home soon. She only went to the Crimson Waste to aide Huntara, right?”

She only nodded and worked her jaw. That’s what she was going to keep telling herself. Catra would be home soon. That they had

even talked the night before. Finally, Swift Wind understood he wasn't going to get anywhere with her at the moment and left her alone in the room.

Adora snapped the folder closed and put her face in her hands. The distraction was helping the migraine, but it surged with a vengeance the moment Catra was mentioned. Then there was that damn ringing in her ears.

Everyone was so certain Catra was out in the Crimson Waste. How could she be when she was gone? Adora failed. The pulse from the Heart killed her, right in front of her. She didn't pull up her shield fast enough. A confession of love followed by kissing her moments before she was gone, before she felt the last exhale against her own lips. Not even She-Ra could save her.

Adora smacked the file off the table as she felt her body threaten a transformation. She just had to wake up from such a perfect dream. Catra was *with* her, they kissed so much more, she remembered their entire relationship before the war, they made love many times. And she quickly woke up to an empty spot next to her before she forced herself to numbly get on with her day. Finally, she let herself cry. Maybe if she just let it out, she could push away the headache and the ringing in her ears.

"Adora?"

Glimmer took her seat next to her sobbing friend, ignoring the scattered papers on the floor. She put a hand on her shoulder only to have it smacked away.

“Alright, what’s going on? You’ve been acting off since the meeting. Mermista even told me she was worried about you”.

“Don’t you *dare* lie to me, Glimmer,” she cried. “Where is Catra?”

“The Crimson Waste,” she told her, a little confused. “She should be back here soon. I just talked with her and Bow”.

“Bullshit!” Adora stood and wiped her face angrily. Her eyes held a blue glow even as she fought it. “How dare you say something like that! Why… why can’t you, of all people, just tell me the truth? I know she’s gone, okay?!”

Glimmer reached for her when she grabbed her head again. That time, she couldn’t fight it and transformed. Glimmer sighed and finally realized what was going on and stood before grabbing Adora’s hands. She’s panicked about this kind of thing many times before. It had just been a while since it was so severe. And She-Ra wasn’t involved those times.

“Adora, I promise she’s okay. She might be a little scraped up when she gets home, but I *swear* she’s very much alive”. She squeezed the hands in hers. “Look at me”.

“Glimmer, please, just…” she roughly pulled her hands away, “leave me alone”.

Adora left the room and desperately tried to transform back to no avail. She shoved past several guards and left the castle. All she knew was she needed to leave before she turned violent like last time, especially if her best friend was going to be her target. So she ran.

Somewhere along the way, her strides grew shorter when she transformed back. Her lungs burned, begging for oxygen as she continued to run and cry. Whenever the tears had started again, she didn't know. She didn't know how far she got into the woods until she fell to her knees while the sobs took over. Adora grabbed her head in an attempt to rationalize what was reality and what wasn't. The headache was still ever present but she couldn't find enough of her own magic to transform again even if she wanted to.

Everyone was certain her girlfriend was just in the Crimson Waste. The one person who she thought would always tell her the truth, no matter how painful, even said so. Adora curled in on herself so tight her forehead was on her knees while she sat on her heels. Nothing made sense. Everything before this morning had to be the most perfect dream.

Adora swallowed a sob and tucked her hand into the collar of her shirt and found the scar Catra had given her a few months ago. If it was all a dream, that definitely shouldn't have been there. Unless she had some fucked up one night stand with some other magicat hybrid.

She didn’t know how long she stayed there. At least long enough she ran out of tears to cry and just felt like puking instead. Her breathing was still unsteady and labored. She felt a hand on her back as snow crunched behind her, giving away someone had crouched down.

“I said leave me alone, Glimmer,” she said quietly, her voice hoarse from sobbing for so long.

“Ouch. If you were going to guess who I was, you could have picked someone less insulting”.

“Catra?” Adora looked over her shoulder.

“Hey, Adora”. She put a hand on each shoulder and gave a squeeze. “Sparkles said I’d probably find you out here”.

“When did you get back?”

“About a half hour ago”. Catra wrapped her arms around her from behind and rested her chin on her shoulder. “It took me fifteen minutes to find you, even with following your footprints. Care to tell me what happened?”

“I thought… I thought you died at the Heart. Th-that I didn’t get my shield over you in time”. She put her face in her hands,

shocked she even had a single tear to shed. “Please tell me you’re not some stupid simulation of my mind”.

“Hit me”.

Adora broke Catra’s hold and turned to face her. “Are you *insane*?! I’m not hitting you”.

“If I’m a simulation, it won’t actually hurt me, right?”

“Catra, I’m *not* going to hit you”.

“Then kiss me”.

Adora tackled her backwards, crashing their lips together. She sighed against her lips in relief that Catra had her familiar warmth, her lips tasted exactly how they should, she smelled like herself mixed with the unmistakable smokiness from the cantina in the Crimson Waste. She was as real as it could get.

Catra held her hips as her girlfriend held her face tightly as she kissed her with need. It wasn’t sexual, just the pure need to know nothing was fake. She let Adora set the pace of their kiss. It grew deeper, more desperate, as her hands wandered into her hair.

“You’re here,” Adora whispered against her lips, fresh tears slipping from her eyes.

“I’m here,” Catra confirmed and sat up with her still in her arms. “Bad day?”

Adora nodded and sighed. She felt Catra’s tail curl around her waist and pressed their foreheads together. The headache had eased into one she knew for certain was related to the amount she had ran and cried, exhaustion and dehydration lumped into one.

“Wanna head back? It’ll be getting dark soon”. She gave her a quick kiss and chuckled softly when she heard Adora’s stomach growl. “Plus I’m sure you could use something to eat”.

Scorpia quietly approached Catra, who was laying on her back in the middle of the garden with her arms out to the side. Her friend had one of Adora’s shirts on, clearly a little too big for her smaller frame, and white and gold boots that were clearly not hers. She wasn’t sure if she was just enjoying the warmth from the day moon overhead or if she was actually asleep. Or even dead with the way she looked.

The last thought was quickly erased as an option when she finally saw Catra’s chest rise when she inhaled. Still, she wasn’t sure if her friend was asleep or just relaxing. So Scorpia just stood there

quietly before visibly jumping when her friend spoke, still not moving from her position.

"You don't have to just stand there, Scorpia".

"How'd you know it was me?" She asked and stepped closer.

"My nose hasn't failed me yet. You can sit with me if you want".

"Oh, I don't want to interrupt…" she paused and tried to figure it out before just saying, "whatever you're doing".

"Laying in the daylight. It's been a few days since we actually got to see the day moon because of the clouds". Catra barely cracked an eye open. "But if you're going to stand there, at least stand so you're blocking it from my eyes".

"So I heard Adora had a… um… a really bad episode," Scorpia said as she sat next to her.

"And you came here to talk about how I'm handling it". She rolled to her side, facing away. "I don't want to. We already talked it over. She said she was going to talk to Perfuma about it too".

“As your friend, I just want to try to help you process it. I know how you can get”. Scorpia used her own tail to clear snow from the space behind herself. “Plus I know you don’t particularly like snow and you’re laying in it”.

Catra stayed quiet and curled her tail around herself.

“Come on. Just a little?”

“I’m worried about her, okay? She hasn’t freaked out like that in a really long time. I mean, I didn’t see it”. She drug a claw through the snow in front of her face. “Sparkles filled me in on what happened and what she was saying. Adora told me it felt like she woke up into a nightmare from an amazing dream. And the headaches”.

“Headaches?”

“I don’t really understand it, no one does. I guess she involuntarily transforms if she’s feeling a massive wave of emotion, good or bad, or if She-Ra or her inner magic or whatever feels like she’s in danger and won’t transform on her own. Usually she has to fight it when she’s insanely happy”. Catra rolled over to face her friend. “Adora told me it starts with headaches, at least when it’s negative. She also said Perfuma told her it could be related to her trauma from the war”.

“Like how you freeze, stare off into nothing, tremble, and cry when you have your episodes? Only…” Scorpia raised an eyebrow. “She transforms unwillingly instead?”

“At least twice. I think if it’s extremely bad. And I mean extremely. You’ve seen her go through it similar to how I do and She-Ra doesn’t take over. And she’s had some pretty bad ones without… all of this happening”.

Scorpia laid back next to her friend to watch the clouds overhead. “I understand. At least a little. I’m no She-Ra or anything”.

“Huh?” Catra rolled over to face Scorpia.

“I sometimes get flashes from when… from when I was chipped. I hurt you. I hurt Adora. I hurt… Perfuma. Or tried to”. She rolled her head over to look at Catra with a sad smile. “I know it’s not easy”.

“Why haven’t you said anything?” She propped herself on her elbow. “Seriously, Scorpia. You’re always telling me to talk about this shit”.

“I talk to Perfuma about it”. She laughed softly. “It’s alright”.

“So, here’s the thing, I tell you and Perfuma all the time that I talk to Adora about it and both of you tell me I need to talk to more

people than just her". She cocked an eyebrow. "Did I understand that right?"

Scorpia sighed and looked back at the sky. "You did. But Adora's not a therapist like Perfuma. And I know I'm not either, but I've know you longer. And I was almost like a third party in everything. The thinking is that it would be easier for you to talk to me because of it".

Catra flopped back down onto her back and watched the clouds pass over head. A comfortable silence came between the two. The logic behind what Scorpia said was sound. It was a lot easier to talk to her than the flower princess sometimes. Especially if it was anything relating to being in the Horde basically her whole life.

"I wasn't the greatest friend to you," Catra suddenly said.

"No, but you're working on it now. That's what counts, wildcat". Scorpia laughed and pointed a pincer at the sky. "That one sorta looks like Emily".

"I guess". Catra sighed and closed her eyes. "Do you think I… deserve having you all as friends? Or… or Adora's love?"

"Of course I do!" She bumped a pincer against Catra's arm. "You went through… a lot is an understatement. Honestly, we could all tell how much Adora loved you through everything. And how

much you loved her. Everything was so messed up then that I swear you two were the only ones who didn't notice".

"Probably," she mumbled and stretched.

Catra opened her eyes again to watch the clouds. Scorpia wasn't one to lie to anyone, ever, even if she later apologized profusely with a crushing hug if the truth hurt. She had to believe her friend, or at least try to. Hopefully one day she could believe it wholeheartedly herself.

Chapter End Notes

S: I really wanted to get this out midweek so we could do part one of a two part thing today. Unfortunately, life happens and this past week was… a lot of emotions for me. Overwhelming at times, even. With all of that, I only really had the mental ability to work on making sure this chapter was good to go for today and hope you enjoyed it!

Indy: Things have been crazy for the both of us. We both have been mentally shaky at best. It comes and goes for me but it had gotten worse. School continues to press on for me. We hope you enjoy this chapter.

Of Course I Love You! (Pt 1)

Chapter Notes

> There's smut in this one starting at:
>
> She walked up the ramp and transformed back. There wasn't any sign Catra had even really gone to the ship in the first place. That was, until she heard a chuckle coming from the bridge.
>
> And ending at (there's also a chapter break):
>
> Adora smiled at Catra while she fixed her ponytail and walked back to the party beside her. Their hour and a half away from the party left them both a little on the disheveled side. Carta barely had the energy to walk without a small gimp, let alone fix her hair or smooth out her shirt after simply tossing it on.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hey, *She-Ra* ," Catra practically sang as she stepped from around a stack of crates and tugged on the short tail of Adora's shirt.

Adora jumped, nearly dropping the tree that was over her shoulder. Once she got her grip back on it, she glanced down and smiled.

"Do you need something?"

"Oh, I don't know". Catra stepped in front of her and looked her up and down. "I might need another tree moved".

“Stop looking at me like that,” she lightly scolded. “We’re *working* ”.

Catra scoffed and stepped forward to run a finger down Adora’s torso while looking up at her. A teasing smile came to her face when a faint blush came to her girlfriend’s cheeks. She did it again, only this time with all of her fingers. Her hand slowed specifically over her stomach, picturing the muscle underneath the shirt. Adora, even not in her tall warrior form, was very strong and toned. It just became far more evident when she was like this.

“Don’t drop the tree,” Catra teased around a purr, clearly seeing the small shiver her touch caused.

“ *Catra* ”. Adora took a sharp breath as fingers ran back up her stomach. “I’m… taking this over to be cut down for fire wood and-,” she swallowed hard when Catra’s claws gently joined the next slow track down her front, “ *knock it off* ”.

“Or what, *princess* ?” She challenged.

“I… l haven’t figured it out. Y-you could go grab an axe and, uh… help out. You’re *so* distracting right now!”

“I know”. She smirked and brushed her tail against Adora’s thigh. “It’s fun. Oh, there really is another tree that needs moved”.

“Catra!” She yelled after her as she walked away with a purposefully flirtatious flick of her tail.

Adora groaned in mild frustration and shifted the tree over her shoulder. She continued on her path to where a group of Thaymor villagers were waiting. After she gently lowered the tree to the ground and looked up, she froze.

Catra had that damn smirk on her face as she walked over with an axe over her shoulder with her wrist idly resting on the handle. Adora wasn’t exactly being serious about helping like that. Yet here she was, teasing her. Daring her to do something about it.

“ *What* are you doing?” She asked in disbelief.

“Helping”. Catra swung her axe down and left the blade imbedded in the trunk and folded her arms. “*Exactly* like you said”.

“You… I…” Adora glanced at the group of villagers and just stared at Catra instead.

“Out with it, princess. Don’t be shy now”.

“Nothing,” she finally managed and turned around as she felt her face get warmer when Catra dislodged the blade.

“Whatever you say!” Catra laughed. “Chop chop with that other tree!”

Adora balled her hands into fists as she walked away and heard a solid contact of the axe against the trunk. She had half a mind to turn back, take the tool from Catra, and drag her off to the woods for a little while. Maybe she could have a little payback still. She effortlessly lifted the tree Catra had mentioned. Making a bunch of firewood wasn’t particularly what Adora thought she’d be doing with her day while it seemed like everyone else was swinging a hammer or cooking food or stringing lights for their springtime party.

A party.

Adora smirked at that thought. She could easily get payback at a party. For now, though, she would settle with the small jaw drop she got from Catra when she lifted the tree directly over her head.

“Where’s it going?” She asked.

Catra only pointed to the ground in front of her. Her tail flicking gave her interest away. Adora exaggerated slowly lowering the tree to the ground, secretly loving the way her girlfriend was undressing her with her eyes.

“Focus, kitty cat,” Adora whispered only loud enough for her to hear. She gently grabbed Catra’s chin with her thumb and

forefinger with her own teasing smirk. Adora felt her swallow hard as her eyes flicked from her chest to her arms and back to her face. " *You* have work to do".

Adora heard a low, frustrated growl come from behind her as she walked away. She knew they still had a couple hours of this. Now, it was just a game to see who would break first.

The hours seemed to drag by. Catra brought the axe down in a final swing, splitting the last chunk of the second tree, before dropping it to the ground. She worked up a sweat in an effort to keep away any thoughts of letting Adora, or specifically She-Ra, absolutely have her way with her. As she was picking up the pieces of wood and stacking them neatly by one of the tents, a pair of hands she would recognize anywhere grabbed several pieces from in front of her.

"Sorry," Adora fake apologized when Catra glanced up, "we need these for the fire pit".

"Then take what you want. There's plenty".

"Oh, don't worry. *I will* ".

Catra shot her a partial glare at the comment. If they weren't at some village she was still trying to get to at least acknowledge she wasn't the enemy anymore, she would have completely jumped on the idea that was laced in those words. Even if she

was about to throw restraint to the wind as it was. Catra was aching and Adora wasn't helping the situation.

"What's wrong?" Adora asked a little too sweetly.

"Y-you need to take that, uh, firewood and walk away," she stammered and grabbed another chunk of wood.

Adora smirked when Catra dropped the few chunks in her hands as she scratched the base of her tail.

"Oh?"

" *Adora* ," she hissed and picked the chunks back before frantically shoving them into her girlfriend's empty hand. "Is that going to be enough for the pit?"

"Hmmm. Maybe a couple more".

"Are you sure?" Catra ran a hand through her hair, forcing it to stay down at the back of her head. "Your hands are full".

"Okay, maybe I just want to see you bend over again".

A bit of an evil smirk came to Catra's face just as she thought about walking away from the situation. Instead of simply obliging, she stood in front of Adora and pushed several chunks of wood from her hands.

" Oops ".

"Seriously? What are you-"

Catra narrowed her eyes and she squatted down in front of her to pick up a few of the pieces. She could smell how turned on her towering girlfriends was. Just to make it worse, she took her time and left a hand on the back of her thigh so she was only picking up the wood one piece at a time.

Adora was pretty sure she forgot how to breathe for a moment when she felt the gentle pinpricks of claws against her thigh. Catra slowly stood while dragging her hand up the back of Adora's leg and stopped with a quick squeeze of her ass. Adora took the pieces of wood back with a frustrated sigh and went to take them to the fire pit when a tail brushing against her hand stopped her.

"Cat- oh…"

"I thought you wanted a couple more," Catra said as she was back on her knees, reaching for a few more pieces while making sure Adora had a great view of her ass in the air.

“Y-yeah. Um, that’s… that’s good. A couple more pieces. Thanks”.

Adora walked over to the fire pit in a bit of a daze. At this rate, Catra was going to be the death of her. She dropped the wood into the pit and sat down. Part of her wanted to change back to her normal self, but she didn’t exactly want to have to transform back in a few minutes when she was inevitably needed as She-Ra.

Unfortunately, all that kept running through her mind was having Catra bent over in front of her. Maybe, just maybe, they could sneak away to Darla for a few minutes. Adora groaned and rested her head on her knees, almost begging those thoughts to go away for a while. But Catra just had to take that cheap shot and now that’s all she could think about. She debated if she would even change back to her smaller self. The thought never fully crossed her mind until now. Maybe that’s what Catra wanted. Some time alone with She-Ra.

As if she summoned her girlfriend by thought alone, she saw Catra sauntering up to her with a playful smirk plastered on her face. Still, Adora crossed her legs and patted her lap to invite Catra to sit with her. She knew it wasn’t the brightest move with the mood they both seemed to be in. Her arms easily wrapped around Catra’s smaller frame once she got herself comfortable in her lap. Adora rested her chin on the top of her head while her girlfriend drew lazy lines and patterns over one of her forearms with a content purr.

“Everything okay, Cat?”

“Yeah. I just can’t get you off my mind”.

“I could say the same,” Adora told her while rubbing upper arm with her thumb.

Catra chuckled quietly. “Not like I can smell you or anything, captain obvious. Wanna sneak off?”

“Definitely”. She held Catra tighter when she moved to stand. “But what if they need-“

“I’m sure they can survive a few minutes without the muscles. You can go back to hauling shit away in a little bit”. She continued muttering under her breath, “probably won’t take long anyhow”.

“What was that?”

“Nothing, princess”. Catra finally got to her feet when the comforting hold around her was released. “I’ll be in the ship for a little bit if you decide to join”.

Adora rolled her eyes when she was swatted in the face with her tail as she walked off. She looked around the village and sighed. No one seemed to really need things moved or reached. Plus, she was able to sit down for a few moments without anyone bothering

her. Maybe she did have a few more minutes to spare. Adora got to her feet with a smile and dusted her pants off before heading towards Darla.

She walked up the ramp and transformed back. There wasn't any sign Catra had even really gone to the ship in the first place. That was, until she heard a chuckle coming from the bridge.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said slowly from the chair once she walked in. "Took you long enough".

"I just needed to-"

Her train of thought came to an abrupt halt once she walked around to the front of the chair. Catra was completely naked already, one leg bent with her heel resting on the edge of the seat while the other was swinging idly in front. Adora watched her bring up some controls on the arm of the chair and hit a button to close and lock the door to the bridge.

"What's wrong?"

"Why are you naked in here?" Adora finally asked when logical thought returned. "Anyone could have walked right on in!"

"Nah, I had the door locked until I saw you walking up. Just when I thought I'd have to take care of a little problem," she spread her

legs a little, “myself”.

Adora’s brain went blank again seeing just how soaked her girlfriend was. There was no doubt she was aching. In a way, she definitely felt bad for not giving in sooner.

“Now that you’re here,” Catra continued, “I’m absolutely dying for some relief”.

She nodded before dropping her belt and jacket to the floor. She quickly took her boots off and tossed them to the side as well. It wasn’t long until her shirt and pants joined the pile as Catra watched with a teasing smile. Adora tossed her undergarments off and approached the chair.

“Stop staring. It isn’t going to finger itself. Or should I just do it for you?”

“No! I’m right here”. She settled on her knees in front of the chair. “What’s with you? You haven’t be like this in mont- oh. Shit. I’m so sorry, Cat. I should have figured it out sooner and-“

“Or you can just shut the fuck up and show me how sorry you are for not noticing sooner. That’s unlike you, Adora”.

Catra chuckled and put her feet on Adora’s shoulders. She didn’t want to admit she was hoping Adora hadn’t changed back. Not

yet. Instead, she decided to let her eyes fall closed as Adora pushed two fingers into her and started a steady pace.

Adora kicked herself mentally when Catra was definitely warmer than usual. The crabbiness from the past few days over pretty much everything suddenly made sense, as did the way she hadn't been eating as much lately on top of having been a ruthless tease nearly all day while they were supposed to be working. Catra may have had the typical female reproductive system and cycle of every other human Etherian that had one. Yet, every other month, starting in the spring and tapering off late fall, it escalated. Her thought of Catra simply aching was probably an understatement.

"Adora," Catra whined and hooked a leg around the back of her neck, "come on".

"Hmm?" Adora smiled up at her and rested her cheek against her thigh. "You've been teasing me all fucking day. Can a girl have a little payback? Are the two fingers not enough, love?"

Catra curled her lip in annoyance and decided to rub her clit slowly herself. Adora knew better. Catra gasped sharply when the fingers inside her roughly hooked and the claws of her unoccupied hand dug into the armrest.

"Hey, don't damage the controls". She kissed the inside of her thigh. "I'll take care of you. I promise".

“Sooner the better, princess”. Catra rested her head back against the chair with her eyes closed.

Adora kissed the back of Catra’s fingers that continued to rub small circles over own clit. She added a third finger and smiled at moan she finally got in response. Her free hand gently pushed Catra’s out of the way before giving her clit a firm lick. When she gave a gentle suck, Catra’s hips jerked up into her face. Adora grunted when her pubic bone smashed into her nose. She decided she could touch herself later, when her nose wasn’t at risk of being broken, and looped her arm under Catra’s thigh to grab ahold of her hip in an attempt to control the rolling of her hips into her face.

Catra let her leg drape over Adora’s shoulder while she kept the other around the back of her neck. While Adora was still taking her sweet time, it was better than nothing. Adora was guiding her hips in time with her trusting fingers and it wasn’t quite enough. Normally, Catra would love it but she was borderline sore and getting irritated with the slow pace. She grabbed Adora by the ponytail and gave a sharp tug.

“Enough teasing. Fuck me like you mean it or I’ll do it myself”.

Adora hummed against her and drove her fingers into her harder. She felt claws did into the back of her head in response with a low moan. Catra’s leg locked tighter around the back of her neck when she flicked her tongue over her clit faster and occasionally gave a gentle suck. Adora heard the quiet whimper from above her as Catra’s other hand joined the first on her head.

She was right at the edge. Catra was so close to coming undone. She was trying to move Adora's head to get her to lick her clit at the right angle instead of holding her on edge. Catra's legs twitched when Adora slammed her fingers into her and held her hand in place while her fingers curled and uncurled repeatedly. She heard Adora moan against her clit as she finally responded to her attempts at guiding and turned her head slightly.

Catra let out a whimper around her heavy breathing just before a pleasured scream ripped through her. Her claws dug into Adora's scalp as her upper body jerked forward and her legs locked her head in place. Catra tossed her head back as a loud moan fell from her lips when Adora refused to relent. Her body was trembling as her girlfriend continued to give suction around her clit and extending her orgasm.

"Flip," Adora said simply once Catra gave her enough room to pull her mouth away.

"Wh-" Catra rubbed her face as she caught her breath. "Adora, we have, uh, a party to get back to. I'm okay for now. And I still need to-"

"I said flip, Catra. You don't need to do anything, trust me".

"Adora-"

"Did I stutter?"

Catra's tail twitched at the blue glow of her eyes. Normally, she'd have listened at that. Instead, she pushed Adora backwards with her foot and crossed her legs. She was going to get She-Ra, preferably without having to actually ask.

"I think you did, princess".

"I know you're not done. We both know you'll feel so much better if you would just…" Adora got to her feet and grabbed Catra's jaw gently, eyes still holding a faint glow. "… flip".

"Stop teasing me with that." Catra smirked.

"You… you want She-Ra, don't you?" Adora laughed quietly. "You could have just asked."

Catra tapped her claws on the arm rest while her girlfriend transformed. She gave a quiet scoff when her new form, unfortunately, still had clothes on. Adora quickly got herself undressed again and towered over Catra.

"Well? Are you going to listen now?"

"I haven't decided". Her eyes widened when her jaw was grabbed and Adora's face was right in front of hers.

“What was that?”

Adora closed the gap before she could respond with a rough, open mouthed kiss. She effortlessly scooped her up and knelt on the floor with her in her lap. Catra grabbed the headpiece Adora had clearly forgotten about and blindly tossed it to where she remembered their pile of clothes were.

Catra whimpered against Adora’s lips when she snaked a hand between them and slipped two fingers into her. She-Ra was bigger all around, and that included the digits on her hands. Catra mentally thanked her for starting with two instead of just diving in with three. She brought their foreheads together and rested one hand on Adora’s shoulder with the other on the back of her neck as she rode her fingers. Adora was right, she was far from done.

“Needy,” Adora whispered. “Want another?”

“*Please*”.

Catra’s head fell to Adora’s shoulder with a moan. She knew it would be more of a stretch than when Adora was her normal size and three fingers deep. Still, she wasn’t expecting to feel a notable difference with as soaked and absolutely horny she was.

Adora continued to let her ride her fingers for a bit longer. She couldn't help but smile at the soft whimpers and moans of pleasure coming from the woman on her lap. They would definitely be doing this again at some point. She slowly removed her hand rubbed Catra's back when she whined in protest.

"Shhh. Come on. Flip over, love". She kissed her cheek, then her jaw. "It'll help. Two or three?"

"Three, you idiot". Catra got off her lap and laid face down on the floor with her hips raised and tail off to the side. "Feels good".

"Hey, my hands aren't as small and I don't want to hurt you in this position". Adora knelt behind her and slowly pushed her fingers in.

"I'll let you know". Catra pulled herself away from the fingers inside of her before pushing her hips back again. "Get a move on, princess. You promised".

Adora's hand landed against her ass. She smiled at the low growl mixed with a moan she got from it. "You talk too much".

Catra opened her mouth to say something only to have her words replaced with another moan as Adora started thrusting her fingers roughly. Her hand quickly went between her legs to rub at her aching clit again only to have it pulled away.

“Just enjoy it, love”. Adora placed a kiss between her shoulder blades. “I’ll take care of it”.

Catra whimpered softly when another kissed was placed just above the base of her tail and Adora’s free hand went around her hip and fingers started rubbing small circles around her clit. A moan quickly followed when Adora sped up her thrusts. There was definitely more power behind it when she was She-Ra and Catra was doing the far opposite of complaining.

Adora hummed quietly in satisfaction when she had her girlfriend taking in sharp gasps every other hard thrust. Occasionally she would add a few rough hooks with her fingers and earn a loud moan she was sure anyone could hear if they were anywhere in the ship.

“Don’t make me hold your hands behind your back,” she said when Catra dug her claws into the floor. “I’d hate to leave this,” she teased the tip of her clit, “unattended”.

“Y-you wouldn’t. Not… not now”. Catra squeezed her eyes closed with a drawn out moan once the quick circles over her clit resumed. “ Please , Adora”.

“Then at least try not to gouge the floor”. Adora sped up her thrusts again, continuing to add random curls to her fingers. “I know you’re close”.

Catra nodded quickly and swallowed a whimper.

Adora smiled and rubbed her clit a little faster while Catra's walls started to twitch around her fingers. Her girlfriend was trying to find the pace she needed by moving her hips and she quickly obliged, thrusting her fingers forward every time Catra pushed her hips back. It was a little slower than the pace she was at, but clearly it's what was needed as a mumbled approval came from below her.

"Come on, love," Adora coaxed. "I can feel you trying to hold it off. Let it happen".

Catra grunted and looked over her shoulder just long enough for Adora to see the eye roll she just had to give. It didn't last long after Adora pushed her fingers in as deep as she could and gave a few sharp hooks. Catra's eyes squeezed shut and her jaw clenched.

Adora returned to following the pace Catra wanted and quickly continued to work at her clit with her other hand while also holding her hips up. Catra's hips slowly started to fall out of rhythm as her breathing turned to panting.

"Ad… fuck ," Catra half mumbled. "I'm… I'm gonna… ah! Ador… ah!"

Catra clenched her hands into fists to avoid creating gouges into the floor as a scream interrupted any thoughts she had. Adora continued to work her through her orgasm relentlessly. Every thrust earned her a new moan or whimper of pleasure.

Adora gently lowered Catra's hips down but didn't remove her fingers. She kissed a trail along Catra's spine while she caught her breath.

"Think you can go one more time?" She asked softly and kissed the back of her head.

Catra nodded slowly. "Just… let me breathe for a moment. And I would… like to take care of you".

"You don't need to," Adora said and finally removed her fingers before gently rolling Catra to her back. "I'm enjoying this as well. Besides, my tongue should be longer than even yours now."

Catra's tail flicked curiously and spread her legs again. "Can't wait to find out".

Adora smiled at Catra while she fixed her ponytail and walked back to the party beside her. Their hour and a half away from the party left them both a little on the disheveled side. Carta barely

had the energy to walk without a small gimp, let alone fix her hair or smooth out her shirt after simply tossing it on.

"Feel better?" Adora asked and wrapped an arm around her waist.

"Mmmhm". She yawned. "Much".

"Don't tell me you're too tired for the party now".

Catra scoffed. "I'm not."

The two walked into a tent that was still in the process of being set up for a place to eat. Thankfully, there was already a long table filled with small snacks. Adora let Catra lead her to the table to help herself along with a few others that seemed to have caught wind that food was available. Catra ignored the few that blatantly stepped away from her, an action Adora noticed. She tried to keep her expression neutral.

"I've been looking everywhere for you!" Glimmer shouted and appeared in front of Adora.

Adora sighed and transformed after swallowing the cracker she loaded with a creamy cheese spread. She grabbed another and tossed it into her mouth before looking at her friend.

“Seriously?” Glimmer said with a blank expression.

“What?” She looked at Catra when she let out a soft laugh.

“It’s a good thing you had half a mind to get dressed before transforming back and getting dressed again”. Catra grabbed a raw fish topped cracker. “If your hair’s still a mess, I can only guess you’d still be naked if you didn’t”.

She gave Glimmer a sheepish smile while she fixed her hair back into a neat ponytail.

“You two… are absolutely impossible”. Glimmer sighed deeply. “You know that, right?”

“It couldn’t wait,” Adora said while she smoothed down the front of her shirt before fixing the longer tail of it.

“I’m almost certain it could have. You don’t see me dragging Bow off for a couple hours of fun”.

“It was only an hour and a half!” Adora defended. “Besides, you don’t exactly have to worry about him going into he-“

“Stop talking right there!” Catra interrupted and looked up at her girlfriend. “I’m… going to find something to help with. Seems like Sparkles has something for you to do anyhow. I love you”.

Adora smiled and rubbed the back of Catra’s head when she nuzzled her face against her stomach. “I love you too. See you in a little bit”.

“You guys are disgusting,” Glimmer muttered after Catra walked off and grabbed Adora’s wrist. “Come on”.

“I think you mean we’re cute,” Adora said as they walked from the tent.

“Disgustingly so. Most of the time”. Glimmer smiled. “But yeah, you two are, I guess. Anyhow, there’s a few boulders that need relocated. If you need anything I’ll be in the medical tent with Aunt Casta!”

Adora sighed softly and shook her head with a smile when her friend poofed away. A few boulders were nothing compared to some of the work she had already done at Thaymor. She quickly found one of the villagers who let her know they were just being moved so they could set up a net for some kind of game that needed the extra room. The task didn’t take very long. She carried the last of four boulders off to the edge of the woods before returning to the fire pit.

She sat down and looked around at everyone putting the final touches on everything. Apparently their spring party was a pretty big deal. There were tons of bright colored tapestries hanging from posts, tents, huts, and strings between poles. Strings of lights were still being put up by some villagers along with Wrong Hordak and the two other clones. Perfuma was busy with a few of the children making small floral arrangements.

Adora sighed softly and watched as one of the villagers lit the fire before he joined her. He looked to her, a small hint of worry in his face.

"Are you sure those three are… good?" The man asked and gestured to the three clones struggling to untangle a string of lights.

"Definitely. They're more clueless than they are harmful". She chuckled. "It's almost a little charming if you ask me. Wrong Hordak's a good cook. The other two… I'm not quite sure what they're good at yet".

"How do you tell them apart?"

"We can't. Not at first anyway". Adora looked out over the people again to watch Mermista promptly put out the torch Sea Hawk managed to get ahold of. "We still haven't named the other two".

There was a brief silence between the two before the man spoke up again.

"I would like to personally apologize, She-Ra. For the way we've treated, and sometimes still treat your wife".

"*Wife*?" Adora nearly choked. "Oh, no! She's not my wife. But I understand where you're all coming from. The only thing I, and any of us, ask is to give her a chance. This," she gestured to where her girlfriend was trying to fix a child's toy, "is the Catra I grew up with. Happy, loyal, fierce, competitive, so strong… even if she has always had some really bad days". She continued quietly, "she deserved better than what she was ever given growing up. Better than what she had to deal with when I… left".

"You speak fondly of her. Are you certain you two aren't wed?"

"I'm definitely certain," she chuckled, yet subconsciously rubbed her shoulder by her neck. The mark didn't seem to appear on She-Ra's form, but she knew where it was supposed to be. "I'm not sure if she would want that".

The man followed her gaze to the woman in question. She was laughing and running around with a few of the little kids now that the toy was fixed. Catra had a ball in her hand and Adora watched as she tossed it straight up into the air and stepped back to watch the kids scramble to catch it. At least until one of the parents came to escort their child away with a mildly disgusted look.

Adora frowned at the one sided interaction before noticing her girlfriend's ears become downturned in rejection. Catra was clearly trying and mostly coming up empty handed. She kicked a rock with the side of her foot and walked away from the other children. Adora watched, hopeful, when one of them chased after her to grab her hand only to see her pull away.

The child was determined and followed her. The little girl faced rejection of her own, but stood strong. She clambered into Catra's lap several times when she sat on a crate until she gave up and let the child stay put. The girl stuffed her once broken toy into Catra's hands in an effort to get her to play. Adora smiled softly at the interaction, even though Catra definitely looked somewhat annoyed for not being left alone.

"She's good with them, you know," the man pointed out. "However, if what you say is true, that you're not wed, I feel it would be a beautiful ceremony".

"Okay, okay. Let's slow down. Did you miss the part where I'm not sure she would even want that? Besides… it's too soon to consider. Maybe…"

"You!" Glimmer appeared in front of her.

"Me? Again?"

“We need you really quick”. She turned to the villager next to Adora. “Excuse us”.

“Of course, your majesty”.

Adora got to her feet followed Glimmer over to one of the old Horde bots still embedded in the ground. With a groan and a small amount effort, she unearthed the metal contraption and went to carry it away until Glimmer appeared in front of her again.

“Yes?” She asked and raised an eyebrow. “What is it? Boulders? More trees? Other Horde pieces laying around?”

“None of the above. It’s you. I didn’t need that moved, I just wanted to talk”. Glimmer sighed when Adora adjusted the defunct bot in her arms. “You just looked like you were cycling through all sorts of emotions and I wanted to make sure you’re okay. You don’t have to stay She-Ra. You’re allowed to take a break. Besides, the party is gonna actually start soon”.

“Yeah. I’m good. Just… tired?”

“You’re a terrible liar. Catra? She’s tired, thanks to you. You? Adora, you’re still pulling bots from being embedded in the ground like it’s something a toddler could do. Where do you want to put that?”

“Somewhere in the woods, probably”. She tried shrugging Glimmer’s hand away. “I can walk”.

“You’re not getting away that easy”.

She teleported them to somewhere in the woods. Adora dropped the bot and sighed in annoyance. She didn’t want to talk. At all. No one needed to know anything about the things running through her mind. Especially not how what that villager said suddenly weighed on her heart.

“Spill”.

Adora tried to think of something else. Anything else. “I’m just worried about Catra”.

“When aren’t you? Try again”.

“No, really”. She glanced over her shoulder in the direction she assumed Thaymor was. “They really seem to not want her there. I mean, I get it. I just wish they would give her more of a chance”.

“The mayor is coming around, actually. If that helps ease your mind on that front. But I understand”. Glimmer sighed. “Catra’s trying and the rejection just hurts her at this point”.

“Yeah”. Adora finally transformed back, exhausted, before admitting, “and sometimes I feel everyone is exploiting what I can do as She-Ra”.

Glimmer didn’t say anything. She just hugged her tired friend.

“The rest is *extremely* personal and I’m not talking about it”.

“Come on!” She urged. “I won’t say a word”.

“ *No* ”. She turned away.

“Adora-“

“Please, Glimmer, just… let it go”.

Adora started to walk in the supposed direction of Thaymor without another word. Again she brought her hand up to her shoulder near her neck. The villagers words sounded like a broken record. Catra said the bite made her her mate. Adora couldn’t help but wonder if that technically mean the same thing as marriage or not. Her mind then wandered to actually, officially getting married and if that’s something Catra would ever want.

In her vision of the possible future, they were. Her one, supposedly last, wish in the Heart of Etheria was to be married to her childhood friend, her old enemy, her best friend, her… favorite person. And hearing that Cata had always loved her as well made that desire grow.

But she forced it away.

They both had things to work through. The war was traumatic for them both. They hurt each other during it. Forgiveness for each other came easy. What wasn't easy was forgiving themselves.

But maybe……

"Adora?"

"Huh?" She looked around for a moment, not quite sure how she got turned around.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer asked for probably the millionth time since she turned Adora towards the true direction of Thaymor. "You didn't hear a word I've said, did you?"

"Honestly, no. I'm sorry".

“Did you hurt your shoulder? You keep rubbing it like you did”. Glimmer took a step closer. “Let me see it”.

“No!” Adora yelled defensively. “The shoulder’s fine. Just… I need to be alone for a few minutes. Can we let that happen?”

Glimmer nodded quietly and let Adora walk away. Instead of going into the village, she made a turn for Darla. When she said alone, she definitely meant alone.

Glimmer continued on into the village and grabbed Catra by the arm and started dragging her from a group of village kids she was telling stories about how the magic was restored.

“And then we kissed and save the universe!” She yelled as she walked backwards, trying to pry her arm free. “What the hell, Sparkles? I was busy”.

“What’s wrong with Adora?”

“I, uh, don’t know what you’re talking about”.

“She’s acting really weird. What did you do?”

Catra raised an eyebrow.

“Yes or no. Did she hurt her shoulder? She keeps rubbing it”. Glimmer watched Catra’s expression go from confused to mildly hurt to worry. “What’s wrong?”

“N-nothing”. Catra’s tail thrashed a little. “Where’d she go?”

“Darla. She said she needed to be alone for a few minutes”.

Catra took half a step back. “She’s been acting weird… how?”

Glimmer shrugged. “She’s doing that thing where she gets so lost in her head that she doesn’t pay any attention to what’s going on around her”.

Catra nodded with an anxious gulp. Maybe she did regret the bite after all. If that was the case, she hoped she would just heal the scar. They wouldn’t have to talk about it ever again. Her body wanted to run, to get away and hide for a while. She was still trying to be better than that. So she stayed put, even if she could feel the sting of the tears at the corner of her eyes.

“Not you too!” Glimmer grabbed Catra’s face. “What’s going on? What am I missing?”

“Sparkles,” she sighed and pulled her hands away, “it’s… it’s nothing you need to worry about. Okay?” She itched at her chest, trying to remember to breathe. “Is… Is Scorpia here?”

“So you’ll talk to her but not me?” Glimmer said sadly. “I would like to help you too. Both of you”.

“It’s one of those… therapy things,” she admitted. “Listen, I’ll… tell you later. If you still want to know. Please, Sparkles, this is me asking you to let me do what I need to do right now”.

Realization washed over Glimmer. She knew Catra had been working through a lot with Scorpia, feeling it was a little easier than talking to Perfuma at times. This was one of those times where she needed someone who knew her longer. And it seemed urgent as Glimmer started to see the signs of panic in her friend. Her first instinct was to teleport her directly into the tent Scorpia was in. She thought far better of it and simply escorted her instead.

“Scorpia,” Glimmer said while still holding Catra by the arm, “you’re needed. Immediately”.

Scorpia glanced up and saw the situation. Catra’s hands were shaking and Glimmer looked more worried than usual, especially considering who the cause of it was. At least in that moment. She dropped the chair she was holding and rushed over.

“Talk time,” Catra whispered and grabbed Scorpia’s arm. “Now. Please”.

“Oh. Oh, no. Yes. Okay”. She followed Catra out once Glimmer let go. “Where to?”

“Anywhere that’s extremely private with enough room I can pace. I *can’t* sit down and talk about this right now. Is there anywhere with those two very simple requests around here?”

“The woods?” She offered before suddenly being pulled along in the direction of the tree line.

Scorpia started to hear soft growls mixing in with Catra’s harsh breathing. Really, she couldn’t tell if it was out of anger or something else. Usually, the angry growls were far louder.

“Should have grabbed rope,” Catra muttered as she stopped in a small clearing before taking off her belt and giving it to her friend turned therapist. “Here”.

“What am I doing with this?”

Catra put her hands behind her back. “I’m really, *really* likely to try to hurt myself over what’s running through my mind. So please, before I put up a fight, restrain my hands”.

“Oh,” Scorpia said quietly, suddenly even more worried.

She stood behind Catra and worked to tie her hands behind her back as quick as her pincers would allow. Once her hands were restrained, the pacing started. She was clearly mulling over her words, trying to figure out how to say what was going on that wouldn’t make Scorpia flip.

“Whenever you’re ready,” she said patiently.

“I… Scorpia, I…,” Catra growled at herself. It really shouldn’t have been so hard to say.

“Take your time”.

“I bit her”.

Scorpia blinked at the three words, confused.

Catra continued to pace, her tail lashing behind her.

“Accidentally? And she’s mad about it?”

“No! It was on purpose. She *asked* me to!” Catra fought her restraints for a moment. “It’s a thing . I… I claimed her as… as my mate”.

Scorpia’s eyes widened in mild shock. She didn’t know the full implications, but could tell it must have been a big deal for Catra.

“And she didn’t want that?”

“She did!” Catra yelled before quieting down. “Glimmer said she’s acting all weird and rubbing where the scar is and wanted to be left alone. Adora said she didn’t regret any of it, that she’s happy, that she *wanted* it . What if she lied to protect my feelings? I don’t care if she wants to get rid of it and never speak of it again. I just don’t want her to spare me like this or whatever if she… if she didn’t really want it”.

Scorpia was still trying to process everything as her friend continued to pace. She noticed her claws extend in what she could only guess was guilt over the situation. Yet she didn’t cut through the belt around her wrists like she easily could. The little thing alone made Scorpia proud. Instead, she found herself pulling Catra away from a tree after she hit her forehead against it a few times, calling herself stupid over and over with each hit.

“Okay, wildcat. Let’s take a moment and breathe. We’ll clean up your forehead later. Let’s slowdown and back up a few steps. Tell me what happened”.

Chapter End Notes

Things missed in smut: not much really. She-Ra got involved. Catra is in our version of “heat”. Otherwise it’s just smut.

S: I wanted to post this midweek so you could get part two today. Unfortunately I’ve been dealing with some medical things lately and didn’t have much time I felt well enough to write or anything related to it. Still feeling kinda shitty but I managed to get this posted. That’s about all I have for this week. Just feeling like a sack of shit and not enjoying whatever is going on with me.

Indy: Things have been a bit frustrating for the both of us me with school and her with the aforementioned medical things. We wanted to post Wednesday but it faltered out. We do plan to commit to the Saturday posts so fret not. The story will still be published. Wishing you all the best!

Of Course I Love You! (Pt. 2)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora bounced her leg while she waited in her captain chair aboard Darla. She had briefly walked out and asked one of the villagers to find Perfuma and tell her to get to the ship as soon as she could. The waiting felt like an eternity. She took off her jacket and dropped it to the floor before resting her head back. Her leg continued to bounce incessantly as she tucked her hand into her shirt to trace the scars left by Catra's teeth.

Her feelings felt like they were all over the place. Adora knew she was probably overreacting. Of course Catra wanted her for as long as she would have her. That much was evident with the way they had fucked in the very room of the ship she was in. She just hoped Catra knew she wanted to have her forever.

"I apologize I took so long, Adora," Perfuma announced as she walked into the bridge. "I came here right away. What's wrong?"

"Nothing and everything," Adora said quietly, her leg still bouncing.

"I'm going to need you to explain further," she said while sitting on the floor in front of her.

“How soon is too soon to get married? I know I’ve known Catra for… forever. But we were enemies for nearly three years. I know we had a relationship while we were in the Horde and Shadow Weaver forced us to forget. And… and then the war,” Adora rambled on. “And then we remembered and confessed again but it’s only been what? Almost a year since the whole Heart of Etheria thing? I think I’d like to marry her someday but I don’t know if she wants that, even if she bit me. Maybe we are married because of that”.

Perfuma blinked at the onslaught of words coming from her very clearly stressed friend.

“So I’m absolutely insane for even *considering* any of this. Understood”. Adora hit the back of her head against the chair. “I’m such an *idiot* ”.

“I never said any of that. I’m just wondering what this is about. You said she bit you?” Perfuma put her hands together. “What’s going on, Adora?”

“I think I’m technically married but… I didn’t even think that’s what it was”. She pulled the collar of her shirt aside to show the very clear scar of a bite.

“Oh! That looks to have happened-“

"*M onths* ago, yes". Adora adjusted her shirt back and put her hand over the location of the mark. "Did I fuck this up?"

"The first question is, did she explain what it would mean?"

Adora nodded. "I'm her mate".

"The second question is, did you want it?"

Again she nodded. "I… I asked her to. Even after she explained it, I nearly *begged* her to".

"My third question is, and you need to be completely honest, do you regret it now?"

Adora's head whipped up and stared at Perfuma in disbelief. The way she even had the nerve to ask that.

"Absolutely not. I'd keep letting her do it if she wanted to. If… if she wanted to bite through the scar again, to draw blood again, I'd *happily* let her do it".

The two stayed quiet even as Adora stood and walked to the window to look out into the village directly ahead. She couldn't figure out what to do next. Was she supposed to make it official

somehow? How did it even work? Was there a tradition or something? She hung her head as the thoughts and questions crashed around her mind.

She glanced back out the window again, trying to figure out how to approach Catra about the situation. If she even should at all. She then wondered if her girlfriend, or mate, or wife, or whatever, had any idea about this. And if so, what her feelings about it were and why she hadn't said a word about it.

Perfuma quietly joined Adora's side. The simple calm presence seemed to urge more from Adora.

"Do you think she knows?" She asked quietly.

"I think she knows what being a mated pair is for her species," Perfuma said calmly. "From what you told me, you seem to both be consenting parties to your situation. Now, I can't tell you if being a mate is exactly the same as marriage, but it's still very important for the both of you. Might I suggest having a conversation with her?"

"Are you insane? She's probably going to think I'm backing out if I do". Adora hung her head again. "I'm not. I'm really, really happy about this. But I'm also scared, Perfuma. What's next?"

"I wish I had an answer. Whatever comes next is completely up to you. Both of you". She placed a gentle hand on Adora's shoulder.

“You two have been through far worse together and even against each other. If you two loved each other through everything that happened, I don’t see that changing”.

Adora nodded and looked up again to see Catra exiting the woods with Scorpia, a hand to her forehead. She leaned closer to the window and squinted. There was definitely some blood on her face. Her first reaction was to turn and run to her. That was until she turned to Perfuma who grabbed her arm.

“We don’t interrupt other therapy sessions, Adora”.

“She’s *hurt* ,” she protested but stopped trying to fight her friend’s hold. “And it looks to me like their session is done”.

“But you don’t know that. We can go back to the party but you have to promise to not actively search for her”.

Adora contemplated for a moment. She knew she would get the chance to talk to Catra at some point. This just wasn’t how she planned for the rest of the evening to go. It was supposed be that they finished with helping set up for the party, they snuck off to Darla and fucked, and then rejoined the party. Not her standing on Darla’s bridge with Perfuma and freaking out about being married and not knowing.

“Question”.

“Go on,” Perfuma urged.

“Is being a mate considered marriage?” Adora rubbed her temples. “I’m just so confused right now”.

“That’s a question for Catra. She would know far more about her species’ courtship than any of us”.

“Not entirely. The Horde didn’t teach much of anything about other species. She said what she does know is from what she found out while she was in the Crimson Waste”. Adora sighed deeply. “ What am I going to do ?”

Perfuma wrapped her in a gentle hug hearing the stress in her voice.

“Find somewhere private and talk,” she suggested to Adora. “That’s all you can do. Acknowledge her feelings and let her acknowledge yours. The way both of you feel is important”. She stepped back and squeezed her shoulders gently. “Let’s go back to the village”.

Adora smiled and followed her out. She wandered back into the heart of Thaymor, looking around to find any sign of Catra. Or even Scorpia. She knew that Perfuma had said to not interrupt. Adora also knew Catra had some kind of injury and they both had

a very, very important conversation to have. The longer she waited, the more it would eat at her.

She saw the Scorpia first and started to make her way over. All she would do is calmly ask her if Catra was free.

“Feel better?” Glimmer asked as she appeared in front of her friend.

“Um… yes and no?” She tried to push by her only to have her arm grabbed.

“I’m going to be honest, I’m so lost on everything that’s going on between you and Catra right now. Trying to get her to talk is going about as well as you asking questions to anything in the First Ones ruins! What is going on?”

“It’s a long story. And it’s not even done. We… *really* need to talk”.

“Adora! Answer me!” Glimmer grabbed her by shoulders. “Catra said she’d tell me later so don’t you *dare* tell me the same thing”.

Adora groaned quietly. “Honestly I’m not completely sure what’s going on either. Which is why I need to talk to her. Like… now . I need some kind of answer and then I promise I’ll tell you”.

“You swear on my mother?”

“I swear on Angella”. She gave Glimmer a hug with a smile. “If it’s what I think it is, you’ll be the first to know. You and Bow. Even if it’s not, I’ll at least tell you what’s going on”.

“Fine”. Glimmer sighed and gestured to the tent Scorpia was outside of. “She’s in there”.

Adora nodded and made her way over. By the time she reached the tent, Scorpia already noticed her and stepped in front of the flap.

“Move, please”.

“I don’t think this is a good idea,” she said held out a pincer. “I’m saying this as a friend to both of you”.

“Is your therapy session not over? If it’s not, I’m really sorry for interrupting”.

“No, it is. I just don’t think you going in there is a-“ she stepped aside timidly at the icy glare she received, “-good idea”.

Adora opened the tent flap and saw Catra sitting on the table getting her forehead cleaned up. Her face was void of emotion as she continued to stare straight ahead. Adora heard a soft growl of annoyance when she was being made to follow the motions of Castaspella's finger. Adora patiently waited while the rest of a standard basic neurological test was done since she clearly hit her head on something.

"Hey, Adora," Catra finally said, barely audible.

"What happened?" She sat on the table next to her.

"Tree".

"I think… we should talk. At least I want- I need to. You don't have to say anything but I just…" Adora sighed deeply. "Can we talk? Please?"

"Yeah. Sure". Catra hopped off the table and stood in front of Adora. "What do you need to say?"

"Privately," Adora clarified. "Far out of earshot".

"Fine". Catra motioned her to follow and shoved the tent flap out of the way. Before Scorpia could say anything she bit out a, "keep your mouth shut".

She didn’t stop walking to even see if Adora was following. She walked up Darla’s ramp, still not waiting around to make sure her shadow was still there. By time she made it to the bridge, her hands were in tight fists. Catra only stopped to pick up Adora’s jacket and turned to toss it to her. She didn’t check her own expression before turning. It must have been far less than desirable considering Adora instantly looked… sad.

“Well, here’s your privacy. Talk”.

“The bite-“

“Get rid of it!” She suddenly yelled. “You don’t have to keep it to save my feelings. If you don’t want it, don’t fucking keep it!”

“I want to keep it!” She yelled back and tossed her jacket into the chair. “Do you really think I would have fucked you the way I did earlier if I didn’t want you? If… if I didn’t *love* you? I’m not lying, Catra. I swear I’m not”.

Catra scoffed. “Yeah. It sure took you long enough to figure it out”.

“Don’t start this now”. Adora reached out her hands. “I know I don’t have to tell you that nature is wreaking havoc on you right now. You’re probably feeling neglected because I took longer than

normal. And I'm sorry for that. But, damn it, I *wanted* the bite. I still do. Look at me".

Catra searched her face and body language for any little tipoff to prove her own misplaced suspicions. The only thing she noticed was Adora's long time nervous habit of chewing on her bottom lip.

"Then what's wrong ? You have Sparkles freaking out. And if it's not the fucking bite, then what is it ?"

"It… technically is the bite," she admitted quietly and covered the spot. "I had a conversation with one of the villagers earlier".

Catra folded her arms and nodded. She knew. She noticed them talking.

"Please, don't get weird about this. I have a feeling you're thinking I never actually wanted it". Adora saw Catra roll her eyes. She guessed that right. "I'm telling you that your assumptions are so very, *very* wrong . Because I want this, Catra. And I hope you want it to. But… I have questions".

Catra furrowed her brows. She thought she explained it. Adora was her mate. Plain and simple. Only she felt the air get knocked out of her lungs by three simple words.

"Are we married?"

“Are we *what* ?”

“Let me rephrase that,” Adora said and took a calming breath. “Are you my wife?”

“I’m your *mate* . That’s what the bite is. I told you that”. Catra ran a hand through her hair before narrowing her eyes. “Is this seriously how you’re proposing to me?”

“No! Ugh!” Adora rubbed her face. “Unless that’s what you want this to be”.

“I know you can do better than this. Try again later. Right now, Adora, I want to know what you’re even talking about”.

“That guy asked if we were married. I know what you said about the bite. I’m just confused . Perfuma wasn’t exactly a major help-“

“You… told Perfuma?” Catra raised an eyebrow.

Adora looked away. They really hadn’t agreed on telling anyone yet. “I’m sorry . I was freaking out.”

Catra heaved a sigh. “I told Scorpia. Same reason”.

Adora glanced up to see her hugging herself. She took a step forward and offered her hands. “I wanted it, Catra. I haven’t changed my mind”.

She glanced at Adora’s hands and then to her face.

“I told you what my dying wish was,” Adora continued to talk after she dropped her hands back to her sides. “I don’t know if you feel the same. If you don’t, that’s perfectly fine. Being your… mate is one thing but marriage? From what I understand, that’s a big deal around Etheria and I won’t be mad if you don’t want that. Because it won’t be just me with She-Ra and all. All of Etheria will know and-“

“I’m stopping you right there,” Catra finally said. “Shut the hell up and listen to one big thing I have to say. You can punch me or whatever you need to do when I’m done. Just listen and think for a moment”.

Adora gave her a confused look but nodded.

“First, I’m sorry for cutting your nervous rambling off. Second, I thought you understood what me biting you like that meant. What… being my mate means. But clearly, something didn’t click in that blonde head of yours”. Catra took a deep, calming breath.

“Marriage at this point is only for show, okay? It’s for everyone else to know and all of that”.

“What are you saying?”

“I’m saying,” Catra closed her eyes before looking right into Adora’s, “we’re a little past the point of marriage”.

She watched something click into place. Once it did, a tear ran down Adora’s cheek. Catra’s stomach dropped. Maybe she was right after all. It was a mistake. She turned away and hugged herself tighter. Adora cleared her throat behind her but she didn’t move more than a step forward, away from her girlfriend who was still processing what was said. Catra wasn’t about to let her see the tears in her own eyes.

“What?” Adora whispered.

“That’s why I said you can heal it if you want. If… if you’re not ready, I understand. Maybe it’s too soon after all”. Catra held the end of her tail in an attempt to comfort herself. It wasn’t something she did often, an old habit from when she was little. “I’m sorry, Adora. Just… just heal it.”.

“Hey, hey, hey. No. Do not shut down on me right now”. Adora wiped the tears that escaped her eyes again. “I wanted it. I asked for it. Catra, I *still* want it. I want this, okay? I want… you”.

Catra closed her eyes and felt protective arms wrap around her from behind. Her own mind was swimming, from the conversation or her overactive hormones, she wasn't fully sure. She thought Adora knew this whole time. Maybe it was too soon, maybe it wasn't. It wasn't like Catra was familiar with any sort of wedding traditions of Etheria except there's a proposal of some sort and a ceremony. There was no way Adora knew anything about her species' courtship. She barely did herself. What she did know was more instinct from whatever kind of hybrid she was than anything.

"I'll… propose better. I promise," Adora said softly with her lips against the back of Catra's head.

Catra let out a breathy laugh.

"I mean it!" She let Catra turn in her arms. "I want to do this right. You deserve that much."

"You already have in my book," she mumbled and nuzzled the side of Adora's neck. "Now, I have a serious question. Please don't lie to me".

"I won't". Adora pulled back to look into her eyes.

"Now that you know the actual weight of it all… are you sure you really sure you want to keep it? If you don't, I understand. Heal it

and we can wait longer if that's still something you want".

"I'm not healing it". She held Catra's face gently. "Unless you want me to. Because, believe it or not, I do love you. More than words can express. If you're not ready, that's okay".

"If I wasn't ready in the first place, I wouldn't have done it. At all".

"So are we deciding that it stays? I'm your mate. Is that what's happening?"

Catra nodded with a small smile, tears in her eyes. "Yeah. It is."

"We're going to have to tell Bow and Glimmer. Especially Glimmer".

" *Excuse me* ?"

"I…" Adora took a small step back while rubbing the back of her head, "…kinda maybe swore on Angella I'd tell her what was going on once I found some stuff out from you".

"You… are *such* an idiot". Catra gave her a kiss. "But I still love you".

“I know I am”. She chuckled. “But at least I’m your idiot”.

_____

Catra thought she was ready to let their friends know. At least at first. As she walked hand in hand with Adora back to the partying village, she suddenly had many second thoughts. She said she would be okay with being there when Adora told them. Catra wasn’t so sure about that. The closer they got to finding the other half of the best friend squad, the more Adora was dragging her along instead of walking side by side.

It wasn’t long until they walked into the tent with a large assortment of food and drink across several tables. Glimmer saw them at the same time and grabbed Bow’s hand before teleporting over.

“Good to see you two are better,” Glimmer said and pointed to the women’s hands. “Now spill. Both of you”.

“Both of us?” Catra questioned. “It’s the same conclusion and I… I’m just going to let Adora say it”.

“Don’t put this on me!”

“Hey, *I’m* not the one who swore on Angella”.

“Ohhh,” Bow winced, “she does have a point there. So… is everything good?”

Adora and Catra glanced at each other and back to the other couple.

“Perfect, actually,” Adora said. “But we need to tell you this… privately”.

“Fine!” Glimmer groaned and grabbed everyone, much to Catra’s horror.

“No, no, no. Why can’t we just-“ she crouched down when they were suddenly somewhere in the woods, “-walk”.

Adora crouched down next to her and rubbed her back. Thankfully the wave of motion sickness usually only lasted a couple seconds. Catra slowly stood back up and started to pick at her claws while she waited for Adora to attempt to explain everything in her own way.

“Private enough?” Glimmer asked, her impatience growing.

“Okay, so,” Adora cleared her throat, “you know Catra and I really, really love each other”.

Catra facepalmed. Of course she was going to make this painfully awkward.

"Well, we… I sorta kinda found out we're… married?"

" *What* ?" Glimmer practically hissed.

"We're not *married* , Adora." Catra groaned into her hands. "Listen, guys, this has been a lot for specifically her to take in over the past… hour. Just bear with me here".

Bow and Glimmer looked at each other and back to them, even more confused. Catra grabbed the collar of Adora's shirt and pulled it aside to reveal the scar.

"Oh, how nice," Glimmer deadpanned, "you bit her".

"That's… what all of this tension was about?" Bow asked. "Really?"

"No!" Catra growled and took a breath to calm down. "Kinda. That's… I… yes, I bit her but the things is, that's a… uh, a m-mating mark".

“A what?” Glimmer asked for clarification, raising her eyebrow at just how red Catra’s face had gotten, enough to show through the winter fur she still had on her cheeks.

“I don’t know, or really understand, a ton about where I’m from or who my people are… or anything like that, but this is… instinctual”. Catra looked at her feet after letting go of Adora’s shirt collar and mumbled quickly, “Adora’s my mate”.

Bow raised his hand. “I’m extremely confused”.

“Congrats?” Glimmer questioned. “I feel like I’m talking to Entrapta. Can we please clarify?”

“It’s a little more than marriage,” Adora said.

Catra coughed at the bluntness of her voice. It was almost matter of factly. Like it was so simple.

That’s when the silence fell over the four. Catra held the end of her tail as some kind of source of comfort. Adora saw the old habit resurface again and ran her knuckles along her spine. Glimmer was looking between them in shock. Bow quietly raised his hand again.

“What?” Catra choked out.

“You two have been more-than-married for how long? I didn’t even know that was a thing”.

“A few months,” she answered while she kept her attention on the tip of her tail. “I know it’s a lot to take in but… this is what’s going on. Can we please get back to the party?”

“Is there like, not a ceremony with this?” Glimmer finally asked.

“I… no. Not unless you really want to watch us having sex. We haven’t really discussed your version of marriage fully but…” Catra sighed. “We’re figuring this out as we go right now”.

“Admittedly, I didn’t fully realize what it was until about a half hour ago,” Adora said and buried her fingers into Catra’s hair at the back of her head. “And, honestly, if I could go back and change anything, I wouldn’t. Except maybe fully understanding”.

Glimmer gave both of them a hug, which Bow quickly joined. Catra let out a puff of air and hugged the two back with Adora. That could have definitely gone far worse.

“We should do a ceremony for you guys,” Bow said a little teary eyed. “This is big. And it’ll just be the four of us and… I’m gonna go see if my dads have anything about what kind of hybrid you

are and we'll celebrate your people's way! I mean, since this is your version of marriage almost."

"No". Catra shook her head and folded her arms. "After what happened last time, I'm not involving your dads in research. Especially about me".

"Oh, come on! They love research! And no one ever said it had to be about you directly". Bow shrugged. "You've said there's others out there like you. It's a great research topic and even you can't deny that".

Catra rolled her eyes and slipped her hand into Adora's. Maybe finding out just a little more of who and what she was wouldn't be such a bad thing. As long as she wasn't directly involved. After the last incident with George and Lance, the last thing Catra really wanted to do was face them again. She just wanted to get back to the party, have some food and something to drink, and just have a good evening with friends and Adora.

"Ready to get back to the party?" Glimmer asked and held out her hand.

"Party, yes. Teleporting again, never am". She took Glimmer's hand while Adora wrapped an arm around her shoulder and Bow grabbed Glimmer's other hand. "But go on".

Chapter End Notes

S: This week kinda really sucked for me so I didn't get a chance for the mid week post I was hoping for since this was part two. After four years of dodging the bullet, I have managed to get Covid. Pretty annoyed by it. Mostly I'm just exhausted and achy. I somehow managed to get the some of the weirder symptoms so I didn't even know I had it until I went to the hospital for other stuff (or what I thought was other stuff).

Hopefully you all continue to enjoy this story. Stay healthy out there!

Indy: Hey everyone I hope you are all doing well. This week has been chaotic for the both of us and I'm doing my best to help Sokuly as I can. Life for me is still busy with work and school. I hope you enjoy and stay safe and healthy!

Discoveries

Chapter Notes

> There are suggested sexual things near the end. It's not explicit smut… this time. Just a heads up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Dads?" Bow called out into the library. "I have a serious question".

Lance came around the corner with a book in his hand. Bow was ready for another ass chewing about considering Catra a friend but actually got a smile. Adora didn't look at Lance at all. Instead, she kept her attention on a distant spot over his shoulder.

"Is it just you and Adora today?"

"Yes and no," Adora answered quietly.

"Glimmer and… Catra stayed in the ship," Bow explained further.

"So you are still hanging out with the Horde commander," George said as he joined his husband.

Neither noticed the slight flinch from Adora. Bow, however, did.

“Okay, let’s not turn this into that again,” Bow said and looked at Adora. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine,” she answered just as quiet as the first time she spoke.

If she wanted to tell the truth, she definitely didn’t want to be in the presence of Bow’s dads. Not after the things they had said, not after what happened last time. As much as she wanted to know what kind of hybrid Catra was, she would have preferred her own quiet research. Alone or with Bow.

“So,” Lance said, ignoring his husband’s glare at the two, “what’s the question?”

“We were all just curious if you guys knew anything about whatever species Catra is. And where they came from”. Bow rubbed the back of his neck. “This really isn’t about her, okay? I mean it is, but it isn’t. There’s more than just her out there”.

“Where are the ecology books?” Adora asked, still avoiding looking at either of them.

“The scientific section is upstairs on your left, about halfway down,” Lance instructed.

Adora quietly walked past them and headed up the stairs to start browsing.

"Are you sure she's fine?" Lance asked.

"She's not," Bow finally said. "She… is still pretty hurt about what you guys said. You two don't know about their history with each other or anything of the smaller things that happened. You can disown me if that's how you really feel, but I'm sticking up for Catra too. She's trying".

"Go get the cat," George said.

"Um… that's not going to happen. I'm putting my foot down on that one. Honestly, Catra only came because Adora asked her to. And she kinda locked us out of the room she hid in on the ship, even when Adora asked her several times to join us with research".

"Adora!" George called up to her after a deep sigh. "You're not going to find what you're looking for in any of those books. Come with us".

Adora put her book away and quietly followed the fathers and son. She knew exactly where they were going and it confused her. The last thing she expected was the First Ones having anything to do with where Catra's kind came from. She sat in one of the chairs and waited while Lance and George both scoured the

shelves for whatever they were looking for. Bow sat beside her put his hand on her forearm.

"It's gonna be okay," he tried to reassure quietly. "Their opinions don't matter. What matters is that you love her the way you do. Okay?"

Adora just nodded with a deep breath.

"Honestly, there's not a lot about the hybrids here," Lance said and put a book and a scroll in front of her. "Even with what little translation we could do, it didn't seem to make sense".

"Crossroads?" Adora questioned as she opened the scroll.

"It's a very old and now defunct portal of sorts, guessing from the pictures. The remnants are… missing," George explained. "We haven't been able to figure out where the location even was".

"They used it as a travel route," she read. "Varying species and goods to and from Etheria…"

"It sounds more like a trade route," Bow commented.

“Various goods exchanged,” Adora continued and opened the scroll further. “So… yes, part of a trade route. Um… this says… some who were passing through asked to stay and call Etheria home, many of which were denied”.

She grabbed the book and flipped through a few pages and rubbed her forehead. If there were any further documents on the crossroads portal, it could take days to weeks to translate it all accurately. It was at least something to look into at some point.

“It’s a log book,” she finally said. “This is why we have so many different species here. Some stayed. Uh, this one… a lizard type individual courted an Etherian, had child”. She chuckled, “I’ll need to find Rogelio and tell him this”.

“I thought you were all… born here,” Bow said. “Well, except you”.

“We were. But it seems like a lot of these different species had children with human Etherians. And then their children and so on. This has been going on for an absolute minimum of two thousand years”. Adora raised an eyebrow as she continued to read and looked to Lance and George. “Anything on something called… a magicat?”

Lance and George looked at each other before shrugging. They’ve heard of the creature but not much else. Lance went back to the shelf and pulled a book to give to her. As Adora read, very little became clearer. The description was somewhat similar to Catra but also not quite close enough.

“How fast can genetics change?” She asked.

“It really depends on how far removed one is from the original source,” Lance answered. “Why?”

“I think… I might have found Catra’s ancestors. Maybe”.

“Do you think there’s some out there?” Bow asked, hopeful.

“I… don’t know. It seems unlikely we’d even be able to find them, if they still exist, without this crossroads thing”.

“So what you’re saying is,” Lance spoke up, fully interested, “these… magicats, some stayed and had children with Etherians?”

“And then their children had children with Ehterians or any of the other groups running around, if possible. And it just continued until… some characteristics stopped showing up. Like here…” she pointed to a page describing magicats, “full cheeks, whiskers, thick fur coating body, true humanoid feline”.

“Meaning…” Bow urged further, confused.

“Those are just the features Catra *doesn’t* have. She has a thin, short, but somewhat dense fur. No whiskers. Her lips are clearly not full like a feline. And going off of that, her tongue is rough but not nearly as much as a cat…” she scratched her head. “I guess some features could just not show up over time. But is there anything on their traditions? Or… behavior?”

“I’m sure there is… somewhere,” Lance said and started looking over the many books and scrolls.

Adora continued to read. The pile of books in front of her continued to grow. Even if there was next to nothing so far, the rest was interesting. Especially whatever the crossroads thing really was and why the First Ones shut it down. She read that it was rendered obsolete shortly before the Heart of Etheria Project began. What wasn’t written anywhere to keep the secrecy, was what the project truly ended up being. Eventually, Adora got up to stretch.

Bow had fallen asleep with his head on the table. Wondering just how long she had been there, she glanced at the clock on the wall. Two hours. She had been reading books and scrolls for two hours. Adora put a hand on her stomach when it growled.

“Go get your friends. Join us for dinner,” Lance said with a smile.

“I… I can’t. Catra won’t set foot in here”. Adora looked at the floor. “Not that I blame her”.

Silence, aside from Bow's quiet snore, filled the room again as she sat back down and flipped a page. Admittedly, the lines of First Ones writing were starting to blur together. There was just so much more to read. Thankfully neither of Bow's dads seemed to entertain her comment.

Finally, she found a book with more answers. Whatever those magicats were, they were described as skittish, yet very capable fighters. Their strength was superior to human Etherians and came close to the First One's own strength. Some had been described as having some sort of magical abilities that wasn't further described. The biggest bit of information Adora had finally found was that of a location called Half Moon, a distant planet from Eternia, which made it even more distant from Etheria, a place it seemed the First Ones had visited at some point. At least there was a place they could attempt to find.

Adora stood and wandered over to one of the bookshelves. After opening and closing a few books, she found what she hoped she was looking for.

"What's that one?" Lance asked.

"Travel records. The magicats are from a planet called Half Moon. Hopefully they took more notes when they visited". Adora sat back down with a groan. "I'm just glad we've found something."

"You said you'd be a few minutes," Glimmer said as she appeared in the room.

Bow sat up straight and blinked the sleep away. “I’ve been asleep for a few minutes”.

“Over an hour,” Lance corrected.

Adora rubbed her eyes and closed the book in front of her before rolling up a couple scrolls that were still open. As much as she wanted to continue, her eyes and back were really starting to hurt.

“Did you find what you were looking for?” Glimmer asked.

“Somewhat. I think. I’m pretty sure I found out about Catra’s ancestors though”. Adora gave a slight smile. “She’s something called a magicat. Or… she’s at least a hybrid of them.”

“That’s something! I’m sure she’ll be glad to know”.

“Can I borrow some of this?” Adora asked Lance.

“Of course! Help yourself. Just make sure they’re not damaged,” George answered for his husband and gave her a pointed look.

“Don’t worry. She hates reading anything about history as it is,” she deadpanned.

“Are you sure you can’t stay?” Lance asked, a touch of sadness in his voice.

Adora looked to Glimmer, quietly asking on the state of Catra. When she shook her head, Adora’s shoulders slumped. Quietly, she gathered a couple books and a scroll before holding her hand out to Glimmer.

“I’ll be right back,” Glimmer told Bow and teleported Adora back to the ship.

“Anything?” Catra asked from the captain chair. “I’d hope so after a couple hours”.

“Sorry, I got caught up reading down a lot of different paths”. She sat on the arm of the chair and waved to Glimmer before she disappeared. “Not exactly what I was hoping to find but…” she held up a book, “I might have found your ancestors from a place called Half Moon”.

Catra’s ears perked at that information and smiled. Maybe this trip wasn’t a complete flop. She held out her hand, quietly asking for the book.

“You hate reading this stuff.” Adora laughed and made her scoot over in the chair to join her. “And I know you don’t know how to read First Ones”.

“Then teach me, smartass”.

“Awww, you wanna learn?” She teased and rubbed her ear.

Catra rolled her eyes and laid her head on Adora’s shoulder when she opened the book. Not a single thing on the page made any sense. Just a bunch of lines and symbols.

“Alright,” Adora finally said and rested her head against Catra’s. “From what I was able to gather, you’re part of a species called magicats. You’re definitely a hybrid from what’s been documented in here. I don’t know much about how genetics work, but not all of their features and abilities are showing up in you”.

“So… they’re real?”

“You knew?”

Catra adjusted to sitting on Adora’s lap with her head tucked under the side of her jaw. “I overheard Entrapta going on about magicats one day when she was ‘needing’ to study me for whatever reason. I asked her about it and she said theres hardly

any information that she's been able to find and assumed they're mostly a myth".

"Well, they're not a myth. And they apparently got here through some trade portal at some point".

Catra just listened as Adora read a few pages to her. There wasn't much to comment on. Unfortunately, it seemed the First Ones didn't seem interested in documenting other species' customs. That still left her with only knowing what came instinctively and the small amount she learned in the Crimson Waste from a few other hybrids.

Adora then unrolled the scroll and started reading from that. Of course there was plenty of information about old Etherian customs and traditions. There was also a plethora of information on First One's culture, unsurprisingly. Catra felt like she was slowly being read to sleep. Adora shifted her as she was curled up against her and accidentally stirred her awake. The quiet grunt of disapproval at the new position made Adora chuckle.

"My leg was falling asleep. Here. Let me teach you some of this".

"Seriously?" She mumbled.

"It's not that hard when you get the hang of it. It's a phonetic system and it's read right to left. Single words fall within these points," Adora pointed to what she was talking about, "and

sentences are where the words are linked together by these lines. And the sounds these symbols represent-"

"You're losing me".

"Alright, here," Adora pointed to a word and followed the symbols as she sounded out the word. "Crossroads. And this one is magicat. This here is magic. And Etheria".

Catra put her hand over the writing on the scroll. "That's enough for the day".

Glimmer appeared with Bow and two plates in her hands a half hour later. The two of them got conned into dinner and offered to take something to Catra and Adora to appease Bow's dads. But when Glimmer went to open her mouth about it, she immediately stopped.

Catra was curled up on Adora's lap, her head tucked under her jaw, sound asleep. Adora had her arms wrapped loosely around her, a book still in her hand as she also slept with her cheek resting against the top of Catra's head. Glimmer elbowed her boyfriend before he continued to get overly happy about the scene before them.

"Should we move them?" Glimmer asked quietly.

“What? No!” He covered his mouth when he saw Catra’s foot twitch.

“You know Darla isn’t exactly quiet. They’ll wake up for sure when we land if not at takeoff. So either we wake them up nicely or… Darla does it for us”.

“I don’t like those options,” he muttered.

Glimmer gave Bow the plates and worked on waking Adora first. The last thing she wanted was to accidentally startle Catra and catch her claws.

“Mmmh?” Adora mumbled when Glimmer touched her cheek.

“We’re about to head back,” she said softly, almost mothering. “Do you want to go to a room for the next fifteen minutes”.

“I’m comfy,” she said sleepily.

“Darla’s going to be loud about departure and arrival. You know that”.

“Fine”. She went to stand when Glimmer stopped her.

“Catra’s still in your lap. Do you want Bow to carry her?”

“No,” she cleared her throat and rubbed her eyes. “I’ll get her”.

Adora set her book on the arm of the chair and got her arm under Catra’s legs. She felt absolutely groggy as she slowly stood.

“Adora?” Catra mumbled sleepily.

“Shhh. You’re okay,” she told her. “We going to a room while we head back. Go back to sleep”.

“I have your food,” Bow said. “Lance insisted”.

“Bring them and put them on the dresser. We’ll eat there”.

Bow followed her quietly and set the plates where he was told and smiled while Adora gently put Catra in the bed. As much as she wanted to eat, her body and mind wanted more of a nap. She quietly thanked her friend before he left and closed the door behind him.

Adora crawled into the bed behind Catra and pulled her close. It wasn't long before she fell right back to sleep.

Catra's heavy breathing started to slow as Adora slowly removed her fingers from being buried inside of her. She still had her teeth sunk into the same spot on Adora's shoulder as before. Even as her ear started to be rubbed, her jaw wouldn't relax enough to let go. Catra took a deep breath in and out through her nose while she relaxed her hands.

"There you go," Adora whispered sweetly and held the back of Catra's head.

She took another deep breath before finally being able to release the bite. Adora took a sharp breath in as she did and slowly lowered Catra's head down to the pillow. Clearly she wasn't expecting that kind of payback for the orgasm she gave not too long ago.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked and wiped a little blood from the corner of her mouth.

Catra nodded and finally opened her eyes. Adora was still over her, one hand next to her head and the other hand's thumb tracing over her lips lovingly. She gently traced over the top half of the renewed bite mark, wiping a little blood away. It was probably the one time she didn't hate making Adora bleed. That and the sex induced scratches over her back, shoulders, and

arms. But the perfect outline of her full bite was something she was proud of.

"I give you one strong orgasm and you turn around and give me two back to back". She traced over the bottom half of the bite, wiping a little more blood away. "Enough to get me to do this again. That's a little rude".

"I didn't hear you complaining". Adora laid down next to her with a warm smile. "In fact, I kept hearing you telling me 'more' and 'harder'. You know Glimmer's going to have something to say. You weren't exactly being quiet about it".

"Good," she mumbled happily and rolled to her side to lay her head on Adora's chest. "Let her say something".

Adora lazily ran her fingers through her hair. This wasn't exactly how she was planning to start the day, but it was perfect. The next step was breakfast. At least after she woke Catra back up once she noticed the soft purr had fallen away within a several short minutes.

Her arm twitched, followed by her foot. Adora could feel her jaw tensing and relaxing periodically against her chest. Catra was in just a light enough sleep that any major movement would wake her. Adora waited, still stroking her hair, until the small twitches stopped. She had woken her up prematurely before and quickly learned to no do that in the form of claws catching her shoulder when they were little.

“Catra,” she said softly and rubbed her cheek, “let’s get some breakfast. You need to eat something before you head out”.

Catra groaned and stretched out her legs over Adora’s hips and arms across her torso. Moving any more was not a priority by any means. Neither was a full breakfast. If nothing else she could quickly ransack the kitchen for a few snacks.

“You don’t have to go,” Adora whispered, a touch of sadness to her voice. “That you from the war isn’t who you are anymore. I don’t even think that was really you during that time. You were hurt and angry and bitter and…”

“Suicidal,” she finished for her. “I know. But I need to do this, Adora”. She lightly drew random lines and shapes over Adora’s upper chest. “I know you guys forgive me… at least mostly. I just don’t forgive myself. This, going to Beast Island, is more for me than anything”.

Adora stayed quiet and rubbed Catra’s lower back.

“Please… don’t fight me on this. I have to go. This is my second, and final, day Micah is allowing”.

After rolling to her side, Adora rested her hand on Catra’s cheek. She rubbed her thumb under her eye, silently wishing she would

change her mind. Fingers gently traced over the bite mark as Catra's eyes followed the movement of her own hand.

"I'll be back tonight for you," Catra said. "Save me whatever you want from dinner. I'm not too picky. Do you still want breakfast?"

"Not really. I'd rather stay right here a little longer". Adora played with the little tuft of fur at the angle of her jaw. "But I do want you to eat before you go".

"I know, I know". Catra trailed her fingers down Adora's side. "I just prefer this".

"I just care about you". She gave her a quick kiss. "A lot. So… we should get out of bed and get breakfast".

"That's seriously one of the worst ideas I've heard come from you".

"It might be". Adora finally decided to roll out of bed. "But I do have to get ready to take you and Hordak to Beast Island".

She walked over to the dresser and grabbed a pair of underwear and pants. As she pulled her underwear on she noticed Catra on her back, propped up on her elbows, just eyeing her. The tip of her tail twitched in amusement.

“What?” She asked with a smile as she pulled her pants on.

“That mating mark looks fucking amazing on you,” she said around a purr. “I wasn’t sure why, but maybe it’s simply because I did that”.

“Stop it!” She said, blushing. “Stop looking at me like that”.

“What?” Catra smirked and bent her knees and let one fall off to the side. “What am I doing? Am I not allowed to look at my perfectly beautiful mate?”

Adora tossed the sports bra she had in her hand onto the dresser as she eyed Catra from between her legs to her smug little smirk. She knew exactly what she was doing and almost any other time it would have definitely worked.

“You’re just trying to get me in bed again, aren’t you?”

“Me? Oh, please, Adora. I wouldn’t *ever* do that when we both have things to do”.

“You little liar,” she teased and walked back over to the bed to run her hands up Catra’s legs.

“I like where this is going”. She let her other leg fall to the side.

“Oh, I promise you don’t”. She purposefully barely brushed a finger over her clit and noticed Catra’s lip twitch at the contact.

“I don’t know. I quite enjoy seeing you with your head between my legs”.

Adora grabbed her hips and sharply pulled her to the edge of the bed before stepping back. She laughed at the shocked and mildly disappointed look on Catra’s face and offered her hand when she sat up. It was pushed away before Catra stood up and opened a separate drawer of the dresser for her own clothes.

“That was a low blow, Adora”.

“I’ll take care of you when you get back”.

Adora grabbed her sports bra and pulled it on. Before she was able to pull her shirt on, Catra grabbed her waist and pulled her close. Her mouth covered the fresh bite, her sharp canines threatening to dig in again. Adora held the back of her neck, waiting. As much as she wanted to fight it, she knew the moment Catra bit down, getting dressed was going to be wasted time.

“I’ll make sure you do,” Catra said quietly around growl before placing a lingering kiss on the mark.

“You… are so mean,” Adora said when Catra pulled away with a smug look.

“Me? You act like I haven’t been mean our whole lives”. Catra pulled her tank top on and looked out the window to see the day moon was still low on the horizon. “We’re not running too late, you know”.

“You may not be hungry, but I am”. She grabbed Catra’s hand after putting her jacket on and led her out of their room. “Fucking you works up an appetite”.

The two walked into the dining hall, hand in hand. Glimmer leaned back in her chair and folded her arms while looking over the two. Adora smiled in greeting while she took her seat next to her. Catra also sat down, a challenging smirk coming to her face.

“Seriously, you two?!” Glimmer threw her hands up. “The castle doesn’t exactly have thin walls and we could still hear you. Would it kill you to quiet down?”

“Yeah, probably,” Catra shot back.

“To be fair,” Adora pointed out, “it’s not exactly our fault you guys have the next bedroom”.

“We don’t share a wall!”

“I just wanted to sleep a little more,” Bow whimpered.

“I’m so sorry,” Catra deadpanned before shrugging. “Not my fault it’s mating season”.

“Hold on”. Adora turned to her in shock. “Is it really?”

Catra took in a deep breath and rubbed her temples. “You *know* my cycle is just like every other predominantly Etherian that has one. We grew up together, dummy. Did I scramble your brain that much?” She paused for a moment. “I mean, sure, I go into something of a heat from time to time but that’s not going on right now”.

“Ohhhh. That was a joke. You were joking”.

“Yes, Adora, I was making a joke. Are you sure you don’t need to go back to sleep for a while? I’d rather you not crash Darla”.

“Honestly, I wouldn’t be shocked if you were lying about not having… a moment at this point,” Glimmer said and put her face in her hand, exasperated.

“Aw, you’re just jealous”. Catra’s tail swayed teasingly and looked at Bow. “You might wanna step up your game there, Arrow Boy”.

“I-“

“In case you forgot, my dad lives here too!”

Bow coughed and straightened up as Micah walked with a wave to everyone. Catra returned it politely and Adora bowed her head in greeting. She definitely wasn’t functioning on full power.

“What are we taking about?” He asked enthusiastically. “I do live here, so what are we planning?”

“A… party?” Bow tried to cover.

Chapter End Notes

S: So… I know it’s Sunday and posts are a Saturday thing. I was, unfortunately, dealing with a hell of a migraine all day yesterday. A trip to urgent care followed by a trip to the ER a few hours later for it was not how I was planning my Saturday. It was a bad one is all I gotta say. But hey, the chapter still got posted before Monday!

I also kinda maybe started a side thing solo so you can expect the first chapter of that at some point today too. Really, I just kinda missed surprising Indy and seeing him as just a reader for a bit. We've been writing together for years now so it's a bit of a gift to him, I think. But also something else for you guys to read between now and Saturday. The chapters are definitely a hell of a lot shorter than my normal, but I didn't want it to turn into another massive project when we have this one going on.

Indy: We apologize for the late chapter. Things got crazy for a bit so we couldn't post yesterday. I know I've not been too chatty in the author notes but I don't have anything new to report on. I've been mentally eh the last week or two. I'm doing my best to keep above water. We hope you enjoy the chapter.

Crossroads

Chapter Notes

> There is a decent size bit of a dream and will be started and ended with ***
>
> There is also a bit of smut in said dream. Stop reading at 'Catra smiled before returning to tormenting Adora's neck.' and resume at 'Until it was all ripped away.' to avoid it. Anything important will be left in the end notes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Darla, enable auto pilot to Beast Island," Adora said and sat down in the chair.

"Affirmative."

She rested her chin in her hand as the ship lifted from the ground and accelerated towards the destination. Adora watched the world pass by through the large windshield. With a sigh, she hit her fist on the arm of the chair and pushed a button to close the door to the bridge.

She wished Catra didn't feel like she had to go. She wished there could have been a way to talk her out of it. Adora wiped the stubborn tear from her cheek. Catra asked to not argue about it. So she wouldn't. Adora knew this was part of how her girlfriend felt she needed to heal. Perfuma had even told her during a therapy session that Catra's way of healing was different and that it was okay. Still, she wished Beast Island, at least without her there to help, didn't have to be part of it.

Adora rubbed her face. Catra could take care of herself. She was strong and capable. She didn't need her there to protect her every waking second. Catra wasn't stupid. She would be okay. Adora just didn't want to see her so hurt ever again. She wanted to make up for all the times she wasn't there when Catra was hurt. She wanted to make up for hurting her in more ways than one.

A loud knock on the door startled her from her thoughts and she immediately touched the button to open the door.

"Is everything okay?" Catra asked and sat herself in Adora's lap with her legs over the arm of the chair. "You don't lock yourself in the bridge too often."

"I'm fine," she half lied but decided to continue when her tail brushed under her nose. "I'm fine but… I'm trying to remind myself this is something you feel you need to do to heal. And that… our way of healing is different and that's okay".

"Jeez. Did Perfuma get to you?" She chuckled. "But yeah, I guess she's right about it, you know."

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra and held her close. She still remembered the dangers she had encountered with Bow, Swift Wind, and Micah. Not only were the creatures more of threat than they looked, the signal is what worried her. She watched Swift Wind give into it followed by Bow and Micah. Even Entrapta had given in.

Her heart latched onto the soft purr coming from the woman in her arms. Growing up together, Adora was able to learn that Catra would purr ever so slightly different depending on a situation. This one had comfort written all over it. That's when she finally realized her heart was racing from the memories she had dug up.

"Adora?"

"Huh?" She was breathing heavy.

"Breathe." Catra gently rubbed her hand. "Do you need to talk?"

"Just… when we found Micah…" she sighed and gripped Catra's hand. "The further you go into the island, the more it fucks with your mind. I want— I *need* you to be careful. Okay?"

"If things get weird, I have plenty to remind myself to get back home to you in one piece. I promise."

Adora nodded and rested her head back against the chair. "Darla, what's our ETA?"

"Approximately five minutes".

Catra continued to stay seated between her legs. She kept her comforting purr just loud enough for Adora to hear as she watched Beast Island continue to draw near. Adora slowly started to relax and rubbed Catra's thigh gently. She could handle until sunset. That's all it was. Catra wasn't staying there for days.

Hordak joined the other two on the bridge quietly. He watched out of the windshield as well.

"So, where are we going?" Catra asked, her purr stopping.

"I see you're feeling better". He pulled up the map on his tracker pad. "Our arrival and departure point is here. The work site is roughly a fifteen to twenty minute walk into the island, here".

Catra just nodded and flicked her ear. The thought of hauling a bunch of junk back to the shoreline for removal for twenty minutes didn't sound particularly appealing. She watched Hordak scroll around the screen before opening another tab and handing it to her.

"These are things we need to try to salvage today. Entrapta has been compiling as much data as she can about the structures left to rot".

"And if we can't?" Catra scrolled through the list. "There's a lot she wants."

“Then so be it. She’s well aware we might not be able to get everything”.

“You‘ve arrived at Beast Island,” Darla announced as the ship descended to the ground.

Hordak took the pad back and made his way to grab his backpack and bag of tools. Catra was soon to follow with Adora beside her, hand in hand. Adora walked with them to the end of the ramp.

“I’ll be back at sundown. Remember to play nice and maybe I’ll bring some snacks back with me”.

“You’re such a dork,” Catra laughed and hugged her. “I’ll see you then”.

“Stay safe, both of you”. She gave Catra a kiss. “I love you”.

“I love you too”.

Catra walked off with Hordak and glanced over her shoulder. She saw Adora give a small wave which she returned with a small smile. She sighed softly as she turned her attention back to the walk her and Hordak had ahead of them.

Hordak dropped his bag of tools and set his backpack next to it. Catra's own backpack joined his before she took a blowtorch and screwdriver from him.

"You can start on the tower," he instructed and gestured to a structure half buried and leaning. "Entrapta said there were strong signals of First One's tech over there."

"Sure," she muttered and walked away.

Catra noticed she was standing on a large metal slab covered in vines. Without a better starting point, she decided to start clearing away the vines covering it. Catra picked up an armful of the excess foliage she clawed away and started to make a pile.

As the morning wore on, her pile continued to grow. She was starting to add large sheets of metal to it. Some she had to cut into more manageable pieces. Something caught her eye under a piece. She brushed the dust away and tilted her head. What little First Ones writing she managed to learn helped, but this specific word she knew simply because Adora pointed it out.

"Crossroads?" She read under her breath and raised an eyebrow.

Not a second later, a faint glow appeared around her feet as the word that was etched into the metal lit up. She took a step back and folded her ears back at the loud grinding of metal on metal.

"Hordak!" She called out. "You have to see this!"

He walked over to join her as the tunnel lit up a pale blue. His eyes widened at the familiar patterns the light was creating near what seemed to be the end of long tunnel. He had seen his fair share of portals.

"This can't be-"

"Let's go check it out!" Her ears perked up as she smiled. "Come on. You know you want to."

"I don't think that's a wise decision, Catra".

"What would Entrapta say?" She challenged, looking up at him. "I… I could try to find my people and where they're from and— Entrapta would love all the data and stuff we could find too. Her list wouldn't even compare. Hell, she'd probably forget about the list if she saw this!"

He narrowed his eyes at a new, growing hum. It was growing louder by the millisecond and he grabbed Catra's wrist to stop her from going towards the tunnel.

“Don’t be a fool! Get back! We need to-“

They were both blown back several hundred feet as the portal violently collapsed in on itself and used the tunnel as a channel for the energy. The heat welded the opening to the tunnel open. The metal surrounding it was scorched and the tower next to it fell over.

Hot. Hordak felt the heat coming from the metal sheet he found himself lying on as he regained consciousness. If it was that hot so far from the opening of the tunnel, he hoped he managed to pull Catra away just fast enough she didn’t get incinerated. He groaned and held his side as he sat up. Hordak knew if he was injured, Catra was far more so. He noticed his armor was singed from the heat as he sat on his knees. His hands were cut and he could tell he was bleeding from somewhere on his face. He looked around for a moment, his ears still ringing.

Then he saw her. Catra was on her left side several feet away, unmoving.

Hordak got to his feet, ignoring the pain through his ribs, back, and left arm. He quickly moved to her and crouched down next to her in a controlled panic. She couldn’t be dead. Working methodically, he made sure she still at least had a pulse and was breathing. It was there but not strong. He could tell her body was slipping into shock.

She had several considerable lacerations on her face, arms, right ribs, and legs. Her right forearm was definitely broken and the arm itself dislocated at the shoulder, presumably from impacting the ground with force. Hordak was thankful she was still unconscious when he grabbed her upper arm and yanked her shoulder back into place.

His next move was to be careful of her neck and head as he picked her up. He carried her to where his backpack was and dug out the tracker pad. Hearing Catra gasp, he pushed on the button for the emergency distress beacon.

"H-Hor… Hordak?"

"Don't move. Do you know where you are?"

"The," she coughed, "fright… z-zone."

"What's going on?" Adora's voice came through the tracker pad.

"We need evacuated. As soon as you can. There's been an accident and we're both injured. I can walk and can carry Catra to the beach."

" *Do. Not. Move*. We'll come to you. Keep the beacon on."

Catra was aware she was in excruciating pain. She still tried to sit up, which only made it worse and she cried out. Adora was there. She would make it better. Really, she would get her to the infirmary faster anyhow.

"Catra?! What happened?"

She groaned once she found a slightly less painful position to lay in. Even if it was, unfortunately, partially against Hordak. She wanted to shove him away, make him get Adora. It's not like he actually cared.

"She's severely hurt," Hordak told her calmly, yet urgently. "The sooner you get here, the better. I'll tell you more later but there was a portal. It collapsed."

"A por— I'm on my way".

"I know you want to save Catra, but you need to slow down and think logically for once," Entrapta chimed in over the comms. "We don't know what came through so we'll need to quarantine them. Bring them right to Dryl. I'll be waiting".

"Take Netossa with you," Micah added. "She can make barriers with her nets. And I'm sending Glimmer as well to make sure you don't do something irrational, Adora".

“I’m She-Ra! I can-“

“You are not to come into contact with us,” Hordak said sternly. “We’re both covered in soot, blood, and who knows what else right now. You were a Force Captain. I know you can think logically at least sometimes”.

Catra coughed again and groaned, holding her stomach.

“Fine! We’ll be there in five. How about both of you stay alive for at least that long?!”

Hordak gently held Catra down. The more she moved, the worse her injuries could easily become.

“Stop moving,” he told her.

“Adora,” she whispered harshly. “I want— *ow, f-fuck*— Adora”.

“She’s on her way. You just need to hold still. And try to stay awake”.

Catra shivered as she kept trying to focus her blurry vision. She was dizzy, her head hurt, she was cold, and didn’t quite know

what else was in pain other than… everything. She weakly tapped Hordak's arm.

"I n-need t-t-to roll," she said as she shivered again.

"Catra-"

"I'm… I think… I think I'm going to… get… sick".

Hordak gently helped her onto her side, even as she cried out in pain again. Something was definitely wrong with her back. He held her head while she retched a couple times, making sure her face wasn't in it. He noted both blood and stomach contents before gently and carefully moving her body away from the spot.

He glanced up when he heard Darla's approach and let out a sigh of relief. When they wanted to get somewhere fast, they could really punch it and make it happen. The ramp lowered and the two were immediately encased in a net dome. Hordak gently picked up Catra's trembling body.

Glimmer had a strong hold on Adora's arms after she tried to run down the ramp. Adora only tugged harder as Netossa walked by, keeping the two inside of a net as they went.

"Catra!"

She flicked her ear at the sound of her name, but it sounded so far away. Her eyes were unfocused and heavy. Eventually, she let her body win and closed her eyes while a pain free darkness washed over her.

"No. No, no, no!" Adora pulled against Glimmer harder. All her fighting earned her was a quick teleportation away.

"Here you go," Netossa said as she led them to the med bay. "Go on and lay her down. We can get her patched up and stable on the way."

"We?" Hordak questioned and gently laid Catra on the table.

"I've been exposed to you guys. I'll be in quarantine too. Might as well be of use other than an escort."

Hordak nodded in acknowledgment and went over to one of the cabinets. He knew basic field trauma care, enough to get Catra stable enough to get proper care in Dryl. Netossa caught a few gauze rolls and a bottle of saline wash before getting to work on cleaning some of her wounds. Hordak managed to start an IV in her hand and held the bag of fluids above his head while applying some pressure to it.

“Of course you know how to be a doctor.”

“No. It’s field training. Adora knows how to do this as well, but since she’s She-Ra, she doesn’t use the knowledge much anymore. I don’t blame her for that. I would do the same.”

“What’s the damage?” Netossa asked as she wrapped gauze around a cut on Catra’s leg.

“Many lacerations as you can see. Some scrapes. Her shoulder was dislocated and her arm is quite broken”. He pressed his fingers to the side of her neck. “She definitely has a rather severe concussion. Some burns. And I’m pretty sure her back is injured.”

“And you’re fine?!”

“No,” he stated plainly. “The armor helped, but I have cuts and likely some internal injuries. She takes priority over me right now. This is about keeping her alive”.

Adora came sliding around the corner and quickly got to her feet as she ran to the door of the med bay. She immediately hit the keypad with her fist to open the door but was greeted by a net blocking further entry. Netossa had the IV bag held above her head while Hordak was working on suturing the worst of Catra’s cuts.

“Just let me in!” She screamed and punched the net. “I can heal them! We’ll worry about quarantine later. Please!”

Glimmer appeared behind her and grabbed her shoulders. She was shrugged away just as fast to avoid an abrupt teleport away. Adora’s eyes started to hold the faint glow of She-Ra.

“Come on, Adora!” Glimmer yelled at her, hoping to somehow get through to her friend while still being fended off. “We don’t know what’s on them. It could be dangerous to us all! Let’s go .”

“Please,” she cried and let the transformation happen. “I can fix this.”

“Get her out of here!” Hordak yelled as he was suturing a large gash on her leg closed.

Netossa walked over to the door after setting the bag of IV fluids down. “I’m sorry.”

The door closed in front of her face and she heard the lock engage. The next thing she knew, she was back in the bridge. Glimmer had been able to finally grab her and teleport her away. Adora shoved her hand away and stood by the chair. She could override the lock or simply pry open the door, but it wouldn’t do any good with Netossa’s net in the way.

“Welcome to Dryl,” Darla announced.

For the first time since the distress signal, Adora sat. She didn’t move once the ship landed. She didn’t even move when Glimmer left her to join the others. Instead, she put her head in her hands. She couldn’t transform back and she felt numb. Catra was clearly dying or at least close to it.

“Adora?” Glimmer reappeared. “Are you coming?”

“Why? I’m just going to be in the way, right? None of you are letting me just… heal them. Knowing Hordak, he’s probably really hurt and just ignoring it. And Catra?” She took off her headpiece and left it fall from her hands. “You saw her. We wasted so much time when it could have been so easy. Just go. I’ll wait here”.

“Come on. Don’t be like that. It’s for the best right now, until we have a better idea of what’s on them.” Glimmer picked up the headpiece and held it out. “You don’t have to transform back if you can’t.”

“So Netossa can help but not me?!” She snapped.

“Okay, we both know you’re not exactly… rational right now. I know you’re worried about your girlfriend. I’m worried about her too. But you’re doing that thing where you run in headfirst, regardless of what’s going on”. Glimmer put her headpiece back on her. “Normally we’d love that about you, but this is different.

You can’t heal either of them if you’re affected by anything on them yourself. Think this through”.

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“Shadow Weaver is *going* to kill us,” Adora whispered as Catra kissed up her neck.

“Mmmmm. I don’t think she’s watching training today. Besides, we’d be far too distracted at this point to get a good time on the course.”

Adora closed her eyes and tilted her head to the side, giving Catra far more access to the side of her neck. Her breath was hot on her skin as she took breaths between the open mouth kisses still landing over her skin. Adora buried her fingers into Catra’s hair, pulling her closer.

“You’re beautiful, Adora. Every inch of you”. She gently nipped her neck and received a low moan. “Don’t ever forget that, okay?”

“How could I when I have you to remind me?” She ran her hands over Catra’s shoulders. “You’re not half bad to look at either”.

“Idiot”.

“Yeah, I love you too”.

Catra smiled before returning to tormenting Adora’s neck. She smelled good, almost too good. It was intoxicating. She only got to get this drunk from her for a short window every month, and she made sure to indulge each time.

Adora raised her hips into Catra’s, searching for some kind of friction. A soft gasp left her when she was given a thigh to rub against. The smug smile against her neck told her plenty. Catra was going to take her until she couldn’t feel her legs. That’s how it usually happened around her ovulation at least. There was no stopping the wild side of her girlfriend when it came to this.

And that thought alone had her grinding a little harder against the leg between hers.

“Needy,” Catra whispered next to her ear. “You know, maybe we should go to training”.

“I… will fucking kill you if you stop this”. Adora dug her fingers into her lower back, attempting to get Catra’s hips to match her pace. “Catra, *please* .”

“So, so, *so* needy,” she purred. “You know I like it when you’re like this”.

“Stop. Talking”. She grabbed the base of her tail. “I think that mouth of yours could be used elsewhere”.

“You little-“

Adora flipped their positions with a smug smile. It quickly fell away when Catra held her hips gently and rubbed her hipbones with her thumbs.

“What’s wrong? You’re usual a wild beast this time of month with me. Stop holding back”.

“I don’t want to hurt you,” she finally said and searched Adora’s face. “Something feels different. And not just that our cycles somehow synched up this month.”

“I can take it, Catra. If it hurts, I’ll tell you. Please, stop stalling”. She laid back down next to her and pulled her back on top. “I can see in your face that you’re dying for this. And I know it feels good for you too”.

“Adora-“

“I’m saying it’s okay”.

“I don’t want you to feel like I’m using-“

“You are *not* using me”. She cut her off with a finger over her lips and looked her in the eyes. “It feels amazing for me too. I know how you get when your heat comes around but I don’t care how different it might be this time. If it hurts, I’ll tell you to stop”.

Catra nodded and buried her face back into Adora’s neck. Something in her chest burned. There was a completely new urge to sink her teeth into her skin coursing through her veins and she didn’t know why. It was confusing and frightening. But Adora wanted it, wanted *her* .

With a low, quiet growl, she slid two fingers into Adora. There wasn’t an ounce of resistance as she moaned into her ear. Catra could feel the fur down her spine start to bristle at the sound. She kissed down her neck again and stopped at the junction between her neck and shoulder.

Adora grabbed the back of her neck when she felt hot, open mouth breathing against the spot she stopped at. The tease of contact was infuriating as fingers continued to pump in and out of her rough and fast.

“Ca-Catra-“

She received a low growl in response and felt teeth grip into her neck. That was definitely new. The hand between her legs

showed no signs of stopping, exactly what she wanted. The added touch of pain as the pressure of the bite increased was exhilarating.

Until it was all ripped away.

"So *this* is what you decide to do instead of your training?!" Shadow Weaver yelled as she had Catra by the hair.

Adora quickly grabbed the blanket from beside the bed and pulled it over herself. "This isn't-"

"I have my own eyes, Adora! I know *exactly* what I've witnessed and I can not believe *you* would do something such as this. Especially with the likes of *this one* ."

Catra hissed and dug her claws into the hand holding her by the hair. Only the grip grew tighter and she visibly winced.

"Let her go! You're hurting her!"

"Oh, Adora, this is *nothing* compared to what she has coming. And you will be joining us".

Catra squirmed again with a growl. That's when she was roughly discarded to the floor. Once she got to her feet again, a hard hand came across her face.

"Catra!" Adora stood to help, only to find herself in Shadow Weaver's hold by the hair to be used as a human shield.

"She won't hurt you. Adora, you know better. I expect this behavior from her. But you ?"

"Let. Her. Go," Catra growled. "Punish me as you see fit. You want me gone so bad, here's your fucking chance. Leave Adora alone".

"Catra," Adora whispered, "don't…"

"I'll be fine," she tried to smile for her, but a tear betrayed her. She knew what was next. "You… you'll be okay too".

Shadow Weaver let Adora go with a shove. She watched as Catra got dressed and grabbed her by the back of the neck when she was done.

"Catra… don't-" Adora started to beg as Catra winced again when Shadow Weaver tightened her hold on the back of her neck.

“It’s okay, Adora. It’ll be okay”.

“Yes. All will be perfect soon enough”.

Catra wiped the tear from Adora’s cheek and let her hand linger for the last time. This was it. And just to rub it in Shadow Weaver’s face more, she kissed Adora.

“Get some clothes on, dummy. I love you, Adora. Okay?”

“D-don’t…”

Adora fell to her knees as she watched Shadow Weaver escort her away after saying, “you have ten minutes to get yourself together and come to the Black Garnet Chamber. Do *not* make me look for you”.

Adora gathered her clothes shakily. Shadow Weaver was going to kill Catra. There was no doubt about that. And now, she had to watch. She wiped her eyes as she wandered into the bathroom and stared at herself in the mirror. After this, all she would have left to care about was being Force Captain.

If she was being honest, she didn’t even care about that anymore.

She put a hand over the faint indents left on her neck from Catra's sharp canines with a sob. After this, Adora figured she'd climb up to her and Catra's spot that looked out over the Fright Zone. Just maybe she'd lose her footing.

Adora got dressed as tears quietly dripped from her chin. She wiped her face dry and choked back the rest that wanted to fall. There was no way she was walking through the halls like that. It would be seen as weak. That's not the last impression she wanted to leave behind.

Swallowing hard, she heard Catra scream in agony from the other side of the towering door. Not wanting to catch the torture in progress, she decided to stop it with a harsh knock.

"Ah, right on time," Shadow Weaver said and pulled Adora in. "Go on. Say your goodbyes".

Adora stepped around the black garnet and the tight fists she had fell slack. Catra's arms were imprisoned in a violent, magic arc of electricity. She was on her knees, breathing heavy. Her hair was a mess, far worse than the messy mane she liked to keep. There was a bruise starting to form under her left eye and on the right side of her jaw. Her nose was leaking blood and there was even some running from her busted lip down her chin. Adora noticed Catra's clothes were ripped in a few places, the fur that was showing through was dirty and a little singed.

It didn't even look like she tried to fight back much, if at all. It looked like she had given up, resigned to her fate.

“Catra-“

“I don’t… want you to watch, Adora”. She looked up. “Try to keep your eyes closed. Please. For me”.

Adora knelt in front of her and held her face gently. “I’m going to get you out of here”.

“You’re *such* an idiot, Adora. You can’t. This is it. Just listen to me. I want you to be the best Force Captain this place has ever seen. I want you to run this place some day”. She pressed her cheek into Adora’s hand. “And I want you to find happiness again”.

“No. C-Catra, no. Don’t you dare give up like this”.

“I’m sorry. Just… kiss me one last time”.

Adora pressed her lips to hers. She tried to pour every ounce of love into it while her heart shattered. Shadow Weaver cut it short and pulled her away, her hands gliding along Catra’s cheeks and chin as she was drug backwards and slammed into a table.

“I love you, Catra,” she whispered while she cried.

“What a shame you’ll never remember these feelings,” Shadow Weaver said and restrained Adora’s writs and ankles to the table. “You know this kind of thing is forbidden. When I’m done with you, everything will be as it should”.

“Don’t hurt her!” Catra yelled and tugged against her own restraints as the current surged through her body.

“You, Catra, are going to watch. And then, you’re next”.

“Oh, I thought you wanted me dead,” she spat. “Just do it!”

“Adora’s mind is far too powerful to completely rid you from her memory. Doing so could kill her. But I can, however, rid her of all memories of your little… relationship. How does that sound, Adora?”

“I won’t let you!” Adora yelled at her. “I will fight you and your stupid magic until it kills me!”

“I’m afraid you don’t have a choice”.

Shadow Weaver put her hands on the sides of Adora’s head, glowing red energy around them. When she cried out in pain, Catra again tried to break free, regardless of the agonizing pain through her body.

“No!” She screamed. “Adora!”

All she could do was watch and struggle to break free until Shadow Weaver slowly stepped away and roused Adora back to consciousness while blocking her line of sight.

“Go on and get some rest, Adora. Dinner has been moved up an hour. Run along”.

“Why… am I in here again?”

“You wanted to report how your cadet squad beat the class above you. You did very well today”.

“Oh, right. Thanks”.

Catra fell back to her knees. She won. Adora didn’t remember anything. Or if she did, she was really good at faking it. But she couldn’t have. If she did, she would have known where to look to find her. That never happened as she turned and walked out without even a glance back.

The door closed and Shadow Weaver turned to her prisoner. “See how easy that was? Things are almost back to normal. I just need to take care of you”.

Catra didn’t say a word. She focused on that last kiss as she felt hands on the sides of her head. If she wasn’t going to remember it, she might as well hold onto it for as long as she possibly could. And then the pain started. She tried to fight it, but Shadow Weaver dug into her memories harder.

The last thing she held onto before blacking out was the softness of Adora’s lips.

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Catra blinked awake, her chest heaving as she breathed. Disoriented was putting it lightly as she looked around. Her surroundings didn’t look like the Fright Zone. The air smelled far too sterile for it to even be the infirmary she remembered.

“Awake again?” Hordak asked from his own bed. “What do you want to ramble on about this time?”

“What are you talking about?”

She turned her head to look at him. He looked different from what she remembered. Green eyes and white hair. It couldn’t have been him.

“So far the things you’ve told me in these mildly coherent states have consisted of you stealing ration bars late at night, somehow managing to sneak into my sanctum to take my tools, putting Imp into a trash can and threatening him with death if he told,” Hordak rubbed his chin, “posing as a guard on more than one occasion, the first time you kissed Adora, the first time you two engaged in intercourse, and how she’s apparently your mate. Enlighten me, Catra, what am I going to hear this time?”

She blinked for a moment before turning her attention to the ceiling. It couldn’t have possibly been her that confessed those things. This was the first time she’s been awake since Shadow Weaver had her imprisoned in the Black Garnet Chamber and was forced through a failed mind wipe.

“How long have I been out?”

“You’ve been in and out if consciousness for a few hours now”.

“No… that’s not right,” she mumbled and closed her eyes. “This isn’t right”.

Hordak turned his attention to the door as it opened. Adora looked exhausted, yet almost triumphant as she walked in and closed the door behind her.

“I’m a little shocked you’re in here,” he said.

“They finally deemed it safe enough for me to heal you both,” she said and went to Catra’s bedside. “Low level radiation in the soot is from the explosion. We’re all still getting a decontamination shower just in case after this”.

“Adora?” Catra cracked an eye open. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine. Just worried about you”. She kissed her forehead. “Now I can heal both of you and we can get our showers and finish this stupid quarantine thing”.

“Heal me?” Catra slowly propped herself up on the elbow that wasn’t in a sling. “Did you hit your head again? You can’t do that, dummy”.

Adora looked at Hordak, confused. “You guys kept saying she has a severe concussion but I didn’t think it was *this* bad”.

“Are… do you still love me?”

She turned her attention back to Catra and covered her hand. “Of course I do. Why are you asking me?”

“Shadow Weaver caught us. She… she wiped your mind. I thought it worked on you but not me. You remember?”

A moment of realization washed over her and she sighed.

"Of course she still loves you," Hordak told her. "You told me less than a half hour ago that she's your mate".

"You… she *what* ?" Adora turned her attention back to Hordak.

"Between the concussion and the pain medication, she's been in and out of consciousness. There's plenty of barely coherent… enlightenments I could have lived the rest of my days without knowing".

Catra started laughing. Genuinely laughing.

"She fucking failed! Shadow Weaver isn't as strong as she thinks. Wow, you," she laughed more, "you really thought you could count on her, Hordak? You can't possibly be *that* stupid".

Hordak pinched the bridge of his nose. "Please, heal her so she shuts up".

Adora groaned in frustration and transformed into She-Ra. She was going to need full access to her magic for Catra. Her girlfriend just so happened to be gawking at her new form when she turned her attention to her. She chuckled and held her face.

“You still might not remember much, or order of events, for about a day. But I’m going to fix you up now. Since you probably don’t remember how this goes, you’ll still feel really sore after this. Just hold still”.

Catra was still at a loss for words that her girlfriend just morphed into a really tall warrior goddess as the space around her began to glow gold. Then she was warm. Everything was so comfortably warm and relaxing that she closed her heavy eyes and pressed her cheek into one of the hands on her face. She felt better as she became aware that her head was back to resting on the pillow, yet still in a bit of a daze.

Adora turned her attention to Hordak and quickly healed up his wounds with far less effort. She returned to her normal form and sat on the edge of Catra’s bed. She was either stuck in there with them or she could go to the room Netossa was in.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra said sleepily. “Where’ve you been?”

“Forced to stay away from you guys for hours since no one knew what was on you. Turns out it’s just low level radiation-“

“If I’m radioactive, you need to go elsewhere”. She sat up and pulled her legs in to try to keep her distance. “Stop being an idiot. It’s not safe”.

“Did you miss the low level part?” She reached out her hand. “I’m not going to die from being around either of you. Would you feel better if I went to Netossa’s room?”

Catra looked at her hand for a moment and simply brushed their fingertips together. That’s all the contact she wanted to risk. As much as she wanted Adora to stay, she couldn’t live with herself if something did happen. They didn’t know what else, if anything, managed to slip through the ancient portal. The tests were taking a while with any further answers.

“Not really.” She lowered her ears. “But I think it’s best if you do”.

Even Hordak was shocked by her words. He thought for sure having Adora there would get her to relax.

“Oh.” Adora looked at the floor and nodded before resting her hand over Catra’s foot. “Okay. I’ll… see in an hour then. For our, um, scrub down.”

Catra hated the rejected expression that fell over Adora as she stood and walked to the door. It was for her own safety. That’s all. She truly wanted her stay. She hoped Adora knew that.

Once the door slid closed behind Adora, Catra put her head on knees. Nothing about this was particularly pleasant. Her whole body ached and now she had to deal with a shower. A small part of her couldn’t wait. Water or not, getting the soot out of her fur

was desired. And she wasn't about to clean it off herself not knowing whether or not it was toxic.

"Do you remember what happened?" Hordak asked.

"A little," she mumbled as a reply. "There was a tunnel. And a portal I think. Uh, Beast Island, right?"

"Correct. How did you open it? I'm curious".

"*Me*?" Her head snapped up and looked at him. "I opened it? Of fucking course I did. It's something I'm clearly good at doing!"

"Calm down!" He snapped. "I'm pretty sure you didn't do this one on purpose".

Catra growled at his tone. Commanding. Just like back in the Fright Zone.

"It was a very old First Ones installation. There's no way you, or I, could have known. Entrapta said there wasn't any further energy readings other than radiation. It's gone and Etheria is intact with no one needing to sacrifice themselves. Unlike last time".

She bared her teeth at him at the comment. Always one to remind her of her mistakes and shortcomings. Just like Shadow Weaver to an extent.

"Don't you dare forget who ousted you right from your throne," she growled, eyeing the crystal in the collar of his armor.

He narrowed his eyes at her and grunted in annoyance. She had him cornered on that one. He remembered all too well the way she clawed the crystal out of the suit so easily. Hordak quickly made her second in command, seeing just how ruthless she could be. It suited her at the time.

"Those days are long over, Catra. You don't need to indulge in this power war again".

A low growl rumbled in her chest. It wasn't like she wanted to remember any of it. For a moment, she wondered if She-Ra was capable of erasing memories. She also knew Adora wouldn't want to risk it, not that she blamed her. If it was even possible in the first place.

Catra ripped the IV from her hand and got out of the bed. Her tail was lashing violently from the back of the hospital gown. Hordak also stood as she stalked over to stand in front of him.

"It would be greatly appreciated if you wouldn't throw everything in my face. But I know how hard that is for you. I know how

much you hated me". She jabbed a claw into the center of his chest as her lip curled in a snarl. " You let Shadow Weaver beat me, manipulate me. I was never good enough. So why didn't you kill me yourself when you had several opportunities to do so?"

Hordak stared down at her. It wasn't his intention to rip open such old wounds. He glanced down at the back of the hand that was at his chest and sighed at the blood streaks over it from where the IV had been.

"You… pitied me." She scoffed and shoved his chest. "You let me be a Force Captain and then your second in command out of fucking pity."

"That's not true, Catra. You were what the Horde was training you to be. Cold and ruthless. You grew to deserve the positions you were given. I feel you realized your potential after Adora-"

Catra growled snatched the crystal from his suit and raised it over head. The dark, angry side of her urged her to shatter it on the floor. Instead, tears ran down her cheeks as she breathed heavily. Eventually she threw the crystal at Hordak and fell to her knees in front of him, sobbing.

Hordak returned the crystal to where it belonged and knelt down in front of her. He placed a surprisingly gentle hand on her shoulder.

“I overstepped,” he admitted. “Those days are over. Even for me. Catra, I still struggle as well”.

“Like hell you do”. She swatted his hand away. “I don’t want or need your pity”.

“Everything I’ve done in my time on Etheria, establishing the Horde, the portal, seizing control… it was all to gain the favor of Prime. I know what it’s like to be cast aside”.

Catra sat back on her heels and hugged herself. She knew all of that.

“You don’t know what it’s like to fight against someone you love,” she whispered. “I could have ended all of this, She-Ra and Adora, so many times, much sooner. But I couldn’t bring myself to do it. I needed her alive. I… I needed her to remember the feelings we had, that I still had. Thanks to Shadow Weaver,” she looked at her hands, “I didn’t know what I was feeling. Why… I never wanted to hurt her”. She clenched her hands into fists, her claws digging to her palms. “But I did”.

Hordak sat on the floor in front of her, legs crossed. “I believe you hurt She-Ra”.

“They’re the same person! I realized that, but I still… ugh!” She buried her face in her hands. “When I was chipped… I hurt Adora.

She wasn’t She-Ra. She broke the sword and couldn’t turn into her at the time”.

“Prime was controlling you. You would have never-“

“You think I don’t know that?!” She abruptly got to her feet and stood over him. “You think I don’t remember that?! It was still me! Controlled or not, it was my claws. I’m tired of having this argument with quite literally everyone. When will one on you realize-“

Hordak stood and grabbed her shoulder. He hated what he was about to do, but he knew it was the only thing he knew how to do to get her attention. He dug his thumb into her shoulder joint and saw her wince. Continuing the pressure, he guided her back down to her knees.

“Are you finished?”

She nodded and rubbed her shoulder once he let go. “What the fuck?”

“Seems old tricks still work”. He crouched down so he was eye level. “I now see why you wanted to go to Beast Island so bad. Catra, you hold immense guilt. However, Beast Island is not a proper outlet for it. If the signal there could latch onto those emotions, you’d be trapped”.

Catra looked away from him and rubbed her arm.

"I also hold guilt. But I've fully accepted what I've done and my punishment. I know it's hard to move forward when you've caused destruction and pain. Still, you must try. If not for yourself, do so for Adora. Don't you think she deserves at least that from you?"

"Sure. Whatever".

She got to her feet and walked back to her bed. They still had more than a half hour to wait around. She curled up on her side, unfortunately still facing Hordak. He just didn't need to see her bare backside for the next, at minimum, half hour.

Catra closed her eyes. She heard enough. Said enough. Sleeping was the only course of action she saw remaining. Even if it was only a light snooze more than actual sleep.

Chapter End Notes

For the smut skippers: main thing missed is Catra's first time with feeling the urge to mark Adora

S: Another week, another chapter.

For those concerned about my heath and ER visit, I'm feeling slightly better. I've been in and out of the ER and doctor's offices so much lately for a lot of different things. Good news, every single test (there's been a lot) I've had so far is great. I'm a "healthy" 28 year old woman. Bad news, no one knows

what's wrong with me. I'm not going to get into everything on here as I don't like to talk about medical things online until there's a diagnosis. Just know it's stressful at the moment and it's taking a bit of a toll on my mental health. I do genuinely appreciate the concern and the well wishes for me feeling better. I definitely need the good vibes and/or whatever else you guys do.

I love and appreciate you all. ❤️ ❤️

Indy: I hope you all like the chapter! I'm on spring break but I still feel like I got a lot of work to do. Hopefully I can actually take the time to reply to comments. Stay safe and I love you all.

Quarantine: Part 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stood in the far corner of the communal shower facing the wall. It wasn't that she was particularly uncomfortable, she had showered in front of men before after cleaning the forge. A communal shower was nothing. It was that Adora barely acknowledged her, nothing more than a simple 'hey' while she grabbed her bar of soap.

Netossa and Glimmer had been chatting quietly as they scrubbed themselves down. Adora was mostly quiet, only offering short responses to the conversation.

"Have you ever thought about healing that?" Netossa asked Adora about the fresh bite mark. "She got you good".

"Yeah," Adora chuckled halfheartedly, "she did. I'm not healing it though".

She looked to Catra who was still facing away from them and frowned. Adora was sure she would have easily been the first one done, wanting out of the water as fast as possible. She knew something was off the moment she stepped under the water without hesitation. Though, it could have been as simple as wanting the soot out of her fur. If that were the case, Adora figured she'd been washing herself faster instead of the halfassed scrub she was giving herself.

Adora looked back to the wall in front of her and worked on getting enough lather in her hands to wash her hair. It reminded her of forge clean out days in the Horde. The only soap they were given was harsher than the standard issue soap and shampoo. It was only single bar somehow meant for both hair and body. She let out a sigh as she worked her fingers into her scalp.

"You know you don't have to stare at the wall like you're going to kill it," Glimmer commented with a chuckle.

"Why are you even joining us for this?" Adora closed her eyes and put her head back under the water. "They were in a net the whole time."

"Entrapta said it would be a good precaution since I was on the ship too."

"So you're saying keeping me away from Catra and Hordak didn't fucking matter in the end?!" Adora punched the wall in front of her. "I could have healed them and you didn't let me. If I was just going to end up in this damn shower and go through quarantine with them at the end of all of this, what was the fucking point, Glimmer?!"

"I didn't know this was going to be the outcome!"

“Enough!” Netossa yelled at the two. “I get it. Adora, you’re pissed. Honestly, I would have been the same way with Spinny. I’m sorry I didn’t let you in, okay? I was just doing what I was told. We’re all stressed out but can we please not take it out on each other like this?”

Glimmer looked over at Catra. “You doing alright over there?”

“Yeah. Just fine”. Her tone was dry as she stepped from the water just enough to attempt to create a lather in her hair.

“You sure don’t sound fine,” Glimmer prodded.

“How about this,” Catra glanced over her shoulder, “I’m taking a shower with some of the world’s worst decontamination soap. I almost fucking died again. I told Adora to hang out with Netossa so she wasn’t around me being radioactive or whatever and now she’s pissed.” She turned her attention back to the wall in front of her while she scrubbed her side with the bar of soap. “And now you’re telling us that Hordak and I could have been healed basically as soon as you guys came to pick us up? Not to mention we also have to explain the bite thing to Netossa now because why would Adora heal everything but that . Yeah, Sparkles, I’m doing just fine.”

“I’m not pissed,” Adora said as she scrubbed her chest.

“Bullshit!”

“Hey!” Netossa cut in again. “Knock it off! Seriously. Can we just… not fight for the next… hell, give me even two minutes. What’s going on with specifically you two?” She pointed between Adora and Catra. “And while you’re at it, I’d love to hear the explanation of this not healing a bite wound.”

“It’s just a bite,” Adora muttered as she worked on rinsing her hair.

“Just a bite?!” Catra snapped and stepped out of the water after she finished rinsing off. “Seriously, Adora?”

“Guys-“ Glimmer tried to stop them but was ignored.

“That’s not what I meant!“ Adora turned to her. “It’s just a bite wound when you look at it. I know it means-“

“It’s way fucking more than *just* a bite wound.” Catra turned her water off. “But if that’s how you feel about it now, fucking heal it!”

“Catra-“

She stopped at the low growl, just loud enough to hear over the water, from the corner and looked over. Adora felt like her heart was in her throat at the cold stare she was getting. She definitely

overstepped and couldn’t tell if she only pissed Catra off or broke her heart a little too.

Or maybe a lot.

Catra had turned back around and put her forehead to the wall, unmoving while water dripped from her body. Adora could see her chest rising and falling in a barely controlled rhythm. Catra was clearly trying to keep herself from really going off the deep end.

“Okay, Adora. That was a little much,” Glimmer scolded. “I know she upset you, but that was… that was really low”.

“I’m definitely missing something important about this whole bite thing,” Netossa said, glancing at everyone.

“Catra?” Adora asked quietly for permission to tell her.

“Tell her whatever,” she snipped. “Doesn’t seem to matter much when you can just heal it on a whim”.

“Catra, I’m sorry,” she tried to grab her hand as she walked by, only to have it pulled away. “I didn’t mean it-“

“Sure you didn’t, Adora”. She ripped a towel a from one of the hooks and wrapped it around herself before turning around. “All I wanted was to keep you safe from whatever the fuck I had on me. I know Entrapta said it was fine or whatever, but I’d rather be safe now than sorry later. I *wanted* you to stay”.

Adora visibly flinched at the tone of her words and put a hand over the bite.

“So go on. Tell her whatever the fuck you want about it. Heal it if you really want to. I need to be alone right now.”

“Catra! Would you just fucking stop!” She called after her. When she didn’t, she grit her teeth at the one thing she knew she wouldn’t ignore as a promise. “Stay”.

Adora turned off her water and rested her forehead against the wall.

“What is going on?!” Netossa yelled into the shower area and turned her water off at the same time as Glimmer. “Seriously. I understand arguments and fights in relationships. Spinny and I still do from time to time. But this… is a little much over a bite”.

“I said I need to be alone right now, Adora,” Catra said slowly after returning to the shower area, even more irritated Adora would pull the card she did at a time like that. “What do you want?”

Silence fell over the four while Adora reached around her own back to run her fingers over the parts of the claw scars she could reach. She was never letting Catra go again. She could do this. Catra looked away with guilt coming to her face. The scars weren't something else they needed to fight about. Not now.

Netossa was about to step in yet again, but Adora beat her to speaking.

"I'm sorry," she whispered and hit her forehead against the wall. "I took that way too far. I wouldn't ever heal it. Not unless you really, truly want me to. Now, please, can you just stay here with me while I tell Netossa? If that's okay."

Catra quietly grabbed a towel for her from one of the hooks and held it out. Adora took it and wrapped it around herself. She waited for the other two to get towels as well. This wasn't exactly something she wanted to share while anyone was naked.

"The bite… it's…," Adora glanced at Catra, "it's a thing. For her- I mean, us. Now. Both of us. It's a thing for both of us".

"It's a mating bite," Catra finally said, stopping Adora from embarrassing herself further. "Long story short, she's my mate".

Netossa raised an eyebrow and looked between the two, silently asking for a slightly longer story.

Catra groaned and rubbed her face. “I’ve had this feeling for years and never knew what it was since the Horde is fantastic at teaching us about our bodies and species. So, I got around to asking someone in the Crimson Waste after I took the place over and was told it’s instinct for our kind. It’s usually a permanent thing, but when your mate can heal themselves at will… yeah. It’s a lot. I worry”. She looked at Adora with a slight glare. “So, I’m sorry if I’m a little sensitive about that kind of talk”.

“So… it’s like marriage?” Netossa asked.

“More than,” Adora said with a small smile. “At least to her species.”

“Oh!”

“Was that good or bad?” She asked and looked at Catra. “I can’t tell”.

“Good! Definitely good”. Netossa smiled briefly. “It makes a lot more sense for… whatever’s going on now”.

“I’m going to get dressed and go to our room,” Catra said quietly and pulled her hand from Adora when she tried to hold it again.

“Catra, come on. I didn’t-“

“Save it for now, Adora. I just… I need a minute”.

_____

Glimmer opened the door to one of the many robots and groaned. It was a late dinner and they were all hungry. Unfortunately, it all just had to be tiny food. Still, she took the platters and set them in the middle of the floor while the robot left.

“Food’s here,” she told everyone and sat on the floor.

Adora rolled from the bottom bunk and reached over the edge of the top bunk to gently nudge Catra. She only gave a short grunt and decided to stay curled up on the top bunk under the blanket while Adora joined the others for dinner.

“Catra,” Netossa tried, “you should join us”.

“Not hungry”.

She stood and walked over to the bunk and grabbed the edge of the blanket. She quickly yanked it from the top bunk and waited,

arms crossed. Eventually Catra sat up and growled at her, holding her hand out for the blanket.

"Uh-uh. I don't think so. Food. Now".

"Whatever. I don't need the stupid blanket anyhow".

Catra laid back down with a huff and curled up. The next thing she knew, her pillow was yanked from under her head.

"Seriously?!" She sat up again.

"It's late. I know you're tired and upset. I'll bet the last thing you ate was breakfast. So, get your ass down here and eat some of this tiny food. Not a request."

Catra curled her lip and swung her legs over the edge of the bunk and jumped down. Netossa finally gave her the blanket and pillow back. She tossed the pillow to the bed but draped the blanket over her shoulders before she sat down with everyone else.

"Huh. I'll just have to start doing that," Adora mused.

"I dare you," she grumbled and picked up a miniature steak. "Why does it have to be tiny?"

“It tastes better,” Hordak said and quickly cleared his throat. “At least that’s what Entrapta says”.

Catra sighed and tossed the tiny food item into her mouth. She pulled her knees to her chest and wrapped the blanket around herself. Adora gently put a hand on her back and she involuntarily tensed at the touch.

Two whole days. She had to be locked in the same room as the four others for two whole days. She tried to rationalize that that was the reason she was so on edge. It wasn’t because of the little fight they had. It wasn’t because everything felt and looked too sterile. It definitely wasn’t because everyone was in stark white scrubs.

“Do you need to talk?” Adora asked quietly.

She was met with silence.

“Catra, listen. I’m so sorry for what I said. I went way too far. Instead of just saying that… telling me to go back with Netossa and hurt a little, I… I just had to bring the bite into it and I fucked up. I shouldn’t have said that the way I did”.

“No,” Catra whispered, her ears flat. “You shouldn’t have. I’m sorry if what I said hurt your feelings. I just wanted you to be

safe, regardless of what Entrapta said. But… you know how I feel about this". She got to her feet and headed towards her bunk. "It's not something to joke about. Not when you could easily heal it whenever".

"Catra-" Netossa started as Catra climbed back into the top bunk but Adora cut her off.

"Let her go". She hugged her knees. "I'll deal with her later. Give her the space she wants right now".

"So she wasn't just saying things in a concussed haze," Hordak mused. "Not that I can say I'm shocked, given how… close you two have always been".

Adora stirred awake in the middle of the night and rubbed her face. Even after all this time, she would still have nightmares of the things she witnessed Shadow Weaver do to Catra and how she was powerless to stop her. In a barely awake haze, Adora moved her foot in search of Catra curled up at the foot of the bed like most nights. When she wasn't there, she sat up quietly and rubbed her eyes.

Instead of the quiet snores she grew used to back then, she heard the other all too familiar sound of muffled sobs and sniffles coming from above her. Adora knew this wasn't the Horde the longer she was awake, especially when she glanced to the wall

and their ridiculous little drawings weren't there. Quietly, she got out of bed to stand on the edge of it to peer into the top bunk.

The position Catra was in brought back less than pleasant memories. She was curled tightly around her pillow, crying into it, with her blanket almost coving her entire body. Only the very top of her hair was visible and Adora did the one thing she used to always do on nights like this and gently tussled the hair she could see.

"Go away, Adora". The whisper was just as muffled as everything else as she tucked her head completely under the blanket.

"Wanna come down?" She asked quietly. "There's plenty of room".

The response of silence and the blanket moving as she curled up tighter only made this scene feel too familiar. Right down to the conversation. Adora continued to reenact it. She couldn't stop.

"I can come up there if you'd like".

It seemed Catra was also reliving those long ago days as her reply was still muffled, "I don't want you to fall off, idiot".

"Then come down here. I'll… try to calm you down and you can stay at the foot of the bed. I won't make you sleep next to me".

Catra slowly unburied herself and looked at her, tear filled eyes glowing in the dark. Adora gave a smile and stroked her cheek.

"Come on. There's plenty of room. I promise".

She slowly and quietly uncurled herself and climbed down. Catra stood at the edge of the bed, hugging herself, until Adora laid back down and threw the blanket open.

"Well, don't just stand there".

Catra crawled in bed next to her and curled up facing away. An all too gentle hand tangled into the hair at the back of her head. It was like their teenage years were on display for anyone that woke up and decided to watch. And just like back then, her tears and sniffles slowly faded away.

"Bad dream?" Adora asked quietly.

Catra nodded and wiped her face with the back of her hand.

"Yeah, me too". She wrapped an arm around her waist and pulled her close. "We're not in the Horde anymore. And we can love each other, sleep together like this, without fear of getting caught. I really am sorry for what I said. It was so very wrong of me. It's

definitely not something I should talk about like that. I know you worry that I'm going to change my mind and heal it. I never want to".

Catra sighed and let Adora slip her hand under the scrub top to rub her stomach gently.

"Can I ask you something? It's… about that time Shadow Weaver took the memories of our relationship and it finally working for her. We don't have to talk about it. I know it's-"

"What about it?" She whispered.

"Before we were caught… you were biting me. Was that…?"

"I think so". She rolled over in Adora's arms. "I didn't know what I was feeling. It was like… it felt like something I needed to do. I don't know how to explain it".

Adora closed her eyes and ran her fingers along Catra's spine. "I wonder if… if you had broken skin then, if she would have been successful. How different things could have been…"

"Hey," she put a hand on her cheek. "Sometimes I wonder how different things could have been if I had remembered what I was feeling towards you. If I would have left with you… or if you

remembered, if you would have stayed. The whole war… there was something there, you know?”

“Yeah,” she laughed quietly and opened her eyes. “The amount of times we could have let each other die, but saved each other instead. Or why I cried in private after we fought. It was all so weird and confusing. You were the… enemy”.

“Confusing doesn’t even cover half of it, Adora. Do I need to remind you of Princess Prom? Half the time I didn’t know if I wanted to kill you or… I guess now that I know what it was, kiss you”.

Adora laughed and got a hand clamped over her mouth so she wouldn’t wake up anyone. When Catra finally moved her hand, she kissed her and smiled.

“That dip of yours, though,” she raised an eyebrow. “You didn’t know what you were feeling?”

“I… I wanted something, okay?” She looked away. “You know what the Horde taught us. Of course I didn’t exactly know what it was. Did you?”

Adora shook her head after bringing Catra’s gaze back to her. She really didn’t. What she remembered was an unexplainable pull. It was the same feeling every time she saved her from something.

She could just never figure out why until Shadow Weaver sacrificed herself.

"I still like the way your eyes glow in the dark".

Catra scoffed, yet still smiled. "Dork".

"Do you want the foot of the bed?" She asked and kissed her nose.

"Don't be such an idiot. No". She rolled back over so her back was pressed against Adora. "I much prefer this. Even if what you said still hurts. A lot".

"I'm really sorry". She kissed the back of her head and tightened her hold slightly. "I mean it".

Normally, this would have been the part where Catra would stay awake a little longer until Adora fell asleep. Once she was, she would quietly move to the foot of the bed where she would stay for the rest of the night. Just in case. They were never caught sleeping under the same blanket. Except by Lonnie on three separate occasions.

Adora gasped and fought the urge to sit up and accidentally wake Catra, who was now definitely asleep.

Lonnie.

She knew. Adora remembered the time she even caught them having sex one time. After a very awkward conversation, she laughed it off and agreed to keep it a secret. She even helped the two of them by guarding closets and occasionally the locker room. Lonnie had to have known this whole time. There wasn't a single doubt about it.

Unless Shadow Weaver wiped her mind of it too. However, she swore secrecy. And Lonnie never broke a promise. Not once.

Adora stared at the wall over Catra's head. She wondered why Lonnie never said anything. They were in the same squad, they were friends. After she defected, Adora knew Lonnie wouldn't have any good reason to say anything to her.

But why not Catra?

Chapter End Notes

S: this one ended up being a bit shorter than I was expecting. I got lucky with the first half of the work week to have time to work on getting out a midweek chapter for you guys.

Indy: I'm doing well and am enjoying spring break as I can. Just hung out with Sokuly after months of not seeing her. It was a very much needed visit. I hope you enjoy.

Quarantine: Part 2

Chapter Notes

Small warning for some PTSD stuff.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora never truly got back to sleep with her mind racing. She would doze off and whenever Catra moved around in her sleep, she was wide awake again. The abrupt knock on the door was less than a pleasant alarm.

Catra got to her feet a little too quick and smacked her head into the bottom of the top bunk with her claws fully out and ready. Adora rolled out of bed and brought her fists up, even if it looked like she was about to fall back to sleep on her feet. Netossa, half asleep, had a net at the ready from her top bunk while Glimmer's hands each held a ball of magic. Hordak, seeming to have expected it, simply sat up on the edge of his bunk.

The group of five waited until the doors slid open to a robot holding a tray of food. Glimmer groaned and lowered her hands. She rolled out of bed and grabbed the tray before dismissing the bot. Catra rubbed the top of her head and yawned while Adora sat back down on the edge of the bed and rubbed the sleep from her eyes. Netossa climbed down from her bunk and took the tray.

"A little slow on your feet, Adora," Hordak commented. "Though, I am shocked you didn't punch the robot."

“Can we not bring that up?” She said tiredly.

“Oh, no,” Netossa said with a smirk. “You don’t get to say something like that and expect us to ignore it. What did you do?”

“They conducted a readiness test in the middle of the night,” Catra explained. “All alarms blaring and whatever. Well, *somebody* decided to sucker punch a guard.”

“It wasn’t my fault he decided to just show up in the barracks!” Adora let out a huff. “At least I was ready.”

Catra let out a chuckle as she stretched. “Poor guy didn’t know what hit him.”

“No. No, I’m sure he knew it was my fist.”

“If that’s your first reaction, I’m a little surprised you didn’t actually stab me those few times I woke you up,” Glimmer said. “Did she always sleep with a knife under her pillow?”

“The cadets were issued a collapsible staff to be kept under their pillows at night,” Hordak explained. “A knife is quite the upgrade.”

Netossa opened the lid on the platter and smiled at the smell of breakfast. She sat on the floor and helped herself to a couple of the tiny breakfast foods.

"Anyone want some?"

The other four huddled around and took a few of the small versions of a normal breakfast. No one really stopped to savor it much, each trying to get enough to fill their stomachs. Until the last piece of tiny toast that everyone reached for.

"I will personally kill each one of you," Glimmer said.

"Bold coming from you," Catra snarked and reached for it only to have her hand pulled away by Adora.

"I love you, but I'm starving."

Netossa held a net with a smirk.

"Oh, no. Absolutely not. I *will* turn into She-Ra."

"This is my home," Hordak said. "It's only right I get the last piece".

“Oh, you wish!” Glimmer yelled.

“Bot, shield, laser!” Catra called out. “Winner gets to eat”.

“Oh, that’s low,” Adora whispered and narrowed her eyes. “You’re so fucking on”.

Hordak grunted and folded his arms.

“What?” Netossa asked.

“It’s a Horde game the kids made up to settle petty debates,” Hordak said with a little disdain.

“Shield beats bot, bot beats laser, laser beats shield,” Adora quickly explained and put her first in the middle of the circle with Catra.

“That sounds… backwards, but it works for me”. Glimmer added her first.

“Don’t you want to eat?” Netossa asked Hordak as she added her first.

“I’ll pass on this one”.

Catra smirked as the first round started. Unfortunately, it was the only round Adora was part of when everyone tossed out laser to her shield.

“What the hell?!”

“It’s not that hard to remember your go to first throw,” Catra teased. “The other two… beginners luck. Don’t worry, I’ll share”.

“If you win, horde scum”.

“You’re next, Sparkles”.

Unfortunately for Netossa, Glimmer and Catra tossed bot while she decided on laser again. Netossa punched Catra’s arm and went to sit on her bunk. Catra smirked and started the next throw with Glimmer. She threw shield while Glimmer threw laser. Catra let out a growl.

“Hey, I’m not completely heartless. You can all have a piece”.

“I didn’t want it anyhow!” Catra yelled and sat on Adora’s bunk.

Adora shook her head with a soft laugh and took her small share and split it while she joined her. Catra folded her arms and looked away.

“You know you’re hungry,” she said and nudged her.

“Fine. Thanks,” she finally said and tossed the even smaller piece in her mouth. The first thing she was doing when they got back was raiding the kitchen for normal sized food.

Hordak returned to his bunk and laid down with his hands folded on his stomach. There wasn’t anything else to do. Except maybe talk to the others, but even so, he knew there was still a level of dislike from them. Especially Catra.

Glimmer returned to her bunk and started to toss a balled up net back and forth with Netossa. It was only breakfast and boredom was already setting in. Adora had laid back down to stare the the bottom of the top bunk while Catra got up to use the bathroom.

As she was washing her hands, she glanced in the mirror. She swore she saw two eerily vacant green eyes staring back until she blinked and that image was gone. She was left staring at her own reflection, however still clad all white. The scrubs they were forced to wear weren’t helping. Catra shook her head with a short

growl and went to turn off the water. Only it was now bright green against the white of the sink.

"Not real," she whispered harshly to herself. "It's not real. It's not real".

Catra looked in the mirror again and froze. Vacant green eyes were definitely staring back.

"It's not real," she kept telling herself like a broken record while she held her head.

She grit her teeth and fell to her knees. For a moment, it felt like she was drowning in that green liquid all over again. As she fought to remember to breathe, her personal whispered mantra was coming out in gasps. She didn't have to wait too much longer before a phantom current surged through her limbs and up her spine. Only then did she forget everything Perfuma, Scorpia, Adora, and even Glimmer taught her when it came to these episodes. Only then did her mantra change.

"All beings must suffer to become pure".

It was her new quiet broken record slipping from her lips as she trembled, cried, and gasped for air. She dug her claws into her scalp in an effort to make herself snap out of it. If the breathing techniques and self reminders it wasn't real weren't helping, old

habits sure did die hard. Another phantom surge through her body made her body finally cry out in pain.

Catra didn't notice the door open. She didn't notice Glimmer at her side or Adora in front of her. She didn't hear either of them trying to get through to her. All she could do was tremble and whisper to herself the same thing, over and over.

"All beings must suffer to become pure".

The color drained from Adora's face as she pulled Catra's hands from her head. She hadn't uttered those words in many months. Adora picked her up and held her close. She pressed kisses against the top of her head over and over while Catra's whispering slowly died into broken sobs.

"Adora?" Glimmer offered her hand. "How about… we get her out of the bathroom."

"Yeah." She nodded. Her own mind was swimming from hearing Catra repeating Prime's words again. "Yeah, that's a good idea."

Adora carefully got to her feet with Catra in her arms and carried her back into the room. Hordak and Netossa made a point to not look at them in an effort of what little privacy they could give. Adora sat on her bed and continued to hold Catra close, almost protectively with her head tucked under her chin. She loosened

her hold just enough for Catra to shift and bury her face against her neck before returning to the protective hold.

"You're okay," Adora whispered and kissed the side of her head. "You're okay. I'm here. I've got you".

"Not to pry, but… she's gonna be alright, right?" Netossa quietly asked Glimmer.

"Eventually," she sighed. "It'll be at least a few hours, if not the rest of the day. You really haven't seen this happen, have you?"

Netossa shook her head. "I mean, we've all seen each other have our moments here and there. We were all in a war, you know. But this, what she's going through? Not this bad."

"Well, this is how she would get often after the… chip. It got a little worse after the war for a couple weeks." Glimmer picked at the edge of her blanket. "Adora too."

Netossa nodded and glanced over at Adora's bunk. She didn't want to pry too much into the moment. The way Adora was holding onto Catra and rubbing the back of her neck was heartbreaking. She didn't think the old Horde commander could ever look so small. It almost seemed like if Adora were to loosen her hold at all, she would simply break apart.

“Adora?” Catra questioned through her tears.

“Yeah,” she replied quietly. “It’s me. I’m right here”.

“It hurts.” She whimpered.

“I know”. Adora bit her lip to hold back her own tears. “I know it does. Do you want to lay down?”

Catra nodded and wiped her face with the back of her hand.

“Top bunk?”

She shook her head.

“Okay”. Adora stood slowly and turned to lay her in her bunk and pulled the blanket over her. “Is it alright if I use the bathroom? I can have Glimmer come sit with you.”

Catra sniffled and nodded.

“I’ll be right back.” She kissed her cheek and motioned Glimmer over.

“Need a minute?” She asked quietly and wiped an escaped tear from Adora’s cheek.

“Yeah,” she whispered. “Thanks.”

Adora walked off to the bathrooms with a hand over her mouth to muffle any sort of escaped cry that came from her as she went. As soon as the door closed behind her, she broke. Knowing she was likely still within Catra’s hearing range, she tried to keep as quiet as possible. Adora hadn’t heard her whisper Prime’s words like that in what felt like forever. The last time she could clearly remember was about a week after magic was restored.

She sat on the floor against the wall and let herself continue to cry quietly. Adora hated Prime more than ever for this. She looked up as the door opened and wiped her face quickly.

“Is she okay?”

“I want to say no, but Glimmer said she has it under control. Just to tell you that she’s trying to go for the back of her neck again,” Netossa informed. “Are you okay?”

“Yeah. I will be. I just… hate seeing her have to go through that. This was the worst one she’s had in… a while.” Adora rested her

head back against the wall. “I’ll be out there in a minute. Glimmer’s been through this with her before. I trust her.”

Netossa gave a comforting smile and let the door close quietly. Adora sighed and closed her eyes. It wasn’t often she wondered what would have happened if she had gotten to Prime’s ship just a little faster, if she would have been able to prevent Catra’s chipping process. She wondered how different things could have turned out. Most of all, she wished she could get her hands on Prime again and make him feel the pain he caused Catra and many others. She felt a pulse of magic through her body as her anger over the tyrant grew.

Instead of letting that happen, she got to her feet. Adora reminded herself that she had destroyed him when she cast him from Hordak as she washed her face. She only wished it had been a little more painful for him. She took a deep breath and quietly went back into the room. After thanking Glimmer, she sat on the edge of the bed and put a hand on Catra’s arm. Now it was time to run down the list.

“Do you want another blanket?”

Catra shook her head.

“An extra pillow?”

Again, a no.

“Would you like someone to get a bot’s attention for some water?”

A small nod.

Adora looked around at the others and Hordak raised his hand, letting her know he would take care of that request. “Okay. Does it still hurt?”

“A little,” she barely whispered. “I… I can still feel it in my back.”

“Where in your back?” she asked and slowly ran her hand down Catra’s back.

“There.”

Adora’s hand stopped just between her shoulder blades. At least it didn’t start in her neck again.

“And… and down.” Catra sniffled. “There and down.”

“Okay. Do you want to be left alone for now?”

Catra rolled over slowly with a quiet hiss of pain and looked up at her, as if her eyes could tell her everything.

"I just need a yes or no".

She shook her head as a tear ran over the bridge of her nose.

"Alright. Shhh. It's okay". Adora quickly slid under the blanket with her and wrapped her arms around her when she put her head on her chest. "You're alright. And safe. And loved. And cared about."

The hours that followed continued to drag. Catra had lightened up just enough to allow Adora to get out of bed after a short and restless half hour snooze. She continued to drift in and out of a light sleep. Hordak had started to pace next to his bunk while Glimmer aimlessly made spells to cast at the floor. Netossa put her head under her pillow in an attempt to make the time pass faster.

Eventually, Adora ended up at the door and hit her head against it. There was nothing to do they haven't tried. Throwing a balled up net around the room with everyone, minus Catra who had fallen asleep for the time, only worked for about a half hour. They played several pointless rounds of bot, shield, laser to try to make time go faster. Arm wrestling matches failed to have much traction in the way of entertainment. Even Hordak joined in on some of the games while Catra chose to watch when she wasn't snoozing.

“I can break us out of here,” Adora said while laying on her back in the middle of the room.

“How do you plan on that?” Netossa asked from her bunk.

“She-Ra. I have a sword that can cut through anything! The door would be so easy”.

“Entrapta would find us another room,” Hordak said as he continued to pace. “And I’m sure she would find something to void She-Ra for a while”.

Adora groaned and pressed the heels of her hands to her forehead. “I’m so bored!”

Catra involuntarily flinched at the door opening. She knew it was just another bot to bring them something. Just as she pulled the blanket back over her shoulder, she listened to the new conversation.

“Hi, guys!”

“Did you seriously tape a tracker pad to a robot?” Glimmer asked Bow. “I’m sure Entrapta has plenty of bots with a screen”.

“I thought the idea might cheer you all up a bit. I brought games for you guys! Is Adora okay?”

“I’m dying of boredom!” She yelled from the floor.

“How’s Catra doing?” Entrapta asked as she entered the picture. “Approximately five hours have passed since the anomaly in her behavior. This social experiment is fascinating! The games will give so much more insight on how people interact with each other while in isolation”.

“You’ve been watching us?!” Catra sat up and glared at the screen.

“I thought you would have noticed the cameras in the corners by now. Anyway! Continue doing what you’ve been doing!”

Bow gave an apologetic smile. “At least you guys will be free tomorrow in time for dinner?”

Catra flopped back down and pulled the blanket over her head with a groan just before the robot left the five of them alone again. Board games weren’t her thing. She didn’t know how to play any. Adora barely did and the ones she did know amounted to two.

“Hey! Bow brought us Last Card Standing!” Glimmer said excitedly before her face fell. “And… Conquerer…”

“What’s so bad about that one?” Adora asked.

“It takes forever to play.”

“And it has a tendency to cause fights,” Netossa added.

“Catra?” Adora sat on the edge of the bed. “Do you wanna play?”

“No. I’ll watch”. She poked her head out from under the blanket. “Do you even know how to play those?”

“Um, only Last Card Standing”. She tussled Catra’s hair. “But we have a deck of cards too. We can teach them some of our old card games. How does that sound?”

“Not right now. Please”.

“Okay”. She kissed her cheek. “Are you feeling any better?”

Catra nodded and sat up to grab her cup of water from next to Adora's foot. "Not great. But better." She looked around at everyone else and sighed. "I'm sorry you guys had to see that."

"There's nothing to apologize for," Netossa said with a smile. "We just want you to be alright. As much as you can be."

"You went through more than you should have," Hordak spoke up. "There was no reason for you to be put through that, other than his sadistic torture. The chip would have been more than enough for his plans. He could have left it at that like he did with everyone else." He watched with a frown as Catra put a hand over the back of her neck. "I'm sorry you ever had to endure that. It was wrong".

Catra let Adora wrap the blanket around her shoulders and kissed the top of her head. She itched the back of her neck for a quick moment before pulling the blanket tighter around herself as Adora joined the others. Netossa motioned her over and she just shook her head.

"Are you sure?" Glimmer asked, pulling out the cards from Last Card Standing. "You won't have to move. Adora can take the cards you want to play. Or we can come closer to you".

"Not this time, Sparkles. I'll feel better if I just… watch for now".

Glimmer took her answer with an understanding nod. Catra watched the small group as the cards were passed out. The rules seemed fairly simple. Colors or numbers had to match, occasionally someone would have to draw more cards than normal, and the person with a single card in their hand won. As she watched, she learned that the winner of the game took first place and everyone else continued.

Catra had gotten comfortable in bed again on her side to continue to watch the second game start. Even with their situation, they all seemed a lot less on edge. Relaxed. At least until Adora cussed Netossa out for making her draw four new cards, saying that she clearly had more than enough. Hordak muttered under his breath when Glimmer was somehow allowed to change the color randomly, something Adora had gotten happy about.

Netossa was the next one to get frustrated with the game, claiming Hordak was holding onto what she called ‘punishment cards’. Glimmer shoved Adora’s shoulder for changing the color on her. They sounded almost happy. Catra sighed and sat up. She wanted the feeling too.

She slowly approached the group and crouched down between Adora and Glimmer. The group gave her a welcoming smile and the two scooted a little to let her in. Catra sat between them quietly and finally managed a small smile when both Glimmer and Adora wrapped her in a side hug.

“Wanna join?” Netossa asked.

“You guys finish this one,” she said and leaned against Adora. “I don’t think it would be very fair for me to start from the beginning while Glimmer has three cards left”.

“You can have some of mine,” Adora whispered and offered her four of her twelve.

“Hunny,” Netossa laughed, “not even She-Ra can help you out of your situation to win first. Sharing cards isn’t gonna get you anywhere”.

“Then stop making me draw more!”

Catra shook her head with a chuckle. It somewhat reminded her of a card game they used to play as kids, only with a lot more cards. And a lot less ruthless.

She excused herself to get the lunch that was brought to them and sat back down between Adora and Glimmer. She wasn’t particularly hungry, but still took one of the small sandwiches to try after putting the platter in the middle.

“Wanna play Find the Lizard?” Catra asked with a smile. “Bet I can still beat ya”.

“We don’t have a lizard card”. Adora chuckled. “And… Rogelio isn’t here to throw a fit about the mess”.

“We can always pick from the deck”. She opened the box of plain playing cards and dumped them into her hand. “Hordak can play Rogelio”.

“We’re not playing this game of yours,” he told her.

“I don’t remember Rogelio actually… talking,” Adora teased her former superior. “Try roaring a bit”.

“Do I even want to know?” Glimmer asked and tossed another small sandwich into her mouth.

“You scatter the cards around on the ground and the first to find the lizard card wins,” Catra explained. “It’s a full contact game too. Adora managed to give me a bloody nose once.”

“Was there anything not… full contact?” Netossa asked.

“We were soldiers! Of course not. Any games we played were in some way training us. Almost anything was fair game. If it could kill someone or put them in the infirmary more than five days, it wasn’t allowed”.

“Although, someone was quite the rule breaker,” Hordak commented. “I’m a little shocked you never actually killed

someone during your little games or even in training”.

“Bot, shield, laser isn’t supposed to full contact”. Adora folded her arms. “But *someone* liked to make it that way over a stupid ration bar”.

“It was the grey kind, Adora!”

“Kyle didn’t need a broken nose!”

“We were thirteen!” Catra finally, actually laughed. “Besides, it’s Kyle. And I *did* split it with you. *And* I gave you the bigger piece. So, I wouldn’t complain”.

Hordak groaned and rubbed his face. He couldn’t believe the two of them used to be his soldiers, both high ranking at one point or another.

Catra jumped to her feet when the door slid open. She didn’t think she could have ever been so happy to see Entrapta instead of only a robot. It only meant good news. The group of five quickly hurried and gave her a group hug.

“You guys are free to go,” she said once they all let go. “No one got sick and all of the tests regarding anything microscopic came

back clear. Plus the data I've collected on social interactions between individuals when confined to a shared space is fascinating! Bow brought you all a clean set of clothes too. Hordak, I cleaned your armor."

"I can't wait to get home," Catra said with a smile.

"Nice to see you calling Bright Moon home," Glimmer said and nudged her arm. "I mean, I know you have before. It's still nice to hear it from you now and then".

"You four have a safe trip home," Hordak said with a small smile.

The now group of four followed the robot that had accompanied Entrapta to get their clothes. It felt like the walk down the hall took far too long. As soon as the door opened, Catra vaulted over the robot and grabbed the small pile her clothes were in. Adora pushed by the bot and rushed in as well, closely followed by Gimmer and Netossa.

Before Adora, or anyone else, could start getting undressed, Catra was already halfway into her leggings. Glimmer shook her head with a small laugh when Catra grabbed her shirt and pulled it over her head before even finishing getting the leggings all the way on.

"Slow down!" Adora laughed and put her fingers through the tail hole of Catra's leggings to grab her tail and thread it through. "You'll hurt it. Again."

“That only happened twice,” she said and rolled her eyes before tugging her shirt the rest of the way on. “My tail’s fine, thank you”.

“I gotta hear this,” Netossa said around a chuckle.

“I woke up late, got dressed too fast, pulled some fur one time. The second… it got stuck in the leg when I was little.”

“Then slow down a little,” Glimmer told her with a smile. “Darla isn’t going anywhere without us and we don’t need you to pull your own tail.”

“I’m just ready to get home.”

Glimmer led the group out from the room and started down the hall. She groaned as they somehow ended walking by the room again. Netossa grabbed her by the shoulder and took a different turn. She wasn’t about to go in another circle.

“Can’t you just teleport us to Darla?” Catra groaned. “This place is a fucking maze”.

”*You* want to teleport?” Glimmer asked and grabbed her arm.

“At this point, yes!” Catra rubbed her temples. “I want my bed, my pillows, my blankets… and normal sized food. Just *please* teleport us. Before I change my mind”.

Glimmer grabbed everyone and teleported them, only she missed her mark and they were somehow still inside of Entrapta’s castle. She quickly teleported again. And again.

“Sparkles!“ Catra pushed her away and sat on the floor with Adora quick to her side. “If you miss one more time… I’m going to puke”.

“Ugh! I hate this place!” Glimmer grabbed everyone again.

“Hold on!” Catra yelled. “Please, give me a damn second!”

She put her head in her hands and continued to sit on the floor. All she wanted was for her surroundings to stop spinning. She grabbed Glimmer’s hand and nodded. Might as well try again. Finally, they wound up just outside of Darla and Catra laid on the ground with a groan. That was enough teleporting around for at least two months.

“Come on,” Adora said gently and helped her up. “You can lay down on the way back”.

“She tried to kill me,” she whined as she walked up the ramp. “And here I thought I could consider her a friend”.

“There’s a reason I was walking,” Glimmer said as she followed. “That place is… confusing”.

“You couldn’t just picture outside and… go there?” Catra asked as the dizziness started to slowly ease.

“Not when I don’t know how far away outside is!”

“You just spent two whole days locked in the same room together,” Netossa said. “There’s no reason to kill each other now that we’re out of there”.

Catra turned to go into one of the rooms and closed the door behind her. Adora continued on to the bridge and sat down. She quickly instructed Darla to take them home, with a stop to drop off Netossa first. Glimmer sat on the arm of the chair as Adora rested the back of her head against it and closed her eyes. She didn’t know how it was possible to still feel fatigued when she didn’t do anything for two long days. They were going home and that’s all that mattered. She would have her bed, pillows, and blanket back. And, maybe even more importantly, some much needed privacy.

She cracked an eye open when Glimmer nudged her.

“So,” she said with a smile, “that party”.

“Wait… that was a serious idea?” Adora asked.

“Yes and no. I think. At the time it was… a coverup. But I was thinking about it while we were locked up and I don’t think it’s a bad idea.”

“You’re planning a party already?” Netossa asked. “Wouldn’t you like a break from everything after what we went through? Take a few days. Do nothing!”

“Do you know her?” Glimmer and Adora asked together while pointing at each other.

“I *am* the queen, you know,” Glimmer said. “I don’t just get a day off”.

“You’re taking at least one,” Netossa shot back. “Both of you. I’d love to see more than that, but mandatory one day. Go to the market, visit a village, go spend a day in Mystacor, have sex all day long for all I care!”

“But,” Adora complained, “there’s clones-“

“I don’t care! Trust me, Etheria isn’t going to collapse without She-Ra for a couple days. We’re well past that threat. And Glimmer, you have your dad”. Netossa rubbed her forehead. “Please. Learn to relax and not worry about planning anything”.

“I make no such promises,” Adora told her.

Netossa folded her arms and looked out the windshield. She knew they were already traveling fast, but it didn’t seem fast enough. Her home was finally coming into view, but it still felt so far. A small part of her wanted to tell Adora to get Darla to pick it up a little more.

Catra eventually wandered from the room she was in with a yawn. The dizziness and nausea finally wore off by the time the ship came to a soft landing. She followed everyone else out to meet up with Spinnerella, who was waiting for her wife to join her for dinner.

“You know you’re always welcome to join us,” Netossa told everyone and motioned them along. “We all had a long few days.”

“Oh, no!” Adora said and chuckled. “We wouldn’t want to intrude or anything. It’s been two and a half days without her. You two should enjoy your night. Together.”

“You wouldn’t be intruding on us at all!” Spinnerella said and gave her a hug before holding her shoulders. “It’s not often we have guests out our way”.

“It does smell really good, even from out here,” Glimmer said with a smile. “But I would like to get back home and see Bow again, and my dad.”

“After the past few days we had, I don’t blame you,” Netossa said. “Just know our door is always open if you want to visit”.

“Maybe one of these days”.

“Hey, Netossa,” Catra said quietly, holding onto one of her own arms, “I’m really sorry. About everything”.

“None of that was your fault at all. Beast Island is dangerous and we barely know about all the first one tech that exists,” she said reassuringly and put her hand on her shoulder. “We’re all here to help each other. So don’t feel bad for what happened”.

“Not just that”. Catra looked away. “Everything from before too”.

“You gotta ease up on yourself. All of us know you made a lot of mistakes. But… you’re not too bad, you know. You’re one of us now”.

“You all look like you need sleep. Go back to Bright Moon and get some rest,” Spinnerella said with a motherly tone. “There will be plenty of time to talk later.”

“Take care of her,” Adora said and gave Spinnerella a hug. “We all had a long quarantine.”

“Oh, you don’t have to worry about that. You three better go home before the day moon comes up.”

The three walked back to Darla and looked out of the windshield to wave one final time before taking off homeward bound. As they took off Adora considered the advice that Netossa gave her and Glimmer. Maybe they really did need a break. A proper break not spent in a quarantine room.

Before they knew it they had arrived back in Bright Moon. Micah was standing at the landing area to welcome them home. The ramp lowered and the trio nearly stumbled out half asleep.

“I’m so glad to see all three of you back,” he greeted. “Especially you Catra.”

“Me? Why?”

“When I heard from Hordak what had happened I, alongside Adora, was scared to even think of the worst. Call me selfish, but I felt I would have been at fault because I was the one who allowed your desired punishment”

“Well, I’m better now”. She offered a small smile. “And I can’t believe I can actually thank Hordak for that”.

Adora looked over with her eyebrow raised.

“Okay, I *guess* you too. I’m just glad to be home”.

“It’s always nice to hear you call Bright Moon home,” he said with a smile. “Wrong Hordak saved you all plenty of food”.

“Is it tiny?” Adora asked skeptically.

“Oh, I assure you it’s normal sized”.

“Alright, count me in,” Catra said as she was right on Adora’s heels in rushing to the castle.

Glimmer started to follow her friends, she stopped when she heard her father whisper to the sky.

“I miss you, Angella.”

Micah wiped the tears from his cheeks and took a deep breath when he felt Glimmer hug him from the side, her head pressed against his chest.

“I miss her too, dad”. She looked up at him. “Do you think she, if she can look in on us wherever she is, forgives Catra?”

“Knowing your mother and knowing what Catra did for you, saving you and keeping you safe, I’d think so”. He pulled her into a tight hug. “She’d be so proud of you. All of you”.

Micah walked back into the castle with his daughter and followed her to the dining hall. The other two were already halfway through their plate. They both looked half asleep as they ate and Glimmer joined them. Micah smiled warmly and told everyone goodnight before approaching one of the members of the kitchen staff on his way to his room.

“Make sure everything is cleaned up when they’re done. Those kids have been through enough these past few days, I don’t want them even thinking they have to pick up a single plate.”

“Very well, sir. Goodnight,” the staff member said.

Adora finished her food and looked over to Catra who still had food on her plate.

“Is something wrong?”

“Huh?” Catra looked over and rubbed her eyes. “No. Just tired”.

“Do you want to go to bed now?” She asked with a smile and stroked her cheek. “You look like you’re about to pass out”.

“Yes. Please,” Catra said tired and timidly. “Sorry, Sparkles”.

“Stop apologizing,” she said stood from her chair and walked over. “I’m not the one who almost died”.

“Eight more lives to burn again,” she joked and slowly got to her feet. “Can’t get rid of me that easy.”

Glimmer gave her a hug. It still shocked her from time to time receiving any kind of affection from anyone outside of Adora. Still, she returned it with a tired smile. This odd little family she found herself in was really starting to grow on her.

“Come on, let’s go,” Adora said and wrapped her arm around Catra’s waist once Glimmer let go. “You can go to bed. I can come

back-"

"No," Glimmer stopped her. "You're going to bed too. I'm not starving, so I'll be headed to my room shortly. I at least want a little food in my stomach first before I go shove Bow to his side of the bed".

The couple made their way upstairs and down the hall to enter their room. They both collapsed on the bed. Adora barely bothered getting her jacket and boots off before crawling up to the pillows. Catra didn't take any time curling up as Melog head butted her forehead.

"I missed you too," she mumbled and tiredly patted their head. "Right now, I just wanna sleep".

"I missed our bed," Adora said, seeming to almost fall asleep as she spoke. "It's a really nice bed".

"Yeah". Catra closed her eyes as Melog curled up by their feet and Adora wrapped an arm around her waist. "It really is."

Chapter End Notes

S: Don't have much more to say from Wednesday. I personally had a a bit of a blah mental health day so this is being posted a hell of a lot later than I intended. Lots of second guessing when going through and making final edits and then second guessing those second guesses. But, hey,

it’s up and I can only hope it’s enjoyable. Stay safe and healthy out there.

Indy: I personally really like this chapter. I know my coauthor has expressed lots of doubt but I stand by what we wrote. I hope you’re all doing well and staying safe!

Feeling Better

Chapter Notes

Smut starting at:

For an answer, Catra responded with clashing their lips together again in a heated kiss that was mostly tongue and teeth. They both knew they needed to be a little on the quick side. If Glimmer couldn't find them anywhere else in the east wing, she'd definitely look into the war room.

and ending at: "Well, the clone isn't in here," Catra said after clearing her throat and wiping her eyes."

Missed things will be put in notes. Also small mention of abuse/child abuse at the end.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra rolled over and grabbed at the empty spot next to her. She cracked an eye open and sure enough, Adora wasn't in bed. It was still well before the morning moonrise and earlier than normal for her girlfriend to even be out of bed. She rolled onto her back and itched at her side before at least trying to get back to sleep. Catra rolled onto her other side and itched her lower back before throwing the blanket off. She sat up and rubbed her eyes with a yawn before her ears finally registered the shower was on.

"Couldn't sleep?" Catra asked as she walked into the bathroom.

"Unfortunately." Adora poked her head from behind the curtain. "What are you doing up so early?"

“Itchy and… uh, too warm.” Catra shrugged. “And I might as well go to the bathroom since I’m up.”

“Still?” She closed the curtain to give Catra some sort of privacy while she used the toilet. “It’s been about a week and half. Are you getting sick? We kept the window cracked and it’s still getting chilly at night.”

Catra flushed and washed her hands. “Adora, it’s… it’s been a couple months and… it’s starting.”

“Oh.” Adora stepped back when her girlfriend stepped into the shower with her and hugged her. “You’re not only too warm, are you?”

Catra shook her head and sighed against her shoulder. “Nothing is too bad yet. I just don’t want you to feel-“

“We’ve talked about this. You’re not using me. If I didn’t want to, I’d tell you. Oh, and the rest of it isn’t too much to handle. *You’re* not too much to handle.” Adora took another step back when Catra pushed her gently so she could get under the water. “What are you doing?”

“I’m going to see if the soap you got me will help with the dryness.”

The itchiness was clearly extremely bothersome if Catra was willingly taking another shower by her own decision in such a short time. Adora grabbed the soap bottle while Catra was getting used to the water. Once she was relaxed, Adora put some soap in her hand and started washing her back.

"I thought you were done with the shedding," Adora mumbled and rinsed the short fur off of her hand. "I'm making you unclog the drain next time."

"Trust me, this is the last of it until next year." Catra closed her eyes and relaxed under Adora's hands massaging her back.

Adora handed the bottle to Catra when she was done with her back so she could wash the rest of herself. She kissed the back of her head before Catra turned around and pressed a gentle kiss to her lips. Adora stepped from the shower, grabbed a towel, and wrapped it around herself before quickly brushing her teeth. She exited the bathroom to finish drying off and get dressed for the day.

Just as she was getting her pants on, arms wrapped around her waist. It made her jump a little before a smile came to her face and she rested a hand over one of Catra's arms.

"What do you wanna do today?" She asked and nuzzled the back of Adora's neck.

“I don’t really know. Netossa told Glimmer and me to take a day or two and do nothing.” She let out a sharp breath when Catra nipped the back of her neck. “I… I think maybe I should.”

“You think?” Catra chuckled. “You’ve needed to take a break since the Heart of Etheria, but did you? No, you wanted to start rebuilding villages right away. And then the whole thing with the clones still wandering around. Oh, and-”

Adora turned in her arms and rested her hands at her hips. “Okay! Okay. I get it. I need to take a break.”

“Yeah. Yeah, you do.” She gave her a lingering kiss before continuing, “and I wouldn’t mind relaxing a couple days with you. Among other things.”

Adora brought their foreheads together with a smile. “Sounds like a date.”

“You never really answered my question,” Catra said softly and closed her eyes. “What do you wanna do?”

“Hmmm. Take a walk in the garden? And then we can come back up here and I’ll take care of you.” Adora rubbed her lower back. “Unless you’re just in the sore and crampy part of this.”

“I like the sound of that. After we raise a little hell.”

Adora groaned and moved her hands to Catra's shoulder. "Catra, I know you're feeling better after the whole Beast Island thing but-"

"No, listen". She opened her eyes with a smirk. "We go tell a guard that we're pretty sure we saw a clone wander in, so there should be four, right?"

"If you're including Wrong Hordak, yeah. You know Glimmer is going to have our heads for this".

"Oh, I know. That's part of the fun. Come on!" Catra went to the dresser and started to get dressed. "Besides, I could really use the laugh. Then we can take your little walk".

Adora finished getting herself dressed. Before she knew it, Catra had ahold of her hand and was practically dragging her from the bedroom. They quickly made their way downstairs and started down one of the halls. While they had already passed a couple guards, Catra deemed they weren't the right ones.

Catra's smile fell away when the trio of clones were coming down the same corridor they were in. She had been avoiding the newcomers from the Crimson Waste since they arrived months ago. The last thing she wanted was for them to say the wrong thing.

“Good morning, lit-“

Catra raised her eyebrow at the other unnamed clone who hit his brother in the chest, stopping him from finishing.

“You should learn to listen to our brother,” he scolded. “She is to be called Catra”.

She stopped in front of them and folded her arms. There was still a nagging part of her that wanted to sink her claws in and make them pay for what the made her go through. Yet, that part of her was surprisingly small for a change.

“Good morning,” she said flatly. “He’s right. You should listen. It might save your life and might get me to actually consider putting up with you”.

“Did either of you want breakfast?” Wrong Hordak asked. “I didn’t see you two at the table this morning and Queen Glimmer said to not bother you”.

“Oh, we’ll probably get a snack here in a little bit,” Adora answered. “Right, Catra?”

“Hm. Yeah. Right”. She never stopped her stare downwith the first clone to open his mouth, even as he seemed to shrink back. “You

know, I thought I saw another one of you running around. I'm surprised he's not with you".

"There's another?!" Wrong Hordak asked excitedly. "Splendid! We shall search for our brother".

"Good". Catra's ear twitched and she perked them both up before finally looking at him. "We'll get some guards to help you".

"It would be greatly appreciated. Thank you!"

She tugged on Adora's hand and continued down the corridor as the trio split up to look for the fake clone. Once they were far enough away, Catra let out a laugh.

"You said you were telling a guard," Adora said and stopped their walking. "What was that?"

"Oh, Adora, this is going to be much more fun." She let out another laugh. "Think about it. The guards of this place and the other clones all looking for another one that looks exactly like those three? We can just sit back and watch".

"You're definitely feeling better," Adora mumbled while Catra pulled her along.

“Much,” she agreed.

Adora stopped the next guard they saw. “Hey, um. I’m— we’re pretty sure we saw another clone wander in not long ago. We, uh… we were going to look but we’re not sure which way he went”.

“I’ll have to see how he slipped in once we find him. Thank you, Adora”.

They both giggled once the guard was out of earshot and walked a little further until Catra pulled Adora out to the courtyard garden. She laced their fingers together as they walked down one of the cobblestone pathways.

“I thought you wanted to watch the chaos you just created”.

“We have all day. And they’ll be all over the castle grounds. Can’t we just enjoy this for now?”

Adora smiled and squeezed her hand. She always loved the softer side of Catra. It was a side that was almost held specifically for her eyes alone. The only time anyone else ever really saw it was from being walked in on. And in those times, it was almost like a switch with the way she put her walls back up. Catra insisted she was still working on the whole vulnerability thing.

She picked a red plumeria as they passed by. Hiding it behind her back, Adora pulled Catra to a stop. When she raised her eyebrow in question, Adora gave her a soft smile and tucked the flower into her hair.

"I love you".

"What the hell is this, Adora?" She took the flower out and looked at it. "You know I don't do flowers".

"Oh, come on. It looked good on you".

Catra twitched her ear and squinted at the flower before sighing. She would never admit she might have actually liked it. Adora gave her a kiss after she tucked it back into her hair.

"It's not because I like it, okay?" Catra glanced away. "But I'll leave it since you put it there. What is it?"

"Clearly a flower?"

"No, dummy". She laughed. "What kind?"

"Not a clue. A pretty one".

“Okay. We can go with that”.

Catra found a bench and laid back with her head in Adora’s lap once she sat down. A quiet purr vibrated in her chest as she smiled up at her. For the moment, she no longer cared about the made up clone search. Even Adora didn’t seem to care much as she was looking down at her with a fond smile while stroking her hair.

Adora carefully took the flower from Catra’s hair and placed it on the bench next to her. She absentmindedly rubbed behind her ears as she tilted her head back to let herself simply enjoy the late morning moonshine.

“Alright you two,” Glimmer said as she approached them, “you guys were the ones to see this new clone come in. Why aren’t you searching with us? Catra, I’m sure you could smell him”.

“Eh, they all smell the same,” she said and waved her hand. “If you have everyone else looking, it shouldn’t be long”.

“This isn’t a request for help”.

“I’m taking Netossa’s advice and taking that thing called a break,” Adora said with a smile. “You should try it”.

“You can take a break after we find the clone”. She grabbed both of them and glared at Catra’s whimper. “Are you going to help or do you need convinced?”

“Fine! We’ll help! Just please, don’t teleport. We can walk”.

“Good”. She let go and before disappearing told them, “you two get the east wing”.

Catra sighed and stood, offering her hand to Adora. “Let’s go play along”.

“Don’t forget that this was your idea,” she said and took her hand.

The two wandered back into the castle and walked down to the east wing. They slowly moseyed down the hall, knowing they weren’t going to find anything. Adora was walking slightly ahead of Catra as they went.

Catra quickly poked her head into the old war room while Adora continued walking and smiled to herself. When Glimmer said they got to search the east wing, she didn’t expect they would be absolutely alone. She quickly caught up to Adora and grabbed her hand.

“Hm?”

“We should check the old war room. I thought I saw something”.

“Catra, we both know there’s nobody in there”. She cocked an eyebrow at the tug on her hand. “Are you trying to hide from Glimmer?”

“We can go with that.” She shifted her weight a little uncomfortably at the small twinge in her lower abdomen. “Besides, we can sit down and wait.”

Adora chuckled and shook her head. “Fine. We can hide”.

She followed Catra back and into the war room, quietly closing the doors behind her. They both made sure to keep the lights off and let the light coming through the windows light the room for them, just in case someone walked by.

“So, how long do you want to wait?”

“As long as it takes,” Catra said quietly.

“As long as what-“ Adora was cut short by her lips against hers.

Her mind was still trying to catch up when there was suddenly a wall behind her back and Catra's body pressed against her. She was holding her face, running her tongue against her lips. Adora, while fully expecting what was next once she opened her mouth, still groaned at the contact of their tongues. Once her mind finally caught up, she gently pushed Catra back. Not only did she need to catch her breath a little, she needed to make sure she was correct in her thinking.

"Seriously? In here?"

"No one else is in this wing," she whispered and ran a finger along Adora's lips.

"You're not too sore?"

For an answer, Catra responded with clashing their lips together again in a heated kiss that was mostly tongue and teeth. They both knew they needed to be a little on the quick side. If Glimmer couldn't find them anywhere else in the east wing, she'd definitely look into the war room.

Adora quickly tucked her knee between Catra's legs and she bit down on her lip at the contact. She left a hand at her hips to try to help set a pace as she rubbed against her leg, the other slid up the front of her shirt and squeezed her breasts. Catra's breathing was slowly picking up as she pressed herself harder against Adora's leg. She was just getting fed up with the hand on her hip keeping her from a faster, slightly more desperate movement.

“Adora.” She slid her hands under her shirt and sports bra to gently pinch her nipples. “Stop playing games. We both know this-“ a low moan left her lips when Adora returned the favor to her nipples, “-can’t exactly be drawn out”.

“You’re the one that wanted to stay in here,” she said with a smirk and pulled Catra’s shirt off and tossed it over her shoulder.

“Do you want Sparkles seeing us come from our room when we should have been in this wing?” She took Adora’s shirt off and dropped it to the floor.

“Fine. Okay. You’re right”.

Adora smiled and quickly picked her up and carried her to the table. She sat her on the edge of it while she started kissing her deeply again. Catra slipped her hand down the front of Adora’s pants to gently run her fingers against her clit over top of her panties. Adora moaned into her mouth and rocked her hips into her hand.

She completely fumbled around trying to get Catra’s leggings off, eventually having to break their kiss to physically watch her hands do what they needed to do. Adora had seen Catra naked plenty of times, as well as soaked with arousal. Yet, for some reason, her mind went blank as a clear string of her wetness joined her leggings being pulled down.

“Well, stop staring like an idiot, Adora. Nothing you haven’t seen and touched before”.

Adora pulled her sports bra off as Catra flipped over and leaned over the table, draping her tail over to the side in invitation. While her girlfriend was clearly more than ready, she knew the first day of Catra’s every other month heat could make her rather sore.

“What are you waiting for, princess?” She teased. “For Sparkles to come in?”

“N-no!”

Catra chuckled and kicked her leggings the rest of the way off while she waited, still flicking her tail teasingly. Adora made quick work of her own pants and underwear before she pressed her hips against her ass. She smiled at the soft groan she earned herself as Catra’s tail wrapped around her waist.

She brought a hand between their bodies and ran her fingers along Catra’s dripping slit. She slowly eased a finger into her. With her other hand, she gently rubbed her lower back. When Adora got a small nod, she started to ease a second finger in. She stopped at the second knuckle at the sharp inhale Catra took. The soreness was the exact reason they rarely had sex on the first day of this.

“Catra?”

“Keep going.”

Adora finished sliding the second finger into her and waited until she felt Catra relax. She slowly pulled her fingers back and gently scratched the base of her tail with her free hand when there was a quiet whimper. Catra pushed her hips back to give Adora a hint to keep going. She would get used to her fingers and the slight pain would go completely away after a few minutes.

Catra let out a short hiss when fingers started a slow rhythm of thrusting in and out. She swallowed the whimper so Adora wouldn’t stop again. Her body may have needed a little more time to get used to it, but they didn’t exactly have that kind of time to work with. She pushed her hips back into Adora’s hand harder. It wasn’t the best idea as a yelp left her. Adora stopped.

“Did I say stop?” She knew her voice was trembling.

“No, but…” she leaned forewords and wiped an escaped tear from Catra’s cheek. “Cat, if it’s hurting this much-“

“Keep going.” She lowered her voice to a whisper, “please.”

Adora nodded and resumed. Catra’s back slowly relaxed as she continued a slow pace. She sped up her movements and noticed

the shallow grooves Catra left on the tabletop as she hissed. Adora hated the pained sounds mixing in with the softer moans of actual pleasure. Just as Catra seemed to be getting used to the new pace, the door swung open and Adora froze while Catra fell quiet.

"Seriously?!" Glimmer's yell accompanied the door slamming closed. "We still have meetings in here!"

Adora pulled her fingers out of Catra quickly and winced at the clear whimper of pain from the action being a little too fast. She quickly wiped them off on her leg while Catra busied herself with gathering their clothes. Her face was red in embarrassment as she was given her clothes. Glimmer pinched the bridge of her nose while the two women got dressed.

"Well, the clone isn't in here," Catra said after clearing her throat and wiping her eyes.

"Clearly!" Glimmer yelled and crossed the room. "Was this some sort of joke to you?"

"Actually, yes".

"I can't believe you two." She raised her eyebrow when Catra rubbed her face. "Are you okay?"

“Yeah. I’m alright.” She shifted her weight and glanced at Adora. “Just going through… something.”

“Right,” Glimmer said around a sigh, clearly not believing her. “Did you seriously use the possibility of another random clone wandering around Bright Moon just so you could sneak off and fuck in here?”

“Actually, no,” Adora answered. “We were actually just enjoying being outside. And you told us to search the east wing. Catra’s starting to go into he-“

“Enough!” Catra yelled and put a hand over Adora’s mouth.

Glimmer’s eyes widened in realization. “Well, uh, I’m really sorry for interrupting… that. But please, not in here. Keep this up and you’re getting your own fucking place.”

Glimmer had gathered the rest of the princesses to discuss the party. Instead of the usual meeting in the old war room, she decided to set the meeting up in the courtyard. When Catra had asked why, she was sternly reminded of the claw marks she had left two weeks ago and followed it up with something about the fresh air being nice.

As the discussion was flowing rather well, Catra had her head on Adora's lap and fighting to keep from dozing. Bow was keeping himself occupied with toying with one of his arrows. It really felt like they weren't exactly needed for the planning, but they also didn't want to try to find something else to do.

"Hey!" Scorpia said excitedly. "We can move it to the Fright Zone. We have it looking much better. Even the greenery inside most of the buildings has been somewhat removed. No offense, Adora".

"It's not like I *meant* for plants to grow inside. Does that mean Horror Hall is fixed up?"

"Uh, mostly". Scorpia rubbed the back of her head. "A lot of ex-soldiers have been clearing out the rubble and fixing the masonry and murals. And believe it or not, Hordak is making me a new throne. Since… he kinda destroyed the original. But, hey, the Horde, we caused a lot of damage back then. You guys should come by again. The forge is officially back up and running as it should too!"

"That's actually really nice to hear, Scorpia," Catra said and rolled to her side, her head never leaving Adora's lap. "You know if you ever need extra hands… I'll come help again".

"We have plenty of hands right now. But thanks".

“So, are we relocating the party?” Micah asked. “It’s up to all of you”.

“I think it would be nice,” Glimmer said. “A change of scenery for a party. I say we take Scorpia’s offer. Unless…” she looked at Adora and Catra.

“Oh, we’ll be fine,” Adora assured and stroked Catra’s hair. “We’ve already been back a few times. It’s not that bad.”

Catra simply gave a thumbs up and closed her eyes. After her acknowledgment, the group decided to move the party and the conversations about decorations picked up. She was only half listening as the afternoon light washing over her coupled with Adora’s fingers running through her hair was slowly putting her to sleep.

“I think we should each make something to symbolize our individual magic,” Perfuma said with a smile. “And those of you who don’t have magic can make something to symbolize who you are”.

“I’ll bring a boat and we can set it on fire at the end of the night!” Sea Hawk offered and stood. “It would be amazing!”

“Ah, no. No burning ships in the fright zone,” Scorpia said apologetically. “I think what Perfuma is trying to say is to make a banner or something to hang up”.

“Not exactly the best at arts and crafts over here,” Adora said raising her hand. “You can ask Scorpia about the drawings on the wall next to my old bunk”.

“You and Catra did that when you were kids,” Scorpia said. “I’m sure you’re better at it now”.

Adora shook her head and looked down at Catra who had definitely fallen into a light sleep. She didn’t exactly have backup in her words now.

“You don’t have to draw anything,” Perfuma said. “Maybe… just a color scheme that’s important to you?”

“Isn’t She-Ra, like, gold and white?” Mermista asked. “It really shouldn’t be that hard. I dunno. You could add a rainbow or something”.

“You could draw a sword!” Frost offered.

“We just said I don’t have to draw anything!” Adora shot back.

“We’ll find you a piece of paper big enough and you can trace the sword onto it,” Glimmer said. “If you want to actually do the sword thing”.

“I’ll draw the stupid sword for you,” Catra mumbled sleepily.

“You can’t draw either”.

“I know, dummy”. She rolled onto her back and cracked an eye open. “But it’ll be better than your attempt”.

Adora gave her a glare and shoved her head from her lap.

“Hey!” She yelped.

“Take it back”.

“You wish, princess”. Catra sat up and stretched. “And my banner’s gonna be better”.

“Oh, yeah?” Adora folded her arms. “Care to share what you’re doing? We don’t need someone making the same thing”.

“Trust me,” Catra’s voice lost the teasing tone, falling almost distant, “no one can or will”.

“Catra?” Perfuma asked at the tone change.

“I’ve just changed a lot, okay?”

The group tried to not watch as Catra curled up next to Adora and closed her eyes again. Adora sighed and rubbed behind her ear gently. They all tried to move onto food possibilities but ended up talking about when this would happen. Eventually, it was settled to being in a couple of months.

And then came the question of attire.

“Princess Prom formal,” Forsta stated.

“How about… we don’t do that,” Bow said. “Princess Prom is special. It should have the most formality when it comes to parties”.

“Casual?” Mermista asked.

“It should definitely be more formal than casual,” Glimmer told her.

Adora didn’t care one way or the other. Instead, she glanced down to Catra who had her ears back and tail curled tightly

around herself. She moved her hand from behind her ear to scratch behind her jaw. Finally, Adora felt the faint vibration of a purr against her fingertips and smiled.

"What's wrong?" She whispered as to not draw attention to them.

Silence.

"Catra, don't start this now. You don't have to tell me your idea if that's what it is. I was just joking".

"It's not that". She placed a hand over Adora's. "I know you were".

"Here". Adora stretched out her legs and patted her thigh. "You can put your head back".

She readily took the offer and looked up at Adora. "Really, it's nothing".

"We can talk later". She rubbed her cheek gently. "If you want".

"Also," Catra finally spoke loud enough for the group to hear, "I'm not wearing a full suit until Princess Prom. How's that for an idea on how formal this should be?"

“If you two would listen instead of staring at each other,” Glimmer said with her arms crossed, “you’d know we decided on dress casual. Besides, I’m sure you’ll wear a suit again before that. Unless you’re really planning on wearing a dress for your wedding”.

Catra sat up coughing. “What?!”

Scorpia gasped. “You’re actually engaged now? Like the real Etherian thing?”

“No!” Catra practically squeaked in embarrassment.

Adora covered her own blushing face with a groan.

“So, no wedding?” Frosta huffed.

“No!” Catra stood. “No wedding. No engagement. Not any time soon!”

“Oh, but you’ll bite her without an issue?” Glimmer teased with a smirk.

“Ughhhh! Adora, why did you swear on Angella that you would tell her?!”

Adora looked up with a slightly embarrassed smile. “She’s my best friend?”

“Can we back up about a hundred steps?” Mermista asked. “Not that I care what goes on in your bedroom-“

Glimmer cut in briefly, teasing smirk never leaving her face, “and the war room. And the hallway. And one of the closets”.

“-but I don’t see how biting each other has anything to do with weddings or engagement,” Mermista finished.

Both Adora and Catra’s faces were red with the way the conversation had gone. They looked at each other and Adora put her hand on Catra’s calf comfortingly.

“No. Absolutely not, Adora”.

“They’re our friends”.

“Your friends. That I’m going to kill”. Her tail lashed behind her. “Starting with Sparkles. This isn’t funny! Stop laughing!”

“Oh, you should see the look on your faces,” Glimmer said in between laughs.

“So we’re clear,” Spinnerella said, “it seems the only ones that aren’t confused are Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, and Perfuma”.

“And me, darling,” Netossa said from next to her. “What? I had to take that shower with them”.

“Alright. Now I need an explanation,” Mermista said and leaned forward. “First, it sounds like she bit you hard enough to leave one hell of a mark. Second, you can heal yourself and you didn’t”.

Catra took a deep breath and looked at Adora. She reached up and grabbed her hand, gently tugging her back to sitting next to her. Her ears flattened back with a low, short growl as she gave in and sat. Adora rubbed her back with a smile.

“Come on.”

“Fine! She’s my mate, okay?!”

Silence fell over the group and Catra dug her claws into the ground on either side of her. She felt Perfuma’s stare and glanced up. Catra knew that the scowl she had on her face hadn’t

lightened in the slightest when Perfuma quietly tried leading her through a breathing exercise she was taught what felt like ages ago. She forced herself watch Perfuma and follow along. It was shaky at first, but slowly her breathing leveled back out. The growl she had stuck at the back of her throat finally faded away as she closed her eyes with a deep breath.

"The anger is still something I'm working on," she admitted calmly. "But… we've been a mated pair for several months now. It's a big thing for my species."

"Like marriage?" Frosta asked.

"More than. In a way," Adora answered. "It's—"

"Isn't that a little fast?" Mermista cut in. "I mean, you two were at each other's throats for a couple years."

"That's… another thing." Adora let out a sigh and looked at Catra.

She nodded and picked at the grass.

"Shadow Weaver could wipe minds. She, uh, wiped ours. A lot. We were in a relationship before the war." Adora looked around at the mildly shocked faces. "We got our memories back when she sacrificed herself at the Heart."

“The spell died with her,” Micah said and rubbed his beard. “You mentioned it happened a lot. Was it because of the relationship?”

Catra nodded and sniffled. Adora put a hand on her lower back.

“She caught us a few times but we always found each other again,” Adora explained. “The last time more or less worked since I… I left the Horde not long after. We didn’t have time to, uh, find each other like that again. Until the Heart.”

“I guess that explains why you never let each other actually die,” Mermista said with a shrug. “Is this, like, something to congratulate?”

“I think so!” Perfuma said with a smile. “I’m very happy for you two! I think it’s safe to say we all are.”

“Can we get back to the party stuff?” Catra asked quietly. She was thoroughly done with the topic that had gotten brought up, particularly Shadow Weaver. “Have we talked about food?”

“Is there something specific you want?” Glimmer asked softly.

“Some sort of white fish would be good”.

“Lucky for you, Adora already wrote that down when we first started planning all of this as a joke. Anything else?”

“This was originally a joke?” Micah asked.

Bow jumped and rubbed the back of his head with a nervous smile.

“The, uh, grandness of it, yeah,” Adora said. “We got a little out of hand at the time”.

“Well, I liked the idea. Can we still invite everyone? Whoever shows up is fine. Right?”

“I, for one, love that idea,” Scorpia said.

Catra sighed and laid back to watch the sparse clouds overhead while everyone else bickered about the size of the party and what food to have. She personally would have preferred something a little smaller, but it didn’t really matter to her. A party was a party and ever since leaving the Horde, she wouldn’t exactly turn one down.

Her ears twitched at the sounds of everyone slowly getting up and dispersing as the meeting ended. Adora kissed her forehead and

told her that she was going to head in for dinner. Catra told her she would catch up and continued laying back, staring at the sky. At least until Glimmer was standing over her.

"What?"

"Are you okay?"

"I'm fine, Sparkles". She turned her head to look away.

"I heard that little sniffle." She sat down next to her. "Shadow Weaver… she's still a sensitive topic, isn't she?"

Catra nodded and closed her eyes.

"Adora has never told me a whole lot. But… I do know she treated you poorly. To what extent, I don't—"

"Torture. Physical and emotional abuse." She cleared her throat to swallow the tears. "She would hit me, electrocute me, render me immobile, starve me, call me horrible things."

"Oh," Glimmer said almost silently.

“That, uh, electric arc she had you in? I was in it several times.” She opened her eyes and looked at her friend. “There are still some things I haven’t told Adora about.”

“But… but you grew up together. You slept in the same bunk!” She shook her head. “What do you mean there’s things you haven’t told her?”

“I mean I lied to her about some things. I’ll tell her eventually. But yeah… Shadow Weaver…”

Glimmer put a hand on her shoulder. “I’m so sorry. I should have listened to Adora when Shadow Weaver first came to Bright Moon. I knew she hurt you both but I never knew… how bad. Adora only told me about a few things.”

Catra hummed and looked back at the sky. Glimmer laid down next to her.

“You know, my mom—“

“I’m sorry.”

“I know you are.” Glimmer let out a soft sigh. “Sometimes I think my mom would actually make a real prison just for you for what you did. But, honestly, I know she *never* would.”

“Then why don’t you? You’re the queen now.”

Glimmer was quiet for a long time. A lot longer than Catra was comfortable with.

“I mean, I’d deserve it and I’m sure Adora would understand. And-“

“Because you deserve better,” she finally said. “I won’t lie and say I haven’t considered it. But… Adora vouched for you. And so did Scorpia. They really believed you aren’t a bad person and I can see what they mean now. After you saved me… just before you got me off of that ship, I saw a completely different person. And I got to know you better with our talks.”

“None of that means I deserve better. Not after what I’ve done.”

“I think…” Glimmer blindly grabbed her hand and squeezed. “I think you’ve been tortured enough. You were a child. Horde or not, you never deserved to be… beaten and electrocuted and starved. You paid for your crimes before you ever committed them.”

The only response Glimmer got was a sniffle and a shuddered exhale. When she looked over, she saw Catra had her other hand on her face and her jaw was clenched as she forced herself to not

cry aloud. Still, she saw the tears running across her temple and disappearing into her hair. Glimmer let go of her hand and sat up.

"Hey. I'm sorry. I didn't—"

"Stop." Catra coughed to cover a sob and sat up to stare at her friend through the tears. "You… you mean that?"

Glimmer nodded. "I do. Do you want to head in for dinner?"

Catra shook her head and looked away. "I need to calm down first."

"Do you want company?"

A trace of a smile came to her face as she wiped the tears away. "Like old times?"

Glimmer scooted to sitting behind her with their backs pressed together. "Well, duh. Did you hear that Bow wants party hats?"

Catra groaned. She wasn't surprised by it, but that just meant there was one more thing to worry about at the party. She made a mental note to make it clear that she would not be wearing one.

Chapter End Notes

For the smut skippers: the first day of Catra's heat usually leaves her rather sore. She doesn't care and just wants laid. Adora, however, cares and doesn't particularly enjoy the pain Catra seems to be in. And then Glimmer busts into the war room to see Catra bent over the table.

S: This past week has been… I don't know. My mental health has been acting a fool again. I have decided to start a Patreon for writing but I'm not yet ready to give it out. I'd like to get a few things up for each tier before I do. I'll, of course, drop it in the chapter notes when I'm ready. I will also still post on here, of course. Other than that, I don't have much else to say other than… I can't believe this story is almost done. However, I know I'm super excited for the next installment in this series. It let us have a ton of creative freedom and we hope you enjoy book 2 as much as we did writing the rough draft when we all get to it!

Indy: I've been doing ok. Things have been busy for me. I know I've not been really chatty in my notes but I'm not that interesting. I hope you love the story

Let’s Talk About It

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Catra? Are you asleep?”

Catra stretched her arms and legs out before rolling over and opening an eye. Her voice was still laced with sleep when she replied, “not anymore. Are you okay?”

“Yeah,” Adora said quietly and ran her fingers over Catra’s shoulder. “I’m alright.”

“You don’t sound alright.” She opened her other eye and lightly stroked her girlfriend’s cheek with the back of her hand. “Nightmare?”

“It wasn’t that bad. So… I’d say more like just a bad dream.”

Catra let out a small, quiet scoff at the slight tremble Adora had to her voice and opened her arms. She wrapped them tightly around her when she took the invitation. Even if it was more than a bad dream, Adora didn’t show any other signs of that being the case. She wasn’t in tears or shaking or hyperventilating.

“Wanna talk about it?”

“It was about Prime.” She felt Catra tense. “Really, it wasn’t a nightmare. I kicked his ass and threatened a clone with immediate death if he didn’t remove the chip.”

“And that’s a bad dream?” She asked with a quiet chuckle.

“Well, any dream involving him or anything like that is a bad one. And it’s not like he didn’t still hurt you.” Adora trailed her fingers down Catra’s back and nuzzled her face into her chest. “I just couldn’t get back to sleep. My mind…”

“Racing?”

Adora nodded. “It’s not all bad. I promise. For example, I just can’t believe I actually get to have you now. Like it should have always been, even in the Horde. Sometimes I wonder if they knew about Kyle and Rogelio. And if they did, why didn’t they get mind wiped? Why was it just us? You know…?”

Catra stayed quiet and ran her fingers through Adora’s hair.

“Even if they did know about those two, maybe it was because it was… me?”

"No," Catra finally said around a sigh. "If we're ignoring the whole 'love is isn't allowed' thing, we got wiped because it was you *and* me. Shadow Weaver loved you, you could have done damn near anything and got off with a warning. She despised me. So, of course, when she found out it was me you were fooling around with, it was over and… there go the memories".

"Well, whatever the reason, we got the memories back." She snuggled impossibly closer. "And I got you back and we don't have to worry about Shadow Weaver manipulating us. And we saved the universe. The magic is back across Etheria. And, Catra, I love you."

"I love you too, Adora," she said around a purr.

Adora went back to running her fingers up and down Catra's back with a smile plastered on her face. A whole year since the Heart was almost a month away and she still couldn't believe she was finally happy. Sure, they still had a lot of cleanup to get through and they were going to explore space again, but she could finally let herself *feel*. Catra's purr slowly grew choppy until it finally stopped as she fell back to sleep. Adora decided it was too late for her to bother to try to go back to sleep, her body wasn't about to let that happen. She continued to lay there in Catra's arms, head against her chest, her heartbeat reminding her this was truly real.

The morning light started to filter into their room and Adora carefully slipped from the hold she was in. She waited a moment to see if she had accidentally woken Catra. When all that happened was her rolling over with an ear twitch and a quiet grunt, she figured she was in the clear. She quietly got a change of clothes and made her way to the bathroom to shower.

Adora stepped from the shower and wrapped a towel around herself before wiping the mirror clear. A smile came to her face as she ran a finger over the bite scar. Then she raised an eyebrow at her reflection and looked her arm for a moment. It was a stupid idea, but maybe if she tried…

"Fuck," she muttered after taking her arm from her mouth and looking at the indents she left on herself. "It didn't feel like it took that much…"

"Giving yourself a pep talk to start the day?" Catra tiredly asked before grabbing her toothbrush. "You're so weird."

Adora stared at her for a moment then grabbed her toothbrush from her and then her jaw.

"Huh?"

"It's the teeth, right?"

Catra pulled her head away and raised her eyebrow. "Yes, those are my teeth. What's wrong with you?"

"You bit me… but it didn't feel like it took a lot from you".

Catra snatched her toothbrush back. “My teeth are sharp, dummy. It doesn’t exactly take a whole lot.”

She went back to brushing her teeth while Adora continued to look over her. After rinsing her mouth and putting her toothbrush away, Catra looked at her and folded her arms.

“Listen, if you want me undressed all you have to do is say so. You don’t have to use your eyes. It’s not like I’m wearing much anyhow.” She let her own eyes wander Adora’s towel clad body before stopping at her arm and grabbing it. “What did you do?” She scrunched her eyebrows in confusion. “Did you seriously bite yourself?”

“I, uh, I wanted to see how hard you had to bite to break skin?”

“You… why?”

“N-no reason,” Adora stammered and looked away with a blush rising to her cheeks.

Catra raised an eyebrow and grabbed her face with a smirk. She turned Adora’s head slowly to look at her. She held her there for a moment before she started chuckling.

“What are you laughing at?”

“You”. Catra tucked a wet strand of hair behind Adora’s ear, her eyes flicking to the scar. “You could have asked, you know.”

“What?” Adora whispered, cheeks getting redder.

“You want to return the favor,” she traced over the mark with her finger, “don’t you?”

Adora really tried to say something, but no words came out. Catra patted her cheek gently before taking a step back, the little smirk never leaving her face.

“Here’s the thing, Adora, you’re going to have to bite a lot harder than I had to. And it’s going to really hurt on my end.” Her tail flicked behind her. “But I’m not saying no. Go for it.”

Adora stared after her as she turned around with a wink and walked out, gently clicking the door closed behind her. She really thought about ripping the door back open, possibly breaking it, and doing exactly what Catra said. It just didn’t feel quite right. She wasn’t exactly in the mood and biting her like that should be more intimate. Way more intimate than just walking up to her and biting down.

She looked at the fading marks she left on her arm and rubbed it. Adora knew that was only a fraction of the pain Catra would likely feel, especially with the target being a far more sensitive area than the forearm. The bite she received herself wasn't painless by any means, but she didn't have the sharp teeth. Still, deep down, for whatever nagging reason, she wanted to return the favor. Someday.

With a soft sigh, Adora dried herself and got dressed. She quickly brushed her hair and pulled it back into a ponytail before brushing her teeth and leaving the bathroom to find that Catra seemed to have headed down for breakfast. She quickly made her way down, her stomach's growling driving her pace. When she arrived, Catra was just about half done as Adora took her seat next to her. A tail quickly found a place on her lap as she was passed a few dishes to help herself from.

"Did I miss anything?" She asked just before stuffing a piece of waffle into her mouth.

"Sparkles was just saying how Scorpia contacted her asking for maybe a little extra help with the party approaching faster than we all noticed". Catra took another bite from a strip of bacon. "But you know how Scorpia is, always downplaying it. Saying it's not really a big deal, that she already has plenty of hands".

"Well, I'm sure we could help," Adora said matter of factly. "I can be something of a party planner, especially with the Fright Zone".

“Adora,” Glimmer sighed, “you didn’t even know what a party was until about three years ago. And you didn’t exactly ever plan one”.

“Hey! I helped get ready for Princess Prom!”

“By turning it into some kind of war plan on a board in my room!”

Catra nearly choked on her drink of milk at the comment. Adora making strategic plans. It was almost too funny.

“What?” Adora asked.

“You treated Princess Prom as a…” she gestured vaguely, “battle plan? No wonder it was so *easy* to distract you. You were only… somewhat good at it”.

“Hey! I just didn’t account for *you* to be there. Or even Scorpia for that matter. How was I supposed to know she was a princess?!”

Catra put a hand on her arm. “You didn’t account for *something* to go wrong. That’s where the issue was. Always plan for something to go poorly and always have a contingency. Did you skip that class?”

“No!” She folded her arms and narrowed her eyes at Catra. “You… you were just… ugh!”

“I was just what?” She teased. “Actually better that you at something other than speed? I need to hear it from you”.

Glimmer and Bow couldn’t really contain the chuckles at the halfhearted bickering from the two. The way Catra had a small smirk on her face and Adora’s face was tinged pink was worth not breaking in between them.

“Fine! You were always better at strategy and planning. Happy?”

“Yes, actually. Thanks”. She returned to her meal with a smile. “But back to business, we both grew up there. I think we should go and help”.

“Are you sure?” Bow asked, concern evident in his voice. “I mean, I know you said you don’t have a problem going there. You guys have already gone to help before. I just… worry, I guess. You two were put through a lot, especially you, Catra. Since… you, you know, stayed with them longer”.

Catra looked to her plate and focused on it. He wasn’t exactly wrong.

“I’ll be alright”.

“You don’t have to,” Adora said and stroked the tail on her lap. “Last time you were there, you stuck to the forge area”.

“I want to,” she said with conviction and looked up. “I want to help with this”.

The other three looked at each other before smiling. They all quickly agreed to go help however they could. They decided to get around after breakfast and make the trip.

_____

Catra was the last to step from the end of Darla’s ramp. She waited for a moment and nodded to Scorpia who looked like she was barely containing herself. The Scorpioni woman had gotten better with displays of affection towards her, waiting impatiently for permission. Catra braced for the hug and grunted when it finally happened.

“Yup. Okay”. She felt like she was being crushed for a moment before she was set back on her feet.

“Oh, I’m so glad you guys came! You didn’t really need to but… it really is nice to have you”.

“What do you need help with?” Glimmer asked with a smile.

“Anything you want, really. Um, Horror Hall is over there”. She pointed with her pincer. “That is… if you want to help the few ex-soldiers working over there. Or you could help Perfuma with clearing out the plants that have overgrown the walkways. Some railings could also be fixed up, I’ve been meaning to do so, but just haven’t had the time. Oh! Some of the doors still need locks overridden…….”

Catra started to tune out the things that needed done. Scorpia would never admit that she needed more help around the place than a few straggling ex-soldiers and Perfuma.

“I’ll help Perfuma,” she finally said a little too quiet and held up her hands. “Claws”.

“That’s a great idea, wildcat!” Scorpia noticed she was staring off at nothing in particular and her ears showed mild agitation with the way they were partially pinned back. “Are you alright?”

“Yeah. I am. I’ll… see you guys for lunch. Mess hall?”

“See you there,” Adora said as she tried to give a smile. “I hope we get the grey kind”.

“Yeah”. Her voice trailed off as she started walking away to find the other princess. “Me too”.

“Is she really okay?” Scorpia asked the remaining three.

“It’s… still not exactly easy for us to be here. But, it’s not bad!” Adora finally managed a smile. “I’ll help move some rocks and stuff from Horror Hall. I’ll catch up with you guys later!”

While Adora ran off, Catra was slowly following a cleared path. It was a path she knew well, leading to one of the barracks. Slowly, the path became covered with vines and shrubs, life that was clearly stamped out by the Horde long ago and never returning due to the pollution. At least until Adora changed all of that.

The smog was gone and the daylight put on display the steel structures, all bent to hell. It looked better in the smog. Now, it was like one wrong breeze and they’d topple over. Really, seeing the place she used to call home in new light left her wondering how anything actually worked at all, regardless of how poorly at times.

Working on memory alone, she typed in a few numbers on the keypad and waited for the door to slide open. It had been a long while since she set foot in the cadet barracks longer than quickly passing through after finally receiving her own personal room as Force Captain. As if driven by instinct, she reached for her old headpiece, only for her hands to contact her hair and ears instead.

Catra blinked for a moment, standing at the foot of her and Adora's old bunk. Her chest held a weight she thought she finally left behind seeing the tore up thin mattress and the old drawings, her claw marks across Adora's. Not letting it get turned over to whatever new cadet was one personal favor she asked of Lonnie. At least she had kept the promise she wouldn't let it happen, regardless of how confused she was about it.

She hissed and spun on her heel when she finally came to her senses and caught the scent of someone else in the room with her. Her hand almost made contact with Perfuma's face, barely stopping inches from striking with her claws. Her hand dropped and she backed into one of the poles attached to the bunk.

"I'm sorry," she whispered frantically, gripping onto the pole behind her back. "I'm so sorry, Perfuma. I'm… I'm s-sorry".

"It's okay," she tried to soothe. "You didn't hurt me. I noticed how you walked in here. You seemed a little dazed and I just wanted to check on you. It can't be easy for you to be here, but we do sincerely appreciate the help".

Catra hugged herself, her arms visibly shaking. She kept her eyes on the woman in front of her, deliberately making herself aware of her breathing and trying to slow it. Perfuma only smiled at her efforts and helped guide her along for a moment.

"May I hug you?"

Catra nodded and welcomed the embrace, fully returning it. Her body language gave her away when she started to tense up and Perfuma released her a few seconds later. Quickly she turned away to gather her thoughts.

"I… did this," she slowly admitted and gestured to Adora's old bunk. "When Adora left. When she made it clear she wasn't… coming back with me". She took a deep breath before continuing, "when I felt she left me, abandoned me. Really, now, I realize she left the Horde, not me. She truly wanted me to go with her, to stay with her. And I made my choice… here. I was wrong".

"You made mistakes, Catra. You felt hurt, betrayed even. You were trained to retaliate, you didn't know any better. Adora… changed sides, joined the rebellion, right in front of you. You didn't know how else to react."

"I could have stayed with her," she whispered and realized tears were trailing down her cheeks. She quickly wiped them away. "I should have left with her. I… I think about how different things could have been. And maybe even realized what it was I felt towards her sooner, found love sooner. Shadow Weaver's magic only did so much, I'm sure you saw it when we fought. We pulled our punches. She could have easily killed me as She-Ra if she wanted to. She almost *did* when she was infected and not having any control whatsoever".

Perfuma calmly waited, knowing her now friend wasn't done. It was something she was rather proud of.

“I think that’s when I realized she was holding back every other time we fought for some reason. I mean, I did too. The few times I had a chance, I didn’t want to actually harm her. I,” she sniffled, “would sneak off and cry and hit things… hurt myself… after our battles. Especially the few times I did hurt her. I… I couldn’t believe what I had done sometimes. It only got worse after the portal. The look she gave me, all I saw was hate. I thought I lost her forever, I stopped caring. I wanted to die. I felt so… empty, nothing mattered”.

Perfuma put a gentle hand on her shoulder when Catra couldn’t stop the tears any longer no matter how hard she fought them. She could only guess the things that happened on the other side of the rebellion. If what she was hearing now was only a fraction of it, her time with the Horde couldn’t have been pleasant.

“I still feel like that sometimes, Perfuma,” she cried and hugged herself. “I don’t feel like I deserve any of the care you all have shown me. I-I get scared of myself. I know I scare Adora sometimes. I know you say you believe the vulnerability is worth it,” she turned to face her, tears flowing freely, “but is it? After everything I’ve done? D-do I actually… matter?”

“Of course you do,” Perfuma said and opened her arms, embracing the other woman when she fell against her, sobbing. “I’m proud of you. You don’t have to say anything more if you don’t want to. This was a lot for you. Please, Catra, be open with Adora. I know you fear her leaving, but she won’t. All of us could see the love she had for you, even after the portal. Even if it was usually Double Trouble. She thought it was really you”.

“There you… are…” Scorpia cleared her throat. “I’ll come back. I’m sorry”.

Catra shook her head against Perfuma’s shoulder barely managing, “make her stay,” before another few sobs shook her frame.

“Scorpia, dear, stay with us”.

“Are you sure? This looks… bad and I, um, I don’t know”.

“She wants you to stay,” Perfuma said and gently rubbed Catra’s back as she cried.

Scorpia tentatively walked over to the pair and winced. Catra looked so small. She wasn’t angry. She didn’t exactly show signs of falling into one of her depressive states. She just looked absolutely, heartbreakingly sad. Scorpia’s face softened and grabbed the old blanket from the top bunk and draped it over her shoulders before carefully stroking the back of her head.

“It’s gonna be okay,” she told her friend softly. “You don’t have to be here if you can’t be. I completely understand”.

“I want to be,” Catra replied quietly around sniffles. “I feel like… such a fucking idiot”.

“It’s alright to cry,” Perfuma said. “You didn’t deserve the treatment you received. None of you did. Are you going to be okay?”

Catra nodded and pulled away. She sat on the edge of Adora’s old bunk and wiped her face with the edge of the blanket. Scorpia sat beside her and rubbed her back with a soft smile.

“You can go out to Horror Hall and help there. Less painful memories for you”.

“No, no. I said I’d help with the walkways. I fell into auto pilot and didn’t fully realize where my feet were taking me”. She looked up at Perfuma while tugging the blanket tighter around herself. “I just need a few minutes.”

Across the Fright Zone, Adora helped lift a large steel plate with one of the ex-soldiers who kept looking at her, confused. He knew exactly who she was, yet didn’t understand why she wasn’t She-Ra at the moment. They added the plate to a growing pile of debris and Adora dusted her hands on her pants before walking back inside.

She shrugged off her jacket and hung it on the back of the broken throne. One of the old soldiers had mentioned the new one was going to arrive in a few days. Adora gathered an armful of broken concrete and started making her way back outside when an all too familiar voice startled her.

"What's the deal? We're all a little shocked She-Ra isn't the one working".

"Lonnie! Um, hi. Yeah, I was going to, but I don't want to freak out the soldiers- the ex-soldiers with being the tall warrior lady that tried to basically kill them".

Lonnie blinked for a moment before shaking her head. "We can only roll so many boulders out of here, you know. Like I said, we're confused. Where's the new, old girlfriend?"

Adora's face grew red as she dropped the debris she had. It was blatantly confirmed that Lonnie did remember.

"Decided to not show, huh? Figured as much."

"No!" Adora finally got out. "She's here. Catra's helping Perfuma clear more walkways". She rubbed her forehead, leaving a smear of dust mixed with the sweat she worked up. "Can I talk to you?"

“Uh…” Lonnie looked around at the crew she had been working with. “Take a water break guys!” She faced Adora again. “What do you need? Access to the place again? Most of the locks have been overridden so you’re good.”

“It’s not like that,” she muttered. “I thought we were past this. You know what, never mind. It’s not that important anyhow”.

“Adora, wait!” Lonnie quickly caught up to her after she had decided to walk outside. “Listen, I still have some bitter feelings about you. We were your friends, your… crew. It still hurts, what you did to us, leaving us like that”.

“I know! I’m sorry! Can’t you just… if that’s how you feel, I’ll go somewhere else”.

Lonnie grabbed her wrist and yanked her backwards and barely dodged the fist that was thrown at her face for the action. She quickly let go of Adora and held her hands up in surrender. Adora sighed and folded her arms. The last thing either of them wanted was a fight.

“Just… we all need time still. I’m sure you do too. But you wanted to talk. So, what? What do you want?”

“I want to know why you never said anything to me, or even Catra after I left, about the relationship we had”.

Lonnie stared at her for a moment, dumbfounded. “What are you talking about? I mean, I know you guys stopped asking me to cover for you, but I just thought you managed to make a time slot for your fun. And then you left and I thought you broke up. Catra was already so hurt, I didn’t bring it up”.

It was Adora’s turn to stare at her. “I… n-no. We never broke up,” she quietly admitted and looked away.

“Let me get this right,” Lonnie folded her arms, “you never broke up but you still left her to join the rebellion where you two tried to kill each other… a lot? That doesn’t even make sense!”

“I never wanted to hurt her”.

“Well, you did. Pretty bad. The Catra we all knew left when you did. She was never happy, always reckless and brash and… Adora, she was frightening and relentless”.

“I know! But I didn’t know what she meant to me then!” Adora picked up a rock and threw it as hard as she could over the mound of debris. “All I know is I could have killed her so many times if I wanted to. I always held back when we fought. I hid myself away and bawled my eyes out after our battles. It didn’t make sense at the time, she was my enemy”.

“What do you mean you didn’t know?!” Lonnie grabbed her shoulders and turned Adora to face her and noticed a tear running down her face, making a clean trail through the dust. “Adora, seriously, if you didn’t break up, what the fuck do you mean you didn’t know?”

“Shadow Weaver wiped our memories of our relationship!”

Adora covered her mouth as Lonnie’s eyes grew in shock. She didn’t exactly mean for that to slip out.

“She… what?”

“She tried more than once, actually. We always found each other again,” Adora said quietly while wiping away the stubborn tears. “The last time was the most effective, but maybe that’s because I found… I found the sword not too long after, maybe a month or two. And all the fighting… but still, there was something about her I could never place. I didn’t want to ever hurt her. And I know I did a few times. I still regret all of it, you know. We never got to find each other again. Not until… Shadow Weaver sacrificed herself. The spell died with her”.

“She was actually able to wipe minds?” Lonnie asked in disbelief. “I… I thought that was all talk to keep us out of trouble”.

“No, she could”. Adora looked out over the horizon. “And did. We would always figure it out again after a while until… until the last

one. The deep feelings stayed, but neither of us knew what it was or why we couldn't go through with letting the other die. Catra told me the only time I actually really, truly tried was when She-Ra was infected. I have no memory of ever doing… that".

Lonnie just nodded and let go of Adora, letting her turn away again. She definitely had no idea about any of that. She was also a little taken aback by the next question she was asked.

"What happened to her?" Adora sighed. "After I left".

"A lot of not good things. Her and Shadow Weaver got into a lot. Catra was angry almost all the time. Hordak tried to kill her. Honestly, there was a long period of time just before and well after the whole portal thing where I don't think she really slept or even ate". Lonnie found a nearby boulder to sit on. "We all noticed she had gotten a little thinner and looked like she was about to pass out at any moment but was always, and I mean always, working. I found her at desks in a very restless sleep often."

Adora crouched down where she was and sniffled. Catra had told her a lot, but not everything about how things were after she left. She also almost never talked much about the state she was in, both mentally and physically. Hearing all of this was new. And heartbreaking. She thought she had noticed Catra, or Double Trouble as her, looking thinner than she remembered, yet somehow still muscular.

"What have I done?"

Lonnie barely heard her. “Hey, that’s all over now. You two got each other back. She still loved-“

“But at what cost?!”

“Adora, take a breath. Damn. If Shadow Bitch wiped your mind, how could you have known, huh?” Lonnie lightly threw a small pebble at her head. “Catra started to get a little sloppy with the whole hard ass front she liked to keep up. She truly did love you through all of it. It was actually kinda painful to watch. Rogelio, Kyle, and I kept making bets if it was going to be the battle you two finally kissed and made up. Speaking of, when did you guys kiss and make up, making her ditch the Horde?”

“We didn’t kiss until the Heart,” Adora half chuckled. “But… on Prime’s ship, when she was chipped, we fought. It was the most difficult fight I had with her. She, um,” Adora swallowed heavily, “she died. I-in my arms. It reawakened She-Ra… I think that’s when I really knew for sure that she, for some reason, was extremely important to me. I mean I knew she was the whole time, but that moment is when it really hit”. She sighed and wiped the new tears away. “I thought it was love, but that couldn’t have been it, you know? I loved my friends but how I felt about *her* was different. I just knew I wanted her by my side, always. I never wanted to see her hurt again”.

Lonnie smiled and went to stand next to Adora. “You’re really dense, you know”.

“I’ve been told”. Adora stood and flinched when she was given a quick hug.

“Come on. Let get lunch”. She elbowed her. “I heard it’s the grey kind”.

“Oh, shut up”. Adora shoved her teasingly before starting the walk to the mess hall.

Her and Lonnie made it to the mess hall and Adora gave Catra a small smile. Her expression shifted to concern when she only got a small wave and noticed her girlfriend had barely touched her food. She quickly sat next to her and rubbed her lower back.

“I’m sorry it’s not the grey kind. I thought it was”.

“Funny,” Catra half chuckled. “Are you okay?”

“What? Yeah, I’m fine”. She kissed her cheek.

“You’ve been crying”. She tried to brush the remaining dust from Adora’s face. “Maybe make sure your face is clean next time you try to pass it off”.

“Okay, fine. I just had a moment, okay? Some memories. It’s hard to not think about it all being back. I, uh, talked to Lonnie. She thought we broke up”.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Of course she still remembered and didn’t say anything”.

“She didn’t know what Shadow Weaver was capable of, thinking the mind wiping was something that was made up”. Adora poked around the food on her plate Catra had made for her. “She said you were so… hurt and angry that she didn’t want to bring it up”.

Catra stared at her own plate for a moment before looking to her. “I had a moment too. In the barracks”.

“Alone?” She whispered and grabbed her hand.

“No. Perfuma was there. She followed me in. I didn’t know at first”.

Adora gave her a half smile. “Wanna go to our spot after lunch?”

“I’d like that”. Catra tried to keep her expression neutral when Lonnie sat across from them, Kyle and Rogelio joining not long after.

“Hello to you too,” Lonnie said, her expression matching Catra’s in a forced neutral.

“I’m sorry,” Catra finally said.

“You hurt the three of us,” Kyle spoke up. “But… how about no hard feelings?”

“Oh, there’s plenty of hard feelings,” Lonnie said.

Catra sighed, dejected. It wasn’t like she didn’t deserve it. She had really treated them extremely poorly.

“Guys, now isn’t the time,” Adora said. “She’s… we’re both having a bit of a hard time today. Last time we were here was to get the forge cleaned up. It wasn’t great then, but easier because, well, it’s just the forge”.

“I already told you that you’re not exactly in the clear either”. Lonnie pointed at Adora with a glare forming.

“I think you and Catra need to… talk?” Kyle offered.

“Shut up, Kyle!” Lonnie and Carta said together, annoyed with the suggestion, and then looked at each other.

“I fucked up, okay?!” Catra glanced at Adora and then back at Lonnie before her eyes settled at her plate again. “I was hurt and I took it out on you guys. Sorry won’t fix it now, and I don’t expect you guys to like me ever again. I… accept I was wrong. I did what I thought was right at the time and it ended up making everything worse. I’m still trying to be better, but any of the princesses, and really anyone else, can tell you I still have moments where I just… go back”.

Silence fell over the five of them. Lonnie quietly put an old grey ration bar on the table between them. Adora shook her head and nudged it towards Catra who wrinkled her nose and scoffed at it before smacking it towards Rogelio. The lizard man made a series of roars and grunts before eating it whole.

“Seriously?” Adora asked him and shook her head. “All of this actually good food and you still practically swallow them whole?”

Rogelio shrugged and focused on the food in front of him.

“He still eats pretty much anything you give him,” Kyle said with a laugh.

“Including your ass,” Lonnie teased and shoved him into the lizard.

Catra choked on her water. Adora laughed and patted her back while she continued to cough. Kyle looked mortified as he shoved a laughing Lonnie back.

"Still a thing all these years later?" Adora asked as her laughing died to small chuckles. "Good for you guys".

"At least we didn't break up," he said quickly.

"We… didn't break up," Catra coughed out. She cleared her throat and took a breath. "It's a long story, but it boils down to Shadow Weaver being a total bitch. Let's just say her mind wiping abilities were true".

"O-oh," Kyle whispered and looked at the table. "I'm… really sorry. But, hey, you're back together". He looked up with a smile. "Watching you two fight was painful".

"We've been told," Adora and Catra muttered together.

Chapter End Notes

S: Yeah, yeah. We're a day early. This chapter didn't have much to change during editing, shockingly. We figured that since it's ready we'll, get it posted so we can focus on and do some more work on a bigger thing that's coming later in the series tomorrow without having to remember to post. Trust me, when we get on a roll, we can both forget the day and how late it's getting. So… we hoped you enjoyed some of the feels in this one. It's one of our tamer chapters for sure.

Indy: We didn’t have too much to tweak for this chapter so we figured why not post a day early! I know I’m excited for you guys to read it…I also feel that way about every chapter lol. But seriously I hope you all love it.

Just Like Old Times

Chapter Notes

Smut makes up… a decent amount of this. It starts at:

> Adora nodded and trailed her fingers down the side of Catra's neck, down her chest, and over the swell of her breasts to rest her hands at her waist again. She felt the iron bar of the railing against her lower back as Catra returned to the slow make out, having caught her breath again. There wasn't much between her and a certain death, unless she could transform in time. That thought alone had Adora pushing Catra backwards.

It ends at:

> Catra's eyebrows scrunched as she hit her peak when Adora bit down on her shoulder. As she came down, she carefully released her hold and held the back of Adora's head to hold her in place when she tried to move as well. It already hurt plenty, but if Adora wanted or needed to do it, she was going to help her through as much as possible without letting on how much pain was involved.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora skipped dinner. She knew that was going to be a dead giveaway that she wasn't actually doing particularly well with being back in the Fright Zone unrestricted. Granted, she was never restricted when she came back to help Scorpia in the past, it was just easier to stick to one area. This was different. She wandered around after lunch while everyone went back to cleaning up for a less intimidating party in what used to be solid enemy territory. She did find a handful of minor clean up projects to keep herself occupied for a little while.

Adora didn’t forget she was going to meet Catra at their spot after dinner. It was a last minute decision to just go back to clean up and watch the moonset after dinner instead. Like old times. The only issue was, she got a little sidetracked and lost in her mind while she was busy fixing some of the railings. Eventually, she found herself in the locker room.

She had thought she was happy there. She was willing to do whatever it took it beat the Rebellion. Shadow Weaver always praised her, always wanted what was best for her. At least, that’s what she thought it was. Eventually, she came to realize it was all manipulation. It was all a means to get what *she* wanted while using Adora as a pawn. And Adora fell right into it.

Adora sat on one of the benches and rested her elbows on her knees while she hung her head. She had been happy, successful even. She was promoted to Force Captain and she was about to see combat. There wasn’t much more success than that for a seventeen year old cadet. At least she had been happy about it.

“But at the cost of your friends,” she whispered to herself.

That’s when she looked to what was once her locker, sandwiched between Catra’s and Lonnie’s. Her girlfriend’s wasn’t hard to find with all of the dents and scratches. Lonnie’s had a single dent at the bottom where she had kicked it after a particularly unfair training session. Even Adora was silent after, opting to just take a shower and return to the barracks.

Adora sighed and stood. It was probably a stupid idea. It wasn't even hers and hadn't been for years. She wished she had been right when she opened it. Her training clothes were neatly folded on the top shelf and the sensor pads were still tucked neatly in the bottom of the locker. Taped to the inside of the door were notes from her squad, some pictures were even included next to them. The notes were sometimes the easiest way for Rogelio to communicate. One of her favorites was the lizard scrawling out '*me and Kyle too. Happy for you*' when her and Catra finally told their squad, and only their squad, about their relationship. That's when they found out about Rogelio and Kyle being together.

She let out a teary laugh at one from Lonnie. She wasn't sure why she kept it. '*Do that when we see combat and I'm leaving your ass as princess food*'. Adora remembered in clarity that she had accidentally tripped her and continued on with the simulation. The next two notes were from Catra. One was a simple '*hey, Adora*' and the other, clearly from when they were little kids, '*you're pretty*'. Adora remembered constantly teasing her about the note only to be asked why she still had it. She never had an answer other than, 'because it's from you.'

The pictures are what finally made her cry. They used to have so much fun. One was of a time they sculpted a couple of green ration bars into a horn and stuck it to Rogelio's snout. Another was Lonnie with Catra on her shoulders to hang up some vandalized poster of Hordak. She had one of Kyle taped to a wall with Lonnie giving a thumbs up with Catra. The last was of her having Lonnie in a headlock with Catra midair about to tackle them both.

And she left. She left it all behind.

Adora closed her locker and sat on the floor in front of it. She put her face in her hands as she cried. The memories of actually trying to hurt her once friends came up. All the laughs she shared, all the teasing, all the comforting each other when something went wrong were quickly swept away when she found the sword. She *actively* tried to harm them all, even kill them at one point or another. Adora knew she had come close a few times. Maybe she even did kill some of the soldiers she used to talk to. She had to have, especially as She-Ra. The sword could heal, but the damn thing could also cause so much destruction.

She pulled herself to her feet and wiped her eyes. Catra was probably up at their spot by now. Adora opened her locker again and moved her old clothing out of the way to find where she always kept her grappling hook hidden away. She closed her locker again and made her way to the path she knew extremely well.

Adora carefully scaled the building. The plant growth definitely made it more of challenge with not being able to see the exact spots she would land the grappling hook. Finally, she launched it at the railing and gave a tug to make sure it was secure before hoisting herself up. Sure enough a pair of ears and heterochromatic eyes peered over the railing.

"Took you long enough," Catra teased and offered her hand.

"I got sidetracked, okay?" She responded while Catra helped her over the railing.

“Considering you skipped dinner, it must have been a good one.” She kissed her cheek. “Really, are you okay?”

Adora turned and leaned on the railing to look down at the path she climbed. “Do you think things would have been better?”

“What do you mean?” Catra joined her in looking at the Fright Zone directly below.

“I mean… I left you here. Would things have been better if I didn’t?”

“No,” Catra answered simply. She could practically feel Adora looking at her, waiting for more of an explanation. “We would have been in a constant cycle of being together just to get mind wiped. At least until we ran the place or Shadow Weaver finally died on her own. Things… would have been the same.”

“I don’t mean just you and me. I left… everyone.” Adora returned to looking down. “I was in the locker room and went through my stuff. I’m actually a little shocked it was all still there, exactly how I left it.”

“As if I’d let them turn it over,” Catra mumbled.

"I just… left. You, Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle. Those three never got an explanation. I tried with you." She sighed and busied her hands with unwrapping the grappling hook from the railing. "I tried to hurt everyone, I probably even killed some soldiers. So… do you still think things wouldn't have been any better if I didn't go?"

Catra's tail twitched behind her as she thought. Finally she answered, "I do. Things would have stayed the same. You'd advance the ranks and lead the four of us in combat. We'd still prank Kyle, Rogelio would still shake his head, Lonnie and I would still fight, I'd… have still slept at your feet every night. Like I said, you and I would have been caught in a cycle of mind wiping and loving each other."

"How is that not better than me leaving?! How is that not better than hurting my friends?!"

Catra flinched at the sudden yelling.

"Damn it, Catra, I *was* happy here! *We* were happy here, together! And I just…" she choked on a sob, "I just left it all behind. And for what? A stupid sword and some destiny where I was nothing more than a weapon?"

"And I should have went with you that night," she said quietly and hugged Adora tightly. "We both fucked up. I still loved you."

“But at what cost?” She lightly traced the scar on the back of Catra’s neck. “It can’t be easy waking up next to me or in Bright Moon all the time. Not after the way we fought, not after the way I… I actually tried to kill you once. It’s… it’s not easy for me every single morning. Some mornings I flinch away.”

Catra nodded. She knew. Some mornings she would scramble out of bed herself. It was far more often at first after the war.

“It’s not as often now, thank the stars, but… I dunno. I just know it can’t be easy for you either.” Her fingers continued to outline the scar. “I didn’t make it to a lot of situations on time. Glimmer was held prisoner and her magic was glitching. Bow and so many people of Elberon were kidnapped when I went off to fight the new bot you came up with, I should have made it back sooner. And… and I didn’t get to you fast enough to prevent the chip. I didn’t get to the Heart of Etheria fast enough and Prime’s virus almost killed me.”

“But you still made it through those situations and saved people, Adora.” Catra rubbed her cheek against her jaw. “I think you’re happier now than you would have been if you stayed. Sword or not, I think you would have left once you saw what we… what the Horde was actually doing. You always had a good heart like that.”

“Would you have come with me?”

Catra only offered a shrug.

“Come on, Cat. Would you?” Adora pulled back and held her hands. “I’m being serious.”

“I really don’t know. Maybe. We’ve talked about how I felt when you left. Maybe it would have been different because the decision would have been made together at the same time. I know you said I could have left with you whenever, but… I don’t know.” Catra fidgeted with Adora’s fingers. “I’d like to think I would have left with you. Either if you had stayed or I went with you to find the sword. I just felt…”

“Like I abandoned you. Like… like I was blind to everything Shadow Weaver did to you. I guess I should have known better, a lot better, when I was stitching you up at least twice a month if not more.” Adora rubbed Catra’s knuckles with her thumbs. “Or pressed more about the nightmares and why you were having such bad ones. Or asked more about why you always seemed so dazed after she wanted to talk with you. I should have realized a lot sooner and not agreed with her when it came to your attitude at times even a little bit.” She cleared her throat and looked at the sky to help swallow the tears. “I just wanted to stay in her favor. I… I should have been a better friend.”

“You were the best friend I could have had during all of that.” Catra grabbed her face and guided her gaze away from the sky and to her face. “You were the only one who actually cared at the end of the day.”

Adora watched as she sat on the ledge and let her legs dangle off the edge. They had definitely talked about it at length before. Catra had felt absolutely betrayed and abandoned at the time.

She had been innocent too, just a child. She felt like she wasn't enough. Adora didn't mean to make it seem like that. At all.

But it wasn't always bad.

"Remember when we would sneak up here after curfew?" Adora leaned on the railing again. "And how we had to quiet each others laughing so we didn't get caught?"

"Of course I do." She glanced over her shoulder. "I loved, and still love, your laugh. I'd never forget that, no matter how many times I tried."

"Or how we'd just come up here to think instead of talk. There were a lot of times I missed all of this, you know." She picked at some of the flaking rust of the railing. "I would occasionally climb as high as I could make it on the castle and hoped you were up here in your spot. I hoped you could hear me talking to you somehow." She looked over the railing and sighed before giving a soft half chuckle. "Sometimes I would fall asleep up there thinking about how we would fall asleep up here in the middle of the day, shoulder to shoulder."

Catra hummed an acknowledgment and looked out over what the Fright Zone had become thanks to her. A comfortable silence fell between them. The sky was bright and various shades of reds and oranges as the day moons began to set. The ground below was beautifully green. She almost liked the added touch of vines and flowers crawling up the sides of the steel structures. It was

definitely far different than the place she called home for so many years in a good way.

She looked at Adora who was still leaning against the railing, clearly enjoying the light breeze they could feel from their personal spot on the roof. All her brain could come up with was one word: beautiful. She had always thought that, always tried to make sure Adora knew it. At least until she only thought of her as pretty and never really told her. She was like anyone else, aesthetically pleasing. Catra shook that time of her life away and smiled at Adora. Beautiful. She stood back up quietly and walked over to her, a loud purr rumbling in her throat as she wrapped her arms around her from behind.

Adora sighed quietly and rubbed one of the arms around her. “It’s all so different now, isn’t it?”

“Mmmhm. Though, I wouldn’t say all of it”.

A smile came to her face when Catra’s tail brushed her leg. “No, this has changed too. We don’t have to hide it anymore”.

“The way I feel about you hasn’t”.

“I think that’s changed too”. Adora turned in her arms and brought their foreheads together. “I still love you and you’re still so important to me, but somehow, it feels stronger”.

“Ugh, you’re so gross”. Catra chuckled and brushed their noses together. “Yeah, I guess I know what you mean. But I know one thing that hasn’t changed”.

“Oh, and what’s that?” Adora challenged and pulled back a little.

“You’re still beautiful”.

Adora tried to say something as her cheeks flushed. Even as she tried to speak, flustered, Catra put a finger to her lips.

“I told you before I never want you to forget that, remember? I mean it, Adora. You’re beautiful. I know I wasn’t there to remind you for a few years, but you still are”. Catra’s eyes watched her finger as she moved it from Adora’s lips to rest her hand at her cheek. “Well, I guess you have me beat after all, princess”.

“Wh-what?” Adora stammered out.

“You somehow managed to get more beautiful over the years. I guess everything really is different now”.

“Who’s being gross now?” Adora teased and pushed on her face.

“Way to ruin the moment!” She teased back.

Adora giggled for a moment when the face shove was returned, yet kept a firm hold around Catra’s waist.

“I don’t know,” Adora finally said and pulled their bodies back together. “I kinda like it when you’re being gross like this”.

“Yeah, well, you’re the *only* one who will ever witness it”.

“I’m okay with that”.

Adora brought their lips together gently for a moment. And then again. And again. Until Catra kept their lips locked together with a gentle hand at the back of her neck. Her own hands rested at Catra’s hips. A small nip at her bottom lip told her plenty and she opened her mouth just enough for Catra to deepen the kiss.

Catra brought her other hand to Adora’s jaw as their tongues met. It was slow, nothing frantic or desperate in their make out on the rooftop. Adora hands slowly worked Catra’s belt off and let it drop next to their feet. It was shortly followed by her own. Her jacket was slowly slid from her shoulders and down her arms. She let it join the belts next to their feet.

It was Catra who backed out of the kiss first, gently pecking Adora’s lips before looking at her with a smile.

“That… felt nice,” Adora whispered, smiling back. “Catra-“

“Are you sure you don’t want to see my old room?”

“Maybe next time. I’d rather do this in a place neither of us have too many bad memories”.

Catra raised an eyebrow.

“I-I mean, unless I completely read this wrong and you just want to make out. I’m okay with leaving it at that. I just thought,” she half gestured at the small pile by their feet, “you know… maybe you-“

“Adora, stop talking. I do”. She gently untucked Adora’s shit and ran her fingers over her stomach under it. “I wasn’t planning on showing you my old room just because, you know. There’s at least a bed in there. But I’m okay with up here too. It’s been a long time”.

Adora nodded and trailed her fingers down the side of Catra’s neck, down her chest, and over the swell of her breasts to rest her hands at her waist again. She felt the iron bar of the railing against her lower back as Catra returned to the slow make out, having caught her breath again. There wasn’t much between her

and a certain death, unless she could transform in time. That thought alone had Adora pushing Catra backwards.

She let herself be pulled down by the front of the shirt as Catra knelt down. Adora blindly grabbed her jacket and balled it up before laying her head back on it, this time bringing Catra with her. Her shirt slowly came off next as fingers gently trailed over her stomach muscles on the way. Catra balled the garment up as well before gently lifting Adora's head and adding it to the jacket. A steel roof still wasn't the most comfortable thing to have the back of your head against.

Catra sat back on her heels and pulled her own shirt off, discarding it over her shoulder. She smiled down at Adora. Her face was flushed and she was breathing a little heavier, a smile plastered to her face. Catra tugged her boots off and placed them neatly to the side.

"Hey, come here," Adora said quietly and opened her arms.

Catra returned to hovering over Adora, a hand on either side of her head after tucking her socks into her boots. Adora's hands trailed down her back when she sparked up their kiss yet again. One hand gently rubbed just above the base of her tail while the other made its way back up, her fingers caressing the back of her neck. Catra lowered herself to her elbows and broke the kiss to trail her lips along Adora's jaw.

Adora tilted her head back into the pile of clothes to silently let Catra know where she wanted her to go next. So she did. She

made a slow trail of kisses and gentle bites down her throat, Adora's quiet gasps and hums of pleasure encouraged her on. Catra gently held her jaw and turned her head to the side for full access to the side of her neck, one thing she knew her girlfriend couldn't quite resist.

As if on cue, the gentle love bite she gave just below her ear had her wrapping her legs around her hips. Catra continued laying a trail of open mouthed kisses and bites down her neck, occasionally stopping to suck on the skin just to feel Adora pull her hips down with her legs. She stopped for a moment at the scar and gently bit down over it. It wasn't hard enough to break the skin again, just enough to serve as a reminder.

"Catra," Adora groaned, "you're taking forever".

"What's the rush?" She asked between kisses along her collarbone. "We both know no one knows about this spot of ours. Just us".

"I know, I know". She gently tugged on Catra's hair, pulling her up so their eyes met. "I just… want you is all".

"You'll get me soon enough". Catra brushed their noses together. "I just want to remind you just how beautiful you are".

"Stop with that," she said around a smile.

“Oh, but I thought you liked it”.

“I do. But- Catra!” Adora gasped when her bra was raised over her breasts.

“Hm?” Catra finished removing the article of clothing, careful to not toss it far, and gently moved Adora’s legs from her hips so she could sit back again. “I thought I was taking too long”.

Adora closed her eyes as Catra’s hands ran up her stomach to squeeze her breasts. A gentle thumb brushed over her nipples, prompting another soft moan. Catra smiled at the way she pressed into her hands and bent forward to place a kiss between them. She gently replaced one of her thumbs with her mouth, giving a flick with her tongue. Her own needy gasp left her mouth when Adora fisted her hair and tugged gently.

“You’re beautiful too, Catra,” Adora said while trailing her hands down her sides. “Always have been to me”.

Adora slipped her hands under the waistband of Catra’s leggings to tug her hips down into hers. She carefully worked her tail free and pulled her leggings down just enough they wouldn’t be pushing against it. Catra groaned against her chest and sat up to get her leggings down past her hips.

“I couldn’t reach that far,” Adora defended.

“I know”. Catra gently tugged Adora’s pants down. “Good thing I can, huh?”

She scooted herself back a little to get Adora’s pants and underwear off, also placing them nearby. The last thing she wanted was for anything to fall off the edge. Catra sat there on her knees for a moment simply admiring Adora. She had always been muscular and strong, yet with just the perfect amount of feminine features to top it off. Catra always felt like she won some big jackpot. She kicked her leggings off before she ran her hands up Adora’s thighs as she returned to being as close as she was previously.

“What?” She asked with a smile.

Adora propped herself up on her elbows to take Catra in for herself as she hovered slightly over her with her hands planted next to her head. She too was muscular, just very lean. The true strength she had couldn’t be guessed easily based on looks alone. She couldn’t help but smile fondly. Her girlfriend was perfect and just for her.

“Adora?”

“Hmm? You’re staring too. I never told you enough just how beautiful you are too”. Adora traced Catra’s nose when she looked away with a blush. “I know it’s not your favorite thing to be called, but it’s true. You deserve to know that at least”.

Catra sighed around a small smile. She carefully took Adora’s hair out of the ponytail and kept the hair tie around her wrist. Adora didn’t hesitate to pull her back into another kiss as one of her hands trailed down Catra’s stomach. She didn’t exactly want to wait longer, even if she was enjoying the slower pace.

Getting the hint, Catra shifted to straddle one of Adora’s thighs and spread her legs more to invite Adora lower. She took the invitation and smiled against Catra’s lips at the small shiver she got from barely brushing her fingertips over her clit. Being able to have her like this always felt special, regardless of how rough and fast or soft and slow.

Catra rocked her hips in search of a finger to slip into her. Maybe she was a little needier than she had thought. When Adora only teased at her entrance, seeming to enjoy just how wet she was, Catra retracted her claws and reached a hand down and slowly slid a finger into her. It didn’t take her long to be raising her hips into her hand with each thrust of her finger. Finally, Catra got the finger she was searching for slipped into her.

“I’m going to need more than that,” she whispered next to her ear and slid another into Adora.

A quiet moan fell from her lips before she could even think to answer. “It’s a little obvious with the way you’re nearly dripping”.

“Like you’re not?” She moaned into Adora’s ear softly when another was added into her as well. “Do you want a third?”

“N-not yet,” she stammered at the sudden hook she felt. “Do you?”

“I can wait.”

It seemed Adora forgot how to do much when the hooked fingers kept hitting her favorite spot. Catra took that matter into her own hands rolled her hips into Adora’s hand.

“Fuck,” Adora nearly whimpered and dug her fingers that weren’t being ridden into Catra’s back. “Don’t… don’t stop”.

“Oh, I won’t,” she responded breathlessly and nipped at her jaw. “Don’t you… worry about that”.

Adora regained a little of her composure and twitched her fingers inside of Catra. When all she got was a quiet grunt, she did it again. And again. And on every thrust she took. When she slipped a third finger into her, she got the reaction she wanted in the form of a needy whimper and claws digging into the metal by her

head. Catra may have been on top of her, but she still knew how to push her buttons in the right way.

Catra's bit down over the scar on Adora's shoulder gently. Adora stilled her hand and smirked at the growl she got for the action. Catra stilled her own fingers and shot a glare at her girlfriend and the smirk she still had on her face.

"Oh, no," Adora teased. "I'm so scared. What are you going to do? Bite me again?"

"That seems to be what you want, Adora. Or am I mistaken?"

"Not at all".

"Good." She rolled her hips into Adora's hand and let out a moan when the three fingers inside of her curled.

Catra returned to fingering Adora slow and hard while she kissed over the scar. It was still the only time she enjoyed drawing blood from her. She felt Adora add her thumb into the mix, rubbing small circles against her clit. Her breathing became heavy with moans and whimpers with soft growls laced in. Adora's free hand came to the back of her head and held her still. Catra took the hint and bit down, the thrusts she was giving becoming rougher.

Adora dug her head back into the pile of clothes as her breathing hitched. The best kind of sharp pain finally struck her shoulder and radiated through her neck. The closer Catra got to her peak, the harder she bit down, every bit of pressure giving way to pain and pleasure. Adora would only ever say it hurt in the best way imaginable, almost always sending her over the edge herself.

"Catra… I want…" she grabbed a handful of her hair to continue to hold her in place. "I need to… c-can I-"

Catra's ear flicked and she let out a short exhale through her nose. She was trying to hold off finishing around Adora's fingers driving into her and hooking. She was also sure what the unfinished question was. The shift from what was a simple want into what sounded like a definite need left her a little confused. It didn't work like that for normal *human* people. That was a question for later. For now, she needed to come up with some kind of response, even with her orgasm harder and harder to fight off.

The only thing she could come up with was a muffled, "mmmhm".

Catra's eyebrows scrunched as she hit her peak when Adora bit down on her shoulder. As she came down, she carefully released her hold and held the back of Adora's head to hold her in place when she tried to move as well. It already hurt plenty, but if Adora wanted or needed to do it, she was going to help her through as much as possible without letting on how much pain was involved.

“No, no. Keep going,” she whispered. “Don’t be afraid to hurt me. I’ll be okay”. She tried to hold off the hiss of pain. “Y-you need to bite harder. You’re doing good”.

Catra continued to coax her through it. Blunt teeth needed far more effort, causing far more pain. She gasped when she felt her skin finally start to give way. Adora released the pressure to pull back despite Catra’s hand on the back of head and immediately had a finger pressed to her lips to silence the apology.

“Hold on.” Catra quickly traced a claw over the indents Adora left to scratch her skin open before resting on both of her elbows again. “There. Keep going. You only barely broke the skin”.

“Are you sure?” Adora stroked her cheek. “Because if it hurts too much-“

“It’ll be easier now. I broke the skin further for you. Keep going, Adora”. She winced a little as Adora bit down again and she felt her skin break more. Clawing the skin open a little for her was definitely the right move, regardless of the pain she was still being faced with. “Th-there you go. Good job, love. Now just… stay there for a second”.

She carefully rolled onto her back, bringing Adora with her so she was now the one on top. Catra gently stroked her hair while a few tears of pain slipped before tapping the back of her head gently, telling her to let go. She sucked in a sharp breath as she did.

“I’m sorry,” Adora said and wiped the stray tears from Catra’s face. “Why didn’t you tell me to stop if it hurt that bad?”

“Maybe I wanted it,” she whispered back and sat up with her in her lap to wrap her arms around her while Adora’s legs wrapped around her hips. “It’s never an obligation to return it, but it’s… I dunno… official or something? Did you mean to want to say you needed to do that?”

“I… I felt like I need to. I don’t know.” She looked away. “It’s just… I didn’t mean to make you cry from the pain.“

“I told you it was going to hurt me more than it hurt you. You have blunt teeth”. She rubbed her cheek against her neck while a purr started in her chest. “There’s a reason I walked you through it and clawed it open. But we’re going to sit here for a bit, okay? We both need to stop bleeding, especially you with the white shirt”.

“Catra?”

“Hmm?” She pulled back a little to look at her.

“I love you”. Adora traced the bite she gave, wiping away some of the blood while a tear traveled down her cheek. “So, *so* much”.

“Hey, why are you crying?” Catra gently wiped her tears away. “I’m okay. Really. Shhh”.

“I’m… I’m not sad,” she chuckled and wiped more tears from her cheeks. “I’m just so happy, Catra. It’s a little overwhelming right now”.

“Not overwhelming enough for She-Ra,” she teased.

“Who’s saying I’m not fighting it?” Adora smiled rested her chin on Catra’s shoulder. “Maybe I just want to be… me right now. Regardless of what *she* wants.”

“You mean, regardless of what the magic in you wants.” She chuckled. “But I’ll let you win this once, princess. We’re still sitting here for a little bit, though.”

Glimmer blinked at the two ex-soldiers running up one of the paths. None of the other ones were wearing armor so the scene was a little confusing. The confusion went away the moment one tackled the other to the ground only to have feet planted on their stomach and kicked away. She knew the way Adora would fight back if Catra tackled her. Glimmer’s assumption was proven correct the moment Catra threw her helmet off after a yelp of clear pain. Adora quickly helped her up before taking her own helmet off. Glimmer teleported over with her arms folded. She waited while Adora helped Catra get the armor off and finally

noticed the the reason for the pained reaction when her tail was freed from being tucked up in the top.

"They never made a set for me after all of those years," she muttered and rubbed her lower back at the base of her tail.

"You said you'd be fine," Adora said while taking off her own armor off. "Are you sure you're okay?"

"It's not bad. Just sore. I was fine until I landed like that".

"You two…" Glimmer sighed. "Where have you been?"

"Raiding the storage room," Adora said with a smile. "I can't believe all of this is still here".

Catra picked up the shock baton from the utility belt of the armor and turned it on. "Hey, Adora, remember training?"

"Oh, no". Adora backed away. "Don't you dare".

"You… you really shocked each other during training?" Glimmer asked.

“Sometimes, yes,” Catra answered. “We would spar with them. Along with these”. She grabbed the staff from the belt and extended it.

Glimmer stared between them as Adora grabbed and extended the staff from the other belt with a smirk. “We are not doing this!”

“My money’s on Catra!” Kyle yelled as he ran over with several other ex-soldiers.

“You wish!” Lonnie laughed. “Adora has this in the bag”.

Glimmer groaned loudly and put her head in her hands. The way Catra and Adora smirked at each other had trouble written all over it.

“Do you really think they’re going to?” Bow whispered.

All Glimmer did was gesture to the small circle around their friends as they circled each other.

“Don’t hold back, princess ,” Catra said and tossed the shock baton away and put the staff in the middle of the circle with Adora.

“Oh, weapon retrieval too? You better not hold back either”.

The two stepped away from the staffs and nodded at each other when they were ready. Adora made the first move and the little circle erupted in cheers as the two met each other in the middle, quickly exchanging blows. Adora was the first to pick up a staff and took a swing at Catra only to be tackled back with a shoulder to her stomach. Catra rolled off and ran for the second staff. She picked it up and turned just in time to block the swing taken at her head. Glimmer winced when Catra’s foot made contact with Adora’s ribs. She barely dodged the elbow to the head that followed.

The two continued back and forth, somehow still smiling through the bloody noses and busted lips. After a brief pause and Adora yelling at Catra about holding back, the claws finally came out between swings of staffs. Adora had plenty of superficial scratches, yet not enough to show any loss of skill. They were both still very much in fighting shape, clearly proving why they held the positions they did.

“What are the rules?!” Glimmer finally shouted.

Scorpia turned to her, “well, normally, we would get these sensor pads and we had points during training scenarios. Lose the points, and you’re out. I’ve watched these two plenty. They don’t play around.” She crossed her arms. “It would always come down to who got tired and sloppy first”.

“Are we going to stop them?” Bow asked, growing more worried with the sudden exchange of hits and yells from his friends. “Or are we going to let them kill each other?”

Catra hit the ground with a grunt and got to her feet slower than her normal bounce back. She held her staff in both hands to block the swing Adora took at her head again. Adora continued to put pressure down as she watched Catra’s arms slowly seem to give out.

“You done?” Adora asked around her heavy breathing.

“You wish”. Catra shoved her back and kicked the side of her knee.

Adora held her knee for a moment and still took a swing at Catra. She used the swing as a spring board and came down at her with the staff over her head. Adora fell to her back and blocked the strike. She rolled back and planted her feet into Catra’s stomach and kicked her back, quickly following through with a jab.

The whole circle gasped, groaned in sympathy, and flinched when Catra grabbed the staff and yanked Adora forward and drove her elbow into her chest. Adora fell back, dropping her staff on the way down. She felt the tip of a staff poke her forehead and looked up to see Catra standing over her.

“I win”.

“Yeah,” Adora groaned and sat up holding her chest. “You do. Let me heal myself and I’ll get you”.

“N-no. That’s fine. Really”. Catra rubbed her shoulder. “I’ll survive”.

Adora got to her feet slowly and whispered to her, “don’t worry about that. I won’t heal it, just like I don’t heal mine. Okay?” She wiped blood from Catra’s lip. “Let me fix you up. I beat the shit out of you”.

“You owe me fifty!” Kyle exclaimed while Lonnie dug in her pocket and handed the money over.

The rest of the circle passed the money they owed to others. Glimmer rubbed her temples while Adora was healing herself and then Catra. Bow finally opened his eyes and brought his hands from his face, sighing in relief when both of his friends were very much alive.

“What. The. Fuck!” Glimmer yelled and grabbed them both by the front of the shirt when they walked over, both laughing. “Are you insane?!”

“A little, yeah, probably.” Catra raised her eyebrow. “Why?”

“Who does that for fun?!”

“Us, obviously,” Adora stated with another laugh. “That was fun”.

Glimmer let them go and yelled in frustration. “ *Fun* ?! ”

“Looks like you still got it,” Lonnie said as she walked over. “You cost me fifty, though”.

Adora shrugged sheepishly. “It’s not my fault she’s still got it too. She… clearly became commander for a reason”.

“Could have been both of you if you stayed”.

A low growl rose from Catra’s chest as she turned. “That’s over!”

“Woah, okay”. Adora put herself between them and held Catra’s face. “She didn’t mean it like that. Really, she’s probably right. You know that as well as I do. If things didn’t go they we they did, everything we talked about long ago would have probably happened. But we’re getting better, right? That’s behind us”.

Catra took a couple of deep breaths and pushed her hands away. “I know”.

“What’s this?” Lonnie folded her arms with a smirk. “Working on the temper?”

“Yes, I am! Okay?” Catra rubbed her face. “Really, I am. Sometimes it’s harder without Melog around.”

“Melog?”

“They’re… some magic being from a planet called Krytis. They, uh,” she rubbed the back of her neck, “they reflect what I’m feeling. It’s easier to keep myself in check that way sometimes. I’m trying to be better but there are times…”

Lonnie nodded. “Well… keep it up. The war’s over. Be happy for a change.”

“I’m working on it.”

“Then laugh and smile more around more than just me,” Adora teased and bumped her shoulder. “Trust me. It helps.”

Glimmer stepped between Adora and Catra. “Both of you, listen carefully. None of *that* happens at the party. There’s going to be more people than just the Princess Alliance who won’t understand your absolute insane definition of fun. At all. Got it?”

The two shrugged and nodded.

"Hey, thanks for the help today," Lonnie said. "From all of you. And… it was nice to catch up, Adora. Catra… I'd like to talk more with you someday too. I'm, uh, sorry we didn't get started on the right foot today".

"Yeah. Me too".

The group of four said their goodbyes for the evening and started towards Darla's ramp. It wasn't a long ride back, but long enough that Catra hopped up onto the ledge of a window and laid back. While some clean up was tiring in itself, the emotional toll was greater. Not to mention the lovemaking she had with Adora on the roof. And their little sparing match.

She watched quietly as Adora stretched and sat in her chair to get the ship moving. Thankfully they could all just get back and go to bed since Scorpia also provided them dinner. Her eyes slowly drifted closed as she listened to Bow, Glimmer, and Adora chatting about more party things.

Chapter End Notes

> For the smut skippers: honestly, it's just rooftop smut. They call each other beautiful a lot and just simply admire each other. The important stuff is actually post smut for a change.
>
> S: I don't have much. Work was extra stupid this past week and the poor new guy got thrown into the shit show. Oh, I

also got a new tattoo on a whim today so that's about how exciting my life is. And kinda where I'm at mentally. Still not in enough of a depressive episode to finish my rib piece (which could be seen as a good thing) but ya know…

Also if anything seems to flow funky, I'm sorry I didn't catch it. This one got reworked a few times during edits so I wouldn't be surprised if something got missed.

Indy: I hope everyone is doing well. I've been doing less well recently. Schoolwork has been falling behind and I'm kinda getting stressed about it. My mental health has been…ok for the most part. Working on this story has provided a nice outlet so I hope you like it. Outside of that I don't have much to report. I'm a pretty boring guy IRL lol. Stay safe and good luck for those who have to celebrate Easter with family. We hope to hear from you to know you survived.

Moving Forward

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's tail twitched beside her while she stared at the blank tapestry cloth in front of her. She knew what she wanted to do, yet it felt so hard. Really, she didn't think this kind of closure would be so difficult. Maybe this wasn't exactly *that* kind of project, but it was all she could come up to sorta symbolize herself. With a quiet huff she stood up just to sit herself next to Adora.

"Are you going to attempt to draw?"

Adora snorted. "No." She summoned her sword. "But I'm capable of tracing and coloring in the lines. How about you?"

Catra fiddled with the edge of Adora's tapestry. "You won't like it."

"I'm curious." She put her sword in the middle of the tapestry and picked up a paintbrush to dip into gold paint. "You don't have to tell me if you don't want to but-"

"Horde symbol," she blurred out quietly.

“Catra, no.” She put the paintbrush back down and turned to her girlfriend to hold her hands. “No. That’s not you anymore.”

Catra nodded and anxiously fiddled with Adora’s fingers. “That’s not all. But… you’ll see. It’s just hard, all of this. You all have something so good about yourselves and magic and I have-“

“Enough,” Adora said gently, yet firmly. “That’s enough. You have plenty of good too.” She held her face and rubbed her cheeks with her thumbs. “But I trust you, okay? I trust you to show all of us that the Horde… that’s not you anymore. Go on.” She pecked her lips. “Go paint.”

Catra nodded and stood. As she was walking back to her spot, she almost ran into Scorpia.

“Hey!” Scorpia greeted the group of princesses and their partners with a few cans of paint in her arms. “I found more paint! It’s… not the brightest of colors, but if you need it…”

“I’ll take it,” Catra said and grabbed a two of the cans from her arms. “It’s perfect”.

“Uhhhh?”

“Don’t worry about it”. She sat on her knees and pried the lids from the paint before grabbing one of the paintbrushes Perfuma

had given out. “Besides, Sparkles over there brought plenty of bright princess colors.”

Everyone worked on their own tapestries over small talk in an old Horde meeting room. Scorpia said it was the room with enough space for everyone where it didn’t matter how much paint got on the floor. Catra was mostly against it, having spent enough time in the room with other Force Captains. Still, she did have to agree there was more than enough room for everyone to paint and not be in each other’s way.

Adora carefully traced around her sword with gold before looking over the bottles of paint Perfuma brought. She grabbed a few of the bottles to fill in the sword and knelt back down next to her tapestry. Art was never her strongest ability. She worked quietly, trying to not rush through the task as she did with so many others.

Mermista quietly worked on a trident with the Pearl while her pirate boyfriend was enthusiastically painting a ship that was on fire. Not a single person was shocked. Perfuma worked on a rendition of the Heart Blossom while Glimmer was hard at work painting her Moonstone with wings reminiscent of Angella’s around it. Bow was carefully paining out a golden bow with a quiver full of arrows. Frosta was busy making sure the Fractal Flake was pained perfectly before even considering a border or background. Scorpia eventually found her own spot to work amongst the others to work on painting the Black Garnet, though her pincers were proving a little difficult to work with.

“How does one even paint wind?” Spinerella asked no one in particular.

“You could always do a pink tornado,” Netossa recommended. “At least you can make it look nice. How do you make a net look… nice? It’s just lines!”

Catra was the only one with her back facing everyone else, preferring a corner of the room. She didn’t need anyone trying to talk her out of the bright red Horde insignia painted over the middle of her tapestry.

“Why don’t you join the rest of us?” Perfuma asked. “We won’t judge whatever you’re making”.

“No,” she chuckled and glanced over her shoulder. “You will. At least until I’m done with it”.

“At least you have it figured out!” Entrapta said and continued to paint the silhouette of the Crypto Castle. “Hordak is just staring at his”.

Catra’s ear twitched as she looked over at him. So maybe there was one person who could theoretically copy her idea. The look on his face and the way his arms were crossed, told her that he was trying to avoid it. She turned her attention back to finishing up her basic, two toned design. Black background, red insignia.

She put her paintbrush down and drew her hand back before clawing five lines diagonally through the middle.

Adora glanced over at the sound of ripping fabric to see her tail lash against the ground a few times. She looked back at her tapestry and stood with Bow and Glimmer to go over to Catra. A soft gasp left the queen when she saw what had been painted, now with long claw marks ripped into it. The three knelt down around Catra as she wiped her nose with the back of her hand.

None of them caught the small smile on Catra's face when they hugged her, Bow and Glimmer on either side and Adora behind her. Adora kissed the back of her head with a smile of her own. She knew what it meant. Catra let go of her past. Closure. Maybe now she could really, truly start to put it behind her for good.

"I'm proud of you," Adora whispered and kissed the back of her head again. "You needed this, didn't you?"

Catra nodded and wrapped an arm around Bow and Glimmer at her sides. She tilted her head back into Adora's chest. "You have no idea".

The group slowly gathered their things after letting the painted cloths dry enough to be moved and made their way to Horror Hall to help the old soldiers with decorations. The party was the next day and if all they had to worry about was food and drink, that would be ideal. Adora realized the height the tapestries would be at and shifted into She-Ra and groaned. She still didn't have enough height to reach an old hook in the wall.

“You know it’s bad when She-Ra needs a ladder,” Lonnie joked.

“Who needs a ladder when I have a Catra,” Adora said and smiled down at her girlfriend whose tail puffed slightly.

“Uh, no”. Catra tried to take a step back when she was grabbed by the waist and lifted into the air. “Adora, put me down!”

“Oh, come on. Help me out here”. She put her on her shoulders. “Can you reach?”

Catra let out a short growl at the snickers from old and new friends still on the ground. She took Adora’s tapestry, a white background with a basic gold edge and her sword point up in the middle, and stood on her shoulders. Adora held her ankles as she got the tapestry hung before sitting herself back on her shoulders.

“Next?” She mumbled with her hand out.

She was given Memista’s next, a light blue background with a dark blue waved edge, her trident dead center with the Pearl resting on the middle point. Catra held Adora’s head as she shifted over a few feet and hoped the next couple of old hooks were useable. Again, she stood on her girlfriend’s shoulders to hang the tapestry.

The process continued with Sea Hawk's burning ship going next to Mermista's. Following that was Entrapta's painting of Crypto Castle. Catra raised her eyebrow at Hordak's crystal painting before hanging it up.

"Loved, huh?" Adora said and looked at him while Catra sat herself back down. "Any reason?"

He looked to Entrapta with a fond smile. "Someone once told me that my imperfections are… beautiful".

Everyone stared at him for a moment. Catra cleared her throat to stifle any kind of laugh and accepted Frosta's tapestry of the Fractal Flake on a white background trimmed with light blue ice points next. Out of all of the things he could have come up with, he chose the sappy route. Something about it seemed a little funny to her. He was a warlord that Entrapta managed to turn into a guy with a softer side than he let on. In a way, not too much unlike herself with Adora.

At least she could still try to keep some sort of front up in public.

Adora only smiled as Catra stood on her shoulders again and held her ankles. Hordak having a soft, almost sweet side was a little jarring. However, it was welcomed, showing that he had also changed for the better. She walked over to Scorpia's new polished steel throne and handed Catra their friend's painting of the Black Garnet with a bright red border to hang over it.

Perfuma's pained Heart Blossom with a green and floral border was hung next to her girlfriend's. Bow's was hung next, followed by Glimmers. A sad sigh left Catra, knowing exactly why the wings were around the Moonstone. Netossa and Spinnerella's were next, a net dome and a pink tornado respectively. Adora handed her the last one, hers. She didn't particularly want it on display, but it did signify plenty. Adora walked them back over to the left of her own and squeezed Catra's leg.

"It's alright. Hang it up," Adora encouraged. "Your own little story deserves to be up there with the rest of us. Even Hordak's is".

Catra groaned and got to her feet again. Vulnerability still wasn't exactly her thing. She finally hung her tapestry and ran her fingers over the rips and a true smile came to her face. All of that was behind her. She knew it wouldn't completely ease her mind of the guilt she still carried or the painful memories, but it was a start. Instead of sitting back down, Adora held out her arms and she jumped to land in them before being set back on her feet.

"I'm not doing that again," she said and poked Adora's stomach. "Get a ladder next time. What's next?" She looked around at everyone looking at her. "What?"

A smile came to Lonnie's face as she, along with Kyle and Rogelio, ran over to her and gave her a hug. Catra's complaints only continued as a few of the princesses joined while Adora transformed back and chuckled.

“No! Gah! Get off!” Catra squirmed and eventually ducked down and slid away from the group, backing into Scorpia. “Don’t-“

“Too late,” Scorpia said and picked her up in a tight hug.

“Alright… okay. That’s… that’s quite enough”. She took a deep breath when she was finally released. “It’s not that big of a deal. I feel better, okay? Just… drop it”.

Catra helped with moving long tables into place along one of the walls while others continued to put up various decorations. Perfuma added several vases filled with many types of flowers on the tables. Her attention briefly shifted to Adora as She-Ra and shook her head when she lifted an old soldier up in each hand to get some miscellaneous flags hung up. She just had to show off sometimes.

“So, you and She-Ra, huh?” Lonnie asked as they grabbed another table to move.

“Yeah, I guess so. I still get shocked by it all sometimes. After… everything. What about you?”

“Nah, I don’t have time for that. I already have my own little family”. She nodded at Rogelio and Kyle sitting on the floor playing with Imp. “They more or less adopted him after Hordak was gone. It’s been going well, actually. You two?”

“What?” Catra practically hissed. “No. Oh, no no no. We have too much to work through still. Together and… personally”. They set down the table and she rubbed the back of her neck. “We, uh, both get nasty nightmares sometimes. Flashbacks. Occasionally we argue about things, the other slipping into old habits”.

“I guess I’m not all that surprised.”

“There was one time we really got into it”. Catra cleared her throat. She hated remembering their biggest fight since the Heart. “She went She-Ra on me. I dunno, something in me snapped at that, I saw it as a threat”.

“Did you really hurt her, Catra?” Lonnie slapped the back of her head.

“Hey! No. Not physically, at least”. She looked over to her girlfriend who now had a round table over her head to not accidentally hit people as she carried it. “I threatened it, damn near promised it. But I ended up walking away, going as far to keep going when she asked me to stay. I hid away from her specifically for the rest of the night and the entire next day and night. I went to meals later than everyone and didn’t go to bed with her. But we eventually talked and cried it out”.

“Hey, she walked away from you too, you know”.

“We… made a promise to each other. Stay means stay now. Except for that fight”.

“Damn, Catra”. She gave her a gentle shove. “You gotta knock that shit off. But I really am glad you two found each other again… and able to remember everything from before. I can’t imagine…”

Catra only nodded and folded her arms as she watched over the organized chaos of everyone doing something. Decorations were going up everywhere and no one was really listening to Scorpia’s attempts at delegating. Eventually her friend gave up and joined in the fun of decorating. Catra was caught up in trying to figure out what she could even help with next when she felt a sharp snap under her chin.

“Ow! What the fuck?”

“Party hats!” Bow exclaimed with a smile.

“No!” Catra took it off and threw it at him. “I’m vetoing it!”

“Awww come on! It’s like a third ear for you!”

“Absolutely not!”

Adora chuckled at the small commotion Bow brought upon himself. She warned him Catra would never agree to it. Before she knew it, her girlfriend was chasing him down. As she ran by, Adora scooped her up and held her at arm's length.

"I'm gonna kill him if he puts another one on me!" She growled. "Put me down!"

"Please don't hurt him. Calm down".

Catra scoffed and tried to wiggle out of the strong hold of her warrior girlfriend. She wasn't going to actually hurt him. Much.

"Catra".

She brought her foot up and pushed against Adora's forearm to try to break the hold. Eventually she just gave up and sighed.

"There. That's better". Adora set her down and kissed the top of her head. "We'll go to bed here in a little bit".

"I'm not sleeping in the bunks," she muttered as she walked off to find something to do that didn't involve maiming Bow.

"I never said you had to!" Adora called to her with a chuckle.

They had all collectively decided to spend the night in the Fright Zone instead of making another trip back the very next day. It took a lot of convincing from Scorpia, but when Perfuma backed her up about it being not terrible, agreements started to happen. They at least had the option to stay in the rooms Darla had.

It wasn't long until Catra sat in a corner with a yawn. She decided to watch the last of the chaos unfold from a distance. Someone was going to get hurt. Entrapta had climbed onto a ladder that someone finally retrieved and Adora lifted it over her head so she could rig some lights to the ceiling. Frosta was, surprisingly, the one who urged them to not do this, offering to make ice stairs leading up. Adora being herself, insisted.

Glimmer was busy rubbing her temples, trying to not kill either of them for their stupidity while Bow had his hands in his hair, clearly stressed for their safety. When Perfuma walked back into Horror Hall, Catra swore she had an aneurysm from the sight.

"She-Ra! What in the hell are you doing?!"

Catra flinched with a chuckle. Perfuma never swore.

"Uh, lights?"

“Put Entrapta down this instant! There are at least two of us who can get her up there *safely*!“

“I’m almost done!” Entrapta yelled down. “Step to your left! Okay, okay. I need just a little more reach!”

Adora huffed and stood on her tiptoes.

“She-Ra! I mean it!”

“Don’t worry, Perfuma! Just this last wire!” Entrapta shouted a last, “aha!”

Adora finally lowered the ladder back down carefully with a triumphant smile.

“For the record, I offered to help,” Frosta said with her hand up.

“I cannot believe you!” Perfuma took a deep breath. “Scorpia, is there a reason you were okay with this?”

“I, um, I wasn’t exactly for this? I know I didn’t stop it, but… you have to admit that was pretty cool”.

“You Horde people are not okay!” Glimmer shouted and teleported into the air to smack Adora upside the head.

“We were child soldiers. What do you expect?” Catra piped up.

“Not to mention Shadow Weaver,” Lonnie added.

Glimmer stormed up to Hordak. “And you let this happen?!”

“We were trying to win a war. We did what we had to”.

She groaned loudly and started to walk back to Darla, shouting as she went, “I’m going to bed!”

Adora transformed back and yawned. Turning in for the night didn’t sound half bad and looking around, it seemed everyone shared the same sentiment. Just maybe a lot less irritated than Glimmer. Catra got up and stretched before walking up to Adora and taking her hand. Everyone slowly dispersed Horror Hall in search of where they wanted to sleep. Most of the princesses made their way back to Darla while Frosta, Mermista, and Sea Hawk decided to follow Catra, Adora, and a few ex-soldiers to the barracks.

“Hey, where are you two going?” Mermista asked as she stood next to one of the bunks.

“The Force Captain wing. I’m… not sleeping in here again,” Catra said as she glanced at her old bunk. “I can’t”.

“Come on. Just one more ni…” Adora trailed off as she finally saw her old ripped up mattress.

Catra dropped Adora’s hand and held her tail as she kept walking. She stopped at another door with her heart in her throat and quickly tapped a few keys to open the way to the Force Captain wing. She barely heard Adora whisper her name as the door closed behind her.

“Are you okay?” Mermista asked as Adora continued to stare at the claw marks over the thin mattress.

“Y-yeah. I…” she took a deep breath as she looked to their little drawings and her heart sank, “I really, really hurt her. I mean, I knew that but I didn’t know… this”.

“Okay? So she got pissed off and shredded her bed. It’s over”.

“This was my bed!” She snapped. “I’m surprised they never changed it over for someone else, but… Catra probably never let them. She didn’t even let them give my locker room anyone else.”

“Oh…” Mermista glanced at the shredded bed again. “Well, uh, goodnight. I hope you two can get some sleep. If not, there’s always that ship of yours”.

Adora sighed and walked to the door to knock on it. She knew she didn’t have access to anything anymore. To her surprise, it actually opened on the first try and Catra pulled her through. She followed behind quietly and waited while she punched in numbers on another keypad to open her old bedroom door. So maybe she did still have some access if Catra’s numbers still worked.

Adora took in the small bedroom. Catra had her own bathroom at least and actual storage with a small dresser and closet. Her bed was still neatly made. However, the marks of her anger and hurt still lingered on the walls in the form of deep gouges and, from what she could see of the bathroom, the broken mirror too. There were dried bloodstains on the bedding and a knot formed in her throat.

“Catra, I-“

“Don’t. Don’t you dare apologize. I don’t want- I *can’t* argue about any of this right now. We don’t have to stay in here, but I… I already wanted to get some things”.

“I want to”.

Catra turned towards her, confused.

Adora wiped a tear from her face and looked away, hugging herself. "I hurt you. How… how many cold, lonely nights did you have in here? How many times did you cry yourself to sleep and *I wasn't there* ? I don't want to argue, but Catra, let me give you at least one warm night in this place again".

"This is behind us now," Catra said quietly and opened the closet.

"Catra, please!" She cried. "I can't… I can't just see all of this and let it go! I *left*. I hurt you more than I ever realized at the time! Please…"

Catra sighed and closed the closet before walking up to Adora and wrapping her arms around her while she cried.

"I'm sorry," she whispered around her tears. "I'm so sorry. One night… it isn't going to make what I did hurt less, but please, Catra, *please* … I can't just… ignore all of this. I can't…"

Catra rubbed her back gently and continued to hold her close. She had to admit, she didn't quite remember the exact state she had left her room. If she did, she would have never suggested it in the first place. Her belongings could wait.

She gently backed Adora into the bed and made her sit down. Adora's arms wrapped around her hips as she cried against her

stomach. Catra came to know Adora never truly meant to hurt her the way she perceived at the time. It happened and now they had to move past it, even if slowly.

Seeing her room had clearly ripped open some wound deep down for Adora. She knew, without a doubt, she hurt Catra. She's known for years. The full extent of that is what she was in the dark about. And now, she saw what happened behind the scenes, the pain she was directly responsible for. No words from anyone, not even the pieces she could drag from Catra, would have been enough. Somehow, physically seeing it hurt far worse than being told.

"Breathe, Adora," she said gently and took her hair tie out. "We're getting better. You're alright".

"None of this is okay". She looked up to meet mismatched eyes. "It's not".

Catra sighed and crouched in front of her. "Yes, I cried myself to sleep a lot. I missed you. I hurt myself. I don't have a lot of good memories from here after you left. But, Adora," she wiped the tears from her face with her thumbs, "we have each other back. If you really want to give me one warm night in this room for at least one small, good memory, we can stay in here. Is that really what you want to do?"

Adora nodded in between her hands.

“Okay. Now let’s get you calmed down, alright? I’m sure I still have a cup in here. Do you want some water?“

Adora nodded again and sniffled when Catra stood up and went into the bathroom. She wiped her eyes with a sigh as she heard a cup being rinsed out and filled with water.

“It still doesn’t taste the best compared to Bright Moon, but it’s not… bad”. She gave the cup to her and tucked some hair behind her ear. “I love you”.

“I love you too”. She said quietly and took a drink. “Well, the water still tastes how I remember it”.

Catra chuckled softly and took the cup to set on the small dresser before coming back to toss the blanket open. She let Adora get under the covers first and joined quickly after. The mattress was definitely as hard as she remembered, yet still better than the bunks.

Adora laid her head on Catra’s chest with a quiet sigh. She hated what she saw. At least now she could at least try to ease the heaviness she just knew her girlfriend was feeling, yet not showing.

She gently slid a hand up the front of her shirt and drug her nails lightly through the short fur of her stomach before simply gently petting it. Adora slowly moved her hand to her side to

comfortingly trail her fingers up and down. She decided she wasn't going to leave here without her having something better to remember about this room.

"Where are you going?" Catra asked as Adora sat up.

"Nowhere. I know being here isn't easy for you either". She shoved her over onto her side and snuggled back down behind her. "So this is what we're gonna do".

Catra gave in with a smile and pressed herself back into Adora's front further. Maybe she would let herself have at least one good night in her old room. And a good morning when she woke up next to Adora, something she never once got to do in that room.

Adora slowly blinked awake and squinted at the clock on the dresser for a time. It was blank, having been unplugged. She could only guess that it was rather early, knowing her internal clock. Catra stirred a little in her arms, yet remained asleep as she tried to move her arm from under her head. Fearing she would accidentally wake her up, she left it in place. A numb hand was worth it.

Instead of trying to get back to sleep, she gently pulled Catra closer and carefully looked around the room. Adora, now not overcome with emotion, noticed how little was in the room. She had all of the basic things; a clock that she had clearly unplugged at some point and a small stack of paper on the top of her

dresser, a shock baton attached to the wall by the door, the usual staff under the pillow. It seemed the only thing that wasn't standard issue was a few of her spare belts hanging by the closet. That and the many claw marks over the walls.

Adora gently kissed the back of her head. She wondered what things Catra had even wanted from her room if pretty much all of it was the standard things all Force Captains were given. A soft, choppy purr came from beside her and pulled her from her thoughts.

"Morning".

"Mmmm. Hey, Adora". Catra stretched and rolled over. "You stayed".

"Of course I did". She gave her a quick kiss. "And we both slept through the night. I think".

"I woke up once," she admitted and stroked Adora's cheek. "Just to pee. That had to be the first night here in years that I didn't have a nightmare at all".

"As much as I would love to take credit, you had nightmares when I was still here too".

She chuckled and brushed their noses together. “I still think you had something to do with it”.

Adora pulled her arm free and made a few fists to get feeling back in her hand when Catra rolled to her back. “What do you want from in here anyhow?”

“I have some things in the drawers and the closet. It’s really not a lot. Would you have decorated at all?”

“I would have put up a couple of pictures or something”. She kissed her cheek. “I probably would have had you come draw on the wall. And given you my access code”.

“It’s not that hard to guess, dummy”.

“Neither is yours. Which means… I do have access around here still!” Adora rolled on top of her and rested her elbows by her head.

“You still know my favorite number? How embarrassing”.

“I still know a lot of things”. Adora kissed her softly. “I know where your favorite hiding spots are, which shower stall your preferred because it held hot water the longest, where you hid ration bars you stole, your favorite spots to drag me off to”.

“Man, that really is embarrassing for you,” she teased and rested her hands at Adora’s hips. “But thanks for the one warm night in here”.

“Who said we had to stop making better memories for you?” Adora kissed the side of her neck. “We have almost all day”.

Catra sighed and ran a hand up her back. “Not right now, okay? It’s still a lot for me, being in here again”.

“Not really in the mood, huh?” Adora sat up, straddling her hips.

She shook her head and rubbed Adora’s thighs. “Sorry”.

“No, don’t apologize. I’m… not exactly in the mood either. I just know it doesn’t take either of us long to get there if we want to. I just thought-“

“You already gave me one good memory in here. I fell asleep in your arms and woke up the same way. If we’re out here again, maybe we can make another new one. For now, I’m content with this”.

Adora smiled at her and got out of bed. As much as she definitely still wanted to at least cuddle a little longer, her bladder said

otherwise. Catra got out of bed once the bathroom door closed and quickly made it out of habit. With a quiet sigh, she opened one of the drawers and took out a few photographs of her and Adora as well as one of their cadet squad she kept for whatever reason.

As she was going through her closet, Adora rejoined her. “Bringing the suit?”

“Of course I am. I’m not wearing it today, but I want it back. And this”. She pulled out the old jacket she got from the Crimson Waste and put it on. “Unfortunately, Sparkles destroyed my whip during one of our fights”.

Adora walked over to the dresser and picked up the few photos. “Awww. You kept our… actually rather unflattering cadet squad picture”.

“Put those down!” Catra grabbed her wrist. “Please”.

“The rest can’t be that bad”.

“Okay. Fine. I kept a couple of… us. But I ripped one in half”. She let go of Adora’s wrist. “I’ll tape it back together when we get home”.

Adora looked at the two halves under the cadet picture sadly. It wasn't long after that picture was taken that she had left, two weeks at most. It was ripped in two right between their faces. She carefully tucked the two pieces behind the first to move onto the third picture. A rather fun memory when they took the camera from a guard and ran off with it to snap a picture together, their tongues out. They couldn't have been older than eleven.

Catra pulled her suit from the closet and draped it over her arm. "Come on, let's get back to Darla so I can drop this stuff off before we eat".

Chapter End Notes

S: I'm really sorry I didn't get to comments this week! Life got busy with work and my mental stuff and I just kinda needed some time to reset a little. But this still got posted on Saturday, just a little later than I was originally planning for. Part of the main quest in a video game took a lot longer than I was hoping for… in any case, I hope this one was at least a little enjoyable.

Also, for anyone that's doing anything for the eclipse on Monday, stay safe! My area is going to be experiencing totality so I know the traffic and everything else is going to be insane out here.

One of us will be answering last week's comments tonight. Sorry again about that. Life… can be life sometimes.

Stay safe, enjoy the rest of the weekend, and try to have a good week next week!

Indy: Hello everyone. To mirror my coauthor, life has been a lot recently. I've been more subject to anxiety attacks and so that's been fun. School has been doing a great job and making me forget about comments and I'm really sorry for not replying sooner.

I’m also in the path of totality for the eclipse which is gonna be super exciting. Let’s hope it’s not cloudy lol. Other than that my birthday is soon and I’m hoping to have a good day (I work so pbbbbbt but I need money lol).

I really hope you all enjoy this chapter and everyone stay safe and know you’re loved!

Party Time: Part One

Chapter Notes

There is some minor smut in this one.
Starts at:

Catra quickly had her pinned up the against the side of the building, not hesitating with a deep, almost bruising kiss. Adora was startled at first, but quickly returned it, tugging at her hips. This wasn't exactly the place she had in mind for finally getting relief, but Catra gave up the game. Adora's hands quickly ran up her body in search of another button to pop open while Catra bunched her dress up around her hips.

Ends at:

"See you on the dance floor, love".

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora finished putting her hair up just as the bathroom door slid open. She watched Catra as she walked out while finishing the last two buttons of her shirt. She'd only ever seen her wear white two other times, one of which was a far less than pleasant memory.

A memory she swore she was reliving.

Her mind registered the shirt was a perfectly fitted button down with the sleeves rolled to her elbows. Whatever jumpsuit Prime had her in was far too tight to roll the sleeves. Catra tamed her hair for the party, that was evident. Unfortunately, she had slicked it back. Adora took a step back.

“Adora? Are you okay?”

“Huh?” Adora finally looked to her face and let out a shaky breath when her gaze met blue and yellow instead of that electric green.

“You’re shaking and I can hear your ragged breathing from here. Are you okay?”

Catra held out her hands with concern evident on her face. Adora’s hands came to her face before her fingers threaded in her hair.

“No,” Adora whispered as she started messing up Catra’s hair. “No, no, no. Catra…”

“Look at me.” Catra gently grabbed her wrists. “Adora, my eyes are up here. Look at me.”

“Don’t… don’t do that again,” she again whispered and looked at her eyes. “Please. It’s about as long as it was… *that* day now. I just… it’s too much. Especially with you in white. Just… don’t. Please, Catra.”

Catra nodded slowly. “I’m sorry. I didn’t… I just thought… It didn’t bother me so I guess I didn’t think it would bother you. I won’t do

it again.”

She wrapped her arms around Adora when she embraced her tightly. Catra was no stranger to the kind of fear she saw in Adora’s face. Nightmares, panic attacks, PTSD episodes. They were different, but the fear and near horror in her face was always there. Thankfully, this time was easier to remedy and remained brief. Adora stopped trembling after a few minutes and pressed kisses to Catra’s cheeks.

“You look beautiful, Adora.”

Adora opted to not wear the gold belt with the red dress or the hair piece she wore to Frosta’s prom. She pulled back a little to look over her girlfriend and smiled. Now that her hair was a little messier, she looked like herself. She also fully noticed how sinfully fitted the dress shirt was.

“You… you look really nice too. I, uh, I-I like the, um, th-that” she stammered as a blush dusted her cheeks, “that shirt. I really like the shirt.”

“Mmmhm. I’m sure you do. You ready?”

Adora nodded and took Catra’s hand. The two walked to Horror Hall. They looked around at the small gathering that made it so far. It was quite a journey for many, but Catra learned enough

since she was out of the Horde to know most Etherians loved parties. She was sure Horror Hall was going to be full soon.

"There you two are!" Glimmer said as she teleported over and hugged Catra with a groan. "I'm starting to think the Fright Zone was a bad idea."

Catra gave Bow a confused look as she halfheartedly patted Glimmer's back while keeping her other hand raised.

"Oh, she's just worried no one's gonna show up because it's the Fright Zone," he explained when he walked over. "I keep telling her people are traveling".

"He's not wrong," Adora agreed. "Bright Moon is about ten minutes with Darla. A lot of people are probably walking".

"I've arrived with some punch!" Sea Hawk announced as he walked in dressed in a full tuxedo for whatever reason.

Mermista followed him in while shaking her head, dressed in a simple teal blouse and long skirt.

"He wouldn't listen," she said around a groan and stopped following her boyfriend to find a table.

Catra jumped back when Glimmer finally let go and put Adora between herself and Sea Hawk. He turned a little too quick to avoid running into another guest and the liquid sloshed around in the bowl. Thankfully nothing actually spilled but the close call and proximity wasn't a chance Catra wanted to play with.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked.

"I'm wearing white. And it's Sea Hawk. I don't trust him carrying the damn thing with one hand".

"Okay, fair point," Adora said quietly as he walked by.

Catra relaxed again after he passed and linked her arm with Adora's. They walked over to one of tables filled with small appetizers once Glimmer teleported Bow to watch the door from a different vantage point. She could feel Adora staring at her again after she took a piece of cheese.

"What's up?" she asked and put the toothpick between her teeth with a smile. "Is it the white?"

"No! Nope. Nothing's wrong," Adora said quickly and grabbed a couple crackers. "You're just… you just look really, really good. And you're distracting."

“Me?” Catra took the toothpick from her mouth. “What am I doing other than enjoying some cheese?”

“That!” She vaguely gestured at Catra’s face when she tucked the toothpick into the corner of her mouth. “You’re doing… that”.

She raised her eyebrow with a devious chuckle and brushed her tail around Adora’s leg. “I don’t know what you’re talking about”.

Adora’s face only flushed more when Catra turned with a wink, her tail running over her forearm and hand as she walked further down the tables to inspect what other snacks there were. She knew it was going to be a long night if her girlfriend continued to act like that. Not that she hated it. It was just infuriating she couldn’t actually do anything about it. At least yet.

She watched with a quiet giggle when Catra took several steps back when Entrapta brought another bowl of punch to the tables. Catra was definitely on edge about the red liquids being seemingly carelessly carried about.

“Hey!” Catra practically squeaked at the tech princess as she set the bowl on the table. “Watch it! I’d rather not have to take another bath, let alone ruining this shirt. Sparkles just got it tailored for me”.

“Well, it does look very nice”. Entrapta patted her head with her hair before gasping. “Are we people watching and gathering data

again?!”

“Ah, no. You can. Not me”.

Adora watched with a smile as Catra returned to her journey down the table to gather a small plate of snack foods and leaned against the table while Entrapta ran off rather excitedly. Of course Glimmer had a shirt tailored for Catra. Pants were one thing, they needed a hole for her tail. But a shirt like that? That was cruel.

“You look nice,” Kyle complimented as he grabbed a piece of cheese. “Didn’t you wear that to prom a few years ago?”

“Hm?” She finally tore her eyes from Catra. “Thanks. I did. I think I dressed it down enough with taking the belt off for this. But have you seen her?” She gestured down the table. “Come on! She could make a… a towel look good. I mean… she does that too, but that’s not the point! Why is she like… that?!”

“Are you sure you’re okay? You’re looking a little… flushed”.

“Of course I’m fine!” Adora sighed and took a deep breath before fully facing Kyle. “You clean up nice too. Better than the oversized coat you got stuck with at prom. Where are the others?”

“Lonnie’s getting us a table and Rogelio is playing with Imp. You two can join us. If you want. No pressure or anything! I, uh, know

the memories aren't exactly pleasant but I don't want any hard feelings anymore and-"

Adora grabbed his shoulders to pull him out of his rambling. "I'll ask Catra and she'll say 'I'll think about it,' okay? Calm down".

"Yeah. Right. Calm".

She looked back down the tables as he walked away only to find Catra wasn't there. Or anywhere as she looked around. She figured she must have gone to the bathroom and decided to go find Glimmer.

That was, until she felt hands come around her hips.

Her first thought was to throw an elbow to hopefully make contact with the face of whoever it was. A sharp gasp escaped and she forgot about taking a swing when claws lightly dug into her hips.

"Hey, Adora," she whispered right next to her ear with a purr and slid her hands lower.

"Catra, *knock it off* ," she whispered and grabbed her hands.

“Knock what off?” Catra pulled her hands away and took a step back. Her canines poked from behind her lip as she smiled when Adora faced her. “I’m not doing anything. Yet”.

“You’re infuriating,” she said, her eyes briefly flicking to her lips before right back to her eyes. “Hold on. Yet? What’s that supposed to mean?”

“More people are staring to show. You should go say hi”.

Catra gave her a fleeting kiss before sauntering away, sure to glance over her shoulder with a wink. Adora was sure she was going to combust at some point. Either that or She-Ra was going to come out and put Catra in her place. That was a thought she wasn’t exactly going to entertain at the moment.

She walked to the punch bowls and helped herself to a glass from the brighter of the two red drinks. The first sip had her almost coughing. Liquor, and a lot of it. It wasn’t bad, it just caught her off guard. That’s when she noticed it was unmarked and that there were, of course, children around. Adora quickly found Sea Hawk, her annoyance clear.

“Adora! It’s good isn’t it?” He pointed at the glass in her hand.

“What’s in it?”

“Seaboard rum! If you know what you’re doing, it doesn’t taste like lighter fluid”.

“There are *kids* here! Why isn’t it marked?”

“Oh, that does seem to cause a bit of a problem. I’ll get right on that”.

Adora followed him back to the punch, just to be sure he actually did label the bowl that had more than enough alcohol in it. She watched as he pulled a pen from his pocket and lazily wrote on a napkin, ‘For grownups’. He tucked the edge under the bowl and gave Adora a thumbs up.

She sighed quietly and took another sip from her glass. It was strong, yet still dangerously good. There was still a still a faint burn as it went down, but that would gradually become unnoticeable the more that was consumed. All Adora knew was that she was going to have to take it easy with it while watching her back for her sneaky girlfriend.

Adora briefly scanned the room and finally found the woman in question casually talking with Scorpia by the throne. Catra also had a glass of the bright red punch, only hers was already half gone. She must have gotten it while she was off scolding Sea Hawk. Adora wondered if she knew there was liquor in it and if she did, if she even cared.

She had only witnessed her drink a few times outside of the occasional contraband in the Fright Zone, usually at dinner. It was never much, except the one single time she caught her in the middle of the night with some kind of wine. So far, that was the only time Adora scolded her for drinking because she 'was upset'. That situation didn't happen again. Still, the way Catra seemed to not mind the slight burn, and that they were in the Fright Zone, had her just a little worried.

"No looking sad!" Glimmer said and grabbed her shoulders. "This is just a party. And now that we don't have to worry about the Horde putting a damper on things, we can actually enjoy it".

"Try this". Adora handed her the glass.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow and gave it back after taking a sip. "What is that?! Ugh! Is that Sea Hawk's?"

"How'd you know?"

"He's the only one I can think of that would bring spiked punch that's that strong".

"Okay, so I'm not crazy". Adora let out a breath she didn't know she was holding. "Do you think Catra's drinking to get… what did you call it? Drunk?"

“I doubt it”. Glimmer gently rubbed her arm. “I know you’re worried about being here being too much for her, and even yourself, but we’re here for a good time. Relax, Adora. Besides, if you’re that worried, you could always, I dunno, ask her yourself”.

“Yeah. Yeah, you’re right”. She looked over towards Scorpia to see Perfuma had taken Catra’s place. Quickly, she turned around. “I said knock it off”.

“Aw, you caught me this time. I’m still not sure what you mean by ‘knock it off’. I haven’t done anything, I don’t have any big bad plans, I’m not looking to fight anyone… even if some people around here are clearly less than happy to see me”. Catra took a drink from her glass and kissed Adora’s cheek. “It’s a party. Loosen up. I can see how tense your shoulders are from the other side of the room”.

“How are you almost done with that? Seriously, can you not taste the liquor?”

Catra’s eyebrows shot up and looked at the mostly empty glass in her hand. “There’s… liquor in this? I thought it tasted a little odd, but still really good”.

“There’s *a lot* of liquor in it,” Adora half chuckled. “You really didn’t know?”

“How could you not?” Glimmer asked. “I’m sure we could light it on fire”.

“Nah, I knew. I had something quite similar back in the Crimson Waste. It’ll fuck you up quick if you’re not careful. And, no, Adora, I’m not drinking because I can’t handle being here”. She placed a finger over her lips when she tried to say something. “Yes, I overheard the last little bit of your conversation. I promise this is all I need for the night, okay? Lighten up. Are you sure *you’re* okay? I mean… after earlier…”

“I’m fine. I promise.” She held her hand up at Glimmer when she clearly was going to ask about Catra’s own question. “Don’t worry about it.”

“Fine. We’ll talk later.” Glimmer folded her arms before a teasing smile came to her face. “Though… you should probably listen to your mate.” Glimmer lightly punched her arm. “Lighten up. You don’t need to be battle ready”.

Catra couldn’t help the giggle that came from her lips and lightly grabbed Adora’s chin with her thumb and forefinger, a slight challenge twinkling in her eyes. “Yeah, Adora, listen to me”.

“Alright, if you two need a minute I’m sure you could go to one of your old hiding spots”.

“Don’t worry, Sparkles. She can wait”. She ran her thumb along Adora’s bottom lip causing her face to continue to redden. “Isn’t that right, love?”

Catra turned away with a chuckle at the silence she got in response and walked off to find someone else to talk to for a little bit. She was enjoying this game a little too much. The want to just give into her hormones and drag Adora to a random hallway or even the bathroom could wait. The tease was worth it.

“What did she just call you?” Glimmer asked and raised her eyebrow, covering her smile with a fist at the way Adora was blushing up to her ears and nearing the color of her dress.

“I… she,” Adora stumbled over her words, absolutely flustered, “um, I’m… I’m going to kiss— kill her”.

“I definitely think you meant kiss her”. Glimmer couldn’t hold back the laugh any longer. “Really, I think you’d like to be doing lot more than just kissing”.

Adora took a much longer drink and slightly winced at the burn. She couldn’t tell if Catra was riding on the buzz of getting her riled up or the alcohol. Either way, it was going to be a long night. The look in her eyes held a promise. She was going to make her wait. For how long was to be determined and Adora only hoped Catra’s resolve and control of herself would break sooner rather than later. The way she was acting pointed to one thing and Adora knew it was only a matter of time before her girlfriend couldn’t fight nature.

“Hey, guys,” Bow greeted with a smile. “The main courses are just about ready. See, Glimmer, we told you a lot of people were going to show up”.

“Okay, okay. You guys were right,” Glimmer admitted. “I’m so used to Bright Moon being closer to a lot of the surrounding villages is all”.

“Adora? Are you okay?”

“What? Yeah, of course!” She gave a half forced laugh and turned towards him, once again ripping her gaze from Catra. “I’m *so* definitely okay”.

Glimmer couldn’t help but laugh again and link her arm with Bow’s. “Catra’s tormenting her”.

“Isn’t that, like, normal Catra?”

“She’s making me want to rip her clothes off, okay?!” Adora slapped a hand over her mouth.

Bow snickered and put a hand on her shoulder. In a way he felt bad, knowing the feeling. Sometimes Glimmer would purposely

tease him. The only thing Adora had on her side is that it wouldn't be glaringly obvious what the issue was if anyone took a glance.

"So are you going to be eating with us or your… old friends?" Bow asked.

"Hopefully neither," Catra said as she walked by, being sure to brush her tail over Adora's lower back. "I'd much prefer a room for dessert. Adora, I saved us a spot with Lonnie and crew".

"Why?" Adora turned to watch her just continue walking to the table Lonnie had claimed. "Why would she want to eat in a room?"

Bow choked on his spit and discreetly pointed down.

"I doubt she'd want the floor, Bow". Adora chuckled and folded her arms. "But it looks like she wants to eat over there. See ya on the dance floor!"

"How are you still so clueless sometimes?!" Bow said and put his face in his hands as she walked to join Catra and their old squad.

"Why would you want to eat dessert in a room?" Adora asked and sat next Catra.

Lonnie nearly spat out her drink.

"Oh, Adora," Catra said around a purr, "I wasn't talking about food".

Adora's face immediately went pink at the implication. She then lightly slapped Catra's arm with a snort.

"Alright, do you two need the closet?" Lonnie asked.

"No," Catra said simply and folded her hands on top of the table. "We can wait until after the party".

"*We*?" Adora practically hissed quietly through her teeth.

"Mmmhm". Carta looked at her with a devious smile. "It's only a few more… hours. You'll be fine, *princess*".

Lonnie looked between the two of them before groaning. "You could cut the sexual tension between you two with a bar of soap at this point".

That only made Catra's grin widen and slipped a hand under the table to grab Adora's thigh.

“No. Catra, you two are not doing this right now. Not here at least”. Lonnie watched Adora’s jaw visibly tighten. “Seriously?!”

“I’m not doing anything,” Catra said and lightly drug her claws up Adora’s thigh on her way to putting her hand back next to her other one on the table. “I can assure you my hand wouldn’t be dry if I did. My leg itched is all”.

“How can you be so sure?” Adora challenged.

“By the way you’ve been acting the whole time we’ve been here. Plus I can smell you. Sheesh”. The teasing glint never left Catra’s eyes. “You’ll have what you want after this thing”.

“Well, I know I’m glad you accepted the invitation to join us,” Kyle said with Imp in his lap. “We shouldn’t be strangers anymore”.

Rogelio roared and grunted in what seemed to be agreement. Lonnie also nodded with a sigh. Imp only hissed at Catra which was promptly returned with her hair puffed up.

“Was that necessary?” Kyle asked and held Imp to his shoulder.

“He started it”. Catra smoothed her hair back down. “He doesn’t have to like me, but should know I hiss back”.

“Behave,” Adora told her sternly.

For the first time, she saw a crack in the resolve Catra was fronting. Adora saw her tail betray her, the tip of it flicking excitedly. The brief moment was quickly replaced and the tables turned on her.

“Make me”.

So that’s how the game was going to be played. Adora grabbed the base of her tail and gave a quick, gentle tug before letting go. Her own smirk formed as she watched Catra’s claws dig into the table.

“Alright, everyone!” Scorpia got everyone’s attention. “Dinner is served. Come get something to eat. There’s plenty”.

There was the sound of chairs shuffling and people chatting as they fell in line. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle with Imp were quick to join. Adora went to stand and Catra grabbed her wrist.

“Aren’t you hungry?”

“I am”. She smiled when Adora sat back down. “I just need a second. That’s all”.

“Are you o-“ Adora grabbed the hand that was quickly between her legs over her dress and bit her lip.

“I’m perfectly fine, Adora,” she whispered and gave a quick rub with her fingers, reveling in the barely audible whimper from her girlfriend. “It seems you’re the one hanging by a thread”.

Catra removed her hand and stood up to join the line, brushing her tail over Adora’s neck as she walked behind her chair.

Adora was stunned to say the least. Her girlfriend was getting bolder. Her resolve was starting to slip. All she could do was smirk at the thought. Two could play this game. She finally got to her feet and joined Catra in line.

“That was bold of you,” Adora said and folded her arms.

“Hm?”

Adora gently grabbed the base of her tail again and gave another soft tug before scratching the fur at the spot her tail was coming through her pants. Catra took in a sharp breath as her back arched. She quickly slapped Adora’s hand away and turned to face her.

“Cheap. Real cheap, Adora”.

“Oh, and that little move of yours wasn’t?”

Adora almost instantly regretted her words as the line moved and a smirk she knew too well came across Catra’s face. Her arms folded and Adora could feel her undressing her as her eyes scanned up and down her body.

“Good luck,” was all she said and turned around.

Adora just knew Catra was already coming up with a plan, or several, as her tail lazily swayed behind her. She was so screwed and she knew it. Catra was going to drag this out as long as she could bear it herself. Adora only hoped she could speed up her final decision. If not, the next few hours would feel like days.

Catra stayed quiet as the line continued to move. Adora was sure to nearly break at her next idea. It was a low blow, one she was originally going to use in between dances. A few minutes after they ate and before any dancing happened seemed like a great time now that Adora was challenging her. It would drive her insane. Catra only hoped Adora knew she was only going to be tormenting herself with it too. Her planning came to a screeching halt when someone cleared their throat behind her. And it definitely wasn’t Adora.

Her ears pinned back once she turned to see who wanted her attention. She wasn't sure if it was fear or a still simmering anger that she was feeling the moment she saw George and Lance in between her and Adora.

"I didn't mean to startle you," George said calmly. "I… also don't want a fight. I want to apologize for what happened at the library months ago. We've said our apologies to Bow more than once and he did happen to tell us that it was you we should apologize to. He said he wasn't going to do it for us."

Catra nodded slowly, skeptical. She took a step back when the line behind her moved forward.

"You… were second in command," Lance said and rubbed his hands together nervously. "I'm sure you understand why we reacted the way we did. However, we had no right to say the things we did about your and Adora's relationship. It's quite clear how much love you have for each other. I'm no stranger to knowing that a simple sorry doesn't fix anything right away."

"Yeah," Catra spoke quietly. "Neither am I. But… thanks, I guess."

"Does that mean we're good?" Lance asked.

"I… I don't know. Maybe." Catra stepped back again with the line and rubbed her shoulder. "Nowhere near a hundred percent. But… a start… maybe?"

“I can accept a start,” George said. He pointed to Catra’s tapestry next to Adora’s. “That one belongs to you, doesn’t it?”

Catra nodded and turned to face forward. She didn’t want to explain it to them. She thought it spoke for itself. Plus, she was done talking for now. Being blindsided into a conversation with Bow’s fathers wasn’t exactly in her plans.

“Well, for what it’s worth at this point in time, it’s fitting. And… Bow’s proud of you for the display.”

“She’s had enough,” Adora informed quietly. “Don’t push it.”

George nodded while Lance spoke, “we hope you two have a wonderful evening. And maybe, we’ll see you on the dance floor.”

Adora rubbed Catra’s shoulders once they left. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine.” Catra cleared her throat. “Yeah. I’m okay. Just…” she glanced over her shoulder at her girlfriend, “they surprised me is all. Let’s just… get something to eat.”

They got their food in silence between them before making their way back to the table and sitting down. Adora welcomed the

distraction of the food in front of her. Anything to ignore the tail on her lap occasionally flicking over thighs.

“Scorpia was telling me she came up with some last minute games for later,” Catra told the table after swallowing the bite of the ocean white fish she requested. “The dance floor will be open too”.

“What games?” Lonnie asked.

“She was saying she got one of those box things filled with candy for the kids and some other little things for them”. She glanced at Adora who was keeping her attention on her food before back to the rest of their old squad. “For the adults, she said she’s setting up a couple of dartboards and a few extra tables for card games.“

Adora jumped slightly when Catra put her hand over her forearm. “Hm?”

“Were you even listening?”

“Yeah! Games. There’s going to be games. And dancing”. She smiled and dared to look to Catra. “Are we redoing prom?”

She momentarily forgot she needed to breathe when Catra unbuttoned the top button of her shirt. Adora finally took in a deep breath and looked back to her plate.

“I hope with a lot less fighting,” Kyle said. “And a lot less… explosions”.

“And hopefully no kidnapping,” Lonnie added.

“I don’t think we’ll have to worry about…” Catra trailed off for a moment when she saw Adora pull her dress up just enough to expose the thigh closest to her out of the corner of her eye, “uh, that”.

Adora smiled to herself when Catra’s tail twitched excitedly in her lap. Payback tasted sweet for the moment. Somehow, Catra still kept her composure as she continued to talk to their old squad. The little slip that did happen told Adora that she was likely just as antsy, despite the little interruption from Lance and George, under the collected front she was showing.

She small victory was short lived as Catra finished her meal. Suddenly her hand was on her thigh, claws tenderly trailing over the inside.

“I think I’m going to go chat with Netossa and Spinnerella for a few minutes,” she said as she trailed her hand higher.

“You barely know them,” Adora said quickly, forcing herself to keep her hands on the table.

“Hey, we were in quarantine with Netossa and they both said to not be a stranger”. She stood and ran a finger under Adora’s chin. “I’ll catch up with you in a few minutes”.

“How long is she going to drag this out for you?” Lonnie asked after Catra walked away. “I guess I should ask, how long are you going to let her?”

“I don’t know”. Adora groaned and put her head in her hands. “She’s driving me insane. Absolutely insane. She’s always been a little… brat, but this is… ugh!”

“That’s Catra for you”.

“And you still love her?” Kyle asked.

“More than anything”. Adora glanced over to see Catra laughing with Netossa about something and smiled. “Always have. Even if we did have some major issues there for a while”.

“Adora!”

She jumped and hurriedly fixed her dress when Glimmer suddenly appeared. “H-Hey, Glimmer!”

“So, Scorpia’s coming up with games and I think I have a fun one. So far everyone, except Hordak, of course, is on board with a little truth spell game. Wanna join?”

“I don’t see why not. Wait, *Catra* agreed to that?”

“She said she’d have to think about it. How about you three?”

“Hell, no,” Lonnie said. “I’ll be more than happy to watch. *Especially* if Catra’s playing”.

“I’ll play,” Kyle said. “But I don’t think Rogelio will”.

Rogelio made a few grunts and patted Kyle’s back.

“Uhhh,” Glimmer looked at Adora and back at the trio, “can anyone translate?”

“We get a really rough idea and try to guess until he nods, usually,” Lonnie said and looked at him. “You’re not playing are you?”

Rogelio nodded and made a series of noises.

“Because they wouldn’t be able to understand?”

He nodded again.

“Oh, that’s fine,” Glimmer said around a nervous chuckle. “He’s more than welcome to at least watch as well. We won’t play until a little later”.

“Hey, guys,” Catra said walking back over before leaning her hip against Adora’s arm, “Netossa and Spinnerella are coming up with teams for darts if anyone wants to actually compete instead of just throwing for fun. I picked Bow”.

“Oh, so you didn’t want me to play with you?” Adora asked and playfully glared at her.

“I want to play against you and whoever in darts, dummy. Just to kick your ass”. She twirled part of her ponytail around her fingers. “You can definitely play with me later though”.

“Why are you two like this?” Glimmer smacked Catra’s arm. “Always, I swear”.

“You seem to be getting Bow a little… you know, Sparkles”. Catra laughed a little. “You might not be as bad as us sometimes, but

I’m not blind”.

“You…” she covered her face. “You don’t know what you’re talking about”.

“If you need it,” Lonnie tried to help, “leave Horror Hall, go towards the mess hall and take the first hallway on your left, just before where the tables are. Two doors down on your right is a closet big enough for whatever you need to do. I’ve guarded it enough”.

“Hey!” Adora protested. “That’s our closet!”

“And ours!” Kyle also added.

“Seems like a popular one,” Glimmer grumbled.

“There’s a reason for it”. Lonnie shrugged. “The option is there if you need it. And it shouldn’t be occupied since Catra just seems to want to tease all night”.

Catra smirked and tugged on Adora’s ponytail gently. Glimmer just shook her head and teleported away. Adora looked up at Catra again when she felt her shift, just to see her undoing another button.

“Something wrong?” She asked and rubbed the back of her thigh, being sure to linger her hand just below her ass.

“Just warm. There’s a lot of people in here”. Catra shifted her weight when she felt a firm squeeze to her ass before the hand fell back down to the back of her thigh. “I was thinking about stepping out for some fresh air. If… you want to join. I’ll only be out for a minute”.

She simply tucked her hands into her pockets, only brushing the tip of her tail against Adora’s cheek as she started walking towards the door. Adora excused herself and followed. To her, her girlfriend seemed almost upset a little suddenly. She thought maybe she was just starting to get a little anxious and overwhelmed by the crowd.

“Catra? Are you sure you’re okay?”

She didn’t answer as she walked along the side of the building, her tail flicking behind her. The thing that got her to stop was a gentle hand on her shoulder.

Adora was definitely happy with how wrong her assumption had been.

Catra quickly had her pinned up the against the side of the building, not hesitating with a deep, almost bruising kiss. Adora was startled at first, but quickly returned it, tugging at her hips.

This wasn't exactly the place she had in mind for finally getting relief, but Catra gave up the game. Adora's hands quickly ran up her body in search of another button to pop open while Catra bunched her dress up around her hips.

"Here?" Adora breathed against her lips.

"Shut up".

Catra let Adora unbutton and untuck her shirt while she kissed her neck. She ran her claws up her thigh, retracting them when she got to her panties and smirked. Her teasing was paying off. Catra could feel how wet Adora was over the fabric and quickly pulled them aside.

"Are… are you sure. H-here?" Adora gasped then moaned when her question was answered with two fingers plunging into her.

"Do you really want to take the walk to the closet?" She asked and put her leg between Adora's to rest against the back of her hand.

"No". She held onto Catra's shoulders. "Please".

"No, no, princess. I'm not doing anything… for now". She pulled back a little and looked at her hand between Adora's legs and

smiled while grabbing her jaw with the other. “You’re going to ride my fingers. How does that sound?”

“C-Catra”.

“Fuck. My. Hand. Adora”.

She could have finished right there. The hungry look in Catra’s eyes, the hand gripping her jaw with the other between her legs. She was going to listen. At least for now. And Catra watched as she started moving her hips.

Adora heard her moan at the sight. She tugged her close while she rode her fingers, feeling them simply flex and hook on occasion. She knew her breathing was growing heavy, her moans and sighs steady in Catra’s ear. Her knees nearly gave out when she felt a thumb on her clit.

Catra knew she was getting close. She had started grinding against Adora’s leg to get a little friction for herself. Even if it wasn’t nearly enough. It was so unfortunate, her plan. She wanted to finish Adora right there, have her screaming her name. Not yet.

“Stop moving”.

Adora reluctantly stopped, hoping Catra was going to just rail her into the wall. But she didn't. Instead, she pulled her hand away and readjusted Adora's rather soaked panties. She dropped her dress and stepped back, licking her fingers clean.

"What the *fuck* are you doing?"

"See you on the dance floor, love".

"Catra! Seriously?!" She followed quickly after her.

Adora followed her back inside, gritting her teeth. She wanted to grab her by the back of the shirt and have her finish what she started. Better yet, she thought about taking She-Ra's form and throwing her over her shoulder to take her somewhere. The only thing keeping her from doing that was getting payback. Catra was clearly uncomfortable with her own situation, shifting her step for a moment to get her underwear to not rub against her crotch as much.

"Ready to play or not yet?" Catra asked Bow and Glimmer as she sat on top of the table they were sitting at.

"Sure!" Bow exclaimed with a smile and stood. "Who are we playing against?"

Catra looked over her shoulder to her girlfriend. “Did you pick anyone yet?”

“You didn’t exactly give me a chance,” Adora said and folded her arms. “Glimmer?”

“Fine, fine. I wasn’t going to play but…” she stood and linked her arm with Bow’s. “I’d like to kick his ass”.

“You wish!” Bow said with a smile. “You of all people should know my aim is flawless”.

“We’ll see about that”.

Catra hopped off the table and rested her hand on Adora’s lower back as the group walked towards the dartboards Scorpia was just finishing setting up. Catra was unusually quiet as they walked. Usually she would have something to say, considering her and Glimmer’s friendship and how they liked to pick on each other. Adora glanced over and saw a small, yet still neutral smile.

“Something on your mind?”

“Just you”, she answered without looking at Adora. “I’m getting antsy, you know”.

“Then let’s sneak off”. Adora wrapped an arm around her waist. “That was a little too mean, what you did outside”.

“Then get payback. You know me well enough”. Catra lightly dug her claws into her lower back and lowered her voice. “Make me want to tear this thing to shreds”.

“Catra!”

“Shhh!”

“What’s going on back there?” Glimmer asked and looked over her shoulder.

“Nothing to concern yourself with, Sparkles. If you should worry about anything, it’s your aim”.

“You guys don’t want to dance?” Scorpia asked as Catra grabbed a few darts.

“After this game,” Bow said. “Glimmer and Adora really think they can beat Catra and me”.

“But you’re… Bow!” Scorpia laughed softly. “Though… darts are a little different than arrows”.

“Not by much. Similar type of aim”.

Catra and Glimmer each took a few practice throws. On Glimmer’s last dart, she put it right next to Catra’s in the outer ring of the bullseye. Catra gave her a smile. Maybe there would be more of a competition than she originally thought. She gave the darts to Bow to take a few practice throws with Adora.

She knew Adora wasn’t a bad shot. Usually. Catra buttoned every button on her shirt except the very top one. She was going to make this interesting and give Adora some incentive to do far better than her half assed practice throws against Bow’s two bullseyes.

“Ready?” Bow asked.

“You go ahead and throw first,” Catra told him and leaned against the table behind her. “Unless Adora wants to trade for Glimmer”.

Adora thought for a moment before realizing that throwing first with Bow would give her plenty of opportunity to cause a distraction for Catra. “I’ll throw first”.

Catra smiled and folded her arms. Little did Adora know, she already wanted to rip that red dress of hers to shreds. She wanted

to see just how far she was willing to go to push her over the edge, to finally cave.

Adora hit the center bullseye with her last dart and saw Catra undo a button of her shirt. She didn't exactly understand what the point of even buttoning she shirt back up was if she was just going to unbutton it again. She handed the darts off to Glimmer as Catra took hers from Bow. As Catra stepped up to the line, Adora grabbed the base of her tail and let the length of it run through her hand with a smile as she stepped away to lean her hip against a table. She heard the soft huff Catra gave at the gesture.

Catra kept her focus on the board this round. She could maybe afford sloppier throws closer to the end of the game. To start, she needed to try to keep the lead Bow set for them. While Glimmer's aim wasn't as good as her boyfriends, she held her own. She blocked Catra's outer bullseye and barely hit the center on her last throw.

"You said we'd win without an issue," Catra halfheartedly complained as she gave Bow the darts. "Your girlfriend has better aim than either of you let on. Or are you just going easy on her?"

"I… no. I'm not going easy on her".

"Mhm. Sure". Catra rubbed her tail over Adora's leg as she passed by. "Get a couple bullseyes. It'll be worth your effort".

“If it means Glimmer and I win this, which is the plan, it’ll definitely be worth it,” she said with a smile. “Maybe it’s you that needs to focus a little more. I know you can play darts better than that”.

Catra rolled her eyes and watched the darts be thrown. Adora got an outer ring bullseye, she undid another button. Bow blocked it and Catra saw a little bit of a devious smile come to Glimmer’s face. She could only wonder if the other couple was playing a similar game to her and Adora. Only, far more subtle.

Adora turned with a triumphant smile when she hit the center bullseye. She carefully watched Catra undo two more buttons and swallowed hard. Her shirt was at least half open.

“What are you doing?”

“I told you that the bullseyes would be worth the effort”. She took the darts from Bow. “Your move”.

“Strip darts?” Glimmer asked and threw her first one. “There are children here”.

“Then tell her to stop hitting the bullseye”. Catra threw her first. “Besides, I’m unfortunately wearing one of Adora’s bras so I’m covered. I’m also thinking you and Bow are having some similar… fun with each other”.

The comment had her falter her throw and nearly miss the board. “I don’t know what you’re talking about!”

Catra tapped her own nose with a smirk and hit the center bullseye. “Not as strong as Adora right now, but it’s there, Sparkles. You can have the closet first”.

“Are you saying I smell bad?” Glimmer accused.

“I never said that. Just… different”. She followed her friend’s dart with her eyes and watched it hit the open space of one of the numbers.

“How do you not get a headache being able to pick up on all of these smells no one else can?”

“I ignore it all most of the time. On occasion I can’t. With Adora that is. But you?” Catra threw her dart and barely missed the outer ring of the bullseye. “I’m just focusing on that to poke some fun”.

“You’re a jerk”.

“Tell me something I don’t know”.

The two collected their darts and handed them off to their respective teammate. The number on both sides continued to dwindle down. Catra ended up having to untuck her shirt and was down to the last two buttons, much to Adora's annoyance and slight enjoyment.

She knew the next time Glimmer and Catra were up, it would likely be the final round, depending on what numbers they hit. She threw her last dart and made sure to hit the outer rig of the bullseye. Before Catra could undo a button, she grabbed her hands and pulled them away. Adora drug her nails down her stomach with a smirk and undid the button herself.

"Hey, Catra".

"Get a room already!" Glimmer yelled at them.

"Hmmm. Not yet". Catra slipped from in front of Adora with the darts in her hand. "I have a game to win".

"Good luck," Glimmer teased. "I think your head is a little clouded".

Catra scoffed and focused on the board. She could still win. Somehow. Adora's touch still felt to linger over her stomach and that was already enough of a distraction. Glimmer's first two

throws left her at zero, only needing to stick her last dart in the bullseye. Catra was still holding onto three points and was counting on Glimmer missing after she got her three off the board.

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Adora take her hair down and put it over one shoulder just as she let go of the dart. The slight inattention to her aim put her dart in the next number over. Glimmer threw her last one and put it right into the middle bullseye.

"And that's it," she said with a smile and patted Catra's shoulder. "Better luck next time".

"That was a good game, though," Bow said through a smile. "Rematch later?"

"Maybe," Catra grumbled and buttoned her shirt back up and left the top two open.

"Awww," Adora teased and lifted Catra's chin with a finger to look at her. "What's wrong, kitty?"

"Keep this up," she threatened quietly, "and I *will* tear that dress apart, right off your body".

“Sure you will”. She ran her fingers down her throat while she tucked her shirt back in. “It was you who said to get payback. Maybe it’s my turn to make *you* wait”.

“I’ll wait you out all night if I have to”.

“No, you won’t”.

“I’m… going to go sit down for a little bit”.

Adora chuckled as she watched Catra walk back to their table and grab a deck of cards from another on her way. She noticed she shifted uncomfortably again as she walked and chuckled. Not even a card game with their old friends would be enough of a distraction. And Adora knew it.

Chapter End Notes

> For the smut skippers: didn’t miss much other than Catra being a brat and denying Adora relief.
>
> S: I do have to say the eclipse was cool as fuck from my location. Complete totality is a wild thing to see in person. Other than that… my week felt like it took a hundred years to go by. Work was kinda stupid. And yesterday… I swear yesterday took at least three days to go by. Every time I checked the time, only 10 minutes went by when I’m certain it was at least an hour. But we made it to Saturday.
>
> The next chapter will end this first part of the series. There may be a small break between then and the first chapter of the next part. Maybe an extra week or two. I have a couple

things I would like to start work on. More details on that to be disclosed later once I get it figured out a bit more. That and there's some reworking that needs to be hashed out for the start of the next part due to some things that got added/taken out/reworked during edits on this part and it could take a moment.

Indy: I hope everyone got to enjoy the eclipse. I was in the 99.9% range so still super cool! This week has been a long one and every week will be a long one until the semester ends.

Hard to believe we are almost done with the first little bit of this series! We got big plans in store and I hope you like them. The break will be short one but needed.

Outside of that I've been…mentally not good. For those of you who feel like I do right now, unwanted, unloved, and generally annoying to others, I want to say that none of that is true. I am extremely grateful for each and every one of you who reads and enjoys this story of ours. I hope you have a wonderful weekend and a fantastic week next week! Things will get better, we just gotta get through the turbulence.

Party Time: Part 2

Chapter Notes

This chapter is mostly just shameless smut honestly.

Starts at:

Catra quickly opened the door to the building when they arrived and found Adora's mouth against hers again as the door closed behind them. Adora continued to be walked backwards until her back hit a bedpost. She felt a hand on her head, guiding her down until there was an unmistakable thin mattress behind her and Catra on top.

And ends at:

Catra's head thumped down face first into the bed when Adora let go of her hair. Her hips slowly lowered back to the bed as she trembled. Adora ran her hand up and down her back gently until the shaking eased. She laid down on her side and gently pulled Catra to her side and pulled her close.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sat on Catra's lap sideways with a smile after two songs of dancing with Bow and Glimmer. She kissed her cheek when she got a questioning raised eyebrow and wrapped an arm around her shoulders. Really, Catra looked a little lonely sitting at the table by herself once Lonnie and the rest of the squad went off to play darts.

"Is this your way of getting back at me?" Catra asked and wrapped an arm around Adora's waist. "Because this is actually rather sweet".

“Oh, come on. You know you want to dance”.

“Not really, no. I was enjoying watching you have fun”.

“I’ll make it worth your time”. Adora rubbed Catra’s ear and shifted her weight in her lap a little. “Come on”.

Catra held her breath for a moment while Adora got herself comfortable again. Trying to let herself simmer down to not cave wasn’t exactly going the greatest. Even if she thought it worked even a little, Adora’s shifting had her pants pressed tightly against her crotch. She was definitely still more than ready.

“I think I’ll pass,” she finally breathed out.

Adora raised her eyebrow and shifted again. She smirked when Catra’s breath caught again. Maybe she still had a chance to get her to break after all.

“If you don’t want to dance right now, how about we do a rematch with darts?” She ran a finger down the side of Catra’s neck. “I’ll go find Bow and Glimmer again”.

“Th-that’s fine, really. Can you *please* stop adjusting?” She grabbed her hip. “Seriously”.

“What’s wrong?” Adora teasingly undid a button to her shirt. “I’m just trying to get comfortable”.

Catra groaned and let her shift again so she was facing forward while sitting on her lap. Adora quietly chuckled when Catra’s other hand rested on her other hip. She was unraveling.

“Adora,” she whispered, “I suggest you knock it off”.

“Or what?” She leaned back against Catra’s chest. “I finally get what I want? Or better yet, you get what you’ve been after all night. You can threaten all you want about holding out, but we both know you’re hanging on by a thread”.

“So are you,” she grumbled and bucked her hips slightly. She smirked at the soft gasp. “We can play this game all night. But I’m really starting to get irritated with it”.

“Oh, are you giving in?” Adora asked with a smile. “Closet?”

“Please”.

Adora stood up and faced her. She grabbed her jaw to make her look up at her. “After darts”.

Catra narrowed her eyes when Adora let go while running her fingers over her jaw before turning away to find Bow and Glimmer. She was done waiting. Catra was on her heels as she kept walking. Finally, she grabbed her wrist and spun her around.

"I don't give a fuck about darts or dancing or Bow and Sparkles right now, Adora. We can find them later. Right now, I give in. You win. We're going to the closet and I'm going to have my way with you".

"You think so, kitty? Prove it".

Catra growled at the challenge and tugged her towards the doors. If Adora wanted her to prove it, she would. Several times over. Catra was pent up from all of the teasing and her hormones. She knew Adora was almost just as antsy. They probably wouldn't last too long.

They barely made it to the mess hall before Catra had her pinned against a wall, kissing her hungrily. There was nothing slow about it. She didn't bother starting with a slow kiss, gingerly asking for more. She started with tongue and teeth. She made sure Adora would have to catch her breath eventually.

It was Adora who pushed her back to pick her up. For as tough as Catra was acting, her legs quickly found their spot around Adora's waist as she walked towards the closet, working purely on memory as the kisses never really stopped. Adora fumbled around for the handle while Catra snapped her hair tie with a claw. She

set her back on her feet and pushed her back against the door as the handle turned.

Once the door opened, they were greeted with a shocked yelp. Catra suddenly felt a hand on her back that definitely didn't belong to Adora.

"I'm so sorry!" Adora said and covered her eyes with one hand and pulled Catra away from the closet by her shirt with the other.

"A knock would have been great!" Glimmer yelled as the door closed.

"Was that…?" Catra quietly laughed. "There's no way".

"It… it definitely was. Is the mood gone?"

"Far from it. My room?" She grabbed Adora's hand and started leading her towards the barracks.

"Are you sure?"

"I wouldn't have suggested it if I wasn't".

Catra quickly opened the door to the building when they arrived and found Adora's mouth against hers again as the door closed behind them. Adora continued to be walked backwards until her back hit a bedpost. She felt a hand on her head, guiding her down until there was an unmistakable thin mattress behind her and Catra on top.

"Catra-"

"Shhh". She bunched her dress to just below her breasts.

Adora let out a pleasured sigh when Catra's hips pressed into hers while she was kissing her neck. The only other noise that registered aside from Catra's heavy breathing was the sound of ripping fabric. She soon felt cool air hit her wet folds.

"Hey! I kinda need those!"

Catra sat back on her heels panting and grabbed the torn panties and pulled them out from under Adora. She gave a breathy laugh as she watched a thin string of arousal come away with them.

"I don't think you'd be putting these back on, princess," she said around a low purr and held them up just to rub her finger into the wetness left behind to pull a similar string from them with her finger. "See? It's okay, I probably won't be getting mine back on either".

“You… you didn’t have to rip them”.

Catra chuckled and tossed them up by the pillow before leaning over her. Just as she was about to lock their mouths together again, she saw their old drawings out of the corner of her eye. Of course her lust filled haze led them to Adora’s old bunk.

“Not here,” she mumbled and crawled from the bunk.

“I tried to tell you,” Adora said and quickly followed her to her old room.

“Less talking”.

Adora put a finger over Catra’s lips when the door closed behind them. “You can’t rip my dress. Understood?”

“*Only* because I don’t feel like everyone seeing you naked”. Catra pinned her against the wall. “Now, stop talking so much”.

Adora quickly fumbled with the buttons on Catra’s shirt while she felt around her body looking for the zipper to her dress. She pushed her shirt from her shoulders and ran her hands over her arms as she pushed the shirt down them. Catra stopped her

search long enough to toss the shirt to the floor before finally finding the zipper and tugging it down.

She pushed the dress from Adora's shoulders and let it drop around her feet. Catra placed kisses along her jaw, occasionally giving a sharp nip before continuing. Adora pushed Catra's borrowed bra to above her breasts and gave each a gentle squeeze before lightly pinching her nipples between her fingers. It earned her a sharp bite to the side of the neck and a low moan in her ear.

Catra quickly got her pants off and picked Adora up while keeping her back against the door. Her mouth quickly found Adora's again as she was grinding against her stomach. It wasn't long until she felt just how wet her fur there was getting. Catra moaned into her mouth when her nipples were pinched again and felt a surge of warmth settle between her legs. She didn't think that much more was even possible.

"Off," Adora whispered quickly and tugged on Catra's bra.

She quickly removed it the rest of the way and tossed it somewhere in the room before giving Adora's bra the same treatment. Catra returned her mouth to her neck and slowly kissed down to and along her collarbones while supporting her weight with her hands under her thighs to carry her to the bed and lay her down. As she pulled back, she looked down between them and let a purr rumble in her chest as Adora's wetness stretched from her stomach.

“Fuck, Adora”. She ran her fingers through her wet fur and smiled. “All because of me?”

“Yeah, no shi-“

Catra put her fingers in Adora’s mouth and moaned quietly when she didn’t hesitate to lick them clean for her. Her own underwear were getting to be too much so she clawed them away from her body after removing her fingers from Adora’s mouth. She wasn’t in any better of a state as she discarded them to the floor and felt a drip fall from her folds.

Adora closed her eyes and held the back of Catra’s head as she flicked her tongue over her nipple. She sucked in a sharp breath and raised her hips into her when she gave the nipple a gentle suck. Catra switched sides and gently sucked the nipple in between her teeth before giving a soft bite. Adora again raised her hips in response, growing desperate for friction. She was simply aching at this point.

Catra slowly kissed down her stomach, gently raking her claws down her sides as she went. She stopped just below her navel and smiled up at Adora. She was flushed and breathing heavily in anticipation, yet still smiled back. Catra felt her raise her hips again, silently asking for her to continue. Instead, she sat up.

“Catra, I fucking swear. Don’t even think about it”. Adora propped herself up on her elbows to stare her down.

“Or what?” She ran her tail over Adora’s calf.

“I’ll tie you to the bed post,” she challenged, her eyes starting to glow a light blue, “and you’ll watch while I touch and finish myself. And then you’ll go the rest of the party without having any relief. What’s it gonna be, kitty?”

Catra was rendered speechless for a moment upon seeing the threat Adora’s eyes gave away for short moment before the glow faded. She wasn’t going to entertain that. As much as she enjoyed watching Adora touch herself, it was usually part of foreplay. This time held a promise that she would be left hanging. That wasn’t an option at the moment.

Besides, she was *supposed* to be the top this time. There was no way she was about to top She-Ra, now or ever. She knew what her place very well when it came to the warrior goddess.

Catra simply nodded like an idiot.

“What are you nodding about? You want to watch?”

“N-no! I mean… not right now”. She cleared her throat. “I’m not gonna stop this time”.

“That’s what I thought”. Adora pushed Catra’s head down gently. She was getting so tired of waiting.

Her eyes fell closed and tilted her head back into the pillow as Catra kissed up the side of her thigh. Without much further warning, she finally felt her press her tongue flat against her dripping slit. A soft gasp came from her when Catra slowly licked up to her clit and gave a soft suck before licking back down just as slow. Adora tried to move her hips and set a pace but her girlfriend's hands held her firmly still.

Catra continued to lap at her folds slowly. A few broad licks happened before she drug her tongue between the soaked lips. She couldn't control the moan that escaped as she slipped the tip of her tongue into Adora. Catra could feel her trying to desperately move her hips and ride her face so she gave some room for her to work with. She hummed softly as she let Adora practically do all of the work herself, her nose occasionally rubbing against her clit.

Adora gave a whine of protest when Catra pulled her mouth away. She dared a glance down and her face flushed when she saw a thick string connecting Catra's chin to her pussy. All she did was smile up at her while slowly sinking two fingers into her as watching her face contort in pleasure before her head thumped back down to the pillow.

"Fuck me," Adora whispered and moved her hips.

"Of course," she said back around a low purr.

Catra slowly pulled her fingers out before sliding them back in. The first thrust, she watched Adora and the way she dug her head into the pillow and gripped the blanket with one hand while grabbing a handful of her hair with the other. The second slow thrust, she watched her fingers pull out and smirked at the wetness coating them before sliding back in and watched Adora's lips part effortlessly around her fingers.

"Beautiful," Catra whispered. "You're absolutely beautiful, you know".

"You… you should really-" she moaned when Catra sped up her fingers and pushed on her head.

"Hmmm". She smiled and kissed her clit. "I was going to take my time".

"Please don't. Right now, I would really fucking like it if you would just fuck me already".

"Such a foul mouth, Adora". She flicked her tongue over her clit and slowed her thrusts again. "Tell me what you want".

"I thought I made myself clear". She rolled her hips in an attempt to return to the slightly faster pace.

“Awww,” Catra purred and looked away from Adora riding her fingers to her face. “Look at me and tell me what you want. Maybe I won’t make you do all the work”.

Adora looked down and nearly glared at the little teasing smirk and the way Catra had her cheek resting against the inside of her thigh. She would get payback. Without a doubt.

“I want you to- a-ah!” She moaned at the quick swipe of a thumb across her clit. “F-fuck me. Please, Catra. I want another finger. I want your m-mouth-“ another, louder moan left her when she felt the two fingers inside of her hook. “C-Catra, please”.

“You want my mouth to do what?” She continued to tease and slipped the requested additional finger in.

“To stop talking and get on my clit,” she said, staring down at her. Her eyes flickered a glowing blue again for less than a second. “I won’t ask again. Now fuck me”.

Catra just smiled and sped her hand up to match Adora’s hips. Her mouth found a home around her clit and drew random shapes over and around it with her tongue. Occasionally she would give a gentle suck, making Adora’s legs twitch.

Adora was close. Her walls were starting to clench down around the fingers inside of her and her moans were becoming more frequent and louder. Her hands held the back of Catra’s head

desperately, making damn sure she wasn't going to just pull away. Catra was quick to notice, speeding up her thrusts. She doubled down on working Adora's clit with her tongue.

She heard Adora's breath catch as her legs clamped around her head. Her walls started to spasm around her fingers but she didn't slow her pace. Catra actually sped up just a little more and sucked slowly on her clit. Nails dug into her scalp as Adora trembled, moaned, and whimpered. Her breathing was rapid as she was taking in air through her teeth with her jaw clenched.

Catra finally stopped with a purposeful loud gulp as she swallowed most of Adora's juices. What she didn't manage to catch had the blanket, part of her forearm, and chin soaked. All she could do was purr while the grip around her head slowly eased while Adora's legs trembled. Catra left her fingers in place while she kissed the inside of her thigh before resting her head against it.

Adora let out a tired, yet content sigh. She lifted her head to glance down with a smile while slowly stroking Catra's face.

"Hey, Adora," she said softly and turned her head to kiss her palm. "I'd love to come up there and cuddle with you but I need my fingers back".

Adora nodded and let her head fall back again. She gasped softly as Catra slowly removed her fingers and wiped them on the blanket before crawling over her. She held her face gently and pulled her down for a soft kiss.

“You haven’t done that is a while,” Catra commented. “Good job”.

“You were great,” she replied with a dopey smile. “Your turn”.

“In a minute there, princess”. She chuckled. “Right now you’re going to stay put. I can wait a few minutes while you come back to Etheria”.

Adora rolled to her side when Catra laid down next to her and stroked her cheek. Her mind was still a little hazy and if she stood up at that moment, she was sure to crash to the floor. If that’s what Catra’s teasing amounted to for her, she could only guess what the flip side offered.

“Are you okay?” Catra asked and traced Adora’s lips.

“Yeah. I’m great”. She traced over the faint scar of the bite she had given. “Not fair. You can barely see it”.

“My fur may be really short, but it’s enough to hide it a little bit. I could always shave-“

“You better not”. Adora propped herself up on a shaky elbow. “I would be so upset”.

“I won’t!” She laughed when Adora shoved her face. “I promise I won’t”.

Adora smiled and kissed her cheek. And then the corner of her mouth. Catra purred when Adora’s lips found hers. It was slow and lazy at first. She could wait a little longer if Adora needed the time to recover. That thought was pushed away when Adora bit her lip gently.

Catra was still certain she wouldn’t last long, even with their short break. The tip of her tail twitched excitedly as Adora’s hand trailed down her stomach while she continued to kiss her hungrily. Even though she was thoroughly satisfied and a little exhausted, Adora wasn’t about to leave her hanging. Not after the orgasm she gave her.

Sometimes, she really hated it when Catra would please her first. She had a tendency to feel like she couldn’t deliver her end nearly as well. All sorts of teasing and deep lustfulness was usually replaced with just wanting to love and cherish her. It wasn’t a bad thing, but Adora sometimes found it unfair.

“Hey, Catra?” Adora barely grazed over her clit, yet still got a shiver out of it.

“Hm?”

“What do you want from me right now?”

“Whatever you can give me”. Catra tucked some of Adora’s hair behind her ear and raised her hips into her touch. “Slow, hard, fast. Anything”.

Adora smiled and kissed down her neck. She continued down slowly, still keeping her finger just barely touching Catra’s clit with every time she raised her hips. The barely audible whimper made her smirk. Even still a little dazed, she could still try to get some payback.

She stopped and nuzzled her face into the slightly longer fur just below Catra’s navel. Anything to get a quiet giggle out of her before she slowly continued lower. Adora smiled when her tail brushed against the back of her thigh, a quiet encouragement to hurry up. She simply ignored it, choosing to kiss around Catra’s lower lips.

“Adoraaa,” she whined and raised her hips again, looking for some kind of friction.

“Hm? Something wrong, kitty cat?” She peered up to find a burning blue and yellow looking back. “Oh, so you can tease the fuck out of me but I can’t return it? What a shame for you”.

“I told you that you win”. She grabbed the back of Adora’s head and pulled her closer. “I told you I cave, I couldn’t take it

anymore. So, please, can you get a move on?”

“And here I thought you wanted to take your time”. Adora lazily ran a finger between wet lips as she rested her head on Catra’s thigh.

Catra let out a frustrated growl as her hips tried to follow the finger barely touching her. In a way, she knew she deserved the payback. Her claws lightly dug into Adora’s scalp when she finally rubbed a few slow circles over her clit.

“I’m a little shocked you didn’t cave sooner based on how absolutely soaked you are”. She finally dipped the tip of her finger inside of her, only to pull back when she tried to sink onto it further. “Not so fast. You said I could give you anything I could”.

“I didn’t mean like this. I just thought you were exhausted and-“ the rest of the thought died in her throat, replaced with a low moan as Adora slid the finger into her finally.

“I am. But,” she added another and watched Catra’s head hit the pillow, “I’d still like to return the favor as best as I can. So tell me, do you want me to fuck you senseless or not?”

“I definitely do,” she gasped as a third finger joined the other two and started, finally, thrusting at an agonizingly slow pace.

Adora only smiled at the soft moans she slowly pulled from Catra. She decided she wanted to hear much more and ran her tongue over her clit. And again. And again before giving a slow suck. Her rewards were a breathless string of profanities and claws digging into the back of her head.

She sped up her fingers and continued to slowly suck and lick at Catra's clit. Adora knew she probably wasn't going to last long but she wasn't expecting her to unravel this fast. Her walls were already starting to twitch and the grip on her head tightened. It wasn't nearly as fair.

She stopped and pulled her fingers out. The low growl and her head being forced forward was somehow cute. Adora almost enjoyed the small amount of edging she was doing to Catra little too much. She removed Catra's hands from the back of her head and sat up. The glare she received was a completely empty threat.

"Seriously?"

"Hey, I could just stop and tell you to get dressed".

"Don't". Catra narrowed her eyes.

"Then flip".

Catra stared at her for a moment, contemplating on just how much she wanted to listen. Adora moved to get up and she quickly locked her ankles around her waist.

"I didn't see you moving," Adora said with a sly smirk.

"Then make me".

Adora raised her eyebrow. "I'm not blind, Catra. I saw the way you froze".

"What are you talking abo-"

Adora let She-Ra show through her eyes for a third time that evening. The smirk never left her face as she watched Catra's expression try to remain neutral.

"I said flip".

That time Catra did what she was told and rolled over to her stomach. Her hips seemed to lift off the bed on their own accord as her tail rested off to one side. She didn't want to entertain She-Ra fucking her at the moment. If she did, they wouldn't be leaving the room for a long while.

“You want She-Ra”.

“I do not!” Catra looked over her shoulder to see Adora quietly laughing, her eyes no longer holding a glow. “I just need fucked, you know. It’s starting to nearly hurt.”

“Oh, but you listen so well when I do that”. Adora gently grabbed her tail with one hand. “So I think you do. And you probably should have given into nature sooner.

“And I think you’re wro-“

Catra shuddered and moaned when Adora’s three fingers returned to inside of her. Her claws dug into the bedding as she clenched her jaw. The gentle pull on her tail made her toes curl. Adora always knew the fine line between pleasure and pain when it came to it.

Adora quickened her pace as well as placed rough hooks with her fingers. The hair on the back of Catra’s head raised a small amount with another gentle tug to the tail. She watched long rips appear in the blanket as Catra muffled a loud noise between a yell and a moan by turning her face down into the bed. Adora let go of her tail and leaned forward to grab the hair at the back of her head and pull her face from the bed.

“No, I want to hear this. You’ve been driving me insane all evening”.

Catra whimpered as she started to feel her legs tremble. She was so close but still felt so far. She needed……

"Go on. Touch yourself". Adora slowed her fingers much to Catra's displeasure. "I won't deny you relief at this point, Catra. I'm not cruel".

She let out a sigh of relief as her fingers reached between her own legs and started rubbing small circles over her clit. Adora sped back up and smiled at the moan she got for it. The hand of Catra's that wasn't busy working on relief balled the blanket under her hand into her fist. Her moans and whimpers with the occasional pleasured growl started to fill the room.

Adora knew how close she was. She gave a few slow, hard thrusts before she felt Catra finish around her fingers. She tugged on her hair, gently pulling her head back a little further as she cried out Adora's name in pleasure when the fingers inside of her sped up for a few seconds before finally pulling out. Adora couldn't help but chuckle at the wet spot on the bed. She wasn't quite sure who made more of a mess.

Catra's head thumped down face first into the bed when Adora let go of her hair. Her hips slowly lowered back to the bed as she trembled. Adora ran her hand up and down her back gently until the shaking eased. She laid down on her side, gently rolled Catra onto her side so she could breathe, and pulled her close.

“Are you okay?” Adora asked, worried when she heard a small sniffle.

“Yeah”. Catra cleared her throat. “My nose was just pressed into the bed for a moment. I’m not crying”. She rolled over in her arms slowly. “Thanks”.

“I still think you want to have some fun with She-Ra”.

“I hate to ruin your fun, but I don’t right now”. She poked Adora’s forehead. “Dummy”.

_____

Adora followed Catra back inside of Horror Hall. She was a little glad no one seemed to have missed them and the party continued on. She hadn’t been able to find another hair tie anywhere, even her old locker, so she was spending the rest of the night with her hair down. Not that Catra minded at all. She waved to Glimmer and Bow with a smile as they walked over.

“Oh, how nice of you two join us,” Glimmer said and folded her arms. “We were waiting on you to play darts again. What took so long?”

“Not all of us have a boyfriend and can finish in two minutes, Sparkles,” Catra teased.

“It was a half hour!” Bow defended. “And you two kinda interrupted”.

“I’d fix your shirt at some point,” she told him. “It’s inside out. You guys really aren’t good at the sneaking off thing, are you? Unlocked door, shirt inside out”.

“Like either of you are to talk,” Glimmer said and pointed between the two. “Adora’s hair is down and a bit of a mess. Your hair isn’t exactly perfect either. And can you live without making her up?”

Adora covered the side of her neck with a sheepish smile. Really, she didn’t fully realize Catra bit and sucked on her neck hard enough to leave marks. She would have at least healed those.

“I behaved more than usual. I didn’t renew the bite”. She clicked her teeth together with a smile.

Glimmer groaned and threw her hands up. “I love you both but sometimes…”

“Is my shirt really inside out?” Bow asked Adora.

She nodded with a quiet laugh. The three watched as he sulked off towards the bathroom to fix his shirt. They all sat at a table together. Catra mostly tuned out the conversation and yawned.

She was willing to wait out the rest of the party goers for Scorpia's sake. And she supposed Glimmer's too.

Bow came back to the table with two plates of snacks for the four of them to share. He couldn't help the smile that came to his face as Catra's chin dropped to her chest as she started to doze off. Adora gladly accepted the plate and quickly ate a few of the snacks before nudging her girlfriend with her elbow.

"Hm?"

"Are you hungry?"

"Not really". Catra eyed the plate tiredly and took a few pieces of the thinly sliced meats. "Okay, maybe a little".

"So," Bow cleared his throat, "did you guys still want to play darts for the last little bit?"

"I think I'll pass," Adora said around a yawn. "It's been… a night".

Catra rested her cheek in her hand and lazily continued to eat a few of the snacks while she watched out over the party. It seemed a good number of people had decided to call it a night, the dance area wasn't as crowded and card games were wrapping up. Some of the kids had even fallen asleep on a parent's lap. Catra didn't blame them, she was ready for some rest as well.

“If no darts, how about a dance or two?” Bow asked. “You guys were gone long enough that you missed some of the good ones”.

“I don’t dance,” Catra mumbled.

“That’s a lie,” Adora said and elbowed her arm. “You dance pretty well from what I remember”.

“That was all planned and practiced and you know it”.

“Come on, Catra,” Glimmer urged and stood up. “It’s the end of the night. I think you should at least entertain one dance with Adora. Dancing under the sheets doesn’t count”.

“That seems kinda difficult,” Adora said under her breath.

“Having sex doesn’t count,” Glimmer clarified with a deadpan tone and pulled Catra’s chair away from the table. “Just one and I won’t bother you about it again”.

“Sparkles,” Catra groaned, “I really don’t-“

“When was the last time you danced with her? Even if it was just in your room or something”.

“Prom,” Adora answered for her.

“Your most recent dance shouldn’t have such negativity around it,” Bow said and patted her shoulder when he joined Glimmer. “Come on. Please?”

“Adora?” Catra looked over to her and saw her hand was already outstretched. “Fine! One dance”.

Adora smiled when she finally took her hand and walked with her to the dance area. Her other hand settled at Catra’s hip and held her close. Catra jokingly rolled her eyes as she rested her free hand on the side of Adora’s shoulder. It was far different than the dance they shared at Princess Prom years ago. Nothing was choreographed. It felt like it was just the two of them, slow dancing together in the middle of Horror Hall.

Catra touched her forehead to Adora’s with a sudden, quiet purr in her throat. Everything else faded away except the slow song and being in each other’s arms. Adora brushed their noses together with a smile.

“No fighting me on rooftops and almost falling off this time,” Adora teased quietly.

“Wouldn’t dream of it”.

“This is all I could ask for, Catra. This right here”.

Catra scoffed with a smile. “That’s complete bullshit. Don’t think I’ve forgotten what you told me about your little dream at the Heart”.

“What are you trying to say?”

“That I know you want more”. She closed her eyes and rested her cheek on Adora’s shoulder. “Someday”.

“Don’t think I forgot what you said about your little bite,” she whispered sweetly. “We’re a little past marriage, aren’t we?”

Catra gave a soft chuckle. Adora did have a point. Still, the thought of a true Etherian marriage somewhat frightened her.

It came with a different kind of weight in her mind. It meant being married to She-Ra too. Which meant everyone would know. Everything would be so official. Being somewhat secretly past marriage would be enough. Their friends could be the only ones to know for now.

“We still have things to work on,” Catra spoke quietly.

“What are you saying?” Adora’s voice suddenly held an edge of worry.

“I don’t think I’m ready yet”. She pulled back a little and looked Adora in the eyes. “We both know and understand the bite and whatever but… an Etherian marriage, something so official? I don’t know. I mean, I do want to. I want to make that wish of yours come true”. She looked away and bit her lip. “Just… someday. Not right now”.

“Hey,” Adora moved her hand from Catra’s hip to her cheek to gently make her look back at her, “I didn’t mean right now. I… don’t think I’m ready for it either. Catra, I’m She-Ra. It’s not like I’m just some ordinary person getting married, and you won’t be either. It’ll be a lot and… I’m not ready for all of that. I’m okay with what we have. It’s official to us, right? Isn’t that what matters right now?”

Catra gave her a smile and nodded against her hand.

“I love you. Alright?” She smiled “I mean it”.

“I love you too,” she said back around a steady purr.

Adora's hand returned to her hip and smiled when Catra nuzzled against her neck, still purring loudly, and closed her eyes. She rested her head against Catra's with her eyes closed and the smile on her face never left. It was just the two of them left in the room for all they cared.

Neither of them noticed the song had changed. Or the several eyes that were watching. The last time anyone witnessed them dance together, they were at each other's throats and everything was tense. This, however, was the complete opposite. They seemed to have completely forgotten they were even at a party.

"Should we, I dunno, let them know they've been like that for almost two whole songs now?" Mermista asked.

"No". Bow wiped his eye with a smile. "Let them have this".

"Are you seriously crying right now?" Glimmer accused and hugged his arm. "You're such a big softie".

"I'm not crying. I'm just… really happy for them".

"Yeah". She rested her head against his arm. "I *guess* they deserve it. Where did your dads run off to?"

Bow shrugged and looked around before seeing them at one of tables grabbing some of the remaining snacks. He waved and

gave them each a hug when they came over.

"They sure make a good pair." George patted his son's back. "We talked to her."

"Good. I think?"

George nodded. "She said it was a start for possible amends. Not much else."

"I feel so bad for talking negatively about them!" Lance gestured to the two women. "Just look! How… why did we say those things?"

"You were mad and upset," Bow answered the rhetorical question. "It happened and it's really time to move forward."

Catra pulled back when Adora shrugged her shoulder and gave her a confused look. She received a warm smile before her face was gently grabbed and pulled into a gentle kiss as the song came to a close. Her arms wrapped around Adora's waist as she returned it.

Not a second more, she jumped as her tail slightly puffed up at the sound of clapping from around them. Her ears dropped in mild embarrassment as her face turned pink and tried to hide it in Adora's neck. Her girlfriend laughed quietly and rubbed her back,

even if her face had flushed as well. The random round of applause was the last thing she expected from the last few of the guests present aside from their friends.

Maybe everyone was finally seeing the unbridled love they had for each other. Maybe they finally, at the very least, started to recognize Catra wasn't all bad after all. Whatever it was, maybe, just maybe, things were only going to get better from here.

Chapter End Notes

> For the smut skippers: You didn't miss a ton that's important for any plot. Just some shameless, dirty smut. Only real noteworthy points are that 1) the original spot was their old bunk and they moved to Catra's Force Captain room and 2) Adora threatened to use She-Ra again.
>
> S: I can't believe part one of the series is done. It was fun to write but we're more excited about the upcoming parts since we were able to have a ton of creative freedom with some of it. There's going to be a bit of a gap until we start posting part two. Indy has some school stuff to focus on and I have two other things I'm half working on and will probably post in the meantime. One will be fully posted on here, the other will have the first two (maybe three, haven't decided) chapters on here and the rest on Patreon (nothing is really on it other than the 5+1 thing I did, so I'm not going to share any link yet. Though it wouldn't be hard to find it and I can't really stop any of you…). When that time comes, I'll put it in notes on that story. That one is… taking more time to get it how I want to start it than I was hoping for. Both are AUs and both are something I'm working on alone. Indy wants to be a reader again for them and I'm not about to deny that since I do miss surprising him sometimes. So far, aside from the words not doing what I want on the one, they're enjoyable to write so I'm a bit excited to share.

Enough on that, though! I hope you all had a good week and have a good upcoming week. If you're feeling absolutely exhausted, don't worry. It's happening to so many people I know, including myself. We got this!

Stay safe out there, remember that you're loved, and until next time… ❤️

Indy: We made it! Part one is done! It feels like it was just yesterday we started writing this story. We will be taking a break. Sokuly has some stuff in the works. I have a shit ton of schoolwork to do. Gotta love finals week. For those who are in college please try not to do anything drastic in this stressful time. We will all get through it in the end. You got this and you are loved ❤️. I can't wait to see you soon

End Notes

S: And here's a start. Updates are currently planned for at least once a week, twice at absolute most, unless something weird comes up. There is a planned ending of 20 chapters but I'm leaving it open as there are a few things we may need to fix up which may create an additional chapter or two. Until then, y'all stay safe out there with winter weather (if you have to deal with the nonsense we do here in the Midwest US).

Indy: The long awaited release has happened! Well long awaited for us 😂. It's been an interesting journey starting this story and it'll be nerve-racking for me because it is a new fandom. We hope you all enjoy this story as much as we enjoy writing it. There is gonna be a lot of ups and downs, pretty much like the show lol.

I hope you all had a decent holiday week and are doing well mentally. For those who aren't just know that you are loved and appreciated.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!